

GOVERNMENT CONSTRUCTION

When building a government for a nation, tribe, or other polity, it's important to keep in mind the purpose of your work. While there's a great deal of pleasure to be had in worldbuilding for worldbuilding's sake, a working GM should keep in mind three fundamental purposes in building any government.

Governments should provide adventure hooks.

The conflicts within a government, the demands it makes upon a populace, and the problems it faces from rebels, malcontents, rivals, and its own internal corruption should all work to provide you with easy adventure creation grist and interesting events for PCs to encounter. A peaceful, orderly, intricately-designed government may be an enjoyable worldbuilding exercise, but it's not likely to give you much playable content.

Governments should provide guidelines for reacting to PC actions. You need to understand how the local rulers will respond to typical PC hijinks. While you don't necessarily need to explicitly tally the local lord's men-at-arms in full harness, you need to know what kind of resources the local authorities will likely have for dealing with troublemakers and responding to local crises. Is there anything like a police force? Are there particular things that PCs are likely to do or be that are problematic, like being a sorcerer in a magic-banning nation or a human in a land of demihuman supremacists? Your life as a GM will be much easier if you have a rough idea of the kind of muscle and money available to the local rulers at various levels of PC interaction.

Governments should fit the thematic goal of the nation. If you want to have pulse-pounding sword and sorcery adventures in a decadent land of untamed wilderness and debauchorous cities, you probably shouldn't put it all under an all-powerful mandarin. Or if you do, you should have a very good idea of why scholar-officials chosen for academic ability and personal virtue actually fit the kind of play you want to encourage in the area.

With these three points established, you can go through the sections below to quickly generate a government that will help you fulfill each goal.

GOVERNMENTAL DENSITY

First, you need to decide how dense the nation's governmental resources are. Very poor polities simply cannot afford the tremendous superstructure of officials, enforcers, functionaries, and men-at-arms in full harness that richer nations can indulge. As a consequence, they will tend to have very different mechanisms for dealing with public disorders and large-scale problems than more affluent nations.

Low-density governments tend to exist in tribal societies, small fiefs, compact institutions such as monasteries, or poor nations that produce very little surplus for the elites to collect. Their governments usually consist of a single autocrat or small group of leaders and their

personal retainers. There is very little in the way of paid offices, bureaucratic institutions, or low-level functionaries. Taxes and other exactions are gathered and handed over by the common populace based on custom and the threat of direct violence from the leadership, rather than being collected by some intermediary enforcers.

If PCs or others start to create problems in an area, the local citizens will have to deal with it. Only if that proves impossible will they send to their leadership for help, and that help may not be quick in coming. In such cases, the leadership will dispatch one or more trusted retainers to lead the local response. These retainers may dragoon local citizens and resources to their purpose, but their actions will be based on custom, threat, and recognized necessity rather than any written charter.

Medium-density governments are found in richer polities or tribal nation-states where there's enough surplus to feed a thin layer of functionaries. Even in these nations, however, usually no more than one in three hundred people are actually officials or permanently-mustered soldiers. Small bureaucracies may exist devoted to the treasury, the military, economic control, or state religions, but these bureaucrats will tend to be centralized in the capital or other major cities. Villages and other provincial regions will generally have a single governmental representative present, along with a handful of local clerks, guards, and servants, often part-time.

When a crisis happens, the local governmental representative will resolve it with their personal retinue, or enlist locals to assist. Some of these natives may be formally organized as auxiliaries, such as a town guard composed of free citizens obligated to do the work on a rotating basis, or village chiefs charged with collecting crop taxes from their neighbors. These auxiliaries are rarely paid much, if anything, for their work. Many of their duties may be treated as unpleasant corvée labor exacted from the populace by the state.

In a medium-density government, PCs are unlikely to encounter the city watch or other low-level functionaries outside of an actual city. The lowest governmental representative is usually a city or district magistrate or governor, and individual village chiefs are likely no more than important local citizens deputized as such by custom. If the PCs cause serious problems in a city, the rulers may have a certain number of standing guardsmen to deal with them, but major uprisings will require calling out the citizenry, the local garrison, or sending for help.

High-density government is the sort most familiar to modern readers, being a fair description of many of the modern nations of the world. Perhaps as many as one in a hundred or even more are either professional soldiers, clerks, functionaries, or other state-employed servants. Bureaucracies exist in every city and town, and the government has the manpower necessary to involve itself in almost every form of human interaction.

Depending on the competence and responsiveness of the bureaucracy, a crisis might be met with a swift, overwhelming response, or it might meet an interminable delay of confused paperwork and competing departments before an overwhelming response is aimed in precisely the wrong direction. Governments of this kind have a tremendous fund of resources to carry out their will, but their will is often bent and warped by the countless layers of functionaries between the leader and the reality on the ground. In such states, it's not impossible for the ostensible emperor to be unable to control anything he's not personally overseeing, simply because the existing bureaucracies have too much inertia to direct without personal oversight.

As the GM, think about the wealth and general attitude of the populace of this nation and pick a government density that fits. Then if some crisis or calamity strikes in the land, whether PC-generated or not, you'll have some idea what the initial response will look like and what kind of resources they might have to deal with it.

THE RULING AUTHORITY

How many people are actually in charge in the nation? Is it an autocracy based on a single monarch, or is effectively ruled by a council? Don't worry about *who* these rulers are at this stage, just decide if they are one, several, or many significant rulers.

d4	Number of Rulers
1	There is a single nominal monarch
2	There is a monarch and several under-kings
3	There is a group of approximate equals
4	There are a large number of small rulers

THE RULING CLASS

Where are these rulers drawn from? What class or classes provide the leadership of the nation? This limitation may be a formal law or custom, or it may just be a de facto reality based on the local political situation.

d12	Example Ruling Classes
1	Hereditary nobility of blood
2	Powerful merchant-princes and oligarchs
3	Sorcerers and the arcanelly skilled
4	Magically-empowered bloodlines
5	Proletariat peasantry or artisans
6	Minority ethnicity of long historical rule
7	Clergy of one or more local faiths
8	Citizens of a special city or old homeland
9	Outsiders or nonhumans of a certain type
10	Warlords or military leaders
11	Clan heads or ethnarchs of particular groups
12	Colonizer viceroys of a foreign hegemon

THE SOURCE OF LEGITIMACY

Why does anyone pay attention to these rulers? They may have great military might at their disposal, but continued stable rule is contingent on some degree of popular submission to their orders. What have the rulers done to earn the obedience of the people?

d12	Sources of Legitimacy
1	They've simply always been the rulers
2	They're thought wiser and more virtuous
3	Their martial prowess is awe-inspiring
4	The gods chose them as the leaders
5	They were chosen by popular will
6	They're loved for their benevolence
7	They utterly crushed the last batch of rebels
8	They brought greater prosperity to the land
9	They smashed the prior government
10	They brought order out of bloody chaos
11	They led the nation to greater glory and pride
12	They seem less bad than the alternatives

SERVANTS OF THE RULING ORDER

How do the rulers exert their will on the people? What institutions or functionary classes exist to make sure their commands are carried out and their laws are respected? Most nations have more than one institution that can serve to impose the ruler's will, but the one you pick or roll below may be the most powerful.

The ruler's favored enforcers often tend to subsume some of the government's power toward their own class or personal interests. Corruption among powerful government functionaries is a commonplace, and PCs can easily find that the personal trouble they have with some grandee can become a formal crime. Agents of less popular governments can come to be hated or feared by the common people, often with bloody consequences.

d12	Institutions and Agents of Control
1	Subordinate lords pledged to the ruler
2	Obedient commoner bureaucracies
3	Magically-empowered enforcers
4	A major religion allied with state power
5	A powerful and respected judiciary
6	Savage brutes on the government leash
7	Economy-controlling officialdom
8	Divine blessings and curses on the people
9	Ingrained obedience in the populace
10	Hireling enforcers employed at need
11	Sorcerers in service to the ruler
12	A specific ethnic client group of the ruler



FORMS OF RULERSHIP

You may know how many major rulers there are for the nation, but how are these rulers chosen, and what is their general relationship to the rest of government? Use the table below that best fits the number of chief rulers suitable to the land.

You'll want to stick a suitable title on the ruler while you're at it, using the default aesthetic of the nation as a guide. Whether as a datu, emperor, basileus, sultana, or some other title of renown, you can fill in the names for your rulers once you know how many of them there are and how they're to be organized.

d8	Single Rulers
1	King or queen over lesser lords
2	Autocrat with non-noble officials
3	President chosen by certain electors
4	Warlord recognized as the strongest
5	Seniormost representative of the ruling class
6	Divinely-chosen leader of the land
7	Monarch for a fixed term or situation
8	Wielder of some magical legitimacy

d8	Multiple Rulers
1	Nobly-born peers of the realm
2	Seniormost figures in the ruling class
3	Elect chosen by ruling class electors
4	Hereditary heirs to their positions
5	Warlords with the strongest backing
6	Oligarchs of greatest wealth or influence
7	Divinely-chosen representatives of their class
8	Bureaucratically-chosen ministers

DISEASES OF RULE

The final step in creating the government is to roll or pick a substantial problem that it's facing or a driving ambition that is causing conflict within its membership. This problem will help create adventure hooks involving the government; maybe the PCs are caught up in the struggle as unhappy victims, or enlisted by a faction to help gain its end.

Remember that there will always be factions and conflicting interests in any government. Feudal lords don't want the same things that the monarchic king wants, and urban merchants haven't the same interests as rural peasantry. Even a state's main institutions of enforcement might have their own set of goals to pursue.

If you want an extra layer of complication to the situation, you can roll for an earlier problem that the government overcame... but the way in which they overcame it planted the seeds for its current dilemma. Adding historical consequences like that helps give a sense of depth to your world and its rulers.

d12	Current Struggle Within the Government
1	The ruler's trying to crush a too-powerful lord
2	Ministers are trying to usurp power
3	A grand scheme has gone terribly wrong
4	External diplomacy has bungled something
5	A usurper secretly controls a major power
6	Foreign rivals are backing malcontents
7	A different class demands a share of rule
8	The existing ruling class wants more power
9	A disfavored class is being oppressed
10	Popular discontent is destroying legitimacy
11	The prior ruler's incompetence still harms it
12	The heir is unacceptable to many



ONE-ROLL GOVERNMENT DETAILS

While the prior tables give you a basic framework for a government, it can be useful to add a few more details for spice and easier plot hook creation. The tables on this page can be used to quickly generate a few peripheral facts and situations to help flavor a GM's plans. As with the other tools in this section, a GM should simply scale the results up or down to suit the scale of the government.

Thus, if you're creating a tribal kingship where the ruler is one man and his dozen most trusted spear-brothers, a result of "Bribe-hungry and meddling magistrates" might mean that Bragi accepted a dozen sheep from a man to decide in his favor about a land dispute, and so now the victim's kindred are demanding justice. In a grand empire, that same result might speak of an entire province plagued by greedy magistrates.

d6 How Established Is the Current Ruler?

- 1 They're an outsider with few existing allies
- 2 They're newly-ascended to the throne
- 3 They have some basic ties with strong allies
- 4 They have a hard core of useful supporters
- 5 They have an extensive support network
- 6 They're practically an institution of their own

d8 What Problems do their Ministers Have?

- 1 Their chief schemes too much against rivals
- 2 They're out of touch or lazy in their work
- 3 They recently suffered a bloody purge
- 4 Enemy forces have allies among them
- 5 They're distracted by factional infighting
- 6 The leadership tends to ignore their advice
- 7 They tacitly usurp power from the ruler
- 8 They're committed to a very bad idea

d10 A Strength of the Government

- 1 The bureaucracy is extremely efficient
- 2 The military leadership is fiercely loyal
- 3 It has great legitimacy with the populace
- 4 It has firm economic control over the land
- 5 The populace is convinced it will bring good
- 6 Its diplomats are remarkably cunning
- 7 An expert spymaster serves it well
- 8 It has access to powerful sorceries
- 9 It's got firm ties with an important faith
- 10 Nobles have magic blessings or gifted blood

d4 How Stable is the Government?

- 1 Precarious, its authority questioned by some
- 2 It has significant problems, but it functions
- 3 Relatively stable, with strong legitimacy
- 4 Stable, able to endure even fierce shocks

d12 Officials Recently Causing Problems

- 1 Rapaciously grasping tax-farmers
- 2 Ill-disciplined and thieving military troops
- 3 Bribe-hungry and meddling magistrates
- 4 Ever-watchful informers among neighbors
- 5 Tithe-hungry collectors from the state faith
- 6 Corrupt and untrustworthy market officials
- 7 Carelessly superior nobles and their retainers
- 8 Thuggish constables or city guardsmen
- 9 Pitiless inquisitors hunting out dark magics
- 10 Law enforcers acting as if they are the law
- 11 State scholars teaching vile principles
- 12 Corrupt village headmen acting as tyrants

d20 Recent Governmental Event

- 1 A major official was executed for treason
- 2 A critically-necessary heir was born
- 3 A chief minister fell rapidly from grace
- 4 A high noble made rebellious noises
- 5 A major faith was offended by the rulers
- 6 An allied nation was angered by some act
- 7 An enemy nation's spy ring was revealed
- 8 A vast governmental project was announced
- 9 Corrupt officials plundered a great plan
- 10 A major new bureaucracy was formed
- 11 A heavy tax was levied to deal with an issue
- 12 A general was dismissed for incompetence
- 13 A folk hero rose to dangerous popularity
- 14 A major infrastructure project was begun
- 15 A fief or territory was put in new hands
- 16 Certain merchants were fined to beggary
- 17 A terrorist attack by rebels or external foes
- 18 A major faction of officials collapsed
- 19 A large bureaucracy was dissolved
- 20 Internal province borders were redrawn



HISTORY CONSTRUCTION

A GM will often need to build some sort of history for their creations, whether for current nations and groups in their campaign setting or for some long-lost fragment of ancient empire. Rather than bog down in an endlessly-unscrolling timeline of events, it can be convenient to package the past into four stages for any group: origin, rise, peak, and fall. The tables provided here give some suggestions for particulars.

Not every group will need every stage fleshed out, and not every element needs to be detailed in exhaustive fashion. A few sentences about each stage is often all that's necessary for some long-dead empire, and when building some time-lost ruin all you might care about is how the original creators fell.

You can also create epicycles inside this pattern, adding additional rises, peaks, and falls within the group's history until some final burden blots them from the memory of the world. It's generally only worth your time to do this if you plan on very carefully detailing a particular history. For less important actors, the rough outlines are usually all you need.

If you don't already know of their origins, first find out how the group came into being.

d8 How Did They Originate?

- 1 Aboriginal peoples united in the area
- 2 They were refugees from a fallen land
- 3 They were exiles or losers of some civil strife
- 4 They were colonists who became independent
- 5 They were magically created or shaped here
- 6 They all followed a faith or ideology here
- 7 They were a conquering army gone native
- 8 They migrated here for profit or plunder

Now roll or decide what became of the original inhabitants of the land, who might've been the last remnants of the former ruling power of the region or small, disorganized groups unable to successfully resist.

d10 What Became of the Original Inhabitants?

- 1 There were no other humans living here
- 2 They were wiped out in warfare
- 3 They were utterly assimilated
- 4 They were driven into exile
- 5 They became the ruling class
- 6 They became an oppressed underclass
- 7 They were partially assimilated
- 8 They retained small areas of self-rule
- 9 Roll 1d8 twice; both happened
- 10 No one can agree on what happened

Then use the table below to pick out some crisis they faced and overcame, thus instigating their rise.

d00 Historical Crises

- 1–4 Barbarian invasion
- 5–8 Colonial incursion from a greater power
- 9–12 Decadent society or a great social evil
- 13–16 Divine wrath upon them
- 17–20 Domineering neighbor
- 21–24 Economic collapse
- 25–28 Failed external war
- 29–32 Ideological divide
- 33–36 Incompetent governance
- 37–40 Internal refugees from disaster
- 41–44 Loss of cultural confidence
- 45–48 Magical calamity
- 49–52 Malevolent religion
- 53–56 Miserable poverty
- 57–60 Natural disasters
- 61–64 Noble infighting
- 65–68 Religious or ideological excess
- 69–72 Resource exhaustion
- 73–76 Scheming wizards
- 77–80 Some titanic monster
- 81–84 Tyrannical rule
- 85–88 Unsuccessful expansion
- 89–92 Usurpers seizing control
- 93–96 Vicious civil warfare
- 97–00 War with a stronger power

But how did they manage to overcome the crisis? What quality did they demonstrate to get through the hard times or shift the burden onto their neighbors?

d10 How Did They Overcome the Crisis?

- 1 A brilliant and inspirational leader arose
- 2 Organization and unity overcame the trouble
- 3 Grim determination and enduring the evil
- 4 Faith strengthened them against the woe
- 5 Skillful use of magic resolved the problem
- 6 Martial prowess and military cunning
- 7 Diplomatic ties and outside help
- 8 Industrious labor and tireless exertion
- 9 Economic brilliance and trading acumen
- 10 Ruthless but effective sacrifices were made

With the group at its historical peak, what particular marvels, splendid qualities, or exceptional strengths did it demonstrate? The shining peak of a provincial noble house might produce significantly less than the golden age of a world-spanning empire, but something about this period set its stamp on the group and gave them something to be proud of for the remainder of their days.

d12 What Was Great About Its Peak?

- 1 A terrible regional evil was driven back
- 2 Academies were built that are still honored
- 3 Ancient foes were united together
- 4 Grand Workings were sorcerously raised
- 5 It controlled the trade of the entire region
- 6 It was hegemon over its weaker neighbors
- 7 Its armies were fearsomely mighty
- 8 Its culture was compelling to its neighbors
- 9 Magnificent works of art were created
- 10 Numerous legendary heroes arose
- 11 The populace was tremendously prosperous
- 12 Wonderful works of architecture were built

Yet all glories must fade in time. For its fall, pick or roll another historical crisis; this time, the group was unable to rise to the occasion and collapsed due to the stress of the situation. Why couldn't it handle the crisis?

d12 Why Did It Fail At the Final Crisis?

- 1 Its people were too deeply divided
- 2 Its leadership was hopelessly inept
- 3 The gods cursed it to ruin
- 4 Decadence and self-absorption doomed it
- 5 It was vastly overconfident in its plans
- 6 Its neighbors conspired to help ruin it
- 7 It was actually two crises, and it was too much
- 8 It was culturally exhausted and apathetic
- 9 Some tried to take advantage of the crisis
- 10 Its strengths were useless against the problem
- 11 The crisis was far too vast and overwhelming
- 12 Some leaders were allied with the crisis

With the nation or group in ruins, the last step to the process is to determine what happened to the survivors that were not absorbed by the conquerors. While fantasy worlds often consign fallen empires to oblivion, historical collapsed nations tend to melt into the surrounding peoples or carry on as pockets within the new overlord's domain. In your world, it's possible that the serpent-men of the Red-Scaled Imperium were wiped out by the collapse of their thousand-year rule, but it's equally possible that they became the humble swamp-fishers that sometimes bring their catch to human villages.

d12 What Became of the Unabsorbed Survivors?

- 1 They fled for refuge to a neighboring nation
- 2 They sought to hide in a dangerous wilderness
- 3 They were exterminated by bitter rivals
- 4 They degenerated into savage remnants
- 5 They were enslaved by their enemies
- 6 They were magically transformed or twisted
- 7 They were shattered into pockets of survivors
- 8 They became a remnant shadow of themselves
- 9 They forcibly migrated into a weaker land
- 10 They formed the nucleus of a new culture
- 11 They split into several new, smaller groups
- 12 Roll twice; the resultant groups hate each other

With the basic outline of the group's history complete, you can now go on to decorate their past with other historical events, such as those given on the following pages. If you've already established a few historical events for the group as part of building a backdrop with them, you can stitch those existing events into the pattern you've generated here.

All of the results in this section should be selected with an eye for adventuring potential. The old conflicts, past prides, and present travails of a nation are meant to provide situations that the PCs can encounter, and problems that they might be called upon to intervene in. An intricate tale of a hundred-year war is all well and good, but if the story doesn't provide any adventure hooks, then it's recreational worldbuilding rather than a source of playable content.

Also keep in mind that these history tools don't need to be applied strictly to great nations or mighty tribes. Even a gentry family in some remote village might have a history patterned from this table, translated and shrunk down to the scale at which they live. The *Barbarian Invasion* that was a tide of howling warriors to a nation might be a raucous clan of backwoods squatters laying claim to the family's best fields. In the same vein, "diplomatic ties and outside help" might've brought together a national alliance at a state level, and might've called on old marriage ties to marshal a mob of angry villagers at a more familial level. Use the results as cues and general directions rather than stiff descriptions of specific fact.



HISTORICAL EVENTS

The events described here provide a selection of possibilities for your own history-building. When applying them to different levels of your backdrop, scale them accordingly; the *Immigrants* result rolled on a village scale might be a family of foreigners moving into an isolated farmstead, while applying it on a national scale might mean an entire barbarian tribe has marched in and requested citizenship.

Battleground: The group's territory ended up as a battleground between two stronger rival powers, and they suffered bitterly for it.

Betrayal: Either they betrayed some trusting neighbor to a foe, or were betrayed in turn by such a false friend.

Brutal Oppression: Some portion of the group was reduced to a state of wretched subservience by the rest.

Class Struggle: Different classes were in conflict, either subtle or overt, all seeking their own gain.

Consequences: Pick an event of a prior age; it had long-term consequences that were good, for a bad event, or bad, for a good event.

Decadence: Old strengths and glories crumbled away into decadent remnants, the group becoming indolent and indulgent.

Depravity: Vile debauches, unclean habits, and base hungers became commonplace among the group.

Desolation: Some portion of the group's territory was rendered uninhabitable by something, either permanently or for a long time.

Diplomatic Coup: The group achieved an extremely successful alliance or affiliation with a neighboring group that may yet persist.

Economic Boom: Circumstances produced a burst of tremendous prosperity for them.

Enemies Within: A hostile sub-group inside the group worked to do it evil, perhaps on behalf of a neighbor or due to some old grudge.

Evil Wizard: A malevolent sorcerer, arcane cult, or other powerful magical entity caused a great deal of trouble for the group.

Exodus: A significant chunk of the group packed up and left for some supposedly-superior land.

Exquisite Art: The group produced art that is revered to this day, either in general or in a specific medium or form of literature.

External War: The group faced a war with some external enemy or rival nation, with grave consequences.

Freakish Magic: A particular type of magic was developed here that is unknown elsewhere, and its practitioners keep its secrets well.

Golden Age: Everything went remarkably well for the group for an extended period of time, allowing prosperity and success.

Good Wizard: Some magic-using entity of great power protected the group, taught them magic, or otherwise assisted them.

Great Awakening: A tremendous wave of reform, purification, and re-commitment to venerable values swept through the group.

Great Builders: The group constructed a great many vast palaces, monuments, estates, or other structures of wide fame.

Great Infrastructure: Some tremendous work of infrastructure was accomplished: canals, vast walls, roads, aqueducts, mines, or the like.

Hero King: Some king or other ruler achieved legendary glory in war, diplomacy, or governance. Their name is honored even today.

Immigrants: A large group of foreigners entered the land more-or-less peacefully and may or may not have been welcomed.

Inefficient Rule: The group's governance was impractical, inefficient, or corrupt, holding to values that turned out to be unhelpful.

Internal War: A straight-up civil war was sparked in the group, one that involved all or many of its members.

Loss of Confidence: Some encounter with a new group or some shocking event made the group lose faith in its own customs and values.

Magical Disaster: Some large-scale magical disaster scarred the group, either natural in nature or the result of someone's sorcerous doings.

Magical Tech: The group developed a useful and widespread magical tech or infrastructure that may have survived into the present.

Natural Calamity: Earthquakes, multi-year droughts, tsunamis, meteor strikes, or some other ruins smote the group.

New Horizons: The group discovered new territory, whether trans-dimensional, a far terrestrial region, underground realms, or the like.

New Rulers: The group's former ruling dynasty was replaced, either peacefully, through intrigue, or perhaps through outright conquest.

Noble Function: Aside from the usual roles of nobles, their ruling class was all expected to fill some specific role: priest, mage, scholar, or the like.

Noble Strife: The group's nobility found itself embroiled in assassinations, petty wars, and mutual struggle.

Plague: A sickness of vast scope culled many of the group, and may yet linger in some form.

Poverty: Circumstances conspired to reduce the group to a state of great poverty and harsh simplicity for a time.

Power Brokers: The group was a critical regional power broker for a time, their aid or influence critical in determining who would be the hegemon.

Praetorian Coups: Soldiers or guardsmen in service to the ruler ended up becoming the ruler's electors or deposed.

Priest King: One or more religions became deeply intertwined with the legitimacy of the ruling class, priests becoming nobles and vice-versa.

d00	Historical Event	d00	Historical Event
1–2	Battleground	51–52	Loss of Confidence
3–4	Betrayal	53–54	Magical Disaster
5–6	Brutal Oppression	55–56	Magical Tech
7–8	Class Struggle	57–58	Natural Calamity
9–10	Consequences	59–60	New Horizons
11–12	Decadence	61–62	New Rulers
13–14	Depravity	63–64	Noble Function
15–16	Desolation	65–66	Noble Strife
17–18	Diplomatic Coup	67–68	Plague
19–20	Economic Boom	69–70	Poverty
21–22	Enemies Within	71–72	Power Brokers
23–24	Evil Wizard	73–74	Praetorian Coups
25–26	Exodus	75–76	Priest King
27–28	Exquisite Art	77–78	Rare Resource
29–30	External War	79–80	Religious Fall
31–32	Freakish Magic	81–82	Religious Rise
33–34	Golden Age	83–84	Resource Collapse
35–36	Good Wizard	85–86	Secession
37–38	Great Awakening	87–88	Terrain Change
39–40	Great Builders	89–90	Total Collapse
41–42	Great Infrastructure	91–92	Twist of Fate
43–44	Hero King	93–94	Urbanization
45–46	Immigrants	95–96	Weak Throne
47–48	Inefficient Rule	97–98	Xenophilia
49–50	Internal War	99–00	Xenophobia

Rare Resource: A uniquely valuable resource was found or manufactured by the group, which used or traded it to full effect.

Religious Fall: A once-honored religion collapsed, perhaps through divine displeasure, human corruption, or harsh suppression.

Religious Rise: A powerful new religion arose among the group.

Resource Collapse: Some critical resource ran short; water, arable land, timber, magical power, or the like.

Secession: A substantial portion of the group's territory tried to secede from the rest, successfully or otherwise.

Terrain Change: Some portion of the group's land slowly changed its basic ecosystem; plains to forest, desert to savanna, or the like.

Total Collapse: Whether due to war, civil strife, magical curses, or sheer decadence, the group's society collapsed into anarchistic chaos for a time.

Twist of Fate: Roll again; if the event was positive twist it to ultimately be a negative to the group, and vice-versa.

Urbanization: One or more urban sites became unusually heavily populated, growing vastly and having a wide net of supporting towns.

Weak Throne: The central government of the group became weak, and feudal lords or subsidiaries gained much effective independence.

Xenophilia: The group adopted many customs from their neighbors and many foreigners joined the group.

Xenophobia: The group conceived a strong distaste for foreign people and their customs, curtailing outside contact.



RELIGION CONSTRUCTION

While it's certainly possible to create a setting wholly devoid of anything resembling a religion, most GMs will want some manner of faith in their campaign. Note that you should only build the religions you need, the ones that will give you the most playable content and the highest number of adventure hooks. A boring faith, however important it is to the culture or society it's in, just isn't worth much of your mental effort or creative energy.

THE SCOPE OF THE FAITH

First, decide where this god is worshiped. It might be a local deity unknown outside a particular backwoods hamlet, or it might be the state faith of an entire kingdom or continent. Some faiths you create might be entirely dead in the modern age, existing only to help you define the particular god some ruined temple once served.

Use the scope of the faith to scale the results and decisions that follow. A religion led by a single holy prophet might amount to a village wise man for a petty rural god, while an empire's faith might be led by a pontiff hardly less powerful than the emperor.

WHO LEADS THE FAITH?

How is the religion organized, and who makes decisions about its beliefs, actions, and use of resources? When PCs interact with the clergy, who will be deciding how the faith responds to them, and who do the nobles deal with when they want divine favors for the church?

d8	Church Structures
1	Each holy man or woman is the autonomous leader of their own branch of the sect, with however many followers they can gather.
2	There are multiple pontiffs, friendly or otherwise, with subordinate clergy obedient to their own pontiff and perhaps cooperative with others.
3	There is a single pontiff with a layer of upper clergy and temple heads beneath them, who have a layer of minor clergy serving them.
4	Individual congregations are independent, with their clergy subject to the consensus will of their parishioners.
5	Powerful lay believers fund temples that are subject to their family's wishes, staffed by clergy supported by their funding.
6	There is no official clergy; some believers may take up special roles or provide teaching, but they are not qualitatively different from others.
7	The church is entirely part of the secular structure of the land, its clergy no more than officials appointed by the government to their roles.
8	Roll twice; the faith has different structures in different places or contexts.

WHAT IS THE GOD'S ORIGIN?

Where did this deity come from? The religion may be completely wrong about the facts of the matter, but they will have some kind of explanation as to the origins of their god. This origin will tend to shape a faith's relationship with their patron; the literal hero-ancestor of a people will draw a different kind of devotion than a personified abstract principle.

d12	Where Did The God Come From?
1	It's a deified ancestor-king or progenitor
2	It's a legendary historical hero or teacher
3	It's an abstract principle reified as an entity
4	It simply always existed since creation
5	It was an apotheosized sorcerer
6	It's the genius of a particular land or location
7	It was an Outsider or alien from beyond
8	It was a personified natural phenomenon
9	It was another faith's saint turned into a god
10	It was a tamed or placated supernatural entity
11	It was an artificial construct built by humans
12	Roll twice and blend the two

WHY DOES THIS FAITH MATTER?

Most gods provide something important to their worshippers, be it luck, divine blessings, salvation upon death, or curses on their enemies. From a GM's perspective, however, the most important factor is how the god relates to the PCs, and what sort of playable content they bring to the campaign setting.

In some cases this will be obvious, because you're building a faith to be the state religion, or the primary source of Healers in a setting, or some other clear hook. The table below offers some suggestions for other cases.

d10	Why Does The Faith Matter?
1	It's the main purveyor of healing blessings
2	It provides magical favors to the faithful
3	It's locked in conflict with a major local power
4	It supports something the PCs love or hate
5	It's the state faith or otherwise legally important
6	It regularly hires people to do work for it
7	It's trying to expand and needs help
8	It's a huge economic player in the area
9	It plots secret sinister evils against the land
10	It has influence over important locals

WHAT DOES THIS FAITH WANT?

The religion doubtlessly wants something. Individual clerics might have their own desires and ambitions, but as an institution the faith wants something that the PCs can either help or hinder them in obtaining. Some faiths might have multiple desires, either pursued by quarreling factions within the church or as part of some larger vision.

d12	What Does The Faith Want?
1	Crush its religious rivals in the area
2	Destroy a heretical but powerful sub-sect
3	Expand the faith to a foreign land or people
4	Recover holy land or a sacred site
5	Obtain vast material wealth for the faith
6	Depose a hostile royal house or government
7	Smash a specific enemy faith or group
8	Embody their god with a mighty ritual
9	Erect a huge and imposing temple complex
10	Perform a tremendously expensive rite
11	Strengthen or protect its devout believers
12	Roll again; stop a rival from doing that

WHAT ARE THE CLERGY LIKE?

What's the average cleric of this faith like? How do they present themselves to the general public, and what kind of cleric will the PCs most likely encounter if they want to deal with this religion? The more restrictive and demanding the faith is about their clerics, the rarer they will be and the more likely that lay believers handle some rituals of the faith on their own. Conversely, the more strict the qualifications, the more likely those clerics are to have special qualities or magical powers. Some faiths may have multiple kinds of clerics, either as different ranks or for serving different functions in the religion.

d8	What Are the Clerics Like?
1	Just ritual technicians trained in complex rites, with no special moral qualities.
2	Chosen from specific bloodlines or groups and trained to serve the faithful.
3	Experts in some sphere related to the god's portfolio or nature, though trained in ritual.
4	Sorcerers who serve the god as part of their magical studies or efforts.
5	Common believers chosen by their peers for their technical skill and good moral qualities.
6	Isolated ascetics or ritually-separated persons expected to keep a distance from the world.
7	Individuals who step forward and are accepted for their qualities or technical skills as priests.
8	The wealthier believers who can afford to keep up the expensive or demanding ritual practice.

WHAT IS THEIR SOCIETAL FUNCTION?

While a given faith matters chiefly for what it provides by way of adventure hooks, the religion also must serve some meaningful purpose in its surrounding society. It's a common habit of world-builders to assign particular portfolios to gods and then build out their social function from that. While it's possible to do this, it's generally more efficient to reverse this process.

First you pick the function that is being served, and then you roll or choose the god's divine portfolio. The connection between the two may not seem obvious at first glance, but the society will tend to create their own explanations for any apparent incongruities. A forest god who also happens to be the favored deity of a nation's noble elite might influence their iconography, make their duels into ritual hunts, and perhaps be credited as the magical source of noble fertility or special prowess.

Most societies will have certain roles or functions that the gods need to serve. Almost every nation's farmers need to pray to *somebody* for a good harvest, and people will pray for health, luck, protection in danger, success in undertakings, and other common human desires. A GM could create gods for all the common needs listed below, but the table is mostly useful for assigning a particular social role to whatever specific gods or religions that are most relevant to your campaign's scope and your party's adventures.

d20	What Does This God Do in Society?
1	It's the war god or patron of those who fight
2	It's the favorite god of the ruling class
3	It's the patron of an important profession
4	It's a devil-figure that must be placated
5	It provides healing or protection from danger
6	It's a patron of an illegal but inevitable trade
7	It hallows the law and consecrates oaths
8	It's flatly illegal and hated by most
9	It's the protector of an ethnic minority
10	It provides good harvests or human fertility
11	It's the patron of the former rulers of the land
12	It guards particular places within the land
13	It provides wisdom and insight at need
14	It gives good luck to its petitioners
15	It's a protector of the weak and humble
16	It empowers those seeking revenge for wrongs
17	It bestows material wealth upon petitioners
18	It protects the soul in the afterlife
19	It explains the creation and order of the world
20	It prevents some type of common disaster



WHAT IS THE GOD'S PORTFOLIO?

Once you know what the faith's role in society is, you can pick or roll to find out what general portfolio is assigned to the deity. Powerful gods may have several spheres they are responsible for, while niche deities might be gods of only a small, specific, yet important function. The origins of the god will also flavor this choice; an ancestor-hero might have a portfolio associated with their great deeds in life, while a reified cosmic principle probably isn't considered critical to merely human processes and activities.

Remember also that gods tend to bleed into providing the services that their worshipers need from them. If a god is important to the locals, the original myths and understanding of their nature may warp over time into functions and aspects that are more important or significant to the people and their rulers. A god that once embodied a particular natural principle might later be viewed as the patron of some human concern, their original qualities reinterpreted to fit their new role.

d20	Human Concern	Natural Principle
1	A Human Vice	A Local Terrain Type
2	A Kind of Demihuman	Beasts
3	Agriculture	Beauty or Sex
4	Cities	Cosmic Law
5	Commerce	Creation
6	Crafting	Death
7	Deception	Fertility
8	Healing	Forests
9	Justice	Magic
10	Luck	Mountains
11	Marriage or Family	Night
12	Music	One or More Seasons
13	Prophecy	Pain
14	Protection	Sea or Rivers
15	Revenge	Sky
16	Ruling	Storms or Rain
17	Theft or Crime	Sun, Moon, or Stars
18	Travel or Roads	The Underworld
19	War	Time
20	Wisdom	Untamed Nature

WHAT ARE THE FAITH'S STRICTURES?

A religion will make certain demands upon its faithful, with the common believers expected to keep to certain behaviors and the clergy charged with more demanding practices. These strictures and commands usually relate to actions rather than beliefs; theological disputes are meat for priests, while common believers concern themselves with the proper sacrifices, prayers, rituals, and technical procedures for winning the god's favor.

Some of these strictures will be positive, commanding the faithful to act in certain ways. Others will be negative, forbidding them from particular activities. While many faiths might have general prohibitions against blasphemy or other activities widely despised by their society, the table below focuses on special commands unique to the followers of the god.

Of course, not all followers will obey these strictures with the same zeal. Priests and the pious will usually be expected to offer at least lip service to the principles, while common believers may follow them only when their circumstances allow or they feel a special need to curry the god's favor. Nobles and other elites will often make an ostentatious show of such behavior, facilitating it with their wealth and power in order to emphasize their piety and favor with the gods. Indeed, following certain taboos may be a sign of status in a society and show the practitioner is wealthy enough to afford such limits.

d20	Particular Religious Requirements
1	Never/always associate with certain types
2	Never eat a particular common food type
3	Give a significant tithe regularly
4	Make particular sacrifices at certain times
5	Revere/hate a class or group of people
6	Forbid a certain common profession or role
7	Forbid an activity common to society
8	Give secular obedience to the clergy
9	Pray at certain fixed places or times
10	Never/always trade with certain sorts
11	Never/always live in certain places
12	Marry exclusively within the faith
13	Do something society finds repugnant
14	Hold certain places to be taboo
15	Hide the inner faith's teachings from outsiders
16	Make sacrifices that society finds hateful
17	Never/always make war on certain types
18	Honor/degrade a particular profession
19	Make certain pilgrimages to holy places
20	Never/always cooperate with a certain faith

ONE-ROLL TEMPLE DETAILS

It's inevitable that the PCs are going to seek the services of a temple sooner or later, either for the sake of some magical blessing that can be had there or out of more secular interest in its wealth, employment opportunities, or suitability for plundering. The tables below allow you to roll one die of each type and assemble a serviceable shrine out of the results.

When considering the specifics of architectural design or decoration, you can lift the aesthetic of the surrounding culture and simply use that. If the faith is an export from a foreign land, however, it might use a different architectural lexicon, or use materials uncommon in the secular buildings there. Often there are particular structural quirks that quickly identify a building as sacred in its culture, such as purifying baths or ritual walls.

d6 What Do The Locals Think Of It?

- 1 It's held in contempt for its flaws and failings
- 2 Something about it is bothering the locals
- 3 The locals accept it as a tolerable shrine
- 4 It has a good and trustworthy reputation
- 5 It did something recently that gave it glory
- 6 It's held in utmost esteem by the locals

d8 Who Is In Charge There?

- 1 A venal time-server of desultory piety
- 2 A harried and inexperienced new leader
- 3 A dutiful minion of the local secular power
- 4 An incompetent shunted off to the post
- 5 A local prodigy of remarkable abilities
- 6 A grizzled and pragmatic leader
- 7 A charismatic but near-schismatic iconoclast
- 8 A practical and reasonably pious cleric

d10 What Particular Help Can It Provide?

- 1 They have considerable magical resources
- 2 They're unusually flush with cash
- 3 They own a lot of valuable goods or land
- 4 They have the ear of important locals
- 5 The local lord relies on them considerably
- 6 They have useful secular servants
- 7 They know a lot of useful secrets
- 8 They can get crimes or offenses forgiven
- 9 They are owed favors by other temples
- 10 They have a lot of well-armed followers

d4 How Big is the Temple?

- 1 Much smaller than most in a similar place
- 2 Shrunk from its former size
- 3 Normal for a temple of its importance
- 4 Unusually large or grand for its site

d12 What Problems Does It Have?

- 1 A rival faith is doing the temple real harm
- 2 The locals expect a miracle it can't provide
- 3 The leader is fighting with their superiors
- 4 A priest recently did something awful
- 5 The temple got into serious debt lately
- 6 Some disaster physically damaged the place
- 7 Some armed men have a grudge against it
- 8 The elite refuse to patronize it for some reason
- 9 It suffers signs of real divine displeasure
- 10 A sorcerer-priest is meddling with dark forces
- 11 A schismatic is drawing off its believers
- 12 Roll twice; one because of the other

d20 Particular Quirks About the Temple

- 1 It's built into a once-secular building
- 2 It's remarkably well-fortified
- 3 It's connected to a secular business
- 4 The clergy are largely related to each other
- 5 It's in an unusually dangerous location
- 6 It shares space with a friendly faith
- 7 It follows unusual prohibitions or rites
- 8 It has access to some ancient artifact
- 9 The library is remarkably extensive
- 10 It attracts prophets and religious merchants
- 11 It provides some illicit or scandalous service
- 12 It's more a merchant enterprise than a shrine
- 13 It's unusually beautifully-built
- 14 It's a shadow of a once-glorious past
- 15 It's unusually recent in its founding
- 16 The clergy generally hate each other there
- 17 Its leadership is foreign or demihuman
- 18 It deals only with the proven faithful
- 19 It displaced a former faith, perhaps violently
- 20 It actually is another faith, merely concealed



EVIL OR ANTAGONISTIC RELIGIONS

For many GMs, it hardly seems like a sword and sorcery campaign without a sprinkling of nefarious cults and a cackling evil high priest or two. Likewise, GMs of other genres often find it necessary to cook up the occasional evil deity and its host of cultist slaves.

While it's possible to create such faiths as simple plot devices, wicked for wickedness' sake and motivated by irrational zealotry alone, fleshing the faith's reasoning out a little bit further can sometimes produce more usable game content or a more abundant selection of plot hooks.

When you need an evil religion or a faith that's going to be antagonistic to the party's goals, it's worthwhile asking yourself some questions about it.

Most importantly, is this faith genuinely malevolent or is it just situationally opposed to the party's interests? The devotees of Kaaldruk the Iron-Horned might make it a point of religious zeal to murder any interloper who dares enter the taboo ruins of his sacred city, but otherwise the faith may be no more vicious or demanding than any other religion in the area. A party who finds themselves with a pack of Kaaldruk's holy slayers tracking them after their latest ruin expedition may have a negative opinion of the faith, but other locals might just shrug and figure the PCs brought it on themselves.

If the religion isn't really malicious or contrary to local moral codes then you can create it with the tools earlier in this section and just add whatever additional goals or strictures you need to put it crosswise with the PC party. If this religion really is a nefarious one, following heinous principles or obeying sinister powers, then a few more questions need to be answered.

THE REWARDS OF DAMNATION

What do the cultists get out of their service? Why does it seem a good idea to worship a tentacular abomination that hates all human life? Why are these believers rejecting the morals and values of their native culture to adhere to faith that rejects everything their families and society holds dear?

The irresistible will of a dark god or the convenient insanity of mind-blasted devotees are over-worn tropes often used to answer this question. Aside from being stale, they also don't give a GM much to work with; if the cultists are worshiping this dark god because they're crazy or mind-controlled, then there's no way to rationally predict their actions or assess their logical goals.

Instead, it is often better to apply more human reasons to the cultists, and give the more comprehensible rationales for their service. PCs who can recognize the logic behind the cult's service will be in a better position to deal with them and their plans.

Human motivations are also easier to integrate with the rest of the campaign. If the religion is giving the believers something valuable, then that reward will be something others will try to eliminate, exploit, or acquire for their own use.

d12 Rewards of the Sinister Faith

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | It savagely defends an otherwise oppressed or powerless group, requiring service as a price for this aid |
| 2 | The chosen among the believers are granted magical powers or occult gifts |
| 3 | The faith can bestow wealth and material prosperity on those who serve it |
| 4 | It allows an undead or undying state of eternal life for devout servitors |
| 5 | It gives practical protection against a plague, disaster, constant environmental hazard, or other threat against its believers |
| 6 | It provides political power through blackmail, bribery, vile favors, and other works in favor of its followers |
| 7 | Its principles are the comfortably established morals and beliefs of its hereditary believers, as much as they hide them from outsiders |
| 8 | It provides intense physical pleasures or sensory delights that its believers normally would never get to taste |
| 9 | It provides muscle to its faithful followers, letting them murder, beat, or terrorize those who stand against them |
| 10 | It justifies their worst impulses and gives a divine rationale to a vicious, depraved subculture the believers belong to |
| 11 | It promises salvation from an impending catastrophe that will be unleashed on all unbelievers. |
| 12 | It gives its outcast adherents a sense of meaning, importance, and power with its terrible majesty and awful splendor |

If the faith has an open, public presence in a society, it probably is offering some of the same practical benefits that a more temperate religion provides. The tables on the prior page can be used to give a hint about what the dark cult means to its more casual adherents.

A savage blood god who grants inhuman might to its fiercest devotees might simply be a useful war god to rank-and-file believers. They may not have any moral objection to the hideous rituals the elect perform to get their unholy power, but the price of it may be more than they care to pay. Instead, they simply pray to the god for success in battle.

The more widespread the faith, the more likely it is that its most extreme qualities are reserved to its clergy, its most zealous lay believers, or to the more fundamentalist sub-sects of the religion. Outer-circle believers may praise this exemplary piety, but the practical concerns of ordinary life are likely to discourage less dedicated believers from sacrificing so much to their eldritch lord.

ONE-ROLL MALEVOLENT CULT

Most antagonistic religions are built for a particular purpose: a GM needs sentient enemies in some ancient ruined temple, a dark mastermind is needed for some nefarious plot, or a savage land needs some suitably bloodthirsty religions for its people. The prior table can give a GM some ideas about what the faith is offering its believers, but a few more details are often needed to put something usable together.

The tables below let you roll one die of each type to get a general overview of the sinister faith. They assume that the cult is proscribed in the nation or otherwise viewed with dismay by decent people and so forced to remain in hiding. If you're generating an evil faith that can openly function in a land, then just read the table results in light of that public acceptability.

d6 What General Goal Do They Have?

- 1 Glorify their dark god and its vile ways
- 2 Expand the cult in an adjacent community
- 3 Destroy a powerful enemy of the cult
- 4 Extinguish a rival faith and their clergy
- 5 Perform a terrible magical ritual
- 6 Obtain secular control over an area

d8 What's So Horrible About the Faith?

- 1 Unbelievers are to be killed on principle
- 2 Hideous appetites of the flesh are sacred
- 3 Unholy entities from beyond must be called
- 4 Unbelievers are cattle to be used as desired
- 5 The world must die to make room for the god
- 6 Secular civilization must be destroyed
- 7 All law but the cult's must be overthrown
- 8 The god demands a terrible nourishment

d10 How Do the Clergy Enforce Their Will?

- 1 Magical curses scourge the disobedient
- 2 Blackmail and threats of social ruin
- 3 Murder by cult enforcers and monsters
- 4 Mental compulsions implanted by rituals
- 5 Kidnapping before a hideous ritual death
- 6 Traitors are betrayed to cult enemies
- 7 Violence against a traitor's loved ones
- 8 The dark god's divine wrath smites them
- 9 Control of an addictive thing they need
- 10 Lay believers gain glory by purging traitors

d4 How Unified is the Cult?

- 1 Completely united behind its leadership
- 2 Obedient to leaders who sometimes quarrel
- 3 Tenuously balanced factions cooperate
- 4 Badly fractious under many rival priests

d12 What Problems Does It Have?

- 1 The leadership is insane in unhelpful ways
- 2 It caught the eye of a dangerous enemy
- 3 One of its servitor monsters is out of control
- 4 It's running low on sacrifices and slaves
- 5 It's been impoverished by a recent trouble
- 6 There's a dangerous schism in its ranks
- 7 Its god is making unreasonable demands
- 8 The laity is demanding much from the priests
- 9 The enforcers are muscling their clerical lords
- 10 The god's influence has become distant
- 11 An important member has turned traitor
- 12 Another dark faith is warring with it

d20 Specific Traits of the Cult

- 1 It favors monstrous body alterations
- 2 It's a remnant of a now-dead culture
- 3 It has a variety of potent ancient artifacts
- 4 It's a sect of a better-known public faith
- 5 It cuts secret deals with the ruling class
- 6 It has a totemic beast or monster type
- 7 They live where normal people couldn't
- 8 They're cannibals or other gustatory deviants
- 9 They have agents in other religious groups
- 10 They were thought to be wiped out in the past
- 11 A subculture of the land is friendly to it
- 12 It employs technology-like magics
- 13 It has a lot of servitor monsters obedient to it
- 14 An area is tacitly understood to belong to it
- 15 It was once a public and powerful faith
- 16 It has open sympathizers among the great
- 17 It's thought to hold back some awful doom
- 18 They only look like humans
- 19 The visible part of the cult is but a fraction of it
- 20 They serve a purpose that no longer obtains



PLACING RUINS AND POINTS OF INTEREST

Some campaigns revolve almost exclusively around courtly intrigue, urban adventures, or quests through uninhabited wilderness. Most, however, need at least a modest sprinkling of ruins, Deeps, lost temples, hidden lairs, and other “dungeon”-like places of adventure.

As a general rule, you should only worry about placing ruins at the kingdom level of your campaign. Famous sites of adventure might exist elsewhere in the setting, and legendary ruins might be well-known to scholars, but the only ruins you really need to worry about are the ones your players could conceivably want to go adventure in for their next session without crossing half the region to get to them. In addition, local ruins are the ones most likely to be causing problems for the natives and creating situations that require adventurers to help resolve their woes.

ESTABLISHING RUINS

As a rough guideline, start with a half-dozen ruins for the average-sized kingdom. These are not the only ancient remnants in the area, but they’re the most famous or significant. There’s nothing stopping you from planting a minor Deep a half-day’s march outside your starting village, but places of that scale are so small or obscure that only the locals are likely to know about them. These six initial ruins are names familiar throughout the kingdom.

If you don’t have your own ideas about what these ruins are, use the adjacent tables or those on page 238. GMs using the Gyre setting might roll on the Gyre-specific table, while those building for a more standard fantasy setting might use the general one.

Look at your kingdom map and identify the usual paths of travel between its major settlements. Usually this will be by water whenever practical, or along the flattest and safest land routes. Identify the empty spaces in the kingdom that lie between these major traffic routes, places where only rural villages or howling wilderness exist.

Now place each ruin in one of the empty spaces, choosing locations appropriate to their nature. A ruined city was probably on a river or coast, or else at a good ancient trade nexus. A forgotten fortress guarded a once-vital military strongpoint. A Deep might have breached the surface almost anywhere, while a raider lair is almost certainly close enough to a traffic route to pillage it. Roll a pair of Ruin Tags from page 190 to give it character.

Finally, write a sentence or two of description about the ruin. You don’t actually need to flesh it out or turn it into an actual adventure site with the tools starting on page 222. All you need is to know it’s there, and to think about what kind of problems or opportunities it might present to its neighbors. If the PCs decide they really want to check the place out, then you can spend the downtime between sessions turning it into a real adventure site.

d12 Places Specific to the Latter Earth

- 1 An abandoned Outsider outpost, possibly with a hazardous local environment
- 2 A Deep long since abandoned
- 3 An alien xenoforming complex, possibly with a surrounding *arratu*
- 4 A relic-palace of a vanished sorcerer-king
- 5 A city once inhabited by not-quite-humans
- 6 A megastructure of now-irrelevant purpose
- 7 An old stronghold of hostile Outsiders or of antagonistic demihumans
- 8 Massive monument complex dedicated to a vanished kingdom, god, or ethnic group
- 9 Fortress raised by a dead sorcerer-king, lost empire, or militant faith
- 10 Wizard’s lair once or presently inhabited by powerful and dangerous sorcerer
- 11 Roll twice on 1d10; the first roll was built on top of or in the ruins of the second roll
- 12 Roll again, but now inhabited by bandits, exiles, hostile refugees, or other interlopers

d20 General Places of Adventure

- 1 A lost temple to a dead god
- 2 Ruins of an ancient city
- 3 Cavernous tunnels and strange geology
- 4 Ruined fortress of a former empire
- 5 Town ruins swept away by some disaster
- 6 Lair of a legendary beast or monster
- 7 Wizard’s tower or complex
- 8 Failed colony or forward outpost
- 9 Prison-pit to shackle a dangerous power
- 10 Pilgrimage site for a lost religion
- 11 Nexus point for otherworldly powers
- 12 Mortuary complex for a lost people
- 13 Stronghold of exiles, rebels, or invaders
- 14 City or settlement of dangerous nonhumans
- 15 Subterranean settlement or complex
- 16 Abandoned pleasure-palace of a ruler
- 17 Lost fortified bridge or crossing-point
- 18 Sinister ruined estate of a former lord
- 19 Roll again; now inhabited by interlopers
- 20 Roll twice; one built on top of the other

LOCATION TAGS

The work of creating interesting places and memorable campaign elements can be exhausting to a GM. Even when following the pattern provided in this book, the need to generate thumbnails of a dozen different cities, ruins, wilderness features, or other places of interest can frustrate and weary a creator. It becomes difficult to come up with new ideas about each new place or give them some sense of distinction.

Tags are a creative tool meant to ease the GM's burden by assigning each point of interest a pair of characteristic qualities or tropes. These two tags are then blended together and the result gives the GM a better idea of what the place is about and what kind of adventure opportunities are to be found there. Each tag is made up of five different elements, each with three different examples provided.

Enemies are antagonists characteristic of the trope. They're exemplary villains or troublemakers that can be responsible for whatever unhappy situation exists that needs adventurers to help sort it out. They may not be the worst or more dangerous denizens of the place, but they're vexing enough to make trouble for the natives.

Friends are sympathetic or appealing NPCs that the players might be expected to want to help or cooperate with. They're the locals who are most likely to seek out adventurers for help or otherwise provide the hook for getting involved in a situation. The examples provide likely Friends for each tag, but the GM can tweak them to better suit the known interests and inclinations of the players.

Complications are particular twists or difficulties that are characteristic of the trope. They may be partial inversions of the tag, or complexities that it layers onto a situation, or subversions of likely player expectations. Complications are meant to keep problems from being too straightforward and simply resolved without having to deal with the complexities of the place.

Things are macguffins, treasures, rewards, or plunder that might be found at the site, objects that the Enemies or Friends might be fighting over or that might be part of a Complication's entanglements. While a pile of loot is usually enough to catch the eye of any adventurer, a Thing is something specific to the tag's theme.

Places are archetypal locations or characteristic structures for the tag, the kind of places you'd expect to adventure in were you in such a place. Other Places can be used as thematic backdrops for an adventure.

For each point of interest, two tags are rolled and the results are synthesized together when the GM needs a component for their adventure creation. If the tags for a community are Brilliant Innovation and Lawless Class and the GM needs an antagonist, they might pick "Cruelly indulgent elite" and "Grasping guildmaster" from those tags' Enemies lists and blend them together. Thus emerges Theophilus Crane, the ruthless, selfish Thurian

guildmaster of the Arcanocaloric Guild, whose crucial advances in repairing thermal Workings have made him and his guildmates above the law in his native city. In the same vein, the "visionary supporter of the innovator" and "victim of an unpunishable crime" elements of the Friends lists can be turned into Hubert Wheelwright, Crane's brilliant apprentice and the true originator of the techniques that Crane stole, now hiding in terror from his former master's hired assassins.

Whenever you need some set dressing or adventure components for your points of interest, just go to the tags and mix up something that fits them. Some tags will be harder to mesh than others, of course. You could simply reroll them, or instead take some time to figure out a way in which the results actually do apply. Another option is to read one or both of the tags metaphorically, translating the general concept into terms applicable to the situation.

There are four different sets of tags in this section, each one aimed at a different kind of point of interest. While the sets are all aimed at their particular targets, it's quite possible for a GM to mix and match out of any of the sections, either reading them metaphorically or coming up with novel explanations for a literal interpretation. GMs who have access to other Sine Nomine games that involve tags, such as Stars Without Number, should feel free to mix them in as well if they want additional grist.

Community tags are for cities, villages, tribes, subterranean survivor bands, or other broad grouping of people. They give traits that distinguish the community from others like it; they may gesture at its organization or social structure, but the point is to explain what about the place might provide adventure grist for the GM.

Court tags are for noble courts, temple hierarchies, business enterprises, dynastic families, insular clans, or other groups where intrigue, personal relationships, and conflicting goals are apt to be found. People in a court want things and they're likely to be looking to recruit outsiders to help.

Ruin tags are for classical dungeons, lost cities, Outsider ruins, mysterious towers, or other sites where sneaking down corridors and checking for traps are usual adventurer pastimes. They'll help you add flavor to your holes in the ground or piles of cracked masonry.

Wilderness tags are for natural hazards, dangerous lands, remote motherlodes, wild beast territories, and other sorts of encounters or points of interest that might draw an adventurer's attention. They're often useful in filling up a hexcrawl, allowing a GM to plant points of interest in the deep wilderness without having to load it up with an endless parade of villages or minor dungeons.

Each section provides some additional tables and guidance, the better to assist you in using the tags to their full effect. As always, you should take what you need from those tools, using only the ones that you need and adjusting things as your creativity recommends.



COMMUNITIES

While Courts provide tightly-connected webs of relationships for the PCs to entangle themselves in, Communities serve more as adventure backdrops for the heroes, or contexts in which other adventures occur. The particular heroics of the party might significantly change the Community, and the needs and situations of the place might present immediate adventure hooks to them, but the existence of a market town does not serve as the same blatant predicate for adventure that a lost Deep offers.

Most often, Communities serve as the sandboxes in which urban-focused or intrigue-based adventures can occur. For many players, the default mode of interaction in the wilderness or the underworld is combat; in a city or village, that default instinct is going to be conversation. Sudden, brutal violence is by no means alien to a city, but most PCs will be much less inclined to pull their swords on a surly town guardsman than on an Anak warrior.

The resources in this section include both a list of Community tags and a set of tables that can be used to flesh out and characterize particular settlements. While you could optionally choose to use one, both, or neither, they're built to work cooperatively.

To characterize the Community, decide whether it's best considered a rural village, a significant city, or a tribal or provisional gathering of people. Using the appropriate table, find out the basic rationale for the settlement's ex-

istence first; this will tell you a great deal about the kind of locals you'll be finding in the Community and what their chief employments and interests are likely to be.

From there, you can roll or pick to find out who actually runs the Community. This may or may not be the nominal head. The central government might say that the leader of a farming hamlet is the government-appointed headman, but everyone in the village might know that Mother Orde is the one who decides what they're going to do when a problem arises. Tension between real and nominal leadership can make for useful adventure grist.

The "significant locals" column can be used to generate a few NPC hooks for those occasions when you need a suitable local face for your adventure or an NPC you can hang a hook on. The "current pressing problem" is an immediate situation you can color with Community tags or use straight. If you mean to make an adventure hook out of it, be sure it's something the PCs can reasonably influence with their involvement.

For delivery of adventure hooks, the two bottom tables suggest potential local NPCs who might approach the party and some ideas for what the natives could offer by way of payment. These suggestions will be colored by the Community tags and the Friends or Things that are suitable to the Community's situation. As with all the tables, they should be taken as suggestions for you to shape.



RURAL VILLAGES

These tools can be used for the typical medieval-flavored village or rural hamlet beloved of many adventures. Such places are at usually at least minimally self-sufficient. Villages in relatively sophisticated nations might have permanent shops or full-time artisans working a particular trade, but most such hamlets have their entire population engaged in agriculture, with specialists doing particular crafting jobs as their neighbors might need them. Coinage is usually scarce and reserved for use with outside tax collectors and hired workers, as the local trade deals in tacitly-understood favors owed and granted.

While such villages are often very poor, it's not unknown for them to have at least some valuable goods or trades hindered by the village's great remoteness, complete lack of fame, or inability to safely get the good to a market that has a demand for it.

d12 Rationale for the Village's Existence

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Once a garrison outpost of a nation |
| 2 | A mine or quarry, perhaps now exhausted |
| 3 | A spot where refugees of a calamity settled |
| 4 | Holy ground or a temple to a particular faith |
| 5 | A plant or animal grows very well here |
| 6 | It's a safe waypost on a trade route |
| 7 | Refuge for a despised minority or group |
| 8 | A bandit camp that went legitimate |
| 9 | A self-ruled home for demihuman residents |
| 10 | It's a safe base for salvage or ruin plundering |
| 11 | Decayed remnant of an ancient city |
| 12 | It grew up around a lordly manor or estate |

Features of the Village

d12	Who Runs It?	Significant Locals	A Current Pressing Problem
1	A hereditary headman	The village harlot	Vital food stores have been lost or stolen
2	A reeve picked by a lord	The worst local bully	Two families are in a long-running feud
3	A temple representative	A gifted young peasant	A new religion is making trouble with the old
4	A council of elders	A half-savage shepherd	The lord's reeve has been given unreasonable quotas
5	A cruel and feared bully	A charismatic priest	An upstart newcomer is disrupting the native hierarchy
6	A popularly-chosen chief	A major landowner	A socially marginal family is suspected of crimes
7	A dreaded sorcerer	A youth who wants out	A dangerous beast or foe is lurking near the place
8	A pragmatic warlord	Venerable old farmer	A local bully and his friends are causing trouble
9	The richest native there	Criminal in rural hiding	The crops or herds are in very poor condition
10	A traditional squire	Native hedge mage	An ambiguous land dispute is getting bloody
11	A patriarch or matriarch	A noble's local reeve	A curse or magical woe is vexing the people
12	An organization's envoy	Important artisan	Noble quarrels have caused collateral damage

Village Involvements with Adventurers

d12	Local Likely to Interact with Adventurers	Interesting Things the Place Can Offer Heroes
1	An ambitious local who wants to get to the city	An unusually large amount of saved coinage
2	Social outcast who can't ask any local for help	Valuable local specialty product
3	Gentry who wants no local gossip about their need	Heirloom magic item passed down to the leader
4	Ex-city dweller eager for contact with the worldly	A magical service unique to a local tradition
5	Comparatively rich villager with a need	A map or secret leading to a Deep or plunder site
6	Starry-eyed young local swooning for adventurers	A temple with potent healing magics available
7	Village priest in need of outside help	A secret treasure acquired generations ago
8	Reeve who can't reasonably call on natives for a job	Large amounts of produce or local products
9	Village leader who wants expendable help	Ownership of an abandoned farm or structure
10	Burly local militiaman who watches new faces here	Contacts with rural bandits or criminal rings
11	Shifty native who wants some clueless accomplices	Favors from the lord who's very fond of the village
12	Clan patriarch who doesn't want to use their own kin	Young locals willing to take service with the party



MAJOR CITIES

A village is largely self-sufficient and organized around the production of basic necessities. A city, whether a market town or a grand megalopolis, is a place that lives off the produce of tributary communities and produces goods and services of a sophistication far beyond that possible in a small village. These tables can be used for modest market centers or major urban sites, with details being scaled to fit the size of the city.

Cities need a constant flow of food from the surrounding countryside, and not uncommonly a constant flow of new citizens from the villages to make up for the death rate brought about by plagues, malnutrition, and endemic diseases. Only the richest and most advanced urban centers can escape this entropic drain, often with the help of still-operational ancient Workings. Cities are the places most likely to still maintain these great edifices.

d12 Rationale for the City's Existence

1	It's the former seat of a vanished nation
2	It's a trade nexus that has greatly prospered
3	It's an industrial or productive center
4	There is heavy resource extraction nearby
5	It controls a vital defensive point
6	It's built around an ancient Working
7	It's a stronghold of a local subculture
8	It's a sacred city to an important faith
9	It's a shared market for many villages
10	It's a place of great beauty or healthfulness
11	It's a shelter from dangerous environs
12	The natives are somehow bound here

Features of the City

d12	Who Runs It?	Significant Locals	A Current Pressing Problem
1	Hereditary lord	Sinister crime boss	Raiders are scourging local trade routes
2	Merchant prince	Head of a major temple	Criminals have corrupted the local law enforcement
3	Council of oligarchs	Neighborhood patriarch	Displeased locals are rioting for some reason
4	Allied noble heads	Ethnic group elder	The king or local ruler is making harsh demands
5	Royal viceroy	Rich merchant	Food supplies aren't being received as they should
6	Gentry-elected mayor	Feared local mage	Urban groups are arming to resolve some dire conflict
7	Major clerical figure	City watch chief	A recent calamity has done major infrastructure damage
8	Occult power wielder	Decadent noble	A disguised monster is feeding on the city from within
9	Criminal group catspaw	Local magistrate	The rulers have gravely offended a local religion
10	Ethnic group's ruler	Outcast group leader	A rebel group denounces the city leader's legitimacy
11	Chief magistrate	Famous courtesan	A private war threatens with another major city
12	Military strongman	Demihuman enclave head	A major local industry is threatened by events

City Involvements with Adventurers

d12	Local Likely to Interact with Adventurers	Interesting Things the Place Can Offer Heroes
1	City official looking for deniable agents	Large amounts of conventional coinage
2	Wealthy merchant who wants unknown outside help	Expensive urban property
3	Newcomer peasant haplessly looking for assistance	Sophisticated and very valuable local products
4	Demimonde navigator always watching for clients	Formal citizenship and the rights of a local
5	Curious urchin who trades in local news and events	Quiet dismissal of criminal charges or sinister pasts
6	Criminal with a mind to use naive newcomers	Indulgences beyond the power a smaller place to grant
7	Desperate merchant trying to keep their business going	Services of exceptionally skilled specialist professionals
8	Guard chief suspicious of potential troublemakers	Connections with major nobility of the realm
9	Native too infamous for other locals to deal with them	Absentee ownership of rural villages or manors
10	Noble who thinks adventurers will do anything for coin	Rare occult components or magical products
11	Slumming young gentry with a taste for excitement	Blessings from major clergy or high priests
12	Foreigner looking for fellow strangers to help	Business monopolies or tax rights in certain areas

TRIBES AND EXILES

Not all communities are neatly delineated by fields and city walls. Nomadic tribes, scruffy bandit camps, groups of underground Deep survivors, or Blighted warbands all constitute communities. They may be far poorer and more materially primitive than even a farming village, but they have some sort of social structure and self-identity. While some may be violent by nature or habit, more peaceful interactions are usually possible for PCs.

These tables are meant for the sort of barbarian tribals, desperate bandit dregs, and subterranean survivors that an adventuring band is likely to run into at some point in their travels. The basic dynamics of these societies are usually similar, ones based on raw force, personal charisma, and the prospect of plunder or good hunting. Particular roles or details can be reskinned to fit the specifics of the tribe and its environment.

d12 Why Are They Staying Here?

1	It's an unusually well-fortified safe place
2	A charismatic leader bound them together
3	The hunting or resources are very good here
4	They were driven here by a dire enemy
5	Seers or shamans said it was ordained
6	The leadership wants to find something here
7	Their herds or prey have led them here
8	They've been trapped here by the situation
9	They're paralyzed by internal dissent
10	They've been paid or induced to be here
11	Tradition requires they come here
12	Here they can do the most damage to a foe

Features of the Tribe

d12	Who Runs It?	Significant Locals	A Current Pressing Problem
1	Bestially savage tyrant	Best hunter in the tribe	The leader is becoming weak or acting foolishly
2	Wizened elder	Wise man or woman	A settled group is hunting them as mortal foes
3	Magically-gifted chief	Seer or shaman	A curse has been laid on them for some collective sin
4	Holy man or woman	Tribal artisan	They killed someone who had very powerful allies
5	Hereditary chieftain	Skilled scout	They're impoverished and can't reach new resources
6	Outsider or alien lord	Trader with outsiders	A fearsome beast hunts them in the wilds
7	Brutal but cunning chief	Adopted member	Their gods are sending dire but obscure omens to them
8	Foreigner turned ruler	Tribal slave	The tribe threatens to split under some feud or quarrel
9	Council of the elders	Feared troublemaker	Some are seeking a redder, more powerful god to serve
10	No ruler past clan heads	Tribe's most eligible youth	A patron power is using them as expendable fodder
11	Envoy of a patron power	Barely-tolerated wretch	A sickness is raging through the tribe
12	Most charismatic native	Cunning tribal advisor	A rival group has taken over their hunting grounds

Tribal Involvements with Adventurers

d12	Local Likely to Interact with Adventurers	Interesting Things the Place Can Offer Heroes
1	Raid-taken slave looking for a way back home	Guidance and safe passage through their territory
2	Leader with a natural suspicion about outsiders	Knowledge of a hidden place of wealth
3	Low-status native trying to acquire outside support	Exotic and valuable tribal goods
4	Tribal sage who likes news of the outside world	Plunder taken from a foreigner they've killed
5	Curious young tribal interested in strangers	Inherited relic or treasure they've kept
6	Near-outcast who wants a hand with some revenge	Secret for accessing an otherwise sealed place
7	Envoy of another group suspicious of other influences	Loot won in battle against another group
8	Tribal notable who suspects the PCs as potential rivals	They'll raid the party's enemies for a share of the loot
9	Tribal trader who wants access to outside goods	A magical elixir or substance they know how to make
10	Youth determined to show how tribal ways are best	Tribal membership and a place of respect
11	Eligible native looking for new blood in a mate	Slaves they've taken in raids or tribal wars
12	Reformer or innovator whose kindred won't listen	Some young tribals willing to go with the party



COMMUNITY TAGS

Community tags provide adventure grist for any location where a significant number of people have to work together for survival. While the classic “grimy medieval city” or “rural dirt-farmer hamlet” are both archetypal communities, this heading could also include monasteries, isolated ideological groups, subcultures within a larger society, or any other mass of people that lack the implicit hierarchy and shared organization of a Court.

As with the other tags, Community tags should be read as broad strokes and general directions for your creativity rather than a strict description of reality. It can be useful to think about them in a metaphorical sense as well as a purely literal one; maybe the *Monstrous Tribute* that the community is offering is its docile sacrifice of young men to a brutal lord’s meatgrinder border wars.

Two well-blended tags are usually sufficient to give character to any single community. If you’re building a subculture of a particular community, you might choose to roll a third tag, pair it with one of the first two, and then pit it in some sort of opposition or conflict with

the second of the original tags. This conflict or division is what gives the subculture its identity or present focus of effort.

Community tags are particularly susceptible to being altered by the actions of the PCs. It’s not beyond impossibility for an adventuring band to completely overturn the power structure or internal politics of even a good-sized city, let alone a humble farming thorp. If this happens, be ready to pull the negated tag and apply something that makes sense as a consequence or derived outcome of the PCs’ actions. It’s almost impossible for a mere band of adventurers to quell all conflict and struggle in a human community, but they can at least shift the terms of the fights to something they find more palatable.

Major projects as described on page 336 might be used to significantly change a Community’s character or situation. Careful manipulation of existing power bases and the enlisting of useful outside aid can combine with heroic deeds of might to completely alter the existing power balance of a place.

d100	Tag	d100	Tag
1–2	Ancient Infrastructure	51–52	Magical Academy
3–4	Bad Neighbors	53–54	Martial Tradition
5–6	Blood Feud	55–56	Miserable Penury
7–8	Brilliant Innovation	57–58	Mistreated Blighted
9–10	Broken Spirits	59–60	Monstrous Tribute
11–12	Corrupt Laws	61–62	Neglectful Ruler
13–14	Criminal Bosses	63–64	New Industry
15–16	Cultural Center	65–66	Pilgrimage Site
17–18	Cursed Circumstances	67–68	Plagued City
19–20	Decadent Locals	69–70	Population Boom
21–22	Decaying Working	71–72	Raider Scourge
23–24	Demihuman Populace	73–74	Rebel Stronghold
25–26	Dueling Lords	75–76	Rigid Castes
27–28	Enemy Within	77–78	Scars of War
29–30	Faded Remnant	79–80	Seat of Rule
31–32	Fallen Prosperity	81–82	Secret Treachery
33–34	Foreign Enclave	83–84	Sinking City
35–36	Guild Oligarchy	85–86	Theocratic Authorities
37–38	Heavy Fortification	87–88	Toxic Economy
39–40	Hidden Ruler	89–90	Trade Hub
41–42	Hostile Terrain	91–92	Unique Product
43–44	Incompetent Leaders	93–94	Upstart Faith
45–46	Inherited Architecture	95–96	Warring Council
47–48	Inhuman Cooperation	97–98	Widespread Prosperity
49–50	Lawless Class	99–00	Xenophobic Locals

Ancient Infrastructure

The community still has access to some sort of functioning ancient infrastructure, whether it's an array of wall-mounted arcane energy projectors, running water, moving roadways, community-wide climate control, or some other inherited luxury. This infrastructure may be the result of a still-functional Working, or it could be the product of some venerable occult engine that's still operational, or it may be the fruit of the labors of some specially-designed organism or Blighted populace.

- E** Abusive ruler overusing the infrastructure, Foreign agent seeking to cause havoc, Reckless sorcerer seeking to steal its power
- F** Harried chief of the maintainers, Fascinated foreign scholar, Merchant reliant on its use
- C** The infrastructure's cruelly-costly maintenance is coming up, The infrastructure is starting to fray, The infrastructure was actually meant for a much more sinister purpose
- T** Irreplaceable infrastructure component, Spare parts worth vast sums on the market, Secret artifact that can control the infrastructure
- P** Dangerously energetic working zone, Secret hideout inside the infrastructure, Sanctified and holy control center

Blood Feud

Two or more groups of citizens within the community hate each other. Their neighbors or the local law have kept things from too-overt violence, but members of the groups will constantly interfere with their rivals and cause whatever misery they can get away with. This hate may spring from recent events, or it may be an inherited spite from old wrongs.

- E** Wholly unsympathetic group leader, Schemer seeking to exploit the feud, Ruler going to brutal excess to tamp it down
- F** Reluctant participant in the feud, Local digging for the real truth of the quarrel, Merchant who'd profit by a new peace
- C** The groups were formerly the closest of allies, One group is favored by local rulers, One side is getting completely out of hand
- T** A treasure the groups are fighting over, Object of exculpating evidence, Lost symbol of peaceful unity
- P** Bloody back alleyway, Sabotaged business, Group-dominated tavern

Bad Neighbors

The community has a conflict with a neighboring community. This usually isn't part of a larger war, but is instead a personal animosity between them. It may be the community has suffered at their enemy's hands, or they may have been the ones applying the suffering. Constant low-level skirmishes and troublemaking go on between the two.

- E** Foreign lord profiting by the quarrel, Bitter zealot who demands violent action, Real culprit seeking to hide their offense
- F** Despairing peacemaker of a shared faith, Local with family from the rival, Frustrated but helpless ruler
- C** One side seems at fault but is actually less blameworthy, The rulers of both use the quarrel to distract their populace, It was a minor dispute that is spiraling out of control
- T** Proof of the culprit's guilt, Weapons cache meant to start real bloodshed, Treasure that would erase the cause of the dispute
- P** Dangerous no-man's-land between the communities, Burnt home of a sympathizer, Religious festival turned into a semi-riot

Brilliant Innovation

Some local has come up with a wonderful new idea; it may be a magical innovation, a new industrial process, a new agricultural product, a new use for what was thought to be ancient garbage, or some other very useful, profitable idea. Everyone around them is fighting for the chance to exploit this clever new plan.

- E** Grasping guildmaster, Overbearing local ruler, Local leader whose power is threatened by the innovation
- F** Visionary supporter of the innovator, Outside merchant seeking to profit by enabling the innovation, Local leader whose constituency would profit from it
- C** The innovation requires ingredients only adventurers can get, The innovation is riskier than it seems, The innovator is actually a con artist
- T** Critical component for the innovation, Trove of profit from the innovation's test run, Vital planning and design documents
- P** Ambitious test zone for the innovation, Guildhall of upset locals, Tavern with locals fighting over the change



Broken Spirits

The locals are in a state of despair and dull apathy. They've lost the things that used to give them pride and hope, with the best among them carrying on out of habitual duty and the worst giving ready hands to shameful deeds and ignoble acts. No one really believes the future can be better, and most seek only to satisfy immediate appetites.

- E** Cruel tyrant who broke them, Slaver trading on the hopeless, Merchant of despair and its costly escapes
- F** Determined young local leader, Proud old rememberer of better days, Furious rebel against the world
- C** An outside power wants to keep them safely broken, Their fall was due to their own sins and errors, They could be very dangerous if they regain their spirit
- T** Symbolic item of former glory, Resources to kick-start a new source of pride, Treasure laid up in splendid times
- P** Crumbling monument to a past victory, "Wealthy" town area that's shabby and ill-kept, Empty temple to a once-loved god

Criminal Bosses

One or more crime bosses have a powerful influence on the community. They may control crime within the community itself, or they may use it simply as a safe haven from which to direct their minions elsewhere. Local law enforcement may know all about them, but lack the strength to confront them and their paid or intimidated henchmen.

- E** Blatantly overt criminal chief, Well-controlled head of law enforcement, Crime boss bent on using the PCs as catspaws
- F** Victim of an untouchable boss, Determined bounty hunter, Ambitious criminal seeking to make room above
- C** The crime boss' support is what keeps the community prosperous, Local government is almost openly staffed by cartel members, The locals will deal with PC troublemakers for fear of the boss' anger
- T** A boss' secret stash of wealth, A treasure stolen elsewhere and brought here by a boss, Evidence proving one boss is betraying another
- P** Uncharacteristically opulent home in the slums, Sleepy law enforcement headquarters, Dangerous tavern for local minions

Corrupt Laws

What law exists here is for sale, or does not apply to certain favored groups or castes. While some degree of corruption and noble license exists almost everywhere, this community lacks any shred of impartiality. Strangers might be fleeced by local lawmen, evildoers can be absolved by a payment, and powerful gentry do as they please.

- E** Immensely venal magistrate, Local lord who fails to see any problem with the "natural" order, Crime boss taking blatant advantage of the corruption
- F** A crusading law enforcer, Royal investigating censor, Victim of a cruel injustice
- C** The favored class are vital to the community's security, The natives would rather pay predictable bribes than risk facing real justice, The real law is enforced by a secret group of natives
- T** An uncollected pile of bribe money, Stolen goods yet unsold, Blackmail evidence on the chief magistrate
- P** A courtroom where the law is sold, Crime scene with an unconcerned criminal, Site of brutal vigilante justice

Cultural Center

The community produces some wonderful cultural artifact or trains famous artists. The product might be some exceptional cloth, or artistic luxury good, or the scholarly fruits of a famous academy. Trained artists might be students of a particular school, or the apprentices of the current masters of a long artistic tradition who dwell here.

- E** Master artist who suffers no rivals, "Visionary" who wants to tear down the old art for their own new one, Merchant who is trying to control the production for profit
- F** Ambitious young artist of profound talent, Wild genius of very difficult temperament, Aged master proud of his tradition
- C** The art requires resources that are running low, Some other group is cheaply and poorly mimicking the art, Their main market has somehow been cut off
- T** A famous and ancient work of art, An art object made of some priceless substance, An art object encoded with a precious secret
- P** Busy studio or academy hall, Mercantile emporium where the cultural products are traded, Renegade artist's hovel

Cursed Circumstances

The community has been cursed with some blight that makes life difficult, albeit not impossible. An offended sorcerer's vengeful Working, an outraged god's wrath, a local distortion of the Legacy, or a simple history of bad feng shui in the area may have brought the curse about. If you include this tag, you'll want to devise not only the curse, but the reason why the locals haven't left for better lands.

- E** Charlatan offering false hope, Local demagogue blaming a useful culprit, Native profiting from the curse
- F** Scholar seeking details of the blight, Stubborn curse survivor, Aspiring curse-lifter with a secret weapon
- C** It has a profitable side effect, It was meant to be a blessing, It can be aimed by willing conspirators
- T** A personal anti-curse ward, Hidden wealth of a curse victim, A means to lift the curse
- P** Enterprise blighted by the curse, Festival held to pray for mercy, Ruin of a curse victim's home

Decaying Working

A great magical Working has been a critical part of the community since its creation, but now it's beginning to decay. It may function only intermittently, now, or its effects may have curdled into something double-edged. The locals have no idea how to fix it, and indeed, it may not be possible to repair it with modern knowledge of sorcery.

- E** Saboteur from an enemy community, Scavenger stealing critical components, Overconfident wizard attempting a ruinous repair
- F** One of the Working's hereditary keepers, Native dependent on the Working's effects, Desperate researcher of repairs
- C** Part of the community would greatly profit by the Working's failure, The Working risks catastrophic eruption, The rulers punish any talk of it failing
- T** A critical repair text for the Working, Valuable broken Working components, Precious resources crystallized from the Working's energies
- P** Control nexus for the Working, Enterprise dependent on the Working, Site of a Working failure or accident

Decadent Locals

The locals enjoy repulsive vices and shameful appetites. They may have religious sanction for their evils, or neighbors might trade with them for such things, or they could be followers of some ideology that blesses such pursuits. Their economy or their social organization is usually heavily reliant on such traffic, and to ensure its continuance they may have made bargains with things worse than humans.

- E** Trader in hideous sins, Bored gentry in search of a cruel thrill, Once-prey that has become an even worse predator
- F** Local who has secret doubts about the vice, Crusader from outside, Escaped victim seeking vengeance
- C** The victims of the vice are a class or type that their neighbors don't care about in the slightest, They have ways to make their vices give them power, Their society is attractive aside from this hideous urge
- T** A stolen victim of great value to someone else, Proof of an outside noble's trade with them, Precious regalia used in the vice
- P** Salon of hideous beauty, Stinking slave pit, Mundane locale of ordinary business tainted by their evil

Demihuman Populace

A particular breed of demihuman are either the majority here or have the dominant positions in the community. Architecture, local laws, and social customs are all tuned to suit them, and they may not be particularly forgiving or friendly to humans. Communities that are not outright independent usually make an arm's-length submission to a local lord.

- E** Demihuman official who grudges baselines, Baseline local who grudges the demihumans, Outsider preying on the demihumans
- F** Curious young native, Canny local diplomat to humans, Native with a need for baseline help
- C** Their human suzerain wants to erase all independence from them, Something's legal here that's forbidden in baseline communities but natural to them, Their independence is enforced with something they have
- T** Precious demihuman-made goods, Ancient relic revered by the natives, Wealth of a prosperous outside trader
- P** Holy site forbidden to humans, House built to demihuman preferences, Business unique to demihuman needs



Dueling Lords

Two different major powers are fighting over control of the community. Two rival lords, a baron and a merchant-prince, the mayor and a local high priest, or some other combination struggle to achieve dominance. They may both have justifiable claim on running the community, or one may be a greedy interloper.

- E** Third party profiting by the strife, Traitor to one of the rivals, Outsider vulture wanting both rivals to fail
- F** Harried local peacemaker, Impotent judge appointed by a disinterested higher authority. Appealing partisan of one rival
- C** The rival with the most legitimate claim is the least suitable to rule, A vital civic task is left undone until a ruler is determined, Both rivals have terrible plans
- T** Token of legitimate rule, Bribe meant for a powerful local, Proof of a rival's malfeasance
- P** Deadlocked city hall, Site of mob violence between rival groups, Tavern full of well-armed partisans

Faded Remnant

This community used to be much larger and more prosperous, but something happened relatively long ago that left it a shrunken shadow of its former self. Only a tithe of citizens remain on the site, and much of its former architecture is crumbling and abandoned. A few weathered tokens of old glory remain, and some may be jealously maintained, but there simply aren't enough locals left to keep up what they've inherited.

- E** Looter seeking to plunder the remains, Zealot with a plan to return to glory, Outsider strongman who wants to coerce the locals into obedience
- F** Learned scholar of the noble past, Hard-scrabble present survivor, New citizen who sees hope in the place
- C** They don't fully understand what they've inherited, They were crushed because of their past evils, They're not the actual heirs but merely squatters who moved into the empty place
- T** Artifact of the prior golden age, Wealth hidden away long ago, Secret key to unlocking new glory
- P** Near-abandoned city center, Massive decaying monument, Partially fallen town wall

Enemy Within

The locals are convinced that there is some terrible threat against them working from within their society. It may be a matter of dark sorcerers, foreign spies, traitorous neighbors, shapeshifting monsters, or some other hidden evil. This evil may be a recent fear, or it may be an inherited peril they've always had to guard against. The danger itself may or may not exist, or if it exists it may not justify the steps being taken.

- E** Local inquisitor targeting his personal enemies, Leader of the sinister evil, Traitorous local in service to the evil
- F** Unjustly accused victim, Local ruler trying to restrain the mob, Skilled and discerning hunter of the evil
- C** The evil is real but actually running the inquisition, The hunters are creating the evil whether intentionally or no, The evil really is exactly as bad as the hunters say it is
- T** Confession naming perpetrators of the evil, Wealth taken from condemned sinners, Resources gathered by the agents of the evil
- P** Confiscated home of an evildoer, Public execution site for the wicked, Courtroom where the evil is being tried

Fallen Prosperity

The community used to be much richer, but something happened recently to crush its source of prosperity. Different factions of the community might be trying to grasp at the remaining dregs of wealth, others might try to restart the failed industry, and some might look for a new livelihood. Any group or entity thought responsible for the collapse is likely to be treated very harshly, and some locals might find profit in shifting the blame to their enemies.

- E** Outside profiteer squeezing the newly-poor, Local monopolizing the remaining income, Demagogue blaming everything on their enemy
- F** Plucky local trying to make a new go of things, Harried disburser of limited charity, Riches-to-rags native trying to maintain their dignity
- C** Their loss is a rival's gain, Someone's offering them a new industry at a terrible price, The leadership is refusing to accept the new reality
- T** Priceless relic of their former wealth, Supplies vital to a budding industry, Resources once held lightly that now are very precious here
- P** Ill-maintained but splendid public building, Mansion marked by genteel poverty, Empty shop once catering to the rich

Foreign Enclave

Either most or a substantial minority of the locals are descended from foreigners alien to their local neighbors. They may have been religious exiles, economic migrants, indigenous locals surrounded by the existing polity, or a foreign city conquered within the relatively recent past. The locals may not be enthusiastic about being ruled by others not of their kind, and their neighbors may look askance at the way foreign customs or even laws may be maintained.

- E** Ruthless independence fighter, Outsider ruler with no regard for the locals, Local grandee preaching contempt for outsider ways
- F** Peacemaking local leader, Local in love with an outsider, Pragmatic-minded outsider magistrate
- C** Secessionists are being supported by their co-ethnics, The polity's leaders don't want them here, They're hated by their co-ethnics for some reason
- T** Precious relic brought from the homeland, Wealth hidden away for fear of outsiders, Valuable good made as a cultural tradition
- P** Public building in an aggressively different architectural style, Outsider home surrounded by local-style buildings, Civic gathering place of a kind specific to the locals

Heavy Fortification

The community is remarkably well-fortified for a site of its size and role. Tall, stout walls, strongpoints inside the community, concentric defenses, a strategic terrain location, or a large body of standing troops might be present. Some threat is thought to exist that makes maintaining this fortification worthwhile, though it may come at a dear cost to the locals. The community's suzerain may be uncomfortable with these defenses, as they could just as easily be used to defy the ruler.

- E** Outside enemy seeking to pierce the defenses, Rebel trying to declare independence, Heavy-handed local ruler demanding protection money
- F** Industrious maintenance chief, Ruler's appointed local military commander, Local warning of some sudden impending danger
- C** The threat is gone but those who profit by the defenses keep them going, The defenses are impractical, The community can no longer bear the expense of the defenses
- T** Components of a powerful fixed weapon, Payroll for the soldiers, Precious and specialized maintenance components
- P** Oversized weapon emplacement, Top of a looming city wall, Stronghold keep at the center of the community

Guild Oligarchy

While the community might ostensibly be ruled by some other power, real control lies with the senior members of the local craft and labor guilds. Their decisions have the practical weight of law, and much of their time and effort is spent squeezing out competitors and parceling out economic opportunities in the community. Some guilds might have little or nothing to do with their original trade, and now exist purely as shells for political influence.

- E** Profoundly corrupt guild boss, Ambitious newcomer with brutal methods, Ruthless leader of a guild of criminals
- F** Hard-bitten elder among the workers, Outsider trying to make room here, Reformer seeking to oust the corrupt guild heads
- C** The guilds have intermarried or entangled themselves with the ostensible rulers, The guilds offer protection from a real or imagined threat, They guilds hate each other only slightly less than the competition
- T** Priceless symbolic guild regalia, Wealth hidden by the former ruler of the community, Money earned by shady business practices
- P** Bustling guild hall, Purely decorative ruler's court, Shabby worker's housing

Hidden Ruler

While the community has a public leader, the real authority is hidden from outsiders. This ruler may draw their authority from rationales unacceptable to outsiders, they may have cowed the public authority into obedience, or they may have a mutually beneficial private arrangement with the official ruler.

- E** Secret cult-backed leader, Nefarious agent of an enemy power, Minor functionary who is actually the hidden master
- F** Frustrated outside authority, Local seeking better government, Victim of the hidden leader's will
- C** Most people know that the real authority is concealed, The hidden ruler is a mortal enemy of the legitimate authority, The hidden ruler's effective authority is over a large affiliated group rather than the whole community
- T** Information on the hidden government, Bribe money paid to the public authority, Blackmail material on important locals
- P** Unassuming tavern that's a secret headquarters, Tense court of the official ruler, Hidden site where the secret government meets



Hostile Terrain

The community is surrounded by dangerous terrain: miasmatic swamps, perilous crevasses, radioactive badlands, a pocket of *arratu*, or some other harmful topography. The community might prefer the defensive potential of the terrain here, or have found a precious resource worth the danger. The terrain might have formed at some time since the founding, with the citizens struggling to make terms with the new danger.

- E** Bandit chief hiding in the terrain, Monstrous leader in the badlands, Local who's made a secret deal with the terrain's vile inhabitants
- F** Canny badland guide, Innocent researcher eager to explore, Grizzled chief engineer of the community's anti-terrain measures
- C** The terrain is growing somehow, The terrain offers some special profit as well as danger, The community is being crushed by the terrain
- T** Treasure lost within the terrain, Device that generates or protects against the terrain, Precious resource found within the terrain
- P** Edge of the community overtaken by the environment, Building fortified against the terrain, Tavern favored by terrain guides and explorers

Inherited Architecture

Many of the community's structures date back to the ancient past and a long-vanished culture. They have unique architectural traits, perhaps being made of some strange substance or with uncanny qualities. The locals find them too useful or too durable to destroy, but the buildings often have unpleasant little surprises in their under-explored corners, and there may be greater structures still buried by long ages beneath the community's streets.

- E** A Thing from Below, Outside pillager bent on sacking the structures, Reckless explorer opening up things best left sealed
- F** Heir to the ancient arts of maintenance, Chief of the local structure guard patrol, Keeper of a particularly useful structure
- C** The locals mine treasures from the buried depths, The structures were built by Outsiders, They require dark sacrifices to keep functioning
- T** Key to unlock a sealed structure, Artifact of the ancient lost people, Map to a hidden structure
- P** Mundane business in a remarkable building, Ancient structure retrofitted into a habitation, Buried ancient street within a cavern

Incompetent Leaders

The community is led by one or more incompetents. While they must have been very good at something to have acquired the position, they are fundamentally incapable of leading. Uncontrolled passions or lusts, commitment to a hopelessly impractical ideal, pig-headed obstinacy in the face of failure, a total lack of charisma or interpersonal skills, or profound laziness might all unfit them for their post.

- E** Heir who is totally unsuited to their new rule, Disinterested ruler forced on them by their overlord, Charismatic ninny with ridiculous plans
- F** Deposed former leader, Desperate local elder, Victim of one of their bungled plans
- C** An outside rival is backing the fool, The idiot has tremendous institutional legitimacy, They provide a critical skill or ability unrelated to ruling
- T** Embezzled funds from a failed plan, Precious artifact lost through incompetence, Regalia of critical importance to the ruler's legitimacy
- P** Chaotic and ill-kept court, Site of abject disaster, Plaza full of grumbling locals

Inhuman Cooperation

The locals have a deal with some manner of inhuman power, either remnant Outsiders, eldritch entities, nearby monstrous beings, or some other creature generally feared or hated by humans. It may actually be a peaceful exchange, but more likely it involves acts and sacrifices that other humans would refuse. If not secret, this deal is valuable enough to make the community's suzerain avert their eyes, or it may be a bargain so old that time has sanctified it to their neighbors.

- E** Sinister overseer of the bargain's price, Local magnate growing rich off the dark bargain, Alien entity seeking to expand the terms of the deal
- F** Victim of the bargain's price, Outside investigator seeking the truth, Inveterate hunter of the entity's type come to purge the evil
- C** The bargain is actually reasonably fair and decent, The locals don't want the bargain but their neighbors profit by it and so force them into it, However bad the creatures are they're actually better than the human lord
- T** Valuable alien goods, Wealth offered as a sacrifice, Treasure gained by cooperation
- P** Secret meeting hall for the creatures, Prosperous front business, Sinister ritual of sacrifice



Lawless Class

Some class of citizen is either tacitly or explicitly above the law. They may only be subject to punishment for crimes against their own kind, or they may be entirely immune to legal prosecution. In some cases, this immunity may be the product of official indifference rather than high status; some untouchable classes may be considered so lowly that their slaughter of each other isn't worth punishing unless it inconveniences their betters.

- E** Professionally immune provocateur, Cruelly indulgent elite, Grasping mercantile oligarch
- F** Hapless magistrate, Avenger outside the law, Victim of an unpunishable crime
- C** The lawless themselves enforce the law, The immune are most dangerous to each other, Special servants of the immune also are immune
- T** Wealth stolen from a hapless victim, Evidence that an abuser is not legitimately part of the class, Token that grants the bearer the same immunity
- P** Courtroom where some cases are swiftly dismissed, Site of a gaudily obvious exercise of immunity, Shop where the business was ruined by their excesses

Magical Academy

While private tutelage of worthy apprentices can sometimes be had even in remote villages, this community is unusual in that it has an actual school dedicated to teaching magic. Such schools are usually small, with no more than a few dozen pupils, most of whom will fail for lack of talent or discipline. The instructors are rarely first-rate, usually serving only for the pay and status, but sometimes a genius sorcerer will find a reason to observe likely apprentices here. Given the unfortunate accident potential of the school, it's probably isolated or well-fortified.

- E** Amoral headmaster, Secretly monstrous school patron, Unpleasantly talented yet vicious elite student
- F** Plucky young apprentice, Harried but earnest teacher, Instructor with useful side obsession
- C** The academy is patronized by the ruling class, The community grew around the academy, The rulers don't trust the wizards but find them too useful to get rid of them
- T** Long-lost grimoire of power, Brilliant artifice of a genius student, Magical key to a dark power the academy keeps locked up
- P** Battered magical laboratory, Architecturally impossible chamber, Grubby student lodgings



Martial Tradition

The natives have a long tradition of martial expertise. This may be a crisply-organized history of skilled native levies, or it may be a natural belligerence in the people that leaves them familiar with bloodshed. While their neighbors and liege doubtless respect their talents, this very aptitude might make them more willing to turn to steel than prudence would advise.

- E** Ruthlessly amoral military leader, Obsessive martial academy master, Outsider using the locals as brute muscle
- F** Determined local defender, Petitioner in need of their prowess, Keeper of the local martial way
- C** They use weapons only they are able to employ, They've bled themselves white in gaining glory, They're eager to conquer their neighbors
- T** Enchanted weapon related to their way, Plunder taken in a victorious war, Venerated battle harness of a legendary hero
- P** Busy training ground, Cemetery with many memorials, City hall decorated with the banners of the vanquished

Mistreated Blighted

Not all Blighted are violent; many are simply cursed with disabilities or mental compulsions implanted in them by their creators. The locals here have a useful kind of Blighted that provides some valuable service; brute labor, companionship, or more awful fates for those with precious organic components. The locals treat them as nothing but expendable chattel, but the Blighted are unable to effectively defend themselves or survive without the support of their tormentors.

- E** Bloodless local slaver, Faux-benevolent overseer, Reformer seeking a complete purge of them
- F** Blighted leader, Troubled local, Native seeking to take over the work niche the Blighted are filling
- C** The Blighted are emotionally addicted to this kind of servitude, The Blighted could be very dangerous if they got free, Criminals and the unwanted are transformed into the Blighted
- T** Device that imposes the Blight on a victim, Wealth earned by Blighted suffering, Key to the method used to control the Blighted
- P** Workhouse full of cruelly-used Blighted, Stately mansion with rigidly-disciplined Blighted servants, Sinister establishment staffed by disposable Blighted

Miserable Penury

Life is hard in the Latter Earth, but it is exceptionally hard here. People are deprived of all but the barest necessities, and even the local gentry are impoverished compared to their peers elsewhere. Something is making the locals stay, however, whether fear of the alternative, hope for a better future, or a stubborn attachment to their ancestral lands.

- E** Rapacious beggar-lord oppressing even poorer lessers, Outsider who's siphoning off wealth, Brutal gang leader determined to take what they want
- F** Plucky young entrepreneur, Charitable cleric, Suzerain's envoy seeking to improve things
- C** They could be richer if they abandon a defining cultural tradition, They're being bled dry by outsiders, They're hopelessly resigned
- T** A stash of wealth that would be minor elsewhere, Desperately needed resources, A cherished relic that had to be sold for survival's sake
- P** Miserable slum of shanties, Unprofitable fields, Tavern with only the barest minimum of fare

Monstrous Tribute

The locals have cut a deal with some unspeakable entity, trading some vile tribute in exchange for the being's forbearance or assistance. Outsiders may be ignorant of the bargain, or they may know that the community is in thrall but be too fearful of its master to take action against them. The creature likely serves as a protector as well as a tyrant, so the locals may be content with the deal even if it doesn't offer any further inducement or aid.

- E** Ancient artificial intellect-tyrant, Cruel sorcerer-lord, Monstrous quasi-god
- F** Secret rebel against the deal, Investigator looking for evidence, Monstrous rival of the tyrant
- C** They seize the tribute from their neighbors or enemies, The deal is getting progressively worse, Their neighbors are thinking of making their own deals
- T** Ritual instruments forged via atrocity, Forbidden book of hideous truths, Precious resource generated by the entity
- P** Secret shrine to their unholy master, Prison where the tribute is kept, Bustling town street full of sinister prosperity

Neglectful Ruler

The community can't rely on its ostensible suzerain. Whatever lord claims ownership of the place is indifferent to its troubles and pays no attention to its civic disorder. The lord may be incapable of giving help, or convinced their representative can handle it alone, or actively seeking to punish the community for some rebellion or failure of service.

- E** A viceroy sending back false reports, Local grandee seizing control by violence, Cruel local lord who keeps the ruler pacified with tax money
- F** Inspector from the suzerain, Local judge seeking justice, Harried representative in need of help
- C** The ruler has too many problems to care about this place, The ruler would actually make things worse if they paid heed, The ruler's authority is being hindered by some rival power
- T** Tax money not yet sent, A "gift" meant to draw the lord's help, Proof of a plot to seize control of the community
- P** Deserted courtroom, Street crawling with local vigilante groups, Burnt-out home of a political loser

Pilgrimage Site

The community is centered around a major pilgrimage site. This may be a religious location of importance to a major faith, or it may be a more secular institution that draws the traffic, like a famous academy or the remains of some wondrous ancient work. Considerable local tension likely exists over controlling the access to the site and maximizing the profits from foreign visitors.

- E** Outsider boss seeking to seize control of the site, Corrupt hereditary site controller, Rival saboteur bent on despoiling the site
- F** Well-meaning pilgrim, Scholar with dangerous historical theories, Earnest caretaker of the site
- C** The site can only handle so many visitors without degrading, The pilgrimage site is dangerous, The keepers don't fully understand the site
- T** Precious relic of the site, Beautifully-made fake of some critical relic, Secret true history of the site
- P** Expensive pilgrim lodgings, Street full of hawkers of pilgrimage tokens, Alien and wondrous pilgrimage site

New Industry

The natives have established a new industry here, and it's making them a great deal of profit. Old patterns of authority and wealth are being disrupted, and the old gentry are unlikely to be pleased about it. They may be trying to take over the industry, or they may have been the ones to enable it in the first place and are using it to crush the life out of any rival power bases. Outsiders might be playing a major role as well, and it could be they plot to siphon off the profits.

- E** Arrogant and ruthless new oligarch, Scheming old-money grandee, Grasping and heartless industrial magnate
- F** Hopeful new entrepreneur, Local elder trying to deal with the change, Innocently naive outside investor
- C** The gentry would prefer poverty to losing power, The gentry are split on the industry, The industry comes with severe and unequally-distributed downsides
- T** Profit from the industry, A valuable device to improve the industry, Tools of sabotage
- P** Retrofitted old workshop, Resource-extraction site, Crowded worker housing

Plagued City

The community is cursed with recurrent spells of some troublesome disease. The affliction isn't so fatal as to make living there impossible, but it adds suffering and expense to local lives. The plague might be the product of an ancient curse, the results of long-lost toxic remains, or an unavoidable byproduct of whatever industry or purpose justifies the city. It's probably not overly contagious, but visitors may be in some peril all the same.

- E** Charlatan selling false hope, Merciless grandee gladly worsening the plague for profit, Dark sorcerer seeking to weaponize the sickness
- F** Traditional healer wise in the plague's ways, Appealing waif struck down by the illness, Impassioned healer seeking a real cure
- C** The plague has a positive side-effect, Only certain classes suffer the plague, Passage into or out of the community is strictly controlled
- T** A real cure for the plague, Hidden wealth of a plague victim, The key to halting the cycle
- P** Worn-down sickhouse full of locals, Cemetery overflowing with the dead, Business based on providing for a sufferer's special needs



Population Boom

A vast influx of newcomers has recently rushed into the community. They may have been drawn by economic opportunities, or fled some pursuing peril, or been forcibly moved there by a ruler who wanted to dilute the existing native cohesion. The natives may not have the resources or opportunities to integrate these newcomers, and it may be that the new population has no desire to stay longer than is necessary.

- E** Viciously xenophobic grandee, Newcomer leader who despises the locals and their ways, Grasping merchant exploiting one or both groups
- F** Local trying to bridge differences, Newcomer trying to make a new life, Local official trying to keep the peace
- C** The newcomers act like conquerors, Their cultures are extremely inmiscible, The natives are now highly dependent on newcomer industry
- T** Precious relic brought by the newcomers, Loot confiscated or extracted from the newcomers, Riches earned from newcomer labor
- P** Jarringly different newcomer quarter, Market with informally segregated areas, Tavern welcoming to only one group

Rebel Stronghold

The community is in tacit or open revolt against their supposed overlord. If it's distant from their suzerain's power centers or exceptionally well-fortified, they might be an open nest of rebels and provide overt support to their ruler's enemies. More vulnerable communities will provide shelter, secret support, and a base of supply for hidden bands of insurgents. Loyalist locals must keep their sympathies hidden or suffer the consequences.

- E** Psychopathic but charismatic rebel leader, Savage rebel-suppressing general, Traitor leading the rebels to their doom
- F** Idealistic young rebel, Frightened local just trying to survive, Sympathetic outside mediator
- C** One side of the dispute is correct but profoundly unsympathetic, A rebel victory would ultimately be catastrophic, The lord can't afford the disruption that violent suppression would create
- T** Cache of valuable rebel supplies, Tax money stolen by the rebels, Secret rebel identities and plans
- P** Rebel base hidden outside the community, Tavern full of sympathizers, Burnt house of a loyalist

Raider Scourge

Almost every community has some problem with bandits and highwaymen, but this community is seriously plagued with raiders. One or more groups of persistent plunderers are hitting the community repeatedly, and they lack the necessary resources to fend them off or protect all their holdings.

- E** Would-be ruler turned bandit chief, Rival agent backing the bandits, Traitorous native wielding the bandits against their enemies
- F** Runaway ex-bandit, Embittered victim of their plundering, Merchant desperate for help
- C** The bandits are cooperating with a local power bloc, The bandits are a direct consequence of some local political decision, Mustering military force would have dire political consequences
- T** Plunder stolen by the bandits, A shipment of some vital good that was waylaid, Evidence of corroborators or informers
- P** Scene of gory slaughter on the road, Burnt farmstead outside the community, Makeshift and dirty bandit camp

Rigid Castes

The locals are divided into several castes. They may be organized by social role, by imputed nobility of birth, by ethnic origins, or any other dividing principle, but they cannot imagine any other way of organizing themselves. A hierarchy of castes is not inevitable, but there will be social and legal limits applied to ensure that each caste remains fixed in its function. The outside world may or may not respect these distinctions when dealing with the locals.

- E** Conqueror seeking to impose "civilized" castes on outsiders, Impostor who'll commit any crime to conceal their true caste, Abusive upper-caste grandee
- F** Unfairly mistreated caste member, Determined reformer with a "better" caste plan, Outsider trying to undo the caste system
- C** The castes are marked by ancient physiological alterations, Even the low caste locals are convinced the tradition is right, Exceptional money or talent can change a person's caste
- T** Proof of a group's real caste, Goods created by a caste's unpaid labors, Sacred regalia only a certain caste can touch
- P** Caste-divided residential quarters, Temple dedicated to a caste, Workshop of a caste

Scars of War

The community is still bloodied by a recent violent conflict. A crushing bandit raid, a lost siege, getting caught at the periphery of a major battle, or some other calamity has inflicted severe damage on the place. Some communities may suffer a longer-term version of this, their youths lost in a grinding, endless battle against some perpetual threat.

- E** Savage tyrant left over from the fight, Outsider taking advantage of their weakness, Native driven to extremes by their losses
- F** Bedraggled survivor, Outsider who's come to help, Relative of someone lost in the battle
- C** The damage was mostly taken by one group, The losses have thrown the old social order into chaos, The locals are desperate to make the losses "worth it"
- T** Plunder taken during the fight, Wealth left behind by the dead, A cache of treasure concealed by looters
- P** Damaged half-occupied house, Burnt-down civil structure, Fields pocked with torched cottages

Secret Treachery

The community is in secret rebellion against their ostensible liege, having cut deals with his enemies, plotted to betray him for their own gain, or bridled under his tyranny and sought a better lord. The community's leadership is all in on this plot, and outside viceroys or representatives are being kept carefully ignorant of the reality. The common folk may be oblivious to the truth, though they'll doubtless have felt the same motivations and promptings that convinced their leaders to turn traitor.

- E** Suspicious investigator from the tyrant, Scheming local chief who plans to be the new lord, Monstrous thing that they made a pact with
- F** Local being cruelly mistreated by the tyrant, Honest representative trying to resolve the tension, Local grandee trying to stay out of it all
- C** One of the leaders is a double agent waiting to roll all the traitors up, The leaders disagree on methods, There's more than one group of traitors who don't know about the others
- T** Proof of the conspiracy, Bribes intended for the leadership, Relic smuggled in by an outside supporter
- P** Smoky back room, Sullen public gathering, Secret chamber in a leader's home

Seat of Rule

Some important ruler or leading figure resides in the community. This may be the seat of a regional lord, or it could be the traditional residence of a high priest, great magus, merchant house, or other wielder of influence. The community itself may or may not be under their direct control, but the wishes of the august figure must be acknowledged by the locals.

- E** Corrupted and venal ruling figure, Conspiring usurper of the role, Vicious rebel against the ruler
- F** Worried advisor to the ruler, Petitioner seeking help, Rebel against an unjust ruler
- C** The ruler is a figurehead controlled by someone else, The community is struggling to keep the seat, The ruler is not legally recognized but everyone knows the reality of their influence
- T** Riches brought to petition the ruler, Ancestral ruling regalia, Treasure hidden by a ruler of old
- P** Grand and ancient audience hall, Elaborate edifice now no longer used, Public building related to the ruler's role

Sinking City

The community was built atop something unstable, and now that substrate is crumbling. It may be swampy ground or a decaying coastline, or it could be an ancient buried city that's now giving way. In the case of some antique habitation, the denizens that once lived there might be boiling upward as their home is collapsing, or new opportunities may be revealed even as the community's present structure is ruined.

- E** Unspeakable evil from below, Ruthless local causing damage for the sake of profit, Outside exploiter preying on the displaced
- F** Struggling local defender, Native made homeless by the collapse, Curious explorer bent on discovering what lies beneath
- C** The collapse was caused by someone, Only the slums or the noble quarter collapsed, The collapse hasn't happened yet but it's going to
- T** Recently-uncovered treasure, Vault buried when the building became a sinkhole, Key to halt the collapse
- P** Pit where a manor once was, Fallen city wall, Freshly-exposed underworks



Theocratic Authorities

Religious leaders are influential in almost any community, but here they make up the final authorities. It may be an explicit theocracy, with rule by the clerics of a particular faith, or a temple might be so important and powerful that the official leaders are helpless to resist its will. The locals can be expected to be loyal adherents to the faith, or else the less pious majority is deeply intimidated by the religion's believers.

- E** Rebel backed by a rival religion, Heretical priest trying to usurp authority, Eldritch being masquerading as a heavenly envoy
- F** Well-meaning but zealous priest, Insurgent against a wicked theocracy, Harried town leader trying to please the clerics
- C** The theocrats are divided into struggling factions, The theocracy is the result of the former regime's complete failure, The priests don't want to lead but nobody else is acceptable to the people
- T** Religious relic conferring the right to rule, Precious sacred scripture, Tithe gathered for the temple
- P** Ornate and splendid temple, Shrine room within an ordinary house, Magistrate-priest's courtroom

Trade Hub

The site is a major trade hub, connecting several important cities or resource production areas. It's probably at an important river juncture, ancient crossroads, or occupying the only safe path through some perilous wilderness. Its position may be important enough that it can survive on trade alone, despite being unable to feed itself with the surrounding land. Such hubs are usually heavily garrisoned by the lord who profits from their tariffs and taxes.

- E** Cheating merchant prince, Corrupt judge or trade official, Grasping ruler with heavy taxes
- F** Confused foreigner with strange ways, Dealer in some vital adventuring good, Exotic stranger in need of help
- C** The locals trade with Outsiders or other entities normally shunned by humans, The merchants effectively rule the city, There are pockets of exotic cultures found nowhere else in the kingdom
- T** Precious goods not produced in this land, Map to some fabulous foreign treasure, Gift intended for a local ruler
- P** Bazaar full of alien speech, Caravansary built in a foreign fashion, Palace of conspicuous opulence

Toxic Economy

The community is reliant on an industry or product that has toxic or negative side-effects as part of its production. The good is extremely valuable, or the community is extremely desperate, and the side-effects are endured as a necessary evil. It may be that their neighbors or lord are forcing them to produce the good so that they aren't the ones suffering the cost.

- E** Cruel sorcerer-merchant, Indifferent magnate wringing more production out of people, Trader in flesh who profits by the sick and feeble
- F** Healer trying to cure the side-effect, Crippled local maimed by the product, Outside trader trying to soften the consequences of the trade
- C** The side-effect only harms an expendable class of people, The afflicted are isolated from the healthy, The side-effect are social or economic rather than physical
- T** A temporary protection from the toxin, A load of the precious good, A device that worsens the toxin but creates more of the good
- P** Pesthouse full of the crippled, Splendid mansion built off the product's profits, Factory full of lethal fumes and effects

Unique Product

The community produces something unique, a good or service that cannot be had anywhere else in the kingdom. This may be due to some unique resource found only there, or some carefully-guarded craft, or it may be a special service that can only be provided by the locals, who are somehow unique in their forms or abilities.

- E** Magnate forcing more production at a grim cost, Ruler demanding more tribute, Rival saboteur planning to turn the product dangerous
- F** Naive but superbly talented artisan, Innovator seeking to improve the product, Outside trader trying to protect their deal
- C** The product involves a vile component that outsiders can't accept handling, The product is extremely useful to very unpleasant entities, Multiple rulers claim rights over the community
- T** A cache of the product, The secret method of its production, Valuable components used to make the product
- P** Factory full of busy creators, Resource extraction field where a vital component is gathered, Market crowded with traders from far places

Upstart Faith

There's a relatively new religion in the community which is rapidly gaining power. It might be a sectarian offshoot of a major faith, the unique product of a new prophet, or an outside faith backed by wealthy and powerful foreign supporters. Depending on the demands made on believers, the new faith may be a matter of concern only to the existing clergy, or it might be a major flashpoint for conflict in the community.

- E** False prophet gathering thralls, Hostile native cleric with dark plans, Outside manipulator profiting by the strife
- F** Sincere new priest, Local trying to keep out of the crossfire, Existing cleric trying to make peace
- C** The faith has very different teachings for inner and outer members, The secular leadership backs the new faith to weaken the existing temples, The faith has both sympathetic and unpleasant traits
- T** Sacred relic of the new faith, Temple relic stolen by new convert to the faith, Tithe offered up by wealthy new convert
- P** Hastily-made new temple, Now-empty existing shrine, Market with informal religious segregation

Widespread Prosperity

The community is uncommonly rich, not only for the gentry but for the common citizens as well. They may produce a valuable good, oversee precious resource extraction, have special economic favors from the ruler, or simply have inherited a vast body of infrastructure. Their neighbors likely view them with envy, and outside raiders and exploiters find them an ideal target.

- E** Cunning raider chieftain, Greedy overlord, Arrogant local ruler over-proud of their wealth
- F** Local being exploited for their wealth, Agent of the local prosperity's maintenance, Outside trader trying to make an honest profit
- C** The prosperity is coming at another community's cost, Their rivals claim their prosperity is wholly undeserved, The impending end of the prosperity is visible to all
- T** Casually-stored riches, Device that creates some critical infrastructure, Cache of weapons meant to defend the wealth
- P** Commoner neighborhood as opulent as that of the gentry of elsewhere, Market full of luxuries, Edifice of unusually advanced infrastructure

Warring Council

There's more than one leader in the community, but at least some of them are at each other's throats. It might be a conflict between formal leadership and informal authorities, or it could be a struggle among civil officials. Their interests might diverge sharply, or it could be a personal grudge that's boiled over. Outside threats and internal problems are likely being ignored until the power struggle is resolved.

- E** Shadowy kingmaker bent on breaking resistance, Megalomaniacal new leader, "Owned" leader forced to fight for his backers
- F** Neutral leader seeking a resolution, Outside investigator looking to understand the situation, Local suffering from some trouble that's being ignored
- C** The most capable leader is also most at fault, The struggle is being incited by an outside rival, They're arguing over a problem that seems insoluble
- T** Blackmail on a leader, Treasure being fought over, Item that would resolve the struggle
- P** Now-abandoned council room, Site of a steadily-increasing problem, Tavern stronghold of one of the combatants

Xenophobic Locals

The locals despise outsiders. For some "outsiders" may be natives of foreign lands, while others might have a grudge against anyone from outside the community. Almost every community in the Latter Earth has some degree of wariness toward strangers, but these locals have an active loathing, and the few outsiders allowed to trade or interact with them do so at a heavy disadvantage.

- E** Utterly unfair local magistrate, Local magnate who abuses outside laborers, Leader who always paints outsiders in the worst possible light
- F** Secretly curious local, Cruelly mistreated outsider living there, Grudging diplomat seeking a modus vivendi
- C** They have a very good reason for hating strangers, Their outsider neighbors hate them just as much, They're the last remnant of their kind and fear being absorbed
- T** Prized symbol of their people, Wealth confiscated from an outsider, Forbidden outsider objects kept sealed away
- P** Cultural edifice devoted to the local past, Tightly-guarded city walls, Architecture that only makes sense to the locals



COURTS

A “Court” is shorthand for a particular group of NPCs tangled in a mutually-shared enterprise. It might be a classic noble court, a large business, a patriarch-led familial clan or dynasty, a temple with its clergy, a magistrate’s bureaucratic office, or any other circumstance where a number of significant NPCs have to work with each other while perhaps having contrary goals and ambitions.

Court tags are used to provide intrigue-based adventures and help a GM manage the complexity of designing and running more socially-oriented challenges. When the GM needs to generate a social situation that can’t be readily solved with swords these tables and tags can provide the basic outlines for them.

Five different types of Courts are sketched on the following pages. The “major figures” for each provide a list of potential significant players in the Court’s intrigue. A GM should generally pick or roll three such figures to act as the major foci of plots and schemes. “Minor figures” can be used to fill out NPCs necessary for delivering adventure hooks, local color, or agents of the major figures.

Each major figure has some sort of power source that makes their opinions and wishes relevant to the Court’s actions. They can’t be wholly neutralized until they’re either killed or their power source is eliminated, and the former may not be a feasible option for their rivals or the PCs.

Courts are synonymous with intrigue and plotting, and the table of potential internal or external problems the Court faces can be used as seeds of conflict for inspiring these secret struggles. The Court Tags you generate for the group can flavor these results, or you can synthesize an implicit crisis in the tag with one of the results to create a hybrid situation. It may be that this conflict is merely the most immediate manifestation of the larger-scale problem represented by the Court Tags.

In all cases, a GM should be careful to provide some reason why immediate, brute-force violence is not the smartest solution for the problem. Killing major figures might bring down the kind of societal heat that even notoriously cold-blooded adventurers avoid. It’s very likely that their rivals in their Court conflict don’t actually want them dead, particularly if the Court is representing a normal familial clan or business.

The rewards and enticements offered by a Court for resolving its problems should tie in with the society or community it inhabits. A far-flung rural clan might not have much in the way of practical wealth, but if they’ve got a cousin in every village the chance to get a helpful local guide might be worth more than simple coin. A noble family might never be able to openly admit their association with the coarse PCs, but their client families might all have very remunerative work for the heroes.



ARISTOCRATIC COURTS

These courts represent noble houses, monarchic courts, or other combined places of governmental power and exalted lineage. They have a great deal of secular power over some part of the region and their wishes must be respected by the common folk... or resisted with considerable effort.

Very few elites can afford to rule with complete indifference to the opinion of others, however. These courts will usually be seeking alliances with other aristocratic houses, cooperation from rich merchants, and blessings from important local faiths. In a stable region, their chief rivals will be other aristocratic courts. When the area is in turmoil or the social order is in flux, they might find themselves facing powerful commoner clans, ambitious religious organizations, or rich merchants willing to provide reliable order to society.

d12

Main Theme of the Court

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Treachery, an air of suspicion and mistrust |
| 2 | Decadence, of excess and indulgence |
| 3 | Ennui, of exhaustion and loss of meaning |
| 4 | Ambition, of driving forward and upward |
| 5 | Resentment, bitter at their rivals' crimes |
| 6 | Nobility, a sense of obligation to their people |
| 7 | Paralysis, trapped in some internal crisis |
| 8 | Luxury, abundant in wealth and possessions |
| 9 | Tyranny, cruelly oppressing those under them |
| 10 | Dissolution, falling apart from outside stress |
| 11 | Exoticism, following strange outside ways |
| 12 | Might, flexing its power in impressive ways |

People of the Court

d12	Major Figure	Minor Figure	The Source of their Power in the Court
1	Lord/Lady	Affiliated Merchant	They are the only legitimate heir to an important post
2	Ornamental Spouse	Amusing Performer	They control a large chunk of the court's income sources
3	Ruler's Mistress	Butler or Eunuch	They are widely loved and admired by the members
4	Heir Apparent	Footman	They have access to sinister sorceries or magic items
5	Spare Heir	Hanger-On	The others fear violence or brutality from them
6	Court Mage/Priest	Heir's Tutor	They have a special relationship with the nation's ruler
7	Jester or Pet Artist	Hired Assassin	They have blackmail on important members
8	Chief Steward	House Guard	Everyone acknowledges their skill and brilliance
9	Poor Relation	Lady in Waiting	They have a very effective spy ring in their service
10	Senior Relative	Pleasure Slave	They provide intimate services to an important person
11	Cadet Branch Lord	Prying Servant	They have innate magical powers or gifts
12	Lord's Main Rival	Spy for a Rival	They have the support of an important local faith

Problems of the Court

d12	Internal Conflicts	External Conflicts
1	Someone is pursuing someone else's spouse or fiancé	The court somehow offended the nation's ruler
2	Someone is facing financial ruin due to a mistake	A royal advisor wants the court cut down to size
3	Two potential heirs to something are in bitter conflict	A rival court has recently gotten much stronger
4	An elder is making unreasonable demands on others	Hostile forces have attacked and ruined a court asset
5	A danger exists in or near the court's own seat	A traitor to the court is helping a rival group's attacks
6	Someone is skimming off income due others in the court	An important faith is angry with the court over something
7	A court servant is blackmailing their employer	Tenants or merchants have been upset by the court
8	A court resource or asset has been badly damaged	The local ruler has levied a harsh "gift" on the court
9	Someone wants to make a very poor marriage choice	A rival has seized control of an important court asset
10	Someone poisoned or cursed someone else in the court	A reckless member has incurred a group's anger
11	Someone got involved with a criminal organization	Doing something vital will infuriate another power
12	A rebel in the court is scheming against the crown	A rival has laid a legal claim on a court asset



BUSINESS COURTS

These courts can be used to detail powerful merchant houses, business combines, or even ambitious new enterprises that play a significant role in a community.

Business courts provide at least one product or service to the people around them, one important enough or expensive enough to give them considerable influence. Given the state of most nations, every major merchant expects the local rulers to try to take his profits and claim his property sooner or later; the idea of property rights independent of the desires of the ruling class is not a familiar one most places.

The main defense a business court has is to be more valuable to the rulers intact than dismembered. Some emphasize heavy ties with local authorities, while others in wilder lands make themselves too dangerous or too vital to destroy with impunity.

d12 Relations With Their Market

1	Trusted, they're a fixture of the local market
2	Angry, they've done something to infuriate
3	Curious, they've come up with a new thing
4	Resentful, they deal harshly and graspingly
5	Suspicious, they're rumored to do vile things
6	Admired, they're well-loved by customers
7	Novel, they're new to the market here
8	Patronized, favored by the local nobility
9	Affinity, dealing with co-ethnics or believers
10	Apathetic, with customers losing interest
11	Predatory, eliminating weaker rivals
12	Shabby, their goods cheap and minimal

People of the Court

d12	Major Figure	Minor Figure	The Source of their Power in the Court
1	Business Owner	Angry Former Customer	They own rights to a critical part of the business
2	Business Partner	Best Customer	They fronted the initial investment money
3	Buyer Seeking Takeover	Business Guard	They had the idea that made the business work
4	Chief Artisan	Expensive Courtesan	They have information on the owner's criminal doings
5	Corrupt Lieutenant	Gang Extortionist	They keep the local nobility from sucking it dry
6	Head Accountant	Neighboring Businessman	They have ties to an important local faith
7	Innovative Worker	Noble Parasite	They're the only one who can handle the workers well
8	Noble Patron	Shop Clerk	Their relatives make up a lot of the workers
9	Owner's Heir	Street Informer	The business owes them a large monetary debt
10	Rival's Catpaw	Supply Vendor	The business is built on property they own or control
11	Spouse or Lover	Temporary Worker	They have vital connections with important suppliers
12	Wealthy Backer	Thieving Worker	They handle purchases for a critical customer

Problems of the Court

d12	Internal Conflicts	External Conflicts
1	Someone's been cooking the books	A competitor is trying to force a sale of the business
2	A secret flaw has been discovered in the product	They've insulted or offended the nobility somehow
3	A critical resource for making the good is running out	Their customers are furious over a recent product flaw
4	A vital worker has quit in a fury over some offense	Someone's tainting or ruining a critical resource input
5	Someone lost a large sum of funds to theft or error	A noble wants to force his own pet business into place
6	The deed to some vital property has been lost	A local religious group has become angry with them
7	A customer is proving both critical and intolerable	A holder of a vital secret has died or been kidnapped
8	A major stakeholder is coming up with terrible ideas	They're trying to swallow a rival business
9	Income is down but no one can agree on a plan	Someone's hooked them into a terribly bad deal
10	Factions are quarreling over a new product	An enemy is sabotaging an important workshop
11	A family scion is botching their work terribly	Bandits or paid thieves have plundered something
12	The owner's incapacitated and no one is in control	They've signed a deal they suddenly can't complete

CRIMINAL COURTS

Gangs, secret societies, degenerate villainous cults, and other groups of organized rebels against societal laws are represented as criminal courts. These groups all stand in opposition to some generally-accepted principle or code of laws, though many may be tacitly normalized in places.

Substantial criminal enterprises all exist in some sort of relationship with the society around them. Perhaps the locals accept them as an unpleasant inevitability, or they're too dangerous for secular rulers to meddle with them, or they prey on a population that the authorities are indifferent to.

This acceptance can vanish rapidly if the court seems to present a real threat to the government's control, however. Given their outlaw status, the common populace is unlikely to have any concerns about their brutal and extra-judicial suppression.

d12 Their Primary Mode of Crime

1	Extortion, using brute force and threats
2	Blackmail, preying on the wealthy
3	Murder, being proficient assassins
4	Smuggling, sneaking in untaxed goods
5	Black Marketeer, selling forbidden things
6	Slaving, whether legitimate or by force
7	Theft, whether burglary or banditry
8	Fraud, con artists and business cheats
9	Loans, giving high rates and harsh collection
10	Fencing, selling hot goods untraceably
11	Occult, offering forbidden magic to others
12	Piracy, or helping pirates sell their goods

People of the Court

d12	Major Figure	Minor Figure	The Source of their Power in the Court
1	Grizzled leader	Disreputable Priest	They're independently wealthy and doing it for fun
2	Leader's Concubine	Oppressed Local	They have a sinister magical gift or aptitude
3	Brutal Kneebreaker	Protected Merchant	They have a powerful or useful magical device
4	Well-Placed Spy	Shabby Local Fence	They have blackmail about the court's leadership
5	Ambitious Lieutenant	Drunken Healer	They've seduced the court's leadership
6	The Heir Apparent	Cooperative Innkeeper	Their remarkable skills bring in a lot of money
7	Corrupt Magistrate	Tired Harlot	They've special relations with the local rulers
8	Wicked Noble Patron	Would-be Client	They have a profitable front business they run
9	Incompetent Scion	Aspiring Member	They're personally terrifying and capable of murder
10	Outcast Sorcerer	Bribed Guardsman	Their charisma has gotten them a lot of supporters
11	Dangerous Rival	Criminal's Relative	They're diabolically cunning and persuasive
12	Seductive Tempter	Scabby Beggar	They have numerous criminal allies elsewhere

Problems of the Court

d12	Internal Conflicts	External Conflicts
1	Someone's knifed a fellow member again	The local law enforcement isn't staying bought
2	A deed's profits were unfairly split with the members	They're meddling with an extremely dangerous target
3	Someone's stolen court property for their own use	A rival gang or group is moving on their territory
4	The leadership is being roiled by a challenge	A traitor is in league with an enemy group
5	An important member's made a grave mistake	A sorcerer has a grudge against the group
6	Two members are fighting over another's affections	They've drawn heat from a powerful noble
7	The leader's suffering from increasing paranoia	A local religion has a particular enmity with them
8	They're overdoing the crime and drawing excess heat	They acquired something that's causing them dire woe
9	Someone's picked up a very bad habit or addiction	A court faction is getting support from a hostile rival
10	Members are employing magic against rivals	A noble or ruler wants to use them for their own ends
11	A recent catastrophe depleted the court's wealth	Their territory has become very inhospitable to them
12	A faction wants to enter a different sphere of crime	They're in a bad deal they don't dare renege on



FAMILIAL CLAN COURTS

Wherever masses of humans can be found, there will always be found those large, influential extended families that play an outsize role in the community's life. These major families might be characterized by a shared ethnic background, a tradition of some important skill, or an intensely cooperative clannishness in the face of outside rivals.

These tables can be used to flesh out the leading families of a farming village, the not-quite-noble gentry of a major city, or the tribal bands of a barbaric wilderness-dwelling folk. While these courts are assumed to be subordinate to some local ruler, they have enough resources and members to be a problem for nobles that mean to trample them carelessly. That power and ability to protect their neighbors' interests is often what brings them to prominence in their own community.

d12 Relations With Their Neighbors

1	Isolated, distrusted or disliked by most
2	Creditor, with many owing them payment
3	Scorned, derided for some deed or trait
4	Respected, honored for some quality
5	Newcomers, relatively new to the area
6	Loners, not disliked but not close to any
7	Feared, for past acts or present threats
8	Revered, held in dread and awe by most
9	Envied, resented by jealous neighbors
10	Loved, widely adored by other families
11	Needed, for a particular trait or person
12	Hated, barely endured by their neighbors

People of the Court

d12	Major Figure	Minor Figure	The Source of their Power in the Court
1	Adopted Member	Acquainted Noble	They hold the deed to some critical family property
2	Ambitious Scion	Blackmailer	They're the heir to the chief bloodline of the clan
3	Black Sheep	Disowned Wastrel	They're best at the skill or profession the clan practices
4	Clan Duty Keeper	Family Guard	They have considerable blackmail on their peers
5	Disowned Rebel	Family Priest	They have extensive contacts in other families
6	Favored Child	Gossipy Neighbor	They own great amounts of personal wealth
7	Oldest Elder	House Servant	They're notoriously loyal and useful to the family
8	Outsider Spouse	Moneylender	They're an intimate of the local ruler
9	Patriarch/Matriarch	Old Retainer	Everyone in the family loves them very much
10	Reckless Innovator	Secret Lover	They have many capable, loyal children
11	Stern Traditionalist	Tenant Farmer	Their capacity for violence is fearsome to others
12	Young Fosterling	Useful Tradesman	They have access to secret magical items or powers

Problems of the Court

d12	Internal Conflicts	External Conflicts
1	An important member's spouse is having an affair	There's a running feud with another family
2	The clan leader is opposed to a popular plan or goal	The local ruler doesn't like their influence and power
3	The last leader recently died without a clear heir	A member committed adultery with the wrong person
4	A member's bloodline is clouded by suspicion	Someone gravely insulted or offended another family
5	A cadet branch is fighting to seize control	The family's rights are being trod on by the nobility
6	The clan poured much wealth into a failed ambition	The family's source of influence is being subverted
7	Personal grudges have caused resentful factions	A rival family stole something very important from them
8	The new generation is ignoring old, painful duties	A diplomatic marriage has turned out very badly
9	A member is selfishly trading on the clan's reputation	Their neighbors demand they fix a local problem
10	One member is convinced another wants them dead	Their vital interests are making trouble for neighbors
11	A very important young talent has turned rebellious	Ambitious newcomers are attacking their status subtly
12	The leader is betting big on a risky, unpopular scheme	A disowned rebel is trying to usurp control of assets

RELIGIOUS COURTS

Temples, monasteries, seminaries, secret cults, or strictly secular academic institutions can all be represented by a religious court. Wherever a combination of intellectual rigor, obscure practice, and less-than-tangible community services are found these courts can provide structure.

Religious courts exist in the context of a larger faith, though they may not be strictly subordinate to any outside cleric depending on the structure of the religion. Whether independent or obedient to a bishop, however, they are undoubtedly under at least some pressure to cooperate with the local government. Any organization with the money, popular influence, and land holdings held by a major temple is going to have to come to some kind of terms with the local ruler. Minor shrines and remote monasteries may be able to avoid the worst of these exactions.

d12 Their Relations With the Larger Faith

1	Schismatic, despised as heretical
2	Desultory, an apathetic jobsworth sentiment
3	Carceral, a punishment-post for wrongdoers
4	Affable, courteous and cooperative
5	Populist, focusing on the poor lay believers
6	Intellectual, given to sophisticated theology
7	Occult, conducting theurgic magic studies
8	Pioneering, a new missionary establishment
9	Zealous, full of fervent believers
10	Subverted, controlled by a secular power
11	Venerable, old and greatly honored
12	Sectarian, a stronghold of a particular faction

People of the Court

d12	Major Figure	Minor Figure	The Source of their Power in the Court
1	Affiliated Noble	Cleric of Lax Morals	They are thought to produce wondrous miracles
2	Charismatic Priest	Corrupt Priest	They have acknowledged magical skills
3	Dubious Theologian	Fanatical Zealot	Their mastery of doctrine is unanswerable
4	Gifted Healer	Holy Goods Peddler	They've the backing of secret but powerful heretics
5	Guard Captain	Loud Reformer	Local lay believers support them with money and help
6	High Priest	Pious Criminal Boss	They've noble or oligarchic relatives
7	Holy Oracle	Sick Petitioner	They're an expert at seduction and manipulation
8	Richest Lay Member	Slave of the Faith	Charismatic leadership and keen insight aid them
9	Sacred Figurehead	Temple Artisan	They have a pious noble who backs them
10	Stern Inquisitor	Temple Guard	They secretly arrange criminal services for the court
11	Temple Sorcerer	Temple Prostitute	They have a particularly holy lineage or role
12	Temple Treasurer	Tenant Farmer	The upper hierarchy of the faith favors them

Problems of the Court

d12	Internal Conflicts	External Conflicts
1	Someone came up with a very seductive heresy	A popular preacher is leading lay believers astray
2	Omens of divine displeasure have manifested	A rival sect is moving on their unofficial territory
3	A vital ritual item or component has been lost	A noble believer demands an impossible miracle
4	The leader and their chief rival sabotage each other	Court property is being seized by a rival power
5	A forbidden relationship has formed among clergy	The god's power seems feeble to people lately
6	A member demands a very costly ritual be performed	The ruler wants the court to take on an unpopular role
7	Members fight over who is to conduct a great ritual	The upper hierarchy is fighting over the court somehow
8	The greater faith declared a vital activity anathema	A holy demagogue is preaching against the court
9	The clergy have taken up a costly and wicked habit	The ruler is trying to suborn control over the court
10	A zealot reformer is demanding impractical reforms	A noble adherent is demanding special concessions
11	Poverty or need is forcing them to compromise piety	An outside cleric is trying to claim leadership
12	A member is screwing up an important court duty	Rivals are blaming the court for some misfortune



COURT TAGS

Like the other tags in this section, Court Tags are meant to be interpreted in terms of the Court they're modifying. *Affliction's Mark* representing a wasting disease on a temple's senior clergy is going to have a very different flavor than the tumor eating away at a crime boss' brain. A desperate search for the crime that inflicted such a dreadful divine punishment might fit one, while a criminal gang cast into paranoid dread of the boss' mercurial temperament is more in line for the other.

Some tags come with implicit problems as part of their description; an *Awkward Birth* carries with it the turmoil that the Court is experiencing as it tries to deal with a child that shouldn't exist. If you're going to the trouble of generating a Court, it's probably so you can use it in an adventure, so these problems and crises should be phrased in ways that the PCs can get involved in them. The situation might be so delicately balanced between different major players in the Court that the small nudge a group of skilled outsiders can provide is just what it takes to bring the matter to a resolution.

Other tags are more descriptive in nature, and don't have an obvious built-in problem to present to the PCs. In those cases you can just use that tag to flavor the complication implied by the other, or else draw the tag to its extreme and make the Court deal with the consequences of maintaining their place or behavior in the face of an uncooperative world.

Two Court Tags are usually sufficient to give a group its own flavor and style. A royal court made up of three or four quarreling noble houses might have each of the contenders built as their own Court, each with their own pair of tags and their own internal tensions to go with their external rivalries.

Conversely, you might mix two tags for a single Court, but then roll a few more to flavor individual major figures in it, using them as metaphors or creative cues to give personality or detail to the participants in the Court's intrigues. Still, as in all sandbox affairs, don't build more than you need for your immediate content requirements. You can always add more detail later.

d100	Tag	d100	Tag
1–2	Affliction's Mark	51–52	Iron Law
3–4	Ancestral Obligation	53–54	Lost Purpose
5–6	Awesome Legitimacy	55–56	Magical Subversion
7–8	Awkward Birth	57–58	Ministerial Capture
9–10	Blandished Leadership	59–60	New Generation
11–12	Cadet Branches	61–62	New Opportunity
13–14	Capricious Orders	63–64	Outside Debts
15–16	Cultural Insignia	65–66	Overextended Grasp
17–18	Daring Ambition	67–68	Poisonous Cliques
19–20	Dark Secret	69–70	Priestly Influence
21–22	Decadent Court	71–72	Proxy Speaker
23–24	Devil's Bargain	73–74	Rampant Corruption
25–26	Diplomatic Demands	75–76	Recent Brutality
27–28	Disputed Inheritance	77–78	Regency Council
29–30	Excess Heirs	79–80	Restive Lessers
31–32	False Prize	81–82	Rival Dreams
33–34	Fatal Extravagance	83–84	Rival Power
35–36	Forbidden Romance	85–86	Ruling Regalia
37–38	Foreign Ties	87–88	Runaway Rule
39–40	Gate Keeper	89–90	Shining Successor
41–42	Hidden Blight	91–92	Splendid Seat
43–44	Hopeless Rival	93–94	Sublime Skill
45–46	Impure Blood	95–96	Sudden Strength
47–48	Inadequate Tools	97–98	Threatened Violence
49–50	Inept Ruler	99–00	Waning Wealth

Affliction's Mark

Some sort of persistent, incurable illness is gnawing at the court. The principle leader might have been felled by it, or a beloved member, or it may be a spreading curse within its circles. Acute diseases will likely have the sufferers desperate to find some cure, while chronic illnesses might need regular infusions of some costly or morally-dubious remedy.

- E** Manipulative quack, Amorally desperate parent, Secret spreader of plague
- F** Appealing victim, Struggling physician, Worried spouse-to-be of a victim
- C** The sickness is a direct result of their choices, A faction would profit enormously if the current victims died, The only known cure comes with a dire moral or material cost
- T** Palliative that can slow or ease the disease, Proof of its source or cause, The price gathered to pay for a perhaps-real cure
- P** Hushed and shadowed sickroom, Gathering place with an air of forced gaiety, Untouched quarters of the recently dead

Awesome Legitimacy

The things that are certain in life are death, taxes, and this court. They are important, they have always been important, and they always will be important. They may wax and wane, but no one in their society can imagine them ever ceasing to exist, and at most the locals can only think of seizing control of the court or compelling its cooperation. Its destruction is unthinkable. It may have absolute control of some critical social function, have members of legendary awe, or be viewed as the personal property of some divinity or godlike entity.

- E** Implacable tyrant consecrated by custom, Manipulator who cloaks his will in the court's legitimacy, Outsider who'll ruin the court despite the chaos such a thing would create
- F** Court member keenly aware of their responsibility, Local haplessly oppressed by the court, Outsider who deals cautiously with the court
- C** The court really is as indispensable as it seems, The source of its untouchability is weakening, If it goes down it's taking much of local society with it
- T** Regalia of ancient authority, Dusty deed to a rich property, Wealth of a failed rebel against it
- P** Long-forgotten spare throne room, Ancient archive, Gathering place in use for ages

Ancestral Obligation

The court was impressed with some great task, duty, or role by its founder, and much of its influence or moral authority hinges on continuing to carry out that task. Its traditions and structure revolve around being able to carry out the work. Failure means disgrace and perhaps tangible penalties as old pacts are broken. Aside from this, neglecting the duty may result in other negative consequences, perhaps to parties other than the court itself.

- E** Schemer who'd profit by the duty's disruption, Rebel who hates the duty and care nothing for the consequences, Tyrannical leader who forces others to bear the duty's cost
- F** Grimly-determined keeper, Sympathetic member who suffers from the work, Outsider desperately reliant on the work being done well
- C** No one fully understands the duty's meaning any more, The duty comes at a terrible cost, Recent calamity has left them too weak for the work
- T** Vital tool for carrying out the job, Ancient payment for the work, Key to lifting the burden
- P** Ancient work-chamber, Hall emblazoned with symbols of the work, Training hall for carrying on the work

Awkward Birth

A pregnancy is roiling the court and causing severe problems. It may be that a member is pregnant by the wrong man, or a pairing took place that was shocking to society, or a newly-born heir is showing signs of inherited Blight, or a new heir suddenly excludes a displeased prior incumbent. The court can't hush it forever, and abortion is either impractical, unacceptable, or too dangerous to the mother. This may not stop certain members from trying.

- E** Elder who would see the problem "solved", Murderously suspicious husband, Demoted heir
- F** Naive young lover, Desperate hidden paramour, Worried sire of the unwanted child
- C** Secret accusations of illegitimacy are being passed through the court, The disgraced husband's family is enraged, The pregnancy is just a tool the mother is using to get her way
- T** Proof of the real father, Blackmail material on the court's leadership, Wealth stolen away by the former presumptive heir
- P** Nursery much worse-appointed than expected, Prison-like room for the expectant mother, Stronghold estate of the disappointed former heir



Blandished Leadership

The leadership has been led astray by one or more pretty girls or boys. They dote on their paramours, granting them extravagant favors and imperiling the court with the lengths they go to in order to please their beloved. Those not given to romantic dizziness may be enraptured by more physical talents, so occupied in the business of night that nothing is done in the day.

- E** Rival who sent them the playthings as gifts, Ruthlessly manipulative lover, Murderously angry neglected spouse
- F** Sadly displaced former favorite, Frustrated underling, Disapproving moralist
- C** The paramours have a supernatural edge in their charms, Their spouse likes them distracted so as to carry out their own plans, The court is fighting over influence with the paramours rather than the leadership
- T** Priceless luxury demanded by a lover, Trinket of great worth abandoned by them, Wealth gathered to build some pleasure for them
- P** Seraglio of constant liveliness, Court hall abandoned by the leadership, Pleasure-garden redolent of luxury

Capricious Orders

The court is issuing unreasonable orders to those under its authority, demanding excessive tribute, unreasonable obediences, or similar sacrifices. The court leader may be new and over-confident of their power, or the court may be in dire trouble and needs more resources, or rival forces may be goading or manipulating the court into overplaying its hand out of recklessness or ignorance of the true state of affairs.

- E** Arrogant new lord, Mentally unstable or bewitched ruler, Scheming advisor in a rival power's pay
- F** Mistreated subject of the court, Frustrated moderate member, Reasonable rival of the current ruler
- C** The demands are all to fulfill a great secret plan, The demands are punishment for a failed rebellion, The court doesn't want to make the demands but is somehow forced to do so
- T** Heavy load of tribute, Stolen treasure that the court demanded be produced, Privately-diverted wealth from the demands
- P** Angry court reception hall, Public plaza with darkly-grumbling locals, Enterprise closed down due to a failure to deliver on the demands

Cadet Branches

The authority of the court is somewhat splintered, with multiple cadet branches of the family, enterprise, or department having their own share of its power. These branches are likely to struggle over control of the main court, with some of them perhaps preferring the court's dissolution rather than allowing a hated rival to gain control of it.

- E** Disgraced scion with a plan for revenge, Ruler who hates a particular branch, Scheming leader of a minor branch
- F** Bastard offspring seeking recognition, Visionary from a cadet branch, Rightful leader denied their place
- C** One "cadet" branch actually has a right to rule but is too weak to claim it, The main court plays the branches against each other, Outside rivals want the court to remain splintered
- T** Proof of a branch's illegitimacy, Bribe paid to get a branch to cooperate, Blackmail material on the main court's ruler
- P** Ostentatious branch estate, More modest but far older main estate, Court hall with places for all the branches

Cultural Insignia

The court produces some famously revered cultural product, such as literature, poetry, painting, sculpture, music, dance, or other art form. Their members may have a direct tradition of production, or they may be the critical patrons of a tradition of artists or a school that produces the product. The product wins them respect among the cultured, and many would be glad to assist them in exchange for the luster of association.

- E** Ruler who would crush rival schools, Chief artist gone mad with jealousy or megalomania, Rival artist determined to destroy the tradition
- F** Earnest young artistic genius, Poor court member determined to patronize as best they can, Unworldly aesthete concerned only with art
- C** The art has actual magical powers when well-made, The art encourages or glorifies some reprehensible cause, The artists are savagely factional in their different schools
- T** Lost legendary work of art, Proof that a famed piece of art is a forgery of the original, Hidden masterwork of a dead genius
- P** Salon dedicated to appreciating the art, Workshop where the art is made, Grand public structure adorned with the art

Daring Ambition

The court has a grand ambition which is driving its actions, and it's making a major bet on its ability to achieve its goal. Failure will mean catastrophe for the court, while success promises great rewards. Not all the members of the court are necessarily sharing the same risks and potential payoff, however, and some may be paying more than they'd ever profit.

- E** Megalomaniacal leader, Well-meaning but hopelessly optimistic ruler, Secret manipulator driving the ambition
- F** Sympathetic necessary sacrifice for the cause, Court member struggling to do their share, Ally who'd profit if the court succeeded
- C** The court thinks the ambition is one thing but the leadership knows it's another, The ambition's success would be a poisoned gift, A faction plans to monopolize the benefit or shift all the loss
- T** Critical material for the ambition, Costly remnants of a failed effort, A valuable result of progress in the ambition
- P** Enterprise or establishment dedicated to the cause, Newly-constructed edifice, Hall optimistically prepared to celebrate victory

Decadent Court

The court is too absorbed in their pleasures and indulgences. Their cooperation is purchased with coin or flesh, their disports grow ever more costly and excessive, and even the minor members are getting accustomed to shameful enjoyments. Their power is being turned toward facilitating their membership's appetites rather than fulfilling whatever role got them their status in the first place.

- E** Jaded and sensation-starved ruler, Cruel panderer for the court's hungers, Monstrous entity that sponsors or encourages vice
- F** Escaped would-be subject, Inquisitive outside investigator, Frustrated native in need of the court's execution of its duty
- C** The court's leadership is uninvolved and using the vices to blackmail and control their underlings, The court's trying to spread its vices in its own social stratum and profit accordingly, A faction is taking things much too far even for their brethren and involving occult powers
- T** Debt-slave contracts, Hideous but precious idol or art object, Valuable drug made from slaves
- P** Debauched salon, Court public hall made sinister, Pit where the human chattel are kept

Dark Secret

The court has a dark secret that would cost it dearly if it were to be revealed. Loss of influence, station, money, or power might all be consequent. It may involve old treacheries, hidden crimes, secret illegitimacies, dark pacts, or harsh choices that were unavoidable at the time. The uppermost ranks likely know the truth, but the lesser members may have nothing but unpleasant suspicions.

- E** The villain they're allied with, Ruthless keeper of secrets, Amorally villainous ruler
- F** Secretly worried lesser court member, Outside investigator, Bitter survivor of the court's crime
- C** The act was acceptable or normal at the time it was committed, Revealing it would implicate other important powers, The court's leadership has tried to quietly make amends for it
- T** Proof of the heinous crime, Precious treasure acquired through the sin, Valuable relic taken from a victim of the crime
- P** Secret archive full of dark evidence, Noble monument built on a dark substrate, Private sanctum for only the inner circle

Devil's Bargain

The court made a bargain that's now coming back to haunt them. Some pact with an outside power gave them a crucial edge or a desperately-needed boost, but now it needs to provide services, favors, or help that could end up destroying it or costing its leadership dearly. The pact was probably secret at the time, and even revealing it exists could have dire repercussions.

- E** Vile entity it pacted with, Ruler planning on foisting the price off on a victim, Heartless creditor who cares nothing for the damage it does
- F** Undeserving victim of the price, Rival who suspects something is up, Enemy of the power they pacted with
- C** Only a small faction of the court knows about the bargain, The current leadership didn't know about the deal until it was threatened into compliance, The power they pacted with is a mortal enemy of their society
- T** Blackmail material the pact granter is using to control them, Potent relic granted in the deal, Heavy tribute due to the pacting power
- P** Monument to the victory the pact secretly gave them, Secret chambers for the pact's granter, Shrine to the dark entity they propitiated



Diplomatic Demands

Some rival or outside power is making demands on the court that they cannot easily ignore. It might involve some prior offense in need of reparations, a past deal that's come due, or a price required for a favor that the court desperately needs. These demands are more than the court can easily pay, and determining where the burden will fall most heavily is a matter of fierce internal politics.

- E** Scheming shifter of burdens, Outside rival bent on begging the court, Incompetent diplomat who's only making things worse
- F** Victim of unfair exactions, Harried diplomat with no cards to play, Native who desperately needs the deal to go through
- C** The exactions demanded are purely punitive, There's a specific temporary reason the court has to acknowledge the demands, Another party could give a better deal if they were persuaded
- T** Huge down payment on the demands, The precious object the court is trying to acquire, Proof that the demands are unjustified
- P** Diplomatic retreat full of tense people, Site of the problem causing the demands, Hushed court hall full of whispers

Excess Heirs

While the ruler remains vigorous, they have too many legitimate heirs for the court to comfortably absorb. There's not enough wealth or power to give the losers a dignified station, or else the losing heirs may expect to be executed, or the heirs are locked in a court-disrupting battle to force their desired outcome. Various heirs might be backed by rival outside powers searching for a convenient catspaw.

- E** Cruel but talented crown prince, Scion in league with dark powers, Secretly murderous spare heir
- F** Capable but hard-pressed candidate, Hapless ruler unable to enforce a choice, Vengeful retainer of a murdered heir
- C** The ruler desires a Darwinian culling of heirs, The court desperately needs the heirs to cooperate to overcome a threat, Several heirs were formerly unknown
- T** Proof of a candidate's illegitimacy, Bribe from an enemy power, Relic meant to eliminate a rival
- P** Well-fortified home of an heir, Court hall where the factions are well-separated, Ritual occasion of enforced amity

Disputed Inheritance

The court's rule or property is due to pass on to the next generation, but there are multiple claimants to it. Each has some colorable legitimacy, and factions and secret supporters are doubtless rife in the court. They're well-balanced enough that brute force seems a risky route to take, though matters are rapidly coming to a head as the need to establish a new leader is intense.

- E** Cruel and vicious heir, Incompetent heir who has the best claim, Outside enemy backing the strife
- F** Most talented heir but with the worst position, Hapless heir in dire need of protection, Loyal retainer trying to avert disaster
- C** Legitimacy rests on possession of a now-lost relic, If the struggle lasts much longer the patrimony will be ruined or lost, A selfish regent is exploiting the court during the interregnum
- T** Bribe intended for the faction leaders, Precious relic of legitimacy, The real and verified will
- P** Tense and angry court meeting hall, Heir's country estate, Court plaza where the factions don't mingle

False Prize

The court is trying to obtain a goal or ambition that will actually be disastrous for it. Either through political miscalculation, ignorance of the truth, or willful blindness to the consequences, they're plunging headlong towards calamity. Rivals might be secretly aiding them in their purpose, while factions within the court may be uselessly protesting the danger of the path they've chosen.

- E** Foolhardy ruler with grand plans, Treacherous advisor encouraging disaster, Trickster leading the court to its ruin
- F** Clear-sighted court member who is being ignored, Victim of the danger the court is facing, Disfavored faction leader warning of peril
- C** The prize's benefits will attract an overwhelming foe, The prize will corrupt or ruin the court's leadership, The prize comes with secret problems or obligations that will plague the court
- T** Proof that the prize would be a disaster, The key to unlocking the prize, Rich reward that seems to be a foretaste of the prize's benefits
- P** Edifice built as part of the effort, Ruined seat of a former holder of the prize, Secret facility where terrible prices are paid in pursuit of it

Fatal Extravagance

The court is exhausting itself on luxuries or displays of magnificence that it cannot truly afford. It may feel pressured to do so in order to maintain face before its rivals, or it may over-estimate its resources, or it may be being manipulated by whatever group they're buying their luxuries from. Optimistic courts may be betting on a future windfall that may or may not come.

- E** Smiling merchant of addictive drugs, Grandiose ruler, Selfishly hedonistic court member
- F** Court member vainly trying to economize, Worried accountant, Client upset at the lack of expenditures on their vital need
- C** The extravagance is serving a secret magical or ritual purpose, It's being paid for with debt the court intends to never need to repay, The waste is the product of a new ruler who has different expectations of what they deserve
- T** Shipment of precious luxuries, Payment meant for the next round of indulgences, Precious item that is to be pawned or sold to fund the luxuries
- P** Gaudily-adorned court structure, Celebration of wild excess, Ostentatious and newly-built monument to their luxuries

Foreign Ties

The court has strong ties with some foreign power or organization, one that may or may not be hostile to their greater polity. The court draws some considerable advantage from this tie, but it's also expected to assist its affiliate in their own local goals. If the affiliate is an enemy or rival of their people, this tie may be carefully hidden, or it may be a known scandal about the court.

- E** Foreign spymaster with demands, Rival who despises the foreign power, Court member who's a wholly-owned agent of the power
- F** Appealing foreign petitioner, Harried court member trying to square their obligations, Outside inquisitor into suspicious doings
- C** The power used to be friendly to the polity but has recently been viewed as a rival, The court is secretly reliant on the foreign power's support, The support consists of the foreign power not doing something that they could do
- T** Funding from the power, Precious item the court needs to turn over, The macguffin the power wants the court to obtain for them
- P** Court hall in an architectural style like that of the power, Home with foreign-derived elements, Archive with documents in a foreign tongue

Forbidden Romance

Someone in the court is deeply in love with someone they shouldn't be. It may be a rival from another court, a lowly commoner, an incestuous bond, an attraction to a forbidden demihuman, a fellow court member's spouse, or a spectacularly horrible person who can only bring them misery. This love may or may not be reciprocated, and it may be an open secret to others.

- E** Unreciprocated lover who won't take no for an answer, Cruelly manipulative object of affection, Court elder bent on terminating the relationship
- F** Earnest matchmaker friend, Appealing paramour, Aspiring peacemaker who wants the match
- C** The reasons for opposing the match are extremely good, The court member is being exploited by the paramour or their manipulators, A rival court member wants the match to go through so the court member will be disgraced
- T** Proof that the lover is not what they seem, A gift the enamored should not have given, A token that will legitimize the pairing
- P** Secret rendezvous spot, Hidden prison for a reluctant lover, Court festival where unacceptable hints are given

Gate Keeper

The court controls access to some critical resource or social function. It might have an effective lock on the local law, or control the irrigation network for regional farms, or provide vital religious services to faithful believers. If it abuses this power too greatly, however, its rivals will combine against it and may seize control of the resource.

- E** Reckless leader who's overplaying their hand, Outside schemer planning to break their monopoly, Corrupt court member who's undermining the control for their own benefit
- F** Earnest outsider with a monopoly-breaking idea, Frustrated court member trying to reform the monopoly's administration, Hard-pressed local mistreated by the monopoly
- C** The next alternative monopolist is much worse, A monopoly-breaker has vile intentions, The monopoly rests with them for secret but very good reasons
- T** Some good produced by the monopoly, License or leave to violate the monopoly, Device that greatly weakens the monopoly
- P** Site where the monopoly is practiced, Secret wildcatter site of unlicensed production, Private production site of one of the court's elites



Hidden Blight

One or more members of the court are afflicted with the Blight, but are concealing their condition. Their particular Blight is not physically obvious to onlookers, but may have severe psychological or hidden physical manifestations. At least some of the other court members have a good reason to aid this concealment, if only to avoid the scandal of being known to carry Blighted genetics.

- E** Blight-demented leader being shielded by others, Ruthless investigator seeking answers, Murderous court member bent on “resolving” matters
- F** Blighted struggling with their curse, Court member trying to protect the secret, Blighted parent trying to help their child
- C** The Blight is light enough to be lifted somehow, The Blight is somehow useful to the afflicted, They disguise the Blight as a wildly excessive human inclination
- T** Drug that ameliorates the Blight, Proof of a Blighted lineage, Bribe paid to hush the matter
- P** Secret retreat for expressing Blighted urges, Hall of glorified ancestral memorials, Prison for badly-affected Blighted members

Impure Blood

Bloodline and lineage are important to the court, either because of a bloodline-dependent power or a society that places much importance on it. Despite this, the court’s lineage would be considered impure by others were it fully known, perhaps due to some secret pairings in the remote past. The court might have to go to extremes in order to mimic the powers appropriate to their supposed bloodline, or else go to similar extents to crush any hint of the truth.

- E** Court assassin cleaning up loose ends, Rival prying into a dangerous leak, Court member making a terrible bargain to blot out the stain
- F** Court member undeserving of the obloquy, Innocent threatened with disaster by the truth, Hunter seeking the entity they pacted with
- C** The “impurity” was once celebrated in the hidden past, It’s an open secret but their rivals lack actionable proof, They’re privately working to overthrow the rules that would call them impure
- T** Proof of their impurity, Device that gives them power they wouldn’t normally have, Inheritance from their hidden ancestry
- P** Hidden site associated with their concealed blood, Proud monument to their social station, Secret graves of their real ancestors

Hopeless Rival

The court has a rival or enemy that bears a burning desire to destroy them. Unfortunately for them, they’re wholly incapable of doing so. This fanatical desire may be born of past crimes, cheated opportunities, or an ancient feud. In their desperation to strike at their enemy, it’s likely the rival will go to extreme and unwise lengths, perhaps making bargains they ought not to make.

- E** Oft-beaten rival of the court’s ruler, Disgraced court member turned renegade, Spare heir with a grudge
- F** Sympathetic enemy of the court, Rival’s associate trying to stop them from going too far, Inquisitor looking into nefarious dealings
- C** The rival’s hate is very justifiable, The rival’s engineering a clash with a greater power, The rival is being set up as a kamikaze attack by a manipulative third party
- T** Doomsday tool the rival means to use, Blackmail material on the court, Precious relic the rival paid dearly to acquire
- P** Site of the rival’s past defeat, Location related to the hate, Structure built with the fruits of the court’s past victory

Inadequate Tools

The court’s authority and power have been sustained for a long time by a particular set of tools and tactics, such as violence, money, blackmail, legal rights, or perhaps by particular alliances with other powers. Recent events or clumsy missteps by the court have rendered these old tools no longer effective, but the leadership doesn’t have any better idea than to use them again, but harder this time.

- E** Manipulator goading the ruler to excesses, Frustrated ruler with no new ideas, Court member scheming to restore their old power
- F** Anguished victim of their overreach, Court member trying to find new footing, Member fearful of the consequences of their frustration
- C** The tools are “working” but are building up a ruinous debt of resentment, Their efforts are only serving to strengthen their rivals, The tools are actually going to be completely successful if the ruler’s scheme to push them to an extreme works
- T** Relic to empower their favorite tactic, Wealth needed to fuel their plans, Priceless implement necessary to effectively use their tactics
- P** Structure dedicated to their favorite methods, Site where the method went awry, Site of the method currently in use

Inept Ruler

The court's ruler is incompetent or debilitated, but there's no practical way to remove them from power. The alternative might be utterly unacceptable, or the ruler's bungling might be very much to the benefit of a powerful faction in the court. Rivals are doubtless making plans to take advantage of the situation, and internal factions may well be willing to take acceptable losses in order to profit by the chaos.

- E** Insane ruler, Sincere but utterly unsuitable leader, Sinister manipulator influencing the puppet ruler
- F** Competent but unsupported alternative ruler, Victim of the ruler's bungling, Faction leader being crushed by the ruler's ineptitude
- C** The ruler seems like an idiot but is actually trying to achieve a secret goal with their actions, Rival courts are vigorously backing the leader, The leader's deposition would result in a ruinous state of chaos for the court
- T** Token that would legitimize a change of rule, Object that would cure the ruler's incapacity, Wealth that was lost by the leader's bungling
- P** Damaged or decrepit structure owing to the ruler's neglect, Chaotic and confused court hall, Building erected as a folly by the ruler

Lost Purpose

The court's original formation revolved around a particular duty or role that has long since been forgotten. This may be a metaphorical forgetting, like a idealistic young businessman turning to cold-hearted avarice, or it may be a literal loss of some ancient charge or consecrated role. This forgetting may have left the court with ancestral obligations they no longer understand, or resources they no longer use in the intended way.

- E** Leader wholly absorbed in their own ambitions, Outsider made hostile by the court's failure to do their duty, Enemy who prospers by their forgetting
- F** Earnest historian who knows the truth, Last stubborn upholder of the role, Petitioner who needs them to do their old duty
- C** The purpose was a vile and terrible one, Their current prosperity depends on ignoring the purpose, The consequences of their forgetting are going to be dire
- T** Proof of their original purpose, Potent artifact meant to aid their role, Treasure once given to them in repayment for their work
- P** Forgotten chamber for the duty, Lost site of importance, Place damaged by the forgetting

Iron Law

There are troublesome or problematic laws to the court that its members simply cannot break. They may be enforced by magical curses, by an inborn predilection of the court's members, or by a tradition that would unite all rivals against the offender. These laws are likely preventing them from resolving a problem that is currently growing worse.

- E** Suicidally rigid ruler, Troublemaker who exploits the law, Traitor who is somehow immune to the law's force
- F** Innovator trying to work around the law or repeal it, Troubled defender of the law who sees the problem, Affiliate who can't be helped because of the law
- C** The law is there for a good reason and breaking it would be worse than the problem, The law can be changed if a certain great deed is done, The law's enforcer is corrupt or mutable in judgment
- T** Key object that gives the law its force, Token that allows the bearer to ignore or lift the law, Precious treasure that is unreachable as long as the law remains in force
- P** Chamber of judgment, Punishment place for offenders, Site of the growing problem

Magical Subversion

Some member of the court is under magical influence by another, be it an outside enemy or internal rival. It may be mind-bending sorcery, a persistent magical curse, or an arcane blessing that will last only so long as they cooperate. The culprit has some means of ensuring this subversion is not easily detected, either through occult arts or simply ensuring that others never get curious enough to look for such things.

- E** Harmless-seeming member who's a secret mage, Mercenary sorcerer hired by rivals, Court favorite who induces that affection with magic
- F** Suspicious local mage, Relative with suspicions but no proof, Victim of uncharacteristic behavior by the subverted member
- C** The subversion is part of a known and accepted enchantment on the target, They'll die or suffer horribly if the subversion is lifted, They're consciously cooperating with the subverter
- T** Charm to lift the curse or mindbending, Proof of magical interference, The artifact being used to subvert the target
- P** Out-of-place location to find the target, Site that's recently been changed to fit their new demands, Sinister lair where the enchantment was wrought



Ministerial Capture

The upper functionaries or senior household servants of the court have taken effective control of it. The members may be too distracted to realize what's been done, or the servants may have irresistible blackmail on them, or they may have the unjustified but complete trust of the proper leadership. These functionaries are using the court's resources to pursue their own aggrandizement and profit.

- E** Colorless senior bureaucrat, Scheming butler, Spymaster or intelligence chief turned kingmaker
- F** Minor court member who realizes the problem, Lesser functionary upset by the corruption, Proper leader made helpless by the situation
- C** The ministers think the proper leadership is incompetent, The ministers are really serving a rival, The leadership honestly prefers to leave everything to the ministers
- T** Documentation proving ministerial malfeasance, Malversated court resources, Blackmail evidence on the court leadership
- P** Abandoned official audience chamber, Private residence of the ministerial kingmaker, Clerkly offices bustling with petitioners

New Opportunity

Some special new opportunity has been presented to the court, one that offers a great deal of personal wealth or glory. Only some of the court can take advantage of it, however, and it can be easily spoiled by dissent from within; they argue now over who is to be allowed to exploit the opportunity. New unexplored lands, royal monopoly patents, the hand of a very eligible spouse, or some other limited windfall awaits the winner.

- E** Bitter enemy who had the opportunity taken from them and given to the court, Jealous internal spoiler who plots to ruin it, Leader who greedily seeks to keep all of it to themselves
- F** Talented but ill-supported candidate, Outsider who wants the opportunity handled fairly, Disenfranchised true discoverer of the opportunity
- C** It's a trap and will ruin those who embrace it, The ease of any one spoiler ruining it has paralyzed deliberations, The opportunity has its own ideas about who should exploit it
- T** Key to unlocking the opportunity, Rich treasure safeguarded by the opportunity, Token that will allow the holder to exploit the opportunity
- P** Site where the new chance is brightest, Camp or building for preparations, Site of a failed effort

New Generation

The court's prior leadership was recently decimated by age, sickness, misadventure, or political executions, leaving many leadership posts in the hands of much younger, less experienced members. Few of them have a firm grasp on practicalities, and they're acting with a confidence and boldness that may not necessarily be justified by their actual skills.

- E** Reckless spare heir turned ruler, Upstart using a role purely for their personal advantage, Outside rival pouncing on their untested leadership
- F** Harried senior advisor who is ignored, Baffled new ruler who doesn't understand how it works, Idealistic new office-holder with big dreams
- C** The new generation is being held back by ossified existing members, They have magnificent plans that will fail spectacularly, They didn't want the jobs but were forced into them by circumstances
- T** Lost treasure or resources the old guard hid, Ceremonial regalia that imbues legitimacy, Secret plans or archives that the former ruler hid
- P** Newly-remodeled court residence, Audience hall adorned with freshly-changed arms, Ministerial office full of confused and harried clerks

Outside Debts

The court owes something awful to a pitiless outside power, whether a rival court, an enemy of their homeland, a vile sorcerer, a merciless banker, or a grasping lord. The consequences of failing to repay the debt would be catastrophic, but the court can't afford to do so without some members of them being ruined by the price, whether in coin, criminal conviction, disgrace, or eternal damnation.

- E** Ruler who means to shift the debt to another, Savage enforcer of the debt, Culprit who brought the debt on them with their ambitions
- F** Innocent being forced to pay the price, Suspicious investigator looking into the debt, Past victim of the creditor's cruel ways
- C** Revealing the debt's existence would ruin the court, The creditor completely deserves to be paid, An old rival has bought the debt and now holds it
- T** Riches needed to pay off the debt, Proof that the contract was invalid, The document or token that is needed to enforce the debt
- P** Lair of the creditor, Court holding being sold or given away to help satisfy the debt, Great court ceremony made insultingly meager to save money

Overextended Grasp

The court has seized control of land, offices, noble roles, businesses, or some other valuable holding, but they do not hold it securely. Rival forces are pressing on them and they have exhausted their resources in simply gaining the prize, and have nothing left with which to keep it in the face of resistance. The rivals may simply be fighting to determine which of them is to overthrow the overextended court's grip.

- E** Foolishly ambitious ruler, Schemer who has profited by the reach even if it fails, Desperate leader who is abusing the prize to help keep it
- F** Former holder of the prize trying to regain it, Earnest new owner in far over their head, Loyal retainer struggling with insufficient resources
- C** The prize is a poisoned fruit that will destroy them if they don't let it go, They gambled on support that has been somehow delayed or denied, They mean to destroy the prize rather than lose it
- T** Riches meant for the owner of the prize, Device or document that will destroy the prize's value, Treasure the rivals mean to use to seize the prize
- P** Seat of the prize's authority, Court holding that's understaffed and under-resourced, Marginal prize holding that's already been lost

Poisonous Cliques

The court is riven by at least two viciously hostile cliques, both of which are determined to ruin or kill the other. Nonaligned members of the court are forced to submit to one or the other lest they be enemies to both and all normal business of the court is paralyzed by their incessant quarreling. This hostility may be open and overt, or it may be veiled behind venomous courtesies and cruelly heartless protocols.

- E** Outside rival who provoked the clique formation, Traitor seeking mutual destruction, Brutal clique leader who will do anything for victory
- F** Unaligned member trying to stay alive, Outside ally distressed by the infighting, Weak leader unable to rein in the hostilities
- C** One clique is sympathetic but just as determined to attain total victory as the other, The cliques are destroying the very prize they fight over, A secret internal faction waits to pick up the pieces
- T** Treasure the cliques are fighting over, Tool or artifact meant to break the stalemate, Documents showing a traitor within one clique's leadership
- P** Well-separated court residences for the cliques, Holding ruined by their infighting, Destroyed former residence of a loser of the fighting



Priestly Influence

The court's leadership is in the thrall of a particular religion or holy figure, and their wishes are given an undue weight. This influence may be a matter of perfectly sincere faith, or the religion might have some special grip on the court due to blackmail, services rendered, or special need. Such influence often brings the hostility of rival faiths until a more equitable arrangement is made.

- E** Rasputin-esque holy figure, Zealously pious ruler, Spider-minded court chaplain with strings on everyone
- F** Court member who favors a different god, Cast-off former house priest, Client abandoned so that resources could go to the faith
- C** The faith is giving major help to the court, The sect the court follows is considered heretical by the main faith, The faith's opponents in the court are being backed by a hostile outside group
- T** Sacred relic of the faith, Costly tithe sum to be offered to the faith, Symbol of authority over the court's religious practice
- P** Grand newly-built chapel, Abandoned chapel of a former faith, Ritual site for a new ceremony

Rampant Corruption

The court is so corrupt that it's crippling its ability to function. Even the most mundane exercises of authority require that the right people be bribed or induced, and its members have little or no interest in the overall good of the group. The leadership is hanging together only because the court is profitable and they will defend it only insofar as it remains so.

- E** Hopelessly venal ruler, Greedy kingmaker behind the scenes, Colorless head bureaucrat with sticky palms
- F** Member with an earnest loyalty to principle, Court member cast out for not playing along, Victim of some bribed crime the court committed
- C** The court's members actually desperately need the money, All the graft is going to only a few strong hands, Their enemies have multiple traitors on their payrolls
- T** Great hoard of extracted pelf, Inescapable proof of a leader's wrongdoing, Misdirected bribe payment
- P** Grimy back room where deals are made, Court salon made a market for favors, Court structure clearly starved of its supposed funds

Proxy Speaker

The court's leader communicates only through a particular proxy, be it a chief minister, spouse, heir, concubine, confessor, or other figure of importance. The leader may be too sick or enfeebled to lead or the proxy may have systematically cut all their other lines of control. The other members of the court may vie for influence over the proxy, perhaps while ignoring their ostensible real ruler.

- E** Grasping favorite odalisque, Impatient heir-proxy, Scheming regent-minister
- F** Worried child of the leader, Cast-off former advisor, Persecuted enemy of the proxy
- C** The proxy is actually the cause of the leader's incapacitation, The proxy is a much better leader than the real one, The proxy is really working for a rival or enemy power
- T** Cure for the leader's incapacitation, Proof of the proxy's unsuitability, Wealth subverted by the proxy
- P** Abandoned throne room, Sick chamber of incapacitated leader, Proxy's office teeming with petitioners

Recent Brutality

Violence is an unfortunate commonplace in many courts, but something happened here recently that was beyond all usual bounds of polite assassination or genteel political execution. Some vast massacre of a whole family line, a berserk slaughter of an unlucky gathering, a humiliating and unthinkable execution of some grandee, or some other dramatic brutality has put everyone on edge and made many start thinking of some previously unthinkable courses of action.

- E** Ruler with out-of-control bloodthirst, Spree-killing spymaster, Brutal court member with no one daring to check them
- F** Heir to a recent victim, Helpless enforcer of the usual norms, Survivor of a recent massacre
- C** The victims arguably deserved it, The source of the violence is being secretly controlled by a member, Everyone else is about to embrace the new norms of violence if it's not punished soon
- T** Device used to enable the killing, Treasure left behind by one of the slain, List of who is to die next
- P** Haunted site of the killing, Secret memorial to the slain, Unbearably tense court ceremony

Regency Council

A council of powerful regents runs the court due to the youth, incapacity, or sickness of the legitimate ruler. Some of these regents may actually have the ruler's interests in mind, but others are exploiting the court's resources for their own benefit, taking it as no more than their just due for their services. Some may be making a point of ensuring that the regency is a permanent state of affairs.

- E** Abusive prime minister, Selfish parent- or relative-regent, Self-absorbed great noble guardian
- F** Loyal servant of the true ruler, Well-meaning member of the council, Deposed former regent who was too loyal
- C** The regents are keeping a totally disastrous ruler from taking power, The strength of the regents is direly needed right now, One or more regents is in a rival power's pay
- T** Proof of the council's treachery, Remedy for the ruler's incapacitation, Resources necessary to make a loyalist strong enough to take control
- P** Council chamber crowded with servants, Private villa for secret dealings, Ceremonial throne room where the ruler is ignored

Rival Dreams

The court has big dreams; unfortunately, they're contradictory. Two or more major factions each have a grand plan for the court's future success, but these plans are incompatible, and the factions are struggling to determine which of them the court will follow. The leader is either incapable of breaking the deadlock or else they support one of the plans but lack sufficient allies to impose it on the unbelievers.

- E** Charismatic but wildly impractical dreamer-lord, Selfish purveyor of a plan that will chiefly aid them, Stubborn ruler who will brook no compromise with their dream
- F** Genius with poor social skills, Inheritor of a familial dream, Would-be peacemaker between the factions
- C** Both dreams are likely to damage the court, They agree on the goal but have contradictory ways of getting there, The dreams are irrelevant and only an excuse to eliminate a rival faction
- T** Vital resources to achieve a plan, Critical device needed for a plan, Proof that a plan is hopeless
- P** Salon or base where a faction schemes, Field where a partially-complete plan is being furthered, Half-completed monument to glory

Restive Lessers

The court's servants and lesser officials are angry with the leadership. Old privileges may have been revoked, traditional rights and fees may have been curtailed, or particular sacrifices or dire perils may have been demanded of them. The court is confident that their lessers can do nothing but obey, but the minions are very close to a dramatic response.

- E** Ruler who cares nothing for their displeasure, Arrogant chief minister, Outside rival backing disunity in the court
- F** Aggrieved lesser official, Worried grandee who sees trouble coming, Client who needs the court's unimpaired assistance
- C** Traditional but corrupt perquisites were reformed and the minions were deprived of them, A much loved official or leader was killed or deposed, Other courts' minions are getting perks or benefits that this court can't afford to give
- T** Subverted wealth traditionally due to the minions, Document proving old rights, Treasure taken from a leader of the minions
- P** Quietly furious servant's quarters, Ominously deserted hall, Far-too-crowded plaza where the minions gather

Rival Power

The official hierarchy of the court is being challenged by a second power source within the organization, one strong enough to stymie its official lord. This may be a faction formed by a powerful lord, a charismatic religious faction, an intrusive consul of a superior power, or an impatient heir with too many friends. Neither power source can act freely while the other exists, but destroying the rival may bring down the court in the process.

- E** Unofficial pretender to the rulership, Secretive kingmaker, Incompetent leader with strong help
- F** Court member trying to make peace, Victim of the rival factions' infighting, Disillusioned former backer of a faction
- C** The rival power has a very good but also very self-interested reason to seek control, The rival power has all the most competent people, The legitimate lord will bring down the court with him if he's overthrown
- T** Tokens of legitimate authority, Blackmail sufficient to ruin a faction, Resources suborned by a faction
- P** Unofficial throne room of the rival faction, Court offices split into different groups, Unnaturally well-fortified country estate of a faction



Ruling Regalia

The court's rulership rests on one or more ancient, powerful relics. Quite aside from any practical use they may have, they symbolize the leader's right of rule, and any loss of them will throw the court into chaos. It's not unknown for the court's leadership to be suddenly changed when a new rival manages to seize them, whether by guile or brute force.

- E** Master thief in the employ of a rival, Strong-arm court member plotting their chance, Outside figure who just wants the relics' power
- F** Traditional guardian of the relics, Ruler too weak to reliably safeguard them, Would-be thief trying to get them from an unworthy ruler
- C** The relics were lost some time ago and are currently forgeries, The power of the relics is objectively necessary for the ruler to function, A bearer will die if the relics are removed for too long
- T** Device that will destroy or nullify a relic, Perfect forgery of a relic, Another relic perfectly identical in all ways
- P** Tightly-guarded repository for the relics, Ceremonial procession showing the relics, Court structure or edifice powered by the relics

Shining Successor

The impending heir to the court is a remarkable figure, gifted with tremendous aptitudes or personal capability. Everyone is convinced they will lead the court to new heights of glory, though existing powers may prefer that glory be postponed indefinitely rather than give up their current posts.

- E** Bitter mother of a rival heir, Ruler who refuses to admit their capability, Vengeful former heir who was put aside
- F** Worried mentor of the successor, Ruler who fears for their successor's safety, Loyal minion of the successor
- C** The successor is a genius but has truly horrible traits as well, The successor is being backed by a rival who thinks to use them, The successor's talents are vast but are precisely the wrong skills for the situation they will face
- T** Regalia due to the rightful heir, A marvelous work produced by the successor, Proof that the successor has no legitimate claim on rulership
- P** Salon where the successor shines brilliantly, Site of a grand triumph by the successor, Throne room where the successor gets more attention than the ruler

Runaway Rule

Out of overwork, sloth, or carelessness, the court has devolved much of its authority on some subsidiary group or power, leaving it to do the dirty work of a critical function. That group has seized control of that authority, however, and now bids fair to claim leadership of the court itself using its newfound leverage.

- E** Ambitious leader of the lesser group, Indolent and careless ruler, Greedy minister profiting by the devolution
- F** Client suffering due to the subsidiary's actions, Minister robbed of effective power by the group, People being oppressed by the group's excesses
- C** The group has considerable outside backing, The group really is doing something critical to the court's function, The court is now actually incapable of handling the group's duties
- T** Wealth obtained by the group's actions, Treasure given to the group originally to induce them, Powerful relic obtained by the group as a tool
- P** Structure dedicated to the group's devolved duty, Country estate of the group's leader, Abandoned structure of the court that once handled it

Splendid Seat

This court operates from a seat of power far beyond the splendor of their peers. It may be some ancient Working full of magical powers and benefits, or an ancestral fortress famed in song and legend, or a complex built around some source of precious material or extracted good. Much of the authority of the court might derive from their control of this seat.

- E** Ruler who is relying too heavily on the seat's benefits, Saboteur seeking to destroy the seat, Hostile entity bound or associated to the seat
- F** Caretaker of the seat's benefits, Court member fascinated with the seat's history and nature, Servant of a line with ancestral ties to the place
- C** The seat exacts a cost from those who dwell there, The seat's real power is misunderstood by all save the ruler's inner circle, The seat is somehow a prison as well as a throne
- T** Key to unlocking the seat's secret powers, Precious relic of a former age, Wealth obtained through the seat's qualities
- P** Strange chamber of some long-lost purpose, Hidden room deep within the structure, Grand and magnificent structure embodying the site

Sublime Skill

The court is tremendously good at a particular role or function that their society finds important. Magnificent soldiers, legendary artists, famed diplomats, pious official-priests, or some other quality of note defines them. This skill may be the product of a venerable tradition of instruction, however harsh it may be, or it could be the result of a magical bloodline or inhuman admixture.

- E** Ruler who takes the trait much too far in a bad direction, Renegade who uses the skill against the court, Outside power trying to manipulate the skill for their own benefits
- F** Unworldly but extremely talented court member, Outsider curious about the nature of the skill, Friendly rival seeking to test their skill
- C** The skill comes at some compensating cost, The court is fairly useless for anything but that skill, The court is abusing its skill for its own benefit
- T** Relic or item that can confer the skill, Wealth obtained through the skill's exercise, Magnificent trophy of some prior legendary feat of skill
- P** Monument to prior exercise of the skill, Training hall where the skill is honed, Memorial hall full of tokens of past glory

Threatened Violence

The shadow of impending death hangs over the court. The ruler may be ordering capricious executions, assassins may be active, a particularly bloody custom may be in full effect, or the court's superiors may be hunting for traitors. The court members are on edge and willing to do desperate things in order to avoid death or direct the killing toward their enemies.

- E** Paranoid ruler seeing knives in every shadow, Master assassin with a grudge, Renegade who's returned to take vengeance
- F** Survivor of a murdered member, Worried bodyguard looking for help, Frightened member convinced they're next
- C** The violence is being blamed on the wrong source, People are using the killings to settle private scores, The victims were all part of a secret scheme
- T** Poison suitable for eliminating anyone, List of those next to die, Document with information that will stop the killings
- P** Gory scene of death, Unbearably tense court function, Trial full of panicked participants

Sudden Strength

A grand stroke of luck, a brilliant plan, or a feat of sublime diplomacy have resulted in a great influx of wealth, influence, or support from outside the court. The group now has access to a newfound strength that may be fleeting, and not all members may have equal access to the benefits. The existing structure of authority is unlikely to be well-equipped to exert this new influence in delicate or well-considered ways.

- E** Power-drunk ruler pushing things to excess, Desperate rival trying to sabotage the court before it's too late, Outside patron using this new strength as a lever to control the court
- F** Official struggling to cope with the new situation, Old court friend now seeking help, Victim of a poorly-considered exercise of the strength
- C** The new strength is causing damage each time it's deployed, Their backers are just letting the court overextend itself before pulling the aid, The court's agents are taking personal advantage
- T** Money obtained by the good fortune, Potent relic that's part of the new strength, Secret evidence of the real purpose of the help being given
- P** Crushed rival's estate, Gaudily-upgraded court holding, Confused site of sudden activity

Waning Wealth

The court is heading towards poverty, and its members know it. The source of their wealth is under attack, either by a rival, a greedy superior, an outside enemy, or sheer misfortune. If things continue as they are the court will be unable to maintain its place, and its members are contemplating desperate measures to shore up existing holdings or acquire new ones.

- E** Ruler who's making unreasonable demands for member sacrifices, Sinister creditor who demands repayment, Monstrous foe who's ruining their holdings
- F** Harried chancellor looking for money, Client left destitute by lack of support, Former manager of a now-ruined holding
- C** They're cutting secret deals with enemies of their land, Unpopular members are being beggared to support the others, Their clients are being squeezed dry just to keep the court solvent
- T** Long-lost treasure the court is hunting, Deed to some profitable holding, Device that will revitalize or repair a ruined property
- P** Threadbare throne room, Meager noble dining hall, Abandoned once-profitable holding



RUINS

There's hardly an adventurer alive who doesn't like to explore an ancient ruin, so it's inevitable that you're going to be producing your fair share of crumbled keeps, stygian tunnels, and sinister lost cities. The adventure creation tables that start on page 234 can help you flesh out the details of these adventure sites, but you need to have a general framework in place before you can use them effectively.

The Ruin tags in this section are useful in situating the ruin within the context of your own campaign world. Every tumbled-down heap of stones came from somewhere, and it originally served a purpose more exalted than being looted by lawless sellswords.

The one-roll table opposite allows you to create this context for an average fantasy-world ruin. The results are generally applicable to most settings and can be flavored or tweaked to suit your own campaign's particulars.

The following pages include specific tables for six major prior periods of history in the Gyre, whether local kingdoms like the Rule of Shun or region-spanning hegemony like the Vothite Empire. While the details provided in these tables are specific to the Gyre campaign setting, you can just as easily loot their themes for your own world and use them as the models for ancient civilizations in your own setting.

The key to building interesting ruins is *context*. A random magic hole in the ground with assorted monstrous creatures in it is difficult to justify in most campaign worlds. Even if there is some conceit that makes it a normal sort of event, the sheer untethered randomness of it makes it very difficult for a GM to flesh it out in an interesting, engaging fashion. Of course, very few GMs have the time or energy to brew up a half-dozen ancient civilizations that are relevant to their current campaign only in their architectural leavings.

Fortunately, you don't have to. All you need to establish is what the structure was originally meant for, how it ended up ruined, and who if anyone is using it now. The name and particulars of the original creators don't need to be established if it's not convenient; just knowing that it was a border garrison is enough to tell you how you should design its architecture. Knowing that it was overrun by barbarians tells you what kind of damage it should have suffered and what sort of detritus and leavings might be left from that age. Knowing that it's currently a shrine to an obscene faith tells you what kind of inhabitants the PCs are going to meet if they go there and what more modern decorations might exist. Any further details can be conjured as necessary. All you really need is a basic, functional context.



ONE-ROLL RUIN GENERATION

These tables can be used for general fantasy settings, as they include nothing specific to the Latter Earth. If you need a ruin and aren't entirely sure how to characterize it, a single throw of six dice will give you a basic outline to develop.

To this basic framework you can add a pair of Ruin tags and tweak the rolls to mesh accordingly. Some results might not make sense for your intended use for the ruin. You could pick different options in that case, or spend a little time thinking about how the roll might be the actual truth and thus conjure up a suitable explanation.

Fully detailing the interior of the ruin and the kind of combat or exploratory challenges that could be found within involves the tools starting on page 234.

d6 What Do The Locals Think Of It?

- 1 It's traditionally taboo ground to them
- 2 It plays a role in some important ritual
- 3 It and its perils are hated and feared
- 4 It's considered someone's private property
- 5 It's a lure to the greedy and reckless
- 6 They totally misunderstand what it really is

d8 How Did It Become Ruined?

- 1 It was invaded and destroyed by its enemies
- 2 Strife from within tore it apart
- 3 Some natural calamity despoiled it
- 4 A Working's failure or magical disaster struck
- 5 It was abandoned when it became useless
- 6 A plague or curse made it uninhabitable
- 7 Some dire monster or great foe smashed it
- 8 Its inhabitants died out or simply left it

d10 Why Hasn't It Been Plundered Bare Yet?

- 1 The environment around it is very dangerous
- 2 It's cursed, plagued, or has some miasma
- 3 The locals kill or drive off looters
- 4 The true entrance to it is unknown
- 5 It's physically very difficult to access
- 6 It's believed inhabited by fearsome things
- 7 Everyone thinks it's already been looted
- 8 It's confused with a nearby site that is looted
- 9 It's claimed by a powerful local authority
- 10 The prizes it offers aren't conventional riches

d4 How Old is the Ruin?

- 1 Very fresh; ruined within living memory
- 2 Generations old at the least
- 3 Part of a known prior nation or polity
- 4 Belonging to the unfathomable past

d12 What Basic Kind of Ruin Is It?

- 1 A city or other major settlement
- 2 Temple, monastery, or pilgrimage site
- 3 A vast ancient civil infrastructure center
- 4 Artistic monument or aesthetic structure
- 5 Grand private residence or manor
- 6 Fortress or great stronghold
- 7 Mine or tunnel system
- 8 Wizard's tower or occult stronghold
- 9 Border outpost, watchtower, or garrison
- 10 Village or small rural community
- 11 Nonhuman settlement or edifice
- 12 Tomb, necropolis, ossuary, or graveyard

d20 Who's Used The Ruin Before?

- 1 Rebels against the local ruler
- 2 Bandits or other criminal outcasts
- 3 Fanatical religious zealots
- 4 A failed pretender to the local rulership
- 5 Refugees and survivors from a calamity
- 6 A wizard of dubious habits or goals
- 7 A black market trader to bandits or worse
- 8 Overly optimistic settlers trying to reclaim it
- 9 A hapless garrison of local troops
- 10 Monstrous entities lying in wait
- 11 Savage beasts of a dangerous kind
- 12 Adventurers trying to make it a base
- 13 Social outcasts looking for a haven
- 14 Demihumans trying to avoid human places
- 15 Smugglers seeking a good stash spot
- 16 Nominal owners trying to lay claim to it
- 17 Heirs or survivors of the original inhabitants
- 18 An invading warband based here for a while
- 19 Intelligent monsters suited to the environment
- 20 Restless undead and embittered shades



RUINS OF ANCIENT DEEPS

Deeps vary enormously in size, from the innumerable small refuges that once sheltered human escapees and isolated esoteric experiments to vast delvings that sheltered a million humans or more. Most are far smaller than that, however, either due to being built for smaller, temporary populations of laborers or slaves or because their greater portions have collapsed with age or been cut off by destruction or decay.

The sophistication of a Deep varied with its creators. Those cut out by renegade humans in need of a shelter from Outsider patrols tend to be primitive holes gouged into the earth, while Outsider-fashioned Deeps are of smoothly-worked stone, imperishable structural materials, and the occasional remnants of sophisticated arcane control devices. Even so, many have been considerably altered over the ages by newer tenants.

RUINS OF THE BRASS HEGEMONY

Hegemonic ruins favor square, powerful shapes and a heavy stone construction facilitated by the might of the Black Brass Legion and vast corvee labor drafts. Right angles and squared, even interior spaces are characteristic of their architecture.

Some Hegemonic ruins were abandoned long before the present troubles, being remnants of the centuries past when the Reaping King was still forcing his way south from the coast. These forsaken places were usually stripped of their initial furnishings, but the rebels, monsters, and criminals who've made homes in them since have often left their own belongings behind.

More recent Hegemonic ruins are usually the leavings of now-powerless Adunic nobles or Hegemonic clerks and support staff that have long since departed.

RUINS OF THE JIKEGIDA

Ancient Jikegida did most of their construction with powerful exoskeletons fashioned of suborned alien life. These construction shells enabled the building of vast hexagonal structures in which millions of Jikegida conducted their alien debates and infested their wretched prey with new spawn.

Jikegida rooms are preferentially hexagonal, with hexagonal corridors and faceted bubble-windows. Furnishings and implements are frail and light by human standards, reflecting the weaker limbs of the average Jikegida. The acrid stench of an active Jikegida site is tremendous due to their heavy reliance on chemical communication, and some ancient ruins have this reek embedded in the very stone.

d6 Major Types of Deeps

1	A punishment Deep to torment its inmates with miserable conditions and terrifying foes
2	A false-world Deep meant to bubble its prisoners in a sealed custom world
3	A labor Deep to produce something precious to its Outsider masters
4	A war Deep to produce slave-soldiers and military creatures for Outsider conflicts
5	A rebel Deep, where the natives somehow broke loose of their Outsider masters
6	A ritual Deep, where human thralls were used for some eldritch alien end

d6 Characteristic Ruins

1	Pre-Hegemony ruin of a site wiped out by the Reaping King's conquest
2	Pacification garrison once manned for the subdual of newly-conquered lands
3	Absentee Adunic lord's provincial palace for the administration of now-lost lands
4	Fortified court-stronghold where a viceroy once gave instructions to native rulers
5	Well-fortified residential area for Adunic clerks and minor functionaries
6	Prison where rebels and criminals were set to work for Hegemonic masters

d6 Characteristic Ruins

1	A small hatching-burrow for storing torpid hosts that haven't been taken to a larger hive
2	A great shattered mother-hive of hexagonal structures, destroyed by the sorcerer-kings
3	A looming observation outpost for monitoring humanity in ancient days
4	A debate-palace meant for vast gatherings to dispute some alien philosophical point
5	A sealed relaxation dome filled with the noxious life and air enjoyed by the Jikegida
6	Parasitism outpost, once attached to a human Deep to harvest suitable hosts

RUINS OF THE RULE OF SHUN

Shunnite ruins are heavily influenced by ancient Khalan architecture. Stepped stone construction and carvings of hideous suffering and monstrous beasts decorate most of the ruins, usually depicting the enemies of Shun or the “unworthy weak” suffering assorted gruesome ends at the hands of Shun’s favored and their created beasts. Shun himself is depicted only as a featureless, stylized human form.

Shun’s relatively brief rule was focused around his magically-augmented “favored”, men and women made stronger, more intelligent, and more magically gifted than normal humans. Their temple-palaces served as loci of worship for their sorcerer-god, administrative centers of control, and processing points for the vast numbers of “unworthy” guilty of resisting Shun’s grand plans, the latter ending up as further feedstock for his research.

RUINS OF THE VOTHITE EMPIRE

The Vothite Empire was built around mental influence, with thought houses dedicated to particular principles waging memetic war on their rivals via sorcery and magically-charged symbolism. Losing rarely meant physical death, but instead an indoctrination into the winner’s belief system. Nobles were most vulnerable to these mental influences, and so their residences were always carefully constructed to celebrate their own house’s ideals.

The actual ruins tend to have a Classical flavor, with harmonious, symmetrical construction. The chief difference is in the decoration, with slogans, once-meaningful symbols, statuary of ideological significance, and artwork dedicated to the cause all heavily adorning the structures. They almost never have anything resembling conventional fortifications, as military force was literally unthinkable.

RUINS OF THE VOTHITE REPUBLIC

The Vothite Republic utterly rejected imperial principles, and large-scale monuments or symbolic structures are almost never found among their ruins; even statues and non-magical insignia of belief are uncommon. The Classical lines of imperial architecture give way to a looser, more locally-influenced construction. Often the only way to tell a ruin is Republican is due to the lack of any overt symbolic adornment.

The Republic continued to use certain massive imperial structures until infrastructure decay and civil strife made them unsustainable. Huge tenements that once housed hundreds of thought house thralls were repurposed for Republic citizens, while the family seats of thought houses were taken over by fabulously wealthy senators and fortified against the newer, less stable political conditions.

d6

Characteristic Ruins

- 1 Healing shrine with numerous recovery cells and arcano-surgical theaters
- 2 Arena or hall of trials where those blessed by Shun competed to ascertain excellence
- 3 Prison pit where victims were “cultivated” in various ways to be better research stock
- 4 Semi-organic structure infested by the body-warping sorceries of Shun’s followers
- 5 Residential palace full of the insane, trapped, immortal “favored” of Shun
- 6 Occult research center stocked with the monstrous detritus of Shun’s research

d6

Characteristic Ruins

- 1 Memetic monument to a particular aesthetic ideal or abstract political concept
- 2 A thought noble’s palace, usually closely adjoined by the humble servant lodgings
- 3 Rectification center, where a thought house “educated” prisoners into joining their cause
- 4 Concept battlefield, a structure full of conflicting, magically-potent symbology
- 5 Rebel hideout, stocked with now-unstable concepts and tangible mental constructs
- 6 Detritus of a mind-bending Working, now broken but stained by shadows of the past

d6

Characteristic Ruins

- 1 Overgrown forum ringed with administrative buildings for a vanished community
- 2 Huge Republic tenement with a maze of businesses, offices, and homes within
- 3 Republic wayhouse along a vanished road, for travelers, military forces, and merchants
- 4 Stronghold for Republic troops meant to keep provincial fighting from breaking out
- 5 Late-era Republic village or town, heavily fortified to no avail against its pillagers
- 6 Senatorial manor once built in an opulent style by a plutocratically wealthy owner



Before a GM can use the tools on page 234 to start building the individual places, foes, and treasures within a Ruin, they need to have some idea of what that Ruin is like and the overall theme of its contents. A pair of Ruin Tags from the list below can serve as the start of the process; pick or roll two, mix them together, and use the results to inform your later development.

For most of the tags, the Enemies listed can serve as inspiration for major foes within the debris or overlords who've cowed the other inhabitants of the Ruin. The Friends are usually NPCs who would have a particular interest in the Ruin, or potentially friendly Ruin inhabitants who could act as guides, interpreters, or dungeon dragomans for the PCs. If the PCs need a hook to direct them to the Ruin or a friendly face within it to discourage them from immediate assumptions of universal bloodshed, a Friend can lead the way.

Ruins are generally defined by their loss of former utility. A ruined city is no longer inhabited, a ruined fortress is no longer a point of defense, and a ruined palace

is no longer occupied by human royalty. Whatever the place was originally meant to be, it no longer serves that purpose. The Ruin Tags can help detail the earlier tables and add more specifics to its historical fall or slow, inexorable decay.

Just because the Ruin is no longer used as it once was, however, it doesn't mean that it has no use at all. The architectural castoffs of countless eons of humanity often find use as dwellings or strongholds for non-human creatures, or sanctuaries for bandits and outcasts from more peaceful surroundings. Ancient infrastructure or mouldering fortifications can find new life in the re-purposing that a band of Anak raiders or a sect of persecuted cultists can make of it.

Of course, the natural hazards of the environment often do away with such interlopers, creating the potential for multiple layers of past inhabitation and use. Ancient treasures might date from more than one era, and the plunder of a lost age's bandits might be mingled with the modern possessions of hapless now-dead refugees.

d100	Tag	d100	Tag
1–2	Ancient Archives	51–52	Invincible Delusion
3–4	Aspiring Conqueror	53–54	Lethal Treasure
5–6	Automaton Servants	55–56	Limited Access
7–8	Birthing Cyst	57–58	Lingering Curse
9–10	Bitter Remnants	59–60	Living Dungeon
11–12	Civil War	61–62	Lost Colony
13–14	Cyclical Doom	63–64	Magical Wonder
15–16	Decrepit Structure	65–66	Monster Forge
17–18	Desperate Hunger	67–68	Outsider Domain
19–20	Dire Tombs	69–70	Precious Resource
21–22	Distant Gate	71–72	Raider Lair
23–24	Dungeon Heart	73–74	Recruiting Drive
25–26	Experimental Lab	75–76	Religious Zealots
27–28	Failed Intrusion	77–78	Rigid Hierarchy
29–30	Fallen Sanctuary	79–80	Royal Refuge
31–32	False Front	81–82	Sacrificial Bargain
33–34	Feral Magic	83–84	Sealed Evil
35–36	Flooded Halls	85–86	Secret Alliance
37–38	Freshly Looted	87–88	Shifting Interior
39–40	Friendly Foes	89–90	Spatial Flux
41–42	Hidden Within	91–92	Surfacer Hideout
43–44	Hiveminded Natives	93–94	Taboo Place
45–46	Hospitable Natives	95–96	Things Below
47–48	Hostile Environment	97–98	Useless Treasure
49–50	Infectious Miasma	99–00	Wizard's Lair

Ancient Archives

The site once housed archives or information that would be very interesting to certain modern powers. The utility or value of this information should be obvious to the players, even if they're initially unaware of its existence. Known archival sites might have sealed their lore behind some fearsome guardian or a "puzzle" consisting of access procedures that were self-evident in the age it was constructed in.

- E** Maddened archive keeper, Powerful figure who wants the information kept hidden, Secret-seeker who brooks no rivals
- F** Helpful ancient archive attendant, Hired investigator, Seeker of some related lore
- C** The information is conveyed in idioms or forms that are no longer clear, The information is very dangerous to know, The information is buried in seas of irrelevant data that need navigating
- T** Index to the desired information, Key to decoding the data, Cultural work that elucidates the idioms or medium being used
- P** Library full of not-book data storage items, Scriptorium or other scribal zone, Chamber related to the topic or field of the data involved

Automaton Servants

The ruin is still staffed by automaton servants or other immortal minions. Aside from obviously robotic servitors, magical golems, bound spirits, undead thralls, uplifted beasts, or other subject species might be found here. Such minions are usually magically bound to their roles, which may be causing them significant problems if their roles can no longer be carried out. It's possible that some of them have re-interpreted their roles into something they can do, whether or not it's something they should do.

- E** Cruel immortal artificer, Automaton leader gone mad, Outsider seeking to suborn them to their sinister service
- F** Helpful automaton minion, Fascinated outside investigator, Local native who fears the minions
- C** Scrapped automatons are worth a great deal, The automatons are needed to maintain the ruin's basic physical stability, The automatons have merged with or been altered by some outside power
- T** Command key for the automatons, Cache of valuable spare parts, Item they desperately need in order to fulfill their function
- P** Automaton maintenance area, Bank of unmoving figures, Place of endless automaton toil

Aspiring Conqueror

Some power within the ruin has ambitions of conquest, and plans to use the site as a base for dominating the surrounding lands. Such a warlord might be wholly reliant on the ruin's denizens, or they could be recruiting minions from outcasts or renegades and so be willing to parley with adventurers. Not all the lieutenants of such leaders are always supportive of the plan.

- E** Inhuman warlord, Fanatical cult leader, Embittered outlaw-noble
- F** Hapless local village headman, Minion who reconsidered their allegiance, Former leader who was pushed aside by the new one
- C** Some of the locals honestly think the conqueror would be a better ruler, The conqueror actually has a legitimate claim on the land, The conqueror is being backed by enemies of the local ruler
- T** Cache of military supplies, Plunder taken from their first victims, Important hostage in their keeping
- P** Ruin barracks whipped into order, Training field in use, Nearby village they've crushed

Birthing Cyst

A horrible thing is growing in the ruin and will eventually erupt into some catastrophic peril or awful creature. The ruin may have been originally designed to facilitate this thing's creation, or it could have been infested or perverted by some outside power. Outsiders may not realize the nature of the peril, or even mistake its growth for some positive process. The growth could be the product of ancient science, a magical ritual, or a conflux of geomantic forces.

- E** God-beast to be born for a long-dead faith, Obsessed ancient keeper, Outsider determined to provoke the catastrophe for their own ends
- F** Worried local observer, Last surviving keeper of the ruin, Survivor of an early eruption of it
- C** The thing's growth provides some profitable byproduct, People are completely mistaken about what's growing down there, People think it's already hatched and was dispatched
- T** Item needed to harm or kill the thing, Key to halt or abort the process, Precious offerings made to the unborn disaster by fearful observers
- P** Arcane lab where it's growing, Fortified chambers to guard it, Shrine depicting its eventual glory



Bitter Remnants

The ruin is not entirely abandoned, as a remnant of its former creators still occupies the place. These survivors are almost certainly hostile toward the outside world and the intruders who have sought to take the place or loot it for uncounted ages. They may or may not have a full understanding of their ancestors' purpose in the ruin, but they likely use any secrets they do know to best effect against invaders.

- E** Xenophobic remnant chief, Outside ruler determined to exterminate them, Powerful ruin rival that seeks their destruction
- F** Open-minded remnant member, Eager scholar seeking their secrets, Escapee from the terrible cruelties of the remnants
- C** The remnant society is genuinely and completely horrible, The remnants no longer or never did think like humans do, Certain outcasts have trade ties with the remnants
- T** Precious ancient relic they preserved, Loot taken from dead invaders, Secret history of the ruin full of useful information
- P** Ancient but meticulously-kept chamber, Ancestral place of rites unique to them, Maintained monument to past glory

Cyclical Doom

There's a phenomenon to the ruin that makes it tremendously dangerous at certain intervals. Fluxes of ancient radiation, swarms of quick-breeding dangerous vermin, withering geomantic conjunctions, or cyclically-awakened preserved inhabitants might make the place exceedingly deadly for intruders there at that time. The natives may or may not know about the cycle, and if it's a very long one, they might not have been around to see it happen.

- E** Outsider determined to trigger the cycle, Native leader who wants to weaponize it, Outside researcher with no care for the consequences
- F** Native aware of the impending disaster, Researcher trying to stop the cycle, Survivor of the last cycle
- C** The cycle leaves behind a valuable byproduct, The cycle only threatens certain occupants, Outsiders have totally misinterpreted the cycle's meaning or events
- T** Key to trigger or halt the cycle, Device to protect users from the cycle, Object for controlling and directing the cycle
- P** Place scarred by a past cycle's effects, Control or observation center, Monument obscurely referencing the cycle

Civil War

There are at least two organized factions within the ruin that are at war with each other. They all have motives that make simply leaving the place an unappealing prospect, and some of them might be eager to enlist outside help in ousting their rivals. Given the low population of most ruins, the war is likely a restricted one of raids, ambushes, and murders of convenience, and the traps and snares they set might catch more than their foes.

- E** Faction leader with dreams of conquest, Crazy warlord, Treacherous plotter who betrays their hired help
- F** Faction leader with benevolent aims, Innocent local caught in the crossfire, Would-be peacemaker
- C** They both want the same thing but in different ways, Both sides will unite swiftly against invaders, Neither side wants anything that outsiders are going to like much
- T** The macguffin they're fighting over, Weapon to destroy their rivals, Wealth to bribe other helpers
- P** Site of a vicious ambush, Defaced monument or symbol of a rival faction, Dangerous no-man's land zone within the ruin

Decrepit Structure

The ruin is falling apart, and is actively dangerous to its inhabitants. Navigating between areas may require careful progress, extensive rope and piton work, or avoidance of certain obvious-but-hazardous routes. Native inhabitants may have adapted to the hazards or they might be newcomers who are learning the hard way. Some areas in the ruin might provoke a general collapse if they are significantly damaged.

- E** Outside plunderer with no care for the consequences, Outsider actively trying to destroy the place, Berserk native trying to repair things
- F** Refugee forced to live there, Native dweller seeking help to fix things, Architectural researcher
- C** Valuable materials can be looted by those indifferent to the increasing instability, The collapse would reveal or unleash a terrible thing, Many places in it can only be visited once
- T** Resources that can repair the damage, Precious loot that will destabilize the place if taken, Treasure revealed by a structural collapse
- P** Creaking bridge or gantry, Room with numerous holes in the floor, Tower leaning at a drunken angle

Desperate Hunger

Natives of the ruin just can't get enough to eat, and their situation or the surrounding area makes it impractical to move somewhere else. Beasts may be extremely aggressive due to hunger, and intelligent natives might fight more for food than gold or glory. Many of the more savage types may have fallen back on cannibalism or hunting other sapient beings for food.

- E** Obese cannibal chieftain, Native leader who'll do anything to feed their people, Sorcerer who gives dark nourishment to their servitors
- F** Starved urchin-native, Anxious group leader wanting to cut a deal, Innovator trying to open up a new food source
- C** The overpopulation is being resolved by murder, The food-gathering areas were recently blocked off by something, Foodstuffs become toxic or inedible rapidly in the ruin
- T** Cache of preserved food, Key to open new hunting areas, Great treasure that's viewed as trifling compared to the worth of food
- P** Pit of cracked and gnawed bones, Cages of meals-to-be, Viciously desperate feeding area for a group

Distant Gate

The ruin is connected to some interesting distant location, either through a magical gate, a portal of ancient technology, forgotten tube-cars in underground tunnels, or a more mundane hidden passage into an otherwise inaccessible place. The natives may know about and exploit this quality, or the gate may be sealed until some particular procedure or object is used to activate it.

- E** Guardian of the gate, Hostile entity from the other side, Intruder determined to unlock the gate
- F** Hapless intruder from the other side, Native gate-guide, Explorer seeking a route to the gate's destination
- C** The gate was sealed for a very good reason, The gate is one-way, Activating the gate risks destroying the ruin
- T** Key to activate the gate, Codes to control its destination, Treasure from the far side of it
- P** Mysterious transit-chamber with symbolism related to the destination, Room with objects or remains related to the destination, Dangerously energetic gate room

Dire Tombs

The ruin is characterized by a great many tombs or burial sites and a matching profusion of undead. The revenants may be mindless husks animated by dark magic or ambient power, or they could be intentionally created to act as guards or to continue "living" according to some long-lost death-god's teachings.

- E** Undead lord jealous of their solitude, Ravening undead hulk-thing, Necromancer eager for the raw materials
- F** Descendant of the dead trying to keep them safe, Fascinated historical researcher, Undead-hunter trying to contain them
- C** The undead are not all of the same motives, The locals revere and venerate them as ancestors, The undead are just symptoms of something worse entombed there
- T** Burial goods left behind, Plunder taken from unfortunate adventurers, Once-commonplace good that's now extremely valuable
- P** Halls of silent coffin-niches or urns, Chapel to a god related to the burial process, Splendid tomb to a dead hero or ruler

Dungeon Heart

The ruin's physical integrity is bound with a particular creature or object within the site, and if it is destroyed or removed the place will collapse. If the destruction is immediate, this danger should be clearly conveyed to the players unless the GM wants to risk a rapid campaign end. This relationship may be derived from an ancient magical curse, a sympathetic unity of magical power, or ancient self-destruct security mechanisms.

- E** Outsider determined to kill or steal the heart, A heart-creature that would be very convenient or satisfying to kill, Native holding the heart hostage to force obedience
- F** Guardian of the heart, Native eager to warn outsiders of the truth, Explorer with dire suspicions
- C** The "destruction" is metaphorical or societal in nature, Only a specific part of the ruin will be destroyed, No one involved realizes that it will cause a somewhat slow-motion destruction
- T** Device that will undo the link, The precious object that is the heart, Relic to control the linked things
- P** Chamber where the heart's connection is visible, Place that shifts in sympathy to the heart, Damaged room reflecting damage to the heart



Experimental Lab

A sorcerer or ancient artificer once used this place for their experiments, most of which were the sort that would never be tolerated in civilization. They may have been sponsored by some amoral power, or been independent theurges seeking the special resources, environment, or natives of this place to assist in their studies.

- E** Still-surviving researcher, Hideous creation of the arcanist, Outsider bent on seizing all its dark lore
- F** Sympathetic creation of the sorcerer, Witch-hunter bent on destroying the secrets, Local plagued by the lab's emanations or castoffs
- C** The lab is still in use, The lab's patrons don't realize what's really going on there, The lab's creations have gone out of control
- T** Valuable research byproduct, Treasure once owned by a research victim, Potent magical lore related to the lab's focus
- P** Testing chamber for the lab's research, Occult and sinister laboratory, Pens for holding research stock

Fallen Sanctuary

The ruin was a place of security within recent memory, until some event or invasion turned it into its present state. Some of the surrounding locals might have been associated with the site during its heyday and remember interesting facts about it. Others may still nurse dreams of returning it to its former glory once its current inhabitants are slain or driven away.

- E** Dark warlord who overthrew the place, Traitor who arranged its downfall, Terrible creature unleashed in the site's dying throes
- F** Idealistic would-be reconstructor, Native trying to make peace with the locals, Aged keeper of the site's old secrets
- C** The site is fallen to the locals but a sanctuary now to a completely different group, The site is still dangerous and hostile to the interlopers, The locals desperately need to retake the site soon for some pressing reason
- T** Treasures hidden by the former owners, The dark tool used to cast the site down, Token of rightful rule seized by the invaders
- P** Hidden chamber unknown to invaders, Defaced and ruined room dedicated to the site's original role, Chamber re-purposed for the invaders

Failed Intrusion

The ruin recently experienced a serious incursion of outsiders, whether adventurers, bandits, government forces, angry villagers, or other hostiles. These intruders were repulsed, perhaps with significant loss of native life, and the ruin was considerably disrupted by the fighting. Important native leaders might have been killed or wounded, treasures might have been looted, or slaves and hostages might've been taken.

- E** Desperate intruder leader still in the ruin, Bloodthirsty native leader craving vengeance, Dead leader's heir full of terrible ideas
- F** Sympathetic intruder or native survivor, Escaped slave, Vengeful relative of the dead
- C** The intruders are too desperate to have entirely given up, The two sides basically ruined each other, Outsiders have entered to take advantage of the chaos
- T** Useful relic lost by the intruding forces, Stolen treasure of the natives, Tribal treasure now inaccessible due to the chief's death
- P** Site of a hideous battle, Larder where the dead intruders are being kept, Local beast lair full of dragged corpses

False Front

The site actually seems to be a completely different type of place than it really is. You might generate a second basic function for the site and bill it as its true purpose, or conceal it as a currently-functioning structure of some kind. Either it was built this way originally or more recent owners have concealed the truth about it for their own benefit. Others may not realize that the ruin they think they know is just a facade over something deeper.

- E** Secret master of the hidden ruin, Cruel schemer who established the false front, Monstrous foe still buried below the facade
- F** Clueless entrepreneur who means to exploit the false site, Explorer with curious references to the truth, Victim of something from the truth below
- C** The false front is a lure to bait prey, The false front is to deflect interest, The false front is meant to be useful or profitable to the true lord of the place
- T** Key to reveal the entrance to the real site, Incongruous treasure from below, Valuable goods used to maintain the facade
- P** Chamber that doesn't fit with the false front, Secret passage to the depths, Place full of costumes and props

Feral Magic

Some potent Working or other ancient magic has gone berserk or rotten in the ruin, tainting the occupants and making the place dangerous to inhabitants. Whatever the magic once did, it now does it too much, or in the wrong way, or at a grim cost to those within. The natives either cannot escape, or have no place better to go, or are somehow dependent on the twisted magic.

- E** Magically mutated abomination, Native chieftain full of tainted power, Outside sorcerer making reckless use of the magic
- F** Researcher trying to understand or fix things, Sympathetic magic-plagued native, Outside victim of the site's magic
- C** Valuable loot awaits those willing to break the magic further, The magic can be fixed if something dangerous is done, The decay is spreading outside the ruin
- T** Item to ward off the magic, Valuable sorcerous byproduct, Ancient instructions on how to fix things
- P** Thrumming power center of the magic, Lair of magic-twisted beasts, Native shrine to the power

Freshly Looted

The site has been recently plundered, either by adventurers, organized invaders, or a specific faction within the site itself. Many creatures are either dead or driven off, and the rewards for exploration are limited. But as the site is newly-emptied, numerous outside groups or warbands are likely in the process of moving in, cleaning out the remnants of surviving inhabitants and setting up their own bases there.

- E** Conquering Blighted warchief, Ruthless bandit-adventurer who likes the place, Vengeance-mad chief of a rabble of survivors
- F** Sympathetic native driven out of the site, Frustrated adventurer denied a chance to loot, Local official charged with investigating the place
- C** The looters missed the most important treasure, A native faction was working with the looters, A group of natives successfully hid from the looters
- T** Treasure hidden by dead natives, Relic lost by a slain looter, Valuable thing too big and heavy to carry out readily
- P** Empty treasure vault, Ruler's lair plundered and defaced, Hall choked with the recent dead

Flooded Halls

The ruin is largely flooded, perhaps with water and perhaps with some worse substance. Exploring it is difficult, and the heroes constantly risk being trapped by rising waters or flow-shifted obstacles. The natives are either creatures adapted to water or desperate enough to live where few others can pursue them.

- E** Fish-thing with dark hungers, Cult priest of a watery evil, Chief of a piscid humanoid species
- F** Luckless local boater, Hermit who's tried to live there, Courageous treasure-diver
- C** The flooding is cyclical, Water flow can be controlled somehow inside the site, The water is fetid with disease
- T** Pearls or other water-fashioned valuables, Extremely precious relic that would be ruined by being soaked, Device to grant water-breathing
- P** Splendid chamber now crusted by slime or coral, Half-filled room with an air bubble, Space full of totally opaque silty water

Friendly Foes

A group dwells here that would normally be very hostile to humans or outsiders, yet is perfectly willing to deal with adventurers. They may be an anomalous group of their kind, or have desperate need for outside help, or have religious reasons to be cooperative. Few outsiders are likely to take their friendliness at face value, but they should be given the chance to be visibly friendly by the GM so as to clue the players in to the likelihood of peaceful dealings.

- E** Bloodthirsty adventurer who doesn't believe them, Group leader with treacherous plans, Monstrous foe that threatens the group and outsiders both
- F** Friendly being from the group, Local human with secret ties to them, Earnest outside missionary
- C** They're friendly because of a very large misunderstanding they have, They really are totally sincere in their good intent, They've got a problem that only long-term allies can solve
- T** Group-made product normally never available to humans, Treasure they gathered from foes, Relic they're using as a bargaining tool
- P** Meeting space also furnished for humans, Separate dwelling area for outsiders, Chamber for obscure group rituals or worship



Hidden Within

The ruin is actually underneath a seemingly-ordinary structure or inhabited human settlement. Secret passages or long-forgotten portals lead down into it, and only a short space away from ordinary human life a ruin can seethe with sinister secrets. The ruin may have been built over accidentally, intentionally buried, or perhaps excavated by the current structure's original builders.

- E** Thing that creeps up from below at night, Long-buried evil, Reckless adventurer stirring up things beneath
- F** Passage-wise urchin, Architect with too much curiosity, Hapless local sewer worker
- C** The structure's inhabitants have a secret deal with the ruin dwellers, The ruin dwellers masquerade as the structure's inhabitants, Time-delayed catastrophe will happen after the ruin's opened
- T** Key to open the hidden passage below, Treasure hidden in the ruin in ages past, Ancient relic the ruin was made to contain
- P** Passage hidden behind now-crumbling construction, Mundane room above a monstrous evil, Secret passages that have peepholes into the structure above

Hiveminded Natives

A multi-bodied intellect exists in the ruin, whether an ancient AI, hiveminded swarm, telepathic gestalt species, unified golem force, or some other manner of creature. Some such hiveminds are inclined to "recruit" intruders, willing or otherwise. Conflict with these creatures is apt to be very dangerous, as they're capable of coordination at a level impossible to others, yet their single mind makes them more vulnerable to a single point of failure.

- E** Crazy ancient eidolon, Magically warped insect queen, Fungus-infected colony organism
- F** Escapee from the hivemind, Last survivor of a recruited group, Researcher keen to study it
- C** The hivemind's doubts are embodied in conflicting factions, It can focus only on so many bodies at once, It requires a connection to issue new orders
- T** Device to break the hivemind's control, Curative to free a recruit, Intricate treasure fabricated by unified hivemind effort
- P** Living quarters with no private elements, Swarming chamber full of perfectly-synchronized motion, Fetid organic queen-lair of the ruling intellect



Hospitable Natives

While not all denizens of the ruin are friendly, there's at least one faction that's known to be willing to host guests and negotiate for favors. This group may be made up of bandits, exiles, hermits, or other social outcasts who find even the most dubious human visitors preferable to their neighbors, or they might be "civilized" humanoids who find it profitable to parley as well as raid.

- E** Sinister chieftain with ulterior motives, Xenophobic rebel who hates outsiders, Outsider adventurer bent on exploiting their hospitality
- F** Wide-eyed native urchin, Outsider gone native, Outsider envoy trying to make a pact with them
- C** They're hospitable because they desperately need allies, They recently were betrayed by a guest, Their hospitality comes at a high price
- T** Trade goods gathered from the ruin, Map of the ruin interior, Key to unlock a route normally accessible only to ruin natives
- P** Alien but friendly meeting-chamber, Makeshift guest lodgings, Ritual room for strange rites

Infectious Miasma

A contagious disease has infected the natives and might plague any intruders as well. The sickness isn't fatal, but it may induce physical or mental changes that make life in the outside world difficult; the ruin itself might be an environment optimized for the afflicted. Conversely, the ruin might be a leprosarium or place of exile for those who catch some virulent plague or socially-despised illness.

- E** Tyrant physician-chief who controls treatment, Ruler maddened by the illness, Plague priest determined to spread the disease
- F** Innocent native suffering from the sickness, Outsider medical missionary, Hapless chieftain trying to hold things together
- C** The ruin has been sealed off by the outside world, The plague turns the natives into living tools or slave-entities, Cures only temporarily suppress the disease's symptoms
- T** Research needed for a lasting cure, Treasures left by a dead sufferer, Vital resources needed for the sick to survive
- P** Gathering-place full of the walking ill, Shrine to a healing god, Pits where disease-warped victims are exiled

Hostile Environment

Ruins are seldom comfortable, but this one is actively dangerous to those who enter it. Noxious fumes, radiation, magical miasmas, contagious diseases, poisonous liquids, or some other environmental hazard makes progress very risky. Natives are either immune to the peril or have means of negating it. The extreme defensibility of the site may be the reason they continue to lair there.

- E** Sorcerer researching how to weaponize the hazard, Monstrous entity that emits the peril, Vile creature born of the toxic conditions
- F** Explorer equipped with survival tools, Friendly native guide, Entrepreneur trying to exploit it
- C** The hostile environment also produces a valuable resource, Surrounding locals consider it taboo because the hazard is somehow contagious, The hazard is very recent and the natives still don't know exactly how to handle it
- T** Protective gear against the hazard, Controls to shut off the hazard in some areas, Loot from hazard-slain intruders or natives
- P** Mundane location caked in the hazard, Lair of a hazard-mutated beast, Perilous path that snakes through the hazard

Invincible Delusion

The natives of this ruin are totally convinced of something that is simply not the case: their ancient empire never fell, their god has commanded them to live a certain troublesome way, they are the only true humans left in the world, or some other delusion that's likely to cause problems. They've developed rationalizations to explain obvious contradictions to their error, many of which involve hostile responses to bearers of iniquitous falsehood. There may be something about the ruin that's enforcing this delusion.

- E** Hypnotically charismatic leader, Crazy ancient lich-ruler, Leader who knows the truth but profits by the error
- F** Native with suspicions, Outsider trying to convince them, Outsider whom they've mistakenly incorporated into their error
- C** The delusion makes an otherwise unendurable life bearable, The delusion is true in some critical ways, The delusion is somehow infectious
- T** Proof of the delusion's falsehood, Precious goods piled up for a lost cause, Relic of a golden age
- P** Ruin chamber made a pathetic mimicry of some greater place, Ritual chamber to celebrate the "truth", Archive containing troublesome records



Lethal Treasure

The ruin has or produces a very valuable good, but that good is somehow extremely dangerous to acquire or possess. It may be toxic, or cursed, or the acquisition process may be predictably lethal. This danger may be the result of the creatures who create the good, the guardians that watch over it, or the surrounding locals who kill "smugglers" or "profaners" with zeal.

- E** Monstrous beast that produces the good, Ancient construct guardian, Cruel tyrant who forces victims to make or acquire the good
- F** Desperate young adventurer, Native good-maker trying to avoid disaster, Victim of the good's hazards
- C** Extended exposure to the good is harmful, The good is useful but somehow morally dubious in its production or nature, The good needs to be specially processed to make it safe
- T** Large cache of unrefined good, Object to nullify or cure the good's danger, Loot lost in an unsuccessful attempt to buy the good
- P** Hellish processing or production area, Tightly-guarded vault of the good, Area made toxic by the good's effects

Lingering Curse

The ruin is cursed, and everything in it is somehow tainted or troubled by the malediction. There must be a strong reason for the natives to remain, or else the curse itself induces them to stay. The curse may be the result of some ancient crime, a Working gone wrong, a lost war against a magical foe, or a "blessing" in one age that is less appreciated in the modern day. The curse usually takes some time to trigger on intruders, but it may be induced by certain actions.

- E** Vile sorcerer feeding on the energies, Embittered chieftain hating all uncursed, Hapless victim made a monster by the curse
- F** Native sorcerer trying to lift the curse, Outside researcher investigating it, Sympathetic native struggling with the curse's effects
- C** The curse grants a significant advantage as well as a blight, Those cursed need something here to survive, The curse is a mark of native belonging and viewed as proof of loyalty
- T** Object that can lift the curse, Precious offering to the gods for mercy, Treasure left by a victim of the curse
- P** Shrine to some protective god, Curse-warped place of twisted mundanity, Chokingly-blighted place where the curse was first invoked

Limited Access

The ruin can only be accessed at certain times or with certain special keys. Any natives are cut off from the outside world for long periods, and must either have no need for sustenance or sources within the ruin. The obstacle may be magical in nature, or the only access route to the ruin may be subject to natural cycles that make it impassable at most times.

- E** Ruin tyrant who views all outsiders as enemies, Ruthless adventurer trying to block rivals, Mad power locked away in the ruin
- F** Eager young scholar, Adventurer with the key to the site, Native yearning to escape
- C** It's been so long since the last opening that everyone's forgotten about it, The access now opens in a very inconvenient place, The access can be forced by some terrible sacrifice
- T** Key to open the access, Controls that permanently open the site, Loot from the last expedition to enter the site
- P** Passage that opens on a time lock, Vast magical seal, Coastal portal revealed only during a particular low tide period

Living Dungeon

The ruin is alive, either in a literal or metaphorical sense. It may be animated by an ancient eidolon that looks through countless sensors, or infused with the spirit of some arcane mind, or made up of the tiny bodies of countless construction-organisms like some vast coral. Physical damage to the ruin usually brings some hostile response, however muted by age and disrepair, and the structure itself may be conscious enough to strike bargains with inhabitants.

- E** Demented ruin spirit, Sorcerer trying to bend the site to their will, Native chieftain who worships the ruin's genius as a god
- F** Friendly ruin sub-organism, Native ruin-keeper, Explorer avid to learn of the place
- C** It's a colony creature with different minds in charge, The ruin is trying to grow at all costs, The ruin went berserk after its ruination and is now acting irrationally
- T** Poison that can kill the ruin, Precious good created by the ruin's life processes, Indigestible treasures left by prior intruders
- P** Wetly organic passageway, Chamber with a giant maw for feeding, Room with tethered organic servitor-creatures

Lost Colony

The ruin was once a colony site for a now-vanished empire or people. Some of these pioneers might still survive within, albeit doubtless in much-changed form, or else their belongings might include objects or relics that would be very valuable today. The modern heirs to this lost domain might still consider the ruin to be their lawful property, and all within it to be theirs.

- E** Degenerate colony leader, Outside conqueror seeking to seize the site, The hideous thing that destroyed the colony
- F** Confused surviving pioneer-heir, New colonist trying to revive the place, Historian looking for relics
- C** The colonists claimed to belong to the lost kingdom but were really of a much more sinister group, Local powers quarrel over site access, Something extremely precious was lost here
- T** Once-commonplace item that is now precious, Ancient wealth of the colonists, Valuable goods they made before they died
- P** Area decorated in their ancient style, Long-abandoned massacre site, Temple to a forgotten god

Monster Forge

The ruin somehow creates a particular type of monster by its simple existence. It might be an ancient spawning-pit for Blighted, a cloning facility gone berserk, an ancient agricultural complex with feral livestock, an open portal to an Iterum of monsters, a source of very infectious monster-creating plagues, or something in that vein. These monsters probably infest the surrounding area, unless something about their nature requires them to stay close to the ruin.

- E** Alpha monster of the horde, Sorcerous would-be tyrant over the creatures, Terrible anomaly-beast that's even worse than usual
- F** Victim of a monstrous rampage, Grim monster-hunter trying to hold back the tide, Local lord overcome by the wave
- C** The ruin has only recently started to belch forth the creatures, The monsters capture humans to make more of their kind, The monsters were once slaves or servants but have now broken free
- T** Implement meant to destroy or control them, Plunder brought back by raiding creatures, Treasures lost by slain adventurers
- P** Frenetic chamber of ever-blossoming life, Overcrowded living quarters, Re-purposed ancient chamber

Magical Wonder

An active Working in the site produces some wondrous effect; permanent summer, biological immortality, endless foodstuffs, visions of the future, or some other grand marvel. Unfortunately, it's so decayed and ill-tuned that all of these wonders come with related serious negative effects and problems, ones that the natives must struggle to deal with.

- E** Ancient half-mad keeper of the Working, Sorcerous monster born of the decay, Outsider determined to exploit the Working at any cost
- F** Adventurer who seeks the Working's benefits, Researcher who wants its secrets, Sorcerer convinced they can fix the Working
- C** The objects and benefits it confers don't exist outside the ruin, It will collapse disastrously if the ruin is seriously damaged, Nearby communities benefit from it and try to keep out intruders
- T** Device to control the Working's benefits, Ruined Working parts that are valuable still, Research notes that would allow it to be repaired
- P** Chamber of dangerous magical fluxes, Sorcerous emission point where the blessing flows forth, Abandoned laboratory where it was made

Outsider Domain

This ruin was originally constructed to serve a race of Outsiders. It is possible that they were not even humanoid, and the atmosphere within the ruin may still be tainted with alien gases or hostile temperatures. The architecture and lighting was designed for alien bodies, and humans might find it difficult to navigate. Surviving inhabitants might be Outsider remnants or the alien flora and fauna that persisted long after their masters had died out.

- E** Still-surviving alien leader, Monstrous alien "pet", Cult priest revering the dead Outsiders
- F** Surviving heir of human slave-servants, Outsider-hunter seeking prey, Researcher looking for lore
- C** The site once produced something very important to the region at a terrible cost in lives, The alien atmosphere becomes unsurvivable in cycles, Humans Blighted by the Outsiders still live here
- T** Alien artifact of great value, Human treasure collected by dead Outsiders, Alien device that does something very useful to modern humans
- P** Inscrutably strange chamber, Living quarters re-dimensioned to fit non-humanoid bodies, "Garden" full of monstrous flora



Precious Resource

The ruin generates a resource or serves a function that is valuable to those around it. This may be a direct and literal generation, such as a Deep that still automatically extracts and refines silver, or it may be metaphorical, such as a ruin full of undead who are privy to ancient secrets sought by wizards. Completely purging the ruin of perils would probably somehow ruin the process, or else some greedy outsider would likely have cleaned it out by now.

- E** Grasping outsider treasure-hunter, Monster attracted by the resource, Resource-maker using it to gain sinister influence and power
- F** Earnest prospector, Luckless official charged with gathering the resource, Desperate fortune-hunter
- C** The resource is cursed or dangerous, The resource can't be accessed without some kind of agreement with the natives, The resource is sacred to the ruin's dwellers
- T** Hidden cache of the resource, Device that extracts it, Ultra-rare refined example of the resource
- P** Place where the resource is extracted, Fortified zone around the extraction, Vault for the gathered resource

Recruiting Drive

At least one group of inhabitants in the ruin are actively adding to their numbers. This may involve bribes, kidnapping, proselytization, or just the prospect of a better life than their recruits currently have. This group is likely ideological or circumstantial in their ties, like a cult, a rebel group, or a bandit clan, and so new members can be added as quickly as they prove agreeable or profitable to the whole. Those who refuse to join in tend to meet less comradely fates.

- E** Charismatic and ruthless conqueror, Heartless grandee hiring disposable muscle, Hypnotically persuasive cult leader
- F** Unwilling recruit, Rival group's leader, Local ruler worried about the new members
- C** The group recruits under false pretenses and then traps the new recruits in some crime, The group really is offering a better deal than most recruits have, Resentment is building between old and new group members
- T** Proof of some outside power's involvement, Wealth meant to use to entice recruits, Rich gift given by an eager new recruit
- P** Disordered and confused living quarters, Well-trod training area, Empty home of a now-vanished recruit

Raider Lair

Some ruins are dangerous only to intruders, but this one actively sends out raiding parties to plunder the surroundings. Many such lairs prefer to go relatively far afield to obscure their origins and avoid the hostility of their immediate neighbors. Others have specific grudges to nurse, or particular targets that have incurred their wrath. Hostages might be taken back for ransom, labor, or food, depending on the nature of the inhabitants.

- E** Ambitious bandit chieftain, Embittered exiled lord, Monstrous ruler who hungers for outside wealth
- F** Relative of a kidnapped victim, Escapee from the raiders, Local reeve trying to cope with the raids
- C** The raiders are being backed by an outside power hostile to its neighbors, The raiders exact a brutal tribute for their "protection", The raiders had or have a sympathetic cause
- T** Priceless relic taken by the raiders, Cache of supplies they need badly, Loot hidden by the plunderers
- P** Raucous and vile raider camp, Re-purposed room turned into the chief's lair, Treasure chamber full of looted goods

Religious Zealots

Almost everyone has some degree of deference to the gods, but the natives of this ruin are outright fanatics of a particular religious or philosophical cause. They may have inherited from ages of ancestors, acquired it from the teachings of a charismatic prophet, or been persuaded of it by some profitable or terrifying display of divine will. The natives likely have at least one goal that makes no logical sense, but is related to their god's nature or desires.

- E** Frothingly intense high priest, Holy demon or sending of the god, Monstrous entity placated by the group's worship
- F** Member having second thoughts, Missionary of a rival faith, Cynical group member who wants to depose the current leadership in their favor
- C** The god's intervention seems real on some level, Their cult is an offshoot of the locally dominant faith, They have backing from a mother temple
- T** Precious religious relic or regalia, Object blessed with divine powers, Wealth taken from unworthy unbelievers
- P** Room fitted out as an ornate shrine, Chamber carved with religious symbolism, Place dedicated to some bloody or fearsome ritual

Rigid Hierarchy

Most ruins have little organization, with various groups or lone beasts vying with each other as their strength allows. In this one, however, there is a clear and recognized hierarchy of power and authority, and lesser groups and entities are likely to obey the greater even without an immediate threat of violence. Of course, those same groups are also quite likely to conspire with outsiders to remove their vexations.

- E** Iron-fisted monster lord, Ambitious and scheming chieftain, Secret kingmaker working as a humble minion
- F** Hapless outsider slave, Minion with ambition, Bitter native seeking systemic revenge
- C** The current leader is the only one holding back the ruin's denizens from raiding, The groups are being organized by an outside power, The subordinate groups are extremely bitter and restive over the state of affairs
- T** Treasure used to pay off underlings, Potent artifact used to cow subordinates, Tribute extracted from unwilling inferiors
- P** Barbarically luxurious throne room, Disciplined and organized watch post, Labor zone where the inferiors toil

Sacrificial Bargain

The natives of the ruin have made some kind of pact with a dread power or sinister force, receiving support or power in exchange for some sacrifice. This sacrifice might fall directly on the natives themselves or they might plunder their neighbors for wealth, human sacrifices, or such other resources as their patron demands in payment. Failure to hold up their end of the deal may be fatal to the inhabitants.

- E** Malevolent high priest of a dark power, Envoy of a ruthless foe of the local inhabitants, Frantic leader driven to desperate bargains
- F** Sacrificial victim who escaped, Foe of the patron power searching for its catspaws, Native from a rival group that's being beaten down
- C** The bargain seemed an innocent one at first, They're realizing that they can't hold up the deal, The deal was made without the consent of the group's ordinary members
- T** Object that symbolizes and empowers the pact, Wealth granted by the patron, Precious object lost by a sacrificial victim
- P** Terrible chamber of ritual offering, Local homestead ravaged by raiders, Storehouse or living area made abundant by the patron

Royal Refuge

Some exiled noble, unsuccessful pretender, hunted wizard, or other grandee of note remained here for a time, either willingly or under duress. They and their retinue left their traces behind, and remnants of the group might still be present. The principle figure probably died here, though some kinds of creatures or wizards may have been less susceptible to time.

- E** Undead prince in exile, Royal agent convinced the PCs are allies of the rebel here, New usurper claiming the dead one's mantle or name
- F** Well-meaning servant of the royal, Local chief trying to keep his village out of the affair, Sympathetic exile in need of help
- C** The royal tried to make a deal with the creatures here, The royal had secret ties or perhaps even was one of the natives here, The royal's foes are in sudden need of proof of their death
- T** Item proving the royal's legitimacy, National treasure they stole away with them, Book full of blackmail material they recorded
- P** Tattered but once-ornate chamber they occupied, Cache full of carefully-preserved noble regalia, Pathetic and coarsely-monumented grave site

Sealed Evil

The ruin serves as a prison for some terribly dangerous entity or power. It may have been originally designed to serve such a purpose, or retrofitted by later inhabitants due to a sudden need, or possibly even mistaken for some other kind of structure by innocent discoverers of a later era. Something about the evil makes it exceptionally hard to kill or permanently destroy, so imprisoning it "forever" seemed wiser.

- E** Undead immortal sorcerer, Monstrous and nigh-unkillable creature, Arch-Outsider with a biology humans can't be sure is dead
- F** Hereditary warden of the prison, Innocently eager explorer, Ancestral hunter of the evil
- C** The evil was actually a benign entity or is currently mistaken for one, Those who loose it will gain enormous power, It's being tapped for power in a way that risks freeing it
- T** Relic of the dark power's evil, Seal on the creature that's an extremely valuable item in itself, Valuable material created or generated by the prison as a byproduct
- P** Exceedingly well-sealed prison area, Chamber with a temporal stasis cell, Hall full of warning iconography made inscrutable by time



Secret Alliance

The natives of the ruin have a secret deal or arrangement with some outside power, doing their bidding or providing some special service in exchange for considerations. It might be a corrupt ruler, a sinister cult, an Outsider lord, a backwater hamlet chief, or some other figure that wouldn't wish the arrangement to become public.

- E** Merchant with vile black market deals, Official who wants the ruin to remain a problem, Society grandee with sinister appetites
- F** Suspicious noble investigator, Stern inquisitor from the local temple, Local who knows too much
- C** The deal is maintaining a fragile peace, There's an openly-acknowledged deal with them but the real bargain is far more sinister, One side is getting ready to betray the other
- T** Proof of the alliance, Rich plunder taken from an ally's enemy, Relic the mutual cooperation is meant to obtain
- P** Secret meeting place in the wilds, Chamber for an envoy of the ally, Treasure chamber with goods from the ally

Spatial Flux

Space within the ruin has been folded, altered, or corrupted in some way, either by ancient magics, inauspicious geomancy, the depredations of a dimensional monster, failed Workings, fumbled sorcery, or some other woe. Some creatures may use the curdled space as a refuge from their enemies, while others might use it as a gate to some stranger and more terrible place.

- E** Transdimensional abomination, Mad sorcerer making things worse, Obsessive seeker of some hidden grail within the spatial maze
- F** Friendly xenodimensional, Adventurer lost and trapped within the place, Local citizen accidentally caught in a warp
- C** The destinations of the warps can be controlled from within the ruin, The place's architecture is only physically possible with spatial distortions, The warps lead to different times as well as places
- T** Relic that creates or influences warps, Treasure shifted here from an alternate place or world, Wealth physically duplicated by the warps
- P** Escher-like room, Chamber with physical locations split over vast differences, Featureless hall that really never ends

Shifting Interior

The interior of the ruin is not stable, and shifts and alters over time or through some enigmatic cycle. It may be composed of constantly-moving elements of some ancient megastructure, or be spatially distorted by a decaying Working, or infested with inhabitants that are constantly rebuilding or reworking the layout. The natives may have some key knowledge that lets them navigate the changes.

- E** Transdimensional intruder entity, Berserk master of the rebuilders, Sinister exile using the place as a refuge
- F** Friendly native guide, Relative of one lost in the labyrinth, Frustrated builder in need of help
- C** The shifts encode an important secret, If the shifts are interrupted a catastrophe will ensue, The shifts are under the control of the ruin's master
- T** Key to control the shifts, Map of the alterations, The treasure within the labyrinth's heart
- P** Room that's changed from the last time they saw it, Churning death zone of moving perils, Maze of twisty little passages all alike

Surfacer Hideout

Some surface power is using the ruin as a hideout or base of operations. While they may simply be bandits or refugees, they're more likely agents of some greater power who need a discreet base, or some cult or criminal organization that needs a safe place to hide from the law. Friendly merchants or other associates might make contact with them there to provide for necessities, or they could be working to survive entirely separate from the hostile world outside.

- E** Foreign spy chief, Cult high priest, Ruthless hunter of an innocent group that's hiding here
- F** Elder of a despised ethnic group hiding here, Government investigator of the ruin, Local who lives nearby and has seen suspicious things
- C** Rather than displacing the monstrous natives the surfacers have dominated or co-opted them, The surfacers were killed or driven out of the ruin very recently and their effects remain, The surfacers have hidden so well that they no longer understand the situation above
- T** Treasure brought from afar by the surfacers, Loot gathered up from displaced ruin natives, Some precious good crafted or extracted by surfacers
- P** Room reminiscent of home, Carefully-hidden entrance to their zone, Remote meeting place

Taboo Place

The locals surrounding the ruin consider it taboo, and will kill or punish anyone who enters it without their permission. This may be the product of religious reverence, or it could be a holy place of their ancestors, or it could be disputed territory, or it may be that the last time adventurers went in a catastrophe came out. Objects looted from the place will be very hard to sell discreetly anywhere near it.

- E** Relentless leader of the guardians, The monstrous thing within that must not be disturbed, Ruin raider who will cause chaos with their plundering
- F** Earnest young treasure hunter, Native who doesn't believe in the taboo, Local who desperately needs to get inside for some reason
- C** The locals are absolutely right that meddling with the place will bring disaster on them, The ruin somehow marks those who profane it, The ruin can be entered lawfully under some special circumstance or by certain people
- T** Pass to allow lawful entrance, Unsellably distinct treasure from the place, Device to overcome the watchfulness of the guardians
- P** Exemplary warning-pike with heads attached, Long-sealed entrance portal, Vigilant guardpost

Useless Treasure

The ruin was once a carefully-guarded storehouse of some substance or information that was priceless at the time but is now largely worthless. Obscure materials, Outsider goods of no present use, exotic matter fashioned by sorcery and of forgotten purposes, and critical intelligence on empires long since dust might all be found here.

- E** Tireless immortal guardian, Brutally relentless treasure seeker, Maddened sorcerer trying to unlock the "real value" of the treasure
- F** Mistakenly optimistic adventurer, Seeker with a lost key to the wards, Native denizen who knows the treasure is worthless
- C** The natives may prize the stuff even if the world outside doesn't, The treasure really is valuable to the very few who know how to use it, The useless treasure is cased with then-useless material that is priceless now
- T** Tremendously well-guarded dross, Text showing how to use the treasure, Key for suppressing the treasure's security system
- P** Vast vault full of garbage, Guard post manned by undying watchers, Ancient luxury area featuring the material or the wealth it brought them

Things Below

The ruin delved too deep, or opened too many doors to other realms, and things came boiling out that brought its destruction. Those things may have fallen asleep again, or returned to their realm, or yet remained here waiting for fresh prey. They may come and go based on particular time cycles, or when provoked by certain rituals or activities within the place.

- E** Lovecraftian abomination from below, Alien-minded extraplanar conqueror, Cultist leader who reveres these eldritch powers
- F** Historian seeking more truth about the things, Relative of a victim of the things, Eager explorer who doesn't believe in the things
- C** The things are associated with monstrous tides of dangerous vermin, The treasures to be had from delving are almost worth the risk, The treasures were actually living things that ruined the place
- T** Precious object brought from below, The treasure that they were delving up, Wealth left behind by the suddenly-slain natives
- P** Interrupted digging site, Vault laden with the wealth of below, Site of sudden terrible ruin

Wizard's Lair

Wizards often require an emphatic degree of privacy to ward off importunate help-seekers, witch hunters, rivals in the art, or reckless thieves. This ruin is or once was a lair to one such wizard, who probably isn't inclined to view visitors kindly. Even the dead ones may have left behind half-finished Workings and unaging automaton servitors to guard their venerable lore and precious magical relics.

- E** Immortal and heartless wizard, Monstrous creation of a dead mage, Modern sorcerer exploiting the lair of a dead archmage
- F** Well-meaning apprentice, Escapee from one of their experiments, Vengeful mage-hunter
- C** They perform some service vital to the locals but at a terrible price, No one's heard from them for so long that it's thought they're dead, It's actually a lair for a school or cabal of wizards
- T** Precious sorcerous grimoire, Magical item crafted there, Vast wealth given by petitioners
- P** Chamber with a half-finished and dangerous Working, Pens for alchemical monstrosities, Living quarters that are physically impossible somehow



WILDERNESS

It's not uncommon for GMs to have difficulty in fleshing out the wilderness parts of a hexcrawl or exploration-based campaign. One forest tends to look a lot like another, and there's only so many times one can go to the well of "inexplicable magical effect randomly occurring here" before it starts to get stale. Rural villages, lost ruins, and other social- or dungeon-esque points of interest can dot the countryside, but without something interesting in the spaces in between, mere distance fails to provide much useful adventure grist.

Wilderness tags can be used to help spark a GM's creativity and develop some worthwhile points of interest for their wilderness maps or daring forays into the unknown. When designing these points of interest, a few general guidelines are helpful.

A popular default scale for a wilderness hex map is six miles per hex. It's enough space to get lost in but small enough that a determined party could reasonably search it for points of interest in a day's marching. If you want to emphasize the interest of exploring a wilderness rather than focus on some other adventure, you might roll 1d6 for each hex and put a point of interest in it on a roll of 1, or on a larger range of results if you're feeling generous.

For this point of interest you should roll twice on the Wilderness Tags table to get a pair of tropes you can synthesize into a usable result. Make sure to tie

your work together as you go; recurring NPCs, current struggles, or shared history might be reflected in multiple points of interest.

Don't try to turn each point of interest into a full-fledged adventure-worthy site. You'll exhaust yourself in short order if you try to do that. Instead, give each point a couple of sentences of rough description and leave it at that until you've fully populated the part of the map that the PCs are expecting to explore for their next session.

Then go through and pick the handful of points that you intend to turn into full adventure-worthy locations; no more than three or four at the most. Use the tools in the adventure creation chapter to flesh out these points. Don't try to turn them into mega-adventures; they don't need to eat up an entire session of play because the PCs have a whole wilderness yet to explore once they finish with a particular site.

For the rest of the points of interest, go through and give them a single, simple situation, encounter, or object for the PCs to meddle with. Use these sites as opportunities to hook or hint toward the meatier, more developed parts of the wilderness or foreshadow their significance.

Finally, be ready to recycle unused content. If the PCs never find a point of interest, save it as backup material for some later date, when you might suddenly need something to occupy the players on short notice.



WILDERNESS ENCOUNTERS

While it's useful to lay down some wilderness points of interest for a hexcrawl or wilderness exploration game, not everything needs tags and full development. Sometimes you just need a few random encounters on a list to pull from when the PCs run into something.

These tables provide suggestions for normal human encounters, nonhuman sapients, or dangerous beasts or monsters. For the nonhumans and the beasts, fill in the role with whatever kind of creature or nonhuman is appropriate to the setting; a swarm of dangerous vermin in the jungle might be an army ant column, while voracious sand shrews might erupt from the desert.

Wilderness encounters usually start at considerable range, depending on when one side first spots the other. Fleeing, negotiation, or avoidance are usually options, and not all encounters will necessarily end in bloodshed.

d12 Nonhuman Sapient Encounters

- 1 Raiders on their way to pillage a site
- 2 Scouts out surveilling the territory
- 3 Patrol to drive off troublesome intruders
- 4 Campsite of the nonhumans
- 5 Nonhuman workers or resource gatherers
- 6 Religious figure conducting some rite
- 7 Nonhumans chasing a human escapee
- 8 Site of a bloody battle with nonhumans
- 9 Nonhuman traders with valuable goods
- 10 Outcast or deranged nonhuman
- 11 Nonhuman magic-user and attendants
- 12 Hunters pursuing their prey

d12 What's Happening with the Sapients?

- 1 They're arguing hotly over something
- 2 They're pausing for a meal
- 3 They're making far too much noise for stealth
- 4 They're interrogating a prisoner
- 5 They're examining recent loot or a finding
- 6 They're camping here for an interval
- 7 They're fleeing a fearsome pursuer
- 8 They're looking for something to steal
- 9 They need healing or help with a situation
- 10 They're hiding from something hunting them
- 11 They're in an affable and friendly mood
- 12 They're chasing enemies of theirs

d12 Human Encounters

- 1 Hopelessly lost merchant or peddler
- 2 Hermit with a good reason to stay alone
- 3 Escaped slave or prisoner
- 4 Peasant perhaps moonlighting as a bandit
- 5 Dangerous outlaw or outcast
- 6 Explorer, scout, or surveyor
- 7 Patrol of the local authorities
- 8 Miners, woodsmen, hunters, or other workers
- 9 Common traveler, perhaps lost
- 10 Noble or other gentry on a journey
- 11 Pilgrim, perhaps of a malevolent god
- 12 Bandits, marauders, or other adventurers

d12 Beasts and Monsters

- 1 Harmless but annoying local creature
- 2 Hungry pack hunters
- 3 Stalking predator looking for an opening
- 4 Sick or somehow enraged predator
- 5 An ambush predator lying in wait
- 6 Large, dangerously aggressive herbivore
- 7 Uncanny or eldritch monster
- 8 A swarm of dangerous vermin
- 9 A flying monster or beast
- 10 Mated pair of team hunters
- 11 Ghost, animate corpse, or other undead
- 12 Something far too dangerous to confront

d12 What's Happening with the Beasts?

- 1 It's wounded from a recent hunt
- 2 It's magically warped somehow
- 3 It's being chased by something bigger
- 4 Remnants of its last prey are obvious nearby
- 5 It's attacking someone right now
- 6 It's well-fed and disinclined to hunt
- 7 It looks deceptively harmless or weak
- 8 It's something's pet or hunting beast
- 9 It's fighting over a mate
- 10 It's using bait to lure in humans
- 11 It's currently eating its last unfortunate prey
- 12 It's old or crippled and acting unpredictably



WILDERNESS TAGS

These tags provide some basic tropes that you can blend together to create a wide range of potential wilderness points of interest. They assume that the wilderness has some sort of pioneer element dwelling there, and remote villages or hard-pressed hamlets of local dwellers exist to provide some oases of relative security in the wilds.

Even so, the defining characteristic of a wilderness is the absence of reliable order. Once beyond the village palisade the local lord's rule becomes a very theoretical thing, and the wilderness will attract all sorts of inhabitants that have reasons for avoiding more carefully-monitored lands. The dwellers in the area might be sturdy peasants, but they're just as likely to be refugees, rebels, bandits, displaced natives, demihumans, or sentient monsters of some kind. The "friendly" tag results below could pull any such inhabitants in, as all of them might have reasons to want to deal with a strong band of adventurers.

You should also be ready to scale tags up or down in significance depending on your particular needs. If you want to make a major base of operations for the players

where they can safely rest and resupply, a *Military Outpost* tag might refer to a fortified keep on the borderlands with a castellan willing to trade. If all you need is a small point of interest to eat up ten minutes of table time, you might just make it a rustic cabin with a trio of trouble-making soldiers exiled to a perpetual "scouting post" by a superior who's forgotten they exist.

If you're generating a very large number of hex crawl points of interest, you might start getting duplicate combinations from a pair of the tags below. In such cases, you might add a third tag from one of the other categories here, flavoring the synthesis with a *Ruin Tag* or a *Community Tag* to add an additional twist. These additions don't need to be read literally; you can use them as metaphors or as creative prompts to add something fresh to the result.

As with any worldbuilding, take care that you tie historical events, current conflicts, and important NPC figures into multiple situations. Having the same elements show up in multiple ways helps add heft to a world.

d100	Tag	d100	Tag
1–2	Abandoned Village	51–52	Migration Path
3–4	Ancient Guardians	53–54	Military Outpost
5–6	Ancient Monument	55–56	Monstrous Beast
7–8	Arratu Land	57–58	Motherlode
9–10	Bandit Lair	59–60	Nomad Camp
11–12	Beast Swarm	61–62	Outsider Enclave
13–14	Blighted Tribe	63–64	Overgrown Tomb
15–16	Broken Infrastructure	65–66	Perilous Path
17–18	Checkpoint	67–68	Pilgrimage Site
19–20	Collapsed Deep	69–70	Precious Game
21–22	Criminal Meet	71–72	Rampant Experiment
23–24	Cryptic Art	73–74	Refugee Camp
25–26	Cursed Land	75–76	Remnant Road
27–28	Decayed Working	77–78	Remote Monastery
29–30	Demihuman Community	79–80	Ruined Fortification
31–32	Devil Grove	81–82	Savage Hamlet
33–34	Disused Mine	83–84	Sculpted Terrain
35–36	Healing Terrain	85–86	Seductive Peril
37–38	Hermitage	87–88	Taboo Territory
39–40	Historical Survival	89–90	Toxic Ruins
41–42	Isolated Academy	91–92	Treacherous Terrain
43–44	Labyrinthine Tangle	93–94	Twisted Fauna
45–46	Lost Battlefield	95–96	Uncanny Weather
47–48	Lost City	97–98	Working Wreckage
49–50	Magical Springs	99–00	Zealot Colony

Abandoned Village

Wilderness villages tend to be unstable “gold rush” settlements in the best of times, attracting those who lack any sound place elsewhere. This village failed as rapidly as it was formed. It may have been overrun by marauders, depopulated by disease, hollowed out by a failed harvest, torn apart by civil strife, or just abandoned for better prospects elsewhere.

- E** Bandit chief or sorcerer responsible for the ruin, Crazy village head turned hermit, Monstrous entity nesting in the remains
- F** Last stubborn holdout, Lord’s bailiff looking for answers, Hapless pioneer who’s arrived to an empty ruin
- C** It’s now populated by something inhuman, It was built on top of a place abandoned for good reason, The wilderness is reclaiming it in a dangerous way
- T** Heirloom left behind in the flight, Buried treasure of the villagers, The relic that caused the ruin
- P** Overgrown village meeting hall, Home with everything left just as it was at that moment, Burnt-out shrine to the local god

Ancient Monument

A grand monument to some ancient polity is found here. While its actual meaning and significance may be inscrutable, it’s probably big enough and dramatic enough to dominate the hex, even if it’s collapsed or been defaced by the ages. The remains of the civilization that raised it might be found at its base, along with whatever heirs to it remain. Some monuments still have active enchantments or guardians to prevent defacement.

- E** Zealous modern cultist of the vanished polity, Last bitter heir of them, Vile monster that nests in the monument
- F** Eager archaeologist, Weary old hereditary keeper of the place, Friendly creature that’s made the monument a home
- C** The monument is a powerful Working, The monument served a secular or residential purpose, The bulk of the monument is underground or in an extradimensional pocket lterum
- T** Costly decorations or ornaments on the monument, The precious core of the work, Ancient offerings made to it by vanished supplicants
- P** Before some towering megastructure-monument, Amid the cyclopean wreckage of its fall, Secret passages within the monument

Ancient Guardians

There are guardians in this site derived from some ancient polity, whether constructs built to protect some long-forgotten place here or the restless shades of the dead who once dwelled in the location. They may have a simple hatred towards “invaders” or they may be confused, thinking interlopers are part of some ancient enemy group. What they once guarded may not even exist any more in any perceptible way.

- E** Unrelenting golem leader, Maddened sorcerer-lord shade, Sinister heir seeking to suborn the guardians to their service
- F** Diplomatic guardian entity, Greedy treasure-hunter, Local who got trapped in the place
- C** The guardians are to keep something in, A local group uses the guardians as a trap for outsiders, The guardians were never meant to be harmful but what they do to intruders is very damaging
- T** Key to shut down or ward off the guardians, The precious relic they were guarding, Ritual garb that makes the wearer invisible to the guardians
- P** Place of ominously martial statuary, Ghostly street-image of a vanished place, Broken remnant of an ancient landmark

Arratu Land

There is a large pocket of *arratu* at the site, even though it may be too small to show up on the hex map. Such a pocket might be the last remnant of a formerly-great swath, or it could just be a localized tumor created by an Outsider device, a malevolent sorcerer, or a magical disaster. Something about the *arratu*’s placement likely forces the party to go well out of their way to bypass it safely; it might command a narrow pass or be flanked by dangerous terrain on either side.

- E** Outsider beast within the waste, Half-human marauder chief lairing inside, Crazy Outsider wizard who made the wasteland
- F** Foolish explorer who tried to cross it, Wretched slave taken by raiders, Not-too-homicidal native
- C** The wasteland is being contained by a potentially-breakable object here, Locals know how to get through it safely, It’s a very new wasteland and the locals haven’t adjusted to it yet
- T** Equipment to survive the hostile atmosphere within, Precious Outsider relic, Wealth seized by raiders from the waste
- P** Blasted village overrun by alien life, Desolate plain with an unearthly sky above, Lakeshore of a pool filled with a noxious chemical



Bandit Lair

Bandits lair in this hex, which is presumably close enough to civilized lands to serve as a base for their operations. Not every bandit lair is a hidden cave; some operate out of subverted or cowed villages, others hide among remote monasteries, and some just camp in convenient glades long enough to rest, refit, and trade with black marketeers. It might be a seasonal lair as well, with local peasants turning bandit at certain profitable times of the year.

- E** Ruthlessly pragmatic bandit chief, Wealthy grandee wielding the bandits against rivals, Heartless slaver gathering stock
- F** Hapless missionary of a kinder way, Local taken as a slave, Runaway bandit who repents
- C** They have a traditional prey and don't usually rob others, They're the degenerate remnants of a once-noble cause, They're a confederacy of thieving groups that often quarrel
- T** Loot taken from a recent success, Priceless heirloom owned by a noble-turned-bandit, Precious relic the bandits don't realize is so valuable
- P** Raucous glade full of drink and debauchery, Repurposed estate, Makeshift palisaded camp

Blighted Tribe

A tribe of Blighted live in the hex. They may be violent war-creatures naturally hostile to normal humanity or beings cursed with some trait or nature that makes it impossible for them to live in civilization. Relations are unlikely to be warm in either case, but the latter might be persuaded to parley if the party can work around their limitations and win their trust.

- E** Brutal Blighted war-chief, Outsider using them as living tools, Human hunter bent on slaughtering inoffensive Blighted
- F** Native not so Blighted as their brethren, Human trader who deals with them, Local human who knows their ways
- C** Their blight was once very useful to the ancient polity that existed here, They're only Blighted because they lack something to temper it that this site once provided, They're dying out and desperate to win allies against their many predators
- T** Valuable Blighted-made product, Relics of those who twisted them, Trophies taken from their prey
- P** Human structure reworked to fit their nature, Site of a gruesome massacre, Shrine or monument honoring their creators

Beast Swarm

There is a swarm of some dangerous beast in the area, whether it consists of a tide of minuscule vermin or a pack of magically-warped predators. Some of these swarms may serve more as environmental hazards than monsters to be fought; sweeping carpets of mutated radioactive fire ants might be something for the PCs to dodge rather than engage. If the beasts have some mundane value, they might have attracted suitably reckless interest from the locals.

- E** Supernaturally intelligent god-beast, Mad wizard who spawned them, Brutal hunt master driving his wretched minions on
- F** Victim of a beast attack, Animal collector on a mission, Hunter in search of vengeance
- C** The beasts are usually harmless but have recently changed, The beasts are the only thing holding a worse peril back, The beasts gain magical powers in sufficiently large groups
- T** Poison that is very lethal to the beasts, Relic that can control the swarms, Priceless treasure held by a luckless hunter
- P** Site of a bestial massacre, Fetid den of a swarm, Overrun hunter's camp

Broken Infrastructure

There is a ruin here that once enabled some grand ancient infrastructure. A lost canal lock, irrigation control center, magical gate nexus, weather control station, underground transit station, occult communications center, or some other great function was once performed here. The ruin has been unusable for ages, but remnants of its former function might still be found in the surroundings.

- E** Sorcerer looting the wreckage, Monstrous remnant of the former inhabitants or guardians, Modern parasite-monster come to feed on the scraps
- F** Curious arcane student, Tribal who lives in the ruin, Wayfarer forced to seek refuge there
- C** It still works but in a dangerous and unhelpful way, It would cause a tremendous local disaster if it were re-activated, The locals are exploiting it in an unintended fashion
- T** Control key for the original function, Relic related to the original function that does something magical, Precious component from it
- P** Long-ruined control nexus, Collapsed service or operational area, Surrounding area scarred by the decayed remnants of its function

Checkpoint

There's a natural choke point in this area: a mountain pass, a land bridge, a dry ridge in a swamp, a narrow strand of untainted arratu land, a gap in a megastructure, or some other slender passage. Such a chokepoint is likely part of a feature that extends outside the hex, and it may be prohibitively difficult to cross this feature anywhere else. Such valuable, defensible areas are rarely left unoccupied.

- E** Bandit lord who "taxes" passersby, Monstrous creature who hunts there, Ancient guardian of a long-dead polity
- F** Trader in dire need, Explorer seeking a better way, Local currently inhabiting the chokepoint
- C** It can be opened or blocked by a controller, It's only recently become abnormally dangerous, It's known of only by those who want it kept secret
- T** Map of the passage, Token allowing safe passage, Key to controlling the passage
- P** Perfect ambush site, Natural fortress, High observation point commanding the pass

Criminal Meet

This site is used as a meeting place for smugglers, bandits, illegal slavers, fences, or other criminals. Something about the place gives them a good view of any incoming strangers and discreet privacy for their dealings. Some few criminals may remain here at all times to maintain the place, or it might be used only as the situation requires. These criminals may be particular, dealing only with known associates, or they may be far enough from the law to feel comfortable about trading with adventurers.

- E** Corrupt merchant grandee, Sinister black market boss, Monstrous entity that enforces the meet's peace
- F** Theft victim searching for their goods, Frustrated local lawman, Merchant with suspicions about a fence
- C** The local authorities turn a knowing blind eye to it, The meet is trading in something much worse than everyone thinks it is, Significant amounts of stolen goods are stored there
- T** Valuable smuggled contraband, Cache of stolen goods, Precious object that's very hard to fence
- P** Concealed cave storehouse, Rocky observation point, Sheltered glade in a thick forest

Collapsed Deep

An ancient Deep once was located here, but time, warfare, or disaster caused it to collapse. A significant portion of the surface has likely subsided to form an uneven crater. Small sections of the Deep might still be accessible from the surface, and dangerous uncollapsed passageways may still connect these smaller zones. The heirs of the survivors may still persist on the surface or they may have long since died out to natural hazards or dispersion.

- E** Buried undying lord, Surface looter with dreams of rule, The thing that caused the collapse
- F** Friendly survivor descendant, Curious explorer, Native guide to the ancient pit
- C** Things below are digging their way up, The Deep is leaking something dangerous, The collapse was recent and monstrous survivors still flee
- T** Priceless Deep treasure cast up, Exposed arcane components, Potent relic carried by survivors
- P** Ancient vault torn in two, Crevasse cutting through a hundred ruined levels, Buckled structure fragment jutting through the surface

Cryptic Art

A vast ancient work of art has been raised here, back when the wilderness was not so wild. It may be a statue or other sculpted monument, perhaps of entities in no way human, or it may be fashioned of solid light, sound, emotions, or stranger media. The intended meaning of this art is usually incomprehensible to modern humanity and the structure is too large or too difficult to harm for ordinary vandals or time to have erode it entirely. Some ancient forms of art can be dangerous or even lethal to modern humans.

- E** Ancient site guardian, Priest of a cult that's made a religion of the art, Sorcerer bent on suborning a magical artwork
- F** Reckless art connoisseur, Native living in the artwork, Historian trying to decipher it
- C** It has a positive or negative effect on a viewer's body or mind, It's been warped into something monstrous by time or decay, It encodes a terrible or precious secret to those who understand it
- T** Ancient texts that can decode the art's meaning, Precious object used in its construction, Fragment of damaged art that's still valuable
- P** Intended viewing site for the art, Churning inner mechanism of a complex work, Hidden chamber revealing a different perspective of the work



Cursed Land

This site has been cursed. Rather than being a simple xenofomed arratu, some malevolent magic has laid a persistent, dangerous affliction on the area. Creatures may be warped, inhabitants may be plagued, terrible luck might strike all passers-by, or natural physical processes might be perverted. There should be something valuable or attractive here, or else few people would have any reason to engage with the location.

- E** Vile sorcerer responsible for the curse, Hideously-warped native creature, Curse-beast that sweats the malison with its very existence
- F** Local curse victim, Native sorcerer trying to lift it, Hapless pioneer who didn't realize it was there
- C** It has a seemingly positive effect as well, The seemingly obvious source of the curse isn't at all responsible, Someone profits by the curse
- T** Ward to protect against the curse, Precious byproduct of the magic, Key to undoing the curse
- P** Warped and twisted natural feature, Nest of misshapen beasts, Field of grossly-mutated plant life

Demihuman Community

There's a community of demihumans living here, likely intentionally avoiding more well-controlled lands in order to maintain their autonomy. Autonomy alone is unlikely to be all the reason they've avoided civilized lands, however, as few human rulers find it worth the trouble to demand more than a fixed tribute from demihumans, leaving them to control their own affairs. There may be something about this group that makes it impossible for them to live comfortably near humans.

- E** Crazy demihuman leader, Sinister demihuman cult priest, Tyrannical government viceroy
- F** Xenophilic local demihuman, Human trader with lasting ties, Human who's "gone native"
- C** They're apart to keep humans safe from them rather than them safe from humans, They're remnants of a former demihuman kingdom, They're responsible for many local wilderness dangers in order to maintain their privacy
- T** Precious good created by demihumans, Inherited relic of the ancestors, Tribute owed the local ruler
- P** Ceremonial structure of a former age, Village hidden cunningly, Well-guarded wall against outsiders

Decayed Working

There's an ancient Working in the area that is broken or decayed, and the original effect it was intended to produce has been twisted into something dangerous. Infrastructure Workings meant to provide good fortune, health, or swift travel might now create ill-luck, plagues, or vomit forth extradimensional horrors. Small Workings of private buildings might now create localized hazards. Completely destroying the Working might end the problem or create an even greater disaster from the magical fallout.

- E** Working-born abomination, Ancient caretaker gone berserk, Sorcerer tearing apart the Working recklessly for lore and parts
- F** Native who knows how to live with the blight, Ambitious would-be repairman, Curious scholar looking for details
- C** The decay can be contained with vile or costly rituals by the locals, The decay is endured because it fends off outsiders, A local enemy wants to worsen the effect
- T** Parts to repair the Working, Valuable magical byproducts, Precious Working fragments
- P** Decaying Working chamber, Site twisted by the magical effect, Collapsed arcane structure

Devil Grove

While not a full-fledged *arratu*, there's a glade or zone within the hex that's infested with Outsider flora and fauna. Beasts from within prowl the surrounding area, though some circumstance is preventing the glade from growing at a very rapid pace. Some ancient Outsider device may be causing the glade, or it might be the tiny remnant of some ancient wasteland that's shrunk with time and the constraint of the Legacy.

- E** Hideous Outsider predator, Blighted warchief hiding in the grove, Ancient Outsider maintaining the grove
- F** Hard-pressed pioneer, Local hunter harried by the beasts, Adventurer seeking the grove's cause
- C** Local rustics sacrifice to the grove to placate its denizens, The grove is valued as a natural defense against a neighboring threat, Exiles and criminals seek refuge there
- T** Precious byproduct of alien life, Outsider relic in the heart of the grove, Valuable goods on a victim of the beasts
- P** Glen swollen with uncanny life, Windy vale streaked with plumes of alien air, Shore of a pond full of some noxious chemical

Disused Mine

A mine of some kind once existed here. While shaft mines with tunnels and galleries are the common type for present-day delvings, ancient strip mines here may have peeled off whole mountainsides or exposed some massive megastructure that was stripped for parts in a prior, lost age. The forgotten mines of a prior era might have left tailing piles or trace deposits that are valuable to a more depleted age.

- E** Crazy wildcat miner, Thing from delving too deep, Undead and tireless mine boss
- F** Eager prospector, Native dwelling in the mines, Ancient friendly mining automaton
- C** They were mining a buried civilization rather than ores, Groups are fighting over control of the mine, The mine was partially re-purposed for the needs of a group of natives
- T** Motherlode of precious materials, Storehouse of refined product, Map to a virgin strike
- P** Massive pitch-black subterranean gallery, Mound made of centuries worth of tailings, Still-poisoned land in a processing waste zone

Hermitage

A small hermitage was established here sometime in the past to provide solitude for some ascetic. Occasionally small clusters of hermits form around such a central point, meeting at times to check on each other or join in shared discipline. Such anchorites usually shun visitors who aren't also devotees of their path, but occasionally a hermit wins such fame for sorcery or wisdom that pilgrims seek them out. Some hermits have been known to respond with great anger toward these repeated worldly interruptions.

- E** Hermit sorcerer gone mad, Sinister villain hiding as a hermit, Alien hermit with inscrutably evil philosophical principles
- F** Worried relative of a new hermit, Petitioner seeking holy help, Hermit rethinking solitude
- C** The hermits have control over a local magical energy or Working, They keep themselves separate to keep others safe from them and their irrepressible powers, The hermit is hated by the local secular authorities for their aid to its foes
- T** Precious religious relic carried by the hermit, Cast-off worldly wealth, Map to finding them
- P** Austere wilderness cave, Hermit hole in a grave-mound in the swamps, Tall and narrow stone column for sitting on

Healing Terrain

This site borders a shrinking *arratu*, one being slowly driven back by the Legacy, the work of human hands, or some native life form that's capable of successfully competing with the alien life. There are usually some pioneers or scavengers trying to take advantage of the shrinking waste, either to work the newly-arable land or plunder the ruins its receding tide reveals.

- E** Furious and frustrated Outsider wastemaker, Monstrous beast in too small a hunting ground, Local tyrant seeking dominion over the new pioneers
- F** Plucky new colonist, Earnest professional mender of wastes, Luckless soldier sent to defend the new locals
- C** The shrinking wastes are revealing a lost human city below, As the waste shrinks its effects are getting more concentrated inside it, The receding zone is opening a safe path for old enemies to strike the new holdings
- T** Treasures long lost within the waste, Possessions cherished by a now-dead pioneer, Precious product of the alien flora that now grows scarce
- P** Half-warped glade where alien life is losing, Newly-built steading, Exposed ancient structure

Historical Survival

Some small community or remnant group of an ancient empire persists here. They may have been a colony planted before the empire's fall, an outside group that inherited the culture after conquest or subsumption, a chronological distortion cast out of time, a group held in stasis that recently awoke, or some other remnant of a greater past. They may or may not have a clear idea of the present world, but may preserve knowledge of now-lost strongholds and points of power once held by their ancestors.

- E** Embittered revanchist ruler, Vengeful chieftain who blames the world, Transhuman leader of incomprehensible cognition
- F** Heritor curious about outsiders, Desperate chief in need of outside help, Determined preserver of ancient identity
- C** The empire they belonged to was infamous, They're only notionally human, They make deals with rebels and exiles of neighboring lands
- T** Long-preserved ancient regalia, Now-lost relic in common use in their empire, Secret lore to unlock hidden storehouses of their people
- P** Crumbling and dilapidated public building, Crude shrine with too-advanced salvaged ornaments, Passages kept secret from the world



Isolated Academy

A school of sorcerers, esoteric artists, hermit-scholars, or other educators is in the area. The place might once have been the heart of the ancient city where the academy was founded, or it may have special magical or aesthetic traits to attract practitioners, or the topic they study might be abhorrent to civilization. The academy is likely largely self-sufficient but its students and teachers doubtless retain some ties to the outer world.

- E** Sinister headmaster, Powerful instructor with a dark purpose, Monstrous thing the academy serves
- F** Sympathetic young student, Pilgrim aspiring to be admitted, Harried instructor needing help
- C** It has two curricula with the second being much darker and known only to initiates, It's protected by its terrible patron power, An awful sacrifice is demanded of some or all students
- T** Tome of secret lore they've developed, Magical object they've created, Key to bypassing the academy's defenses
- P** Mundanely-impossible lecture hall, Artistic work of inhuman nature, Site scorched and blasted by their mistakes or training errors

Lost Battlefield

A terrible battle was fought here at some point in the past, perhaps before the wilderness became what it is now. The locals may or may not remember the event, but the battle left some pronounced effect on the area. Undead may be exceptionally common here, or an ancient weapon may have curdled the land, or the automatons that fought here may still be watchful for new enemies.

- E** Looter-archaeologist and his minions, Undying warlord, Relentless ancient automaton
- F** Curious scholar from afar, Heir to one of the warring sides, Ancestral caretaker of the field
- C** The battle is reenacted by locals either ritually or in earnest every so often, A priceless item of ruling regalia was lost here, The battlefield's full of unexploded ancient munitions
- T** Potent weapon of ancient days, Precious treasure carried here by a slain noble warrior, Bones of a sainted hero revered by the locals
- P** Hasty and makeshift tomb of a war leader, Land churned up by ancient war magic, Vast burial mound amid a bleak plain

Labyrinthine Tangle

The terrain is remarkably tangled and treacherous, such that it's almost impossible to cross it without a guide or very good map. This tangle may be the result of shifting, boggy ground, wildly overgrown forest, looming cliffs that box in travel, or magical miasmas that baffle and disorient. Some regions might have spatial distortions born of ancient magic, such that only the right keys allow outsiders to pass them.

- E** Sinister master of the labyrinth, Monstrous creature born of the wild, Savage exile hiding in the maze
- F** Helpful local guide, Hapless soul lost within it, Friendly native of the maze
- C** Getting lost in it can leave you very far from your entry point, An environmental hazard harms you more the longer you stay in it, Guides sacrifice certain clients to the powers within
- T** Map of the labyrinth, Treasure lost by a victim within it, Precious object the labyrinth guards
- P** Trail that looks like all the rest, Trees or cliffs too difficult to scale blocking out any distant view, Ancient megastructure with perfectly identical massive decorative fragments that form a maze

Lost City

There was a city here once and its remnants can still be found through the overgrowth. It may have been an ancient city of some lost empire, or it could be a community more recently destroyed by some event and consumed by the surrounding wilderness. In the former case it's probably forgotten by all but the wisest scholars, while in the latter there's some pressing reason that its former people don't dare approach its site any more.

- E** The terrible creature that destroyed it, Vengeful wraith of its last ruler, Savage chieftain who's taken it for his seat of rule
- F** Shy survivor of the original population, Local native who dares to enter it, Ancient city servitor who still functions
- C** The city is plagued with magical aftershocks of the mighty sorcery that destroyed it, The city was smashed before its inhabitants could do a great evil, It's taboo ground for the nearby locals
- T** Ancient city vault's treasures, Precious relic of the dead, Fragment of the thing that ruined it
- P** Desolate street half-buried by earth and decay, City monument worn into illegibility, Wreckage of the catastrophic death of the city

Magical Springs

There's an enchanted spring in the area, one empowered by an ancient Working or warped by ambient currents of magic. The creatures that drink from it might be blessed with some special grace, but it's just as likely that some more sinister consequence comes from imbibing its water. The animal and plant life around it have doubtless been substantially altered by its effects. Most such springwater loses its powers if separated from the main body for very long.

- E** Beast warped by the spring's power, Ruthless sorcerer experimenting with its effects, Barbaric chieftain using it to advance his power
- F** Ancestral guardian of the spring, Pioneer plagued by the spring's effects, Scholar who thinks they can fix any negative effects of the spring
- C** The spring grants a blessing that comes with a substantial cost, The spring's blessing becomes a curse when over-imbibed, The spring's created an entire ecosystem of servitor-addicts
- T** Cure for the changes the spring forces, Vessel that can hold the springwater without losing its power, Precious fragment of the original Working
- P** Pool of obviously uncanny water, Shore marked with the spring's effects, Weird den of a spring-touched beast

Migration Path

A fearsome migration of dangerous creatures crosses this area at certain times of the month or year. During this migration an invincible wave of these entities crosses the site, perhaps to get from one underground entrance to another, or to move from one feeding site to the next, or to immerse themselves in some critical magical aura or ancient radiation. Despite this, there must be something valuable in this area that tempts outsiders to risk being here when the living tide arrives.

- E** Monstrously huge alpha of the tide, Cultist who worships the creatures of the tide, Sorcerer trying to bend the swarm to his will
- F** Treasure seeker daring the migration schedule, Scholar of these beasts, Local trapped here at the wrong time
- C** The tide's schedule is dangerously unpredictable, The creatures are always present but only become dangerous during the migration, The migration path changes very often
- T** Precious animal byproduct of the swarm, Treasure found by a too-slow seeker, Key to predicting or controlling the swarm
- P** Trail stripped bare by the tide, Massive breeding ground, Island full of cowering refugees



Military Outpost

There's a military post located in this wilderness, one planted by an interested government, community, religion, or mercantile group. It may be guarding a trail through the wilds, monitoring dangerous natives, acting as a tripwire against invasion, or be a punishment post for troublesome officers. The outpost is likely to be reliant on regular shipments of goods. Sufficiently large outposts often form the nucleus of a pioneer settlement.

- E** Brutal martinet commander, Wrathful native leader, Crime boss who's suborned the isolated post
- F** Hard-used military scout, Pioneer searching for help, Native leader looking for allies
- C** The outpost has sparked a dispute with a bordering polity, The post is so isolated it's effectively independent, The post has been abandoned or cut off by its patron and is in dire need of supply
- T** Load of vital supplies, Pay for the soldiers, Weapon shipment craved by the natives
- P** Rough-hewn log fort, Piled stone strongpoint on a naturally-defensible site, Tall wooden tower looking over the countryside

Motherlode

Some precious ore, rare wood, magical elixir, arcanelly-potent extract, or other natural product is in great supply here. Anyone capable of extracting it without interruption would become very wealthy, though the natives, the local fauna, or rival competitors may make that ambition difficult to fulfill. The motherlode might be known only to the natives, or is perhaps known to no one at all due to its concealment or exotic nature.

- E** Prospector devoid of moral qualms, Existing site owner who's lethally paranoid, Local lord who intends to utterly exploit the eventual site owner
- F** Humble laborer in the mines, Poor but talented prospector, Land-wise local who knows of it
- C** The substance is very hazardous to the extractor, Extracting it would break a very powerful local monopoly, It was buried or sealed away for a very good reason
- T** Sample proving the motherlode's worth, Ancient tools that make extraction practical, Capital needed to begin extraction
- P** The dangerous extraction site itself, Cave where prior extractors stored their equipment, Makeshift barracks where the laborers sleep

Monstrous Beast

Fearsome beasts are a commonplace in the wilderness of the Latter Earth, but there's something here horrible enough to be remarkable even to the natives. It may be something far too dangerous for the party to have any hope of defeating; if so, it should leave plenty of evidence of its approach or presence, and give prudent heroes the chance to flee or distract it. The natives either avoid this area or must find some way to placate the thing.

- E** Magical abomination born of ancient sorcery, Divinely-infused god-beast, Remnant-creature of a dead empire that still fulfills its duty
- F** Glory-seeking hunter, Native with a lust for vengeance against it, Rapt arcane zoologist
- C** The locals worship it as a god because it actually can and will help them at times, It's guarding a particular site there, Its leavings or sheddings are a precious substance
- T** Treasure of some luckless victim, Relic of the beast's makers, Substance or device that can repel the beast
- P** Site of a horrible slaughter, Monstrous lair full of remains, Gory offering-site where sacrifices are made to it

Nomad Camp

There's a regularly-used nomad camp site in the area, a stopping place for them and their kindred. The site likely has water, a defensible position, or religious significance to them. Depending on the time of year or current raiding activities the camp might be empty, but any random day presents some chance of a group of them seeking shelter here. Wandering encounters in this hex might very likely be with such nomads.

- E** Glory-hungry nomad raid leader, Leader who plans on turning his people into sedentary conquerors, Vision-maddened sorcerer-priest of the nomads
- F** Peace-minded rival of the nomad leader, Local victim of their raids, Former owner of the structure they're now using as a camp
- C** The nomads are raiders or traders as profit suggests, The nomads are forced to move by some outside power, The camp is desperately needed by some local group for practical or religious reasons
- T** Loot hidden in the camp, Trophy taken by the raiders, Tribute offered up to win their mercy
- P** Once-splendid chamber now scuffed and defaced, Vigilantly-guarded oasis, Makeshift shrine to the nomad god

Outsider Enclave

A group of surviving Outsiders dwells in the area, a remnant of their former age of rule. They may rely on stealth or great isolation to preserve their numbers, or they might just be able to kill anyone who gets too close. The enclave is unlikely to have real ambitions of expansion or else it would have been wiped out by now, but it may preserve ancient relics or fell powers that could wreak havoc if used recklessly.

- E** Bitterly vengeful Outsider leader, Human traitor in league with the enclave, Hideous thing unleashed by the enclave
- F** Outsider who sees profit in the PCs, Naively xenophilic human, Victim of Outsider raids
- C** The Outsiders want something that isn't necessarily antagonistic to the PCs, They've only recently awoken from stasis or temporal displacement and are still exploring, They're masquerading as a human group or have one as a front
- T** Potent alien relic, Treasure collected from human thralls, Precious regalia of an alien king
- P** Fetid Outsider nest with a noxious atmosphere, Eerie abandoned ruins of their former day, Maintained shrine to an Outsider god

Perilous Path

A danger-laden bridge, trail, skyway, spatial distortion, tunnel, ancient roadbed, or some other path in this area leads through an otherwise impenetrable obstacle or serves as the sole means of reaching some point of interest. This path should be fairly obvious to explorers, but its destination may not be clear. If the destination is inhabited, it might be guarded by the denizens, or there may be the remains of ancient wayposts that once served the traffic along the path.

- E** Raubritter warrior demanding a toll, Vicious monster lairing on the path, Bandit chief lying in wait to ambush travelers
- F** Helpful native path guide, Ancient maintenance laborer on the path, Explorer seeking the path
- C** The path is one-way only, The path has only recently opened up, The path can be controlled with a particular key or relic
- T** Map of the path, Ancient relic used by the path's builders, Key to unlock the path
- P** Ancient skyway stretching between mountaintops, Tunnel full of long-forgotten defensive traps, Transdimensional pathway through an eldritch wilderness

Overgrown Tomb

A once-honored tomb lies here, forgotten or lost to the depredations of enemies. The structure is likely elaborate enough to be a building in its own right, or an excavation beneath some surface monument. The tomb may house a single glorious hero or be the resting place of an associated group, such as a particular noble lineage, the slain of a great battle, a lost city's municipal ossuary, or some like grave.

- E** Long-trapped undead king, Monstrous beast fat on old corpses, Necromancer jealous of his prizes
- F** Ancestral guardian of the tomb, Curious archaeologist, Last heir of the one entombed
- C** It was originally a different structure turned into a mass grave due to emergency need, It's actually just a mass casualty incident in a structure, Someone's mining the dead for their remains
- T** Precious funerary offerings, Regalia buried with a dead ruler, Text containing secrets lost to the present day
- P** Crumbling monument to the dead, Fallen-in gravesite, Forest of gravestones

Pilgrimage Site

There is some important monument, place, or structure here that attracts pilgrims from far away. It may be a holy site beloved of a local faith, a mythic origin-point for a nearby culture, an oracle or other provider of widely-desired services, or a font of some special favor or benefit that can reward a pilgrim. The site may be under the control of a local government, or it may be too distant or dangerous to be effectively protected or administered by outsiders.

- E** Raider chieftain plundering the pilgrims, Zealot who has seized control of it for their own sect, Once-benevolent holy entity that has become hostile for some reason
- F** Desperate pilgrim from afar, Local administrator beset by woes, Young merchant providing for the pilgrims' needs
- C** Factions are actively struggling over the site's control, The site is being ruined by the pilgrim traffic, The site has a strategic value quite aside from its use to pilgrims
- T** Sacred relic of the site, Offering given by a grateful pilgrim, Token that grants access to the site's most potent reward
- P** Ancient temple on a holy site, Monument to a great deed, Perilous cave of an oracle



Precious Game

Some native fauna here is remarkably valuable, either for the sake of some magical blessing it grants its captor or for the benefits its flesh, pelt, or magical organs can give. Other game may be ritually important, such an animal that grants some ruling legitimacy to a successful hunter. The animal itself is probably either highly dangerous, highly rare, or carefully gamekept by some outside power if it has escaped extinction thus far.

- E** Bloodthirsty hunter who brooks no rivals, Game animal grown warped and lethal, Guardian of the game who kills all interlopers
- F** Sympathetic hunter with a good reason, Local deeply reliant on successful hunting, Zoologist seeking to study the beast
- C** The benefit of hunting the game is only granted if they are captured or killed in a very troublesome way, The animals are found around a different much more dangerous beast, The beasts have multiple life stages with different traits
- T** Trove of beast pelts, Lure for the beasts, Map to their secret breeding grounds
- P** Ramshackle hunting camp, Altar to the beasts, Magical site where the beasts were first made

Refugee Camp

There's a refugee camp in the area made up of people who've fled some calamity. It may be a bandit raid on their villages, an ethnic purge nearby, a religious schism they lost, the collapse of a functioning community, or some other disaster. The refugees have no better place to go or they'd have gone there by now; they're probably dying off to local hazards at a greater or lesser rate, or trying to turn the camp into a functional settlement.

- E** Brutal tyrant over the camp, Local marauder exploiting them, Horrible beast that hunts them
- F** Sympathetic young refugee, Local governmental representative who can't help much, Earnest religious leader
- C** The refugees are highly undesirable to the surrounding polities, They're demihuman or Blighted, The camp's a hotbed of some not-too-quickly lethal but very contagious disease
- T** Vital cache of supplies, Precious possessions of the refugees, Relic they stole or rescued in their flight
- P** Miserable camp of crude shanties, Damp refuge caverns, Ancient ruins made into a camp

Rampant Experiment

Not every Working or spell research is a success, and some effort here went drastically wrong. Some sort of rampantly overgrown flora or monstrosity altered fauna roam the place, the result of magic gone awry. They probably have some quality or trait that was useful to the creator, but it was combined with so many drawbacks or dangers that the result is a menace.

- E** Mad sorcerer who caused it, Creature warped terribly by the experiment, Looter with no regard for the chaos their blundering is releasing
- F** Apologetic apprentice of the culprit, Non-hostile experimental victim, Local desperately fighting the experiments
- C** An outside power is promoting the disaster because it's somehow to their advantage, The experiment results seem wholly beneficial at first, The experiment's area of effect is slowly growing
- T** Cure or tool to halt the experiment, Precious object created by the experiment, Magical tool used in the experiment
- P** Sinister occult laboratory, Normal area terribly warped by the experiment, Local structure destroyed by the experiment

Remnant Road

Some long-lost empire laid a road here, along with the waystations that once served to guard it. The surviving remnant may just be a short segment, or it might still lead to whatever destination of significance it once served. Other ruins of this empire are likely positioned along the road, and modern inhabitants might still make use of it as a highway through rough terrain, or have positioned their own settlements along its length.

- E** Ancient creature that guards the road from "bandits", Bandit chief exploiting a ruined waypost, Local lord who collects cruel tolls
- F** Merchant making use of the path, Local from a colony-village set up at one end, Remnant survivor from the culture that built it
- C** The road is magically useful or well-maintained, The road leads through some tremendously dangerous area, The road is built as a high and stepped structure that forms a tall defensive wall on one side
- T** Magical pass allowing use of the road, Ancient weapon stored in a waypost, Key to unlocking a waypost's vault
- P** Ancient watch station, Stretch of unnaturally perfect road, Monument to a forgotten king

Remote Monastery

There is a largely self-sustaining monastery, temple, hermitage, or other religious site in the area, one inhabited by clergy who have some particular need for isolation. They may be guardians of a holy site, imprisoned heretics, wardens of some refuge for travelers, or a particularly rigorous or heretical sect. They may be willing to provide services for strangers of acceptable character, and might well have problems that their limited resources can't solve.

- E** Sinister-minded abbot, Demonic entity warring on the clerics, Cleric of a rival faith or sect determined to destroy them and all their allies
- F** Friendly if unworldly local cleric, Native who trades with the monastery, Cleric who seriously reconsiders their choice to come here
- C** The monastery has been taken over by zealots or an outside power, The monastery is a cover for sinister occult doings, The place isn't nearly as self-sufficient as it thought it would be
- T** Sacred relic of the place, Offering made by a grateful believer, Sacred text specific to their sect
- P** Well-guarded fields outside the walls, Heavily-fortified monastic building, Hostel for travelers kept outside the monastery itself

Savage Hamlet

There's a village in the area, but its inhabitants are vicious or profoundly unsociable in some way. They may deal violently with outsiders, have abhorrent cultural habits, be the decadent remains of some group cast out for their evil ways, or just Blighted of a kind that get along very poorly with baselines. The party should likely have some sort of indication of their nature given to them before the first contact, or else the village should be savage in ways that don't necessarily lead to likely immediate attack.

- E** Brutal village chieftain, Cruel shaman of a dark god, Non-local criminal who's gone native in a bad way
- F** Rare better-dispositioned local, Missionary trying to civilize them, Local who sees profit in dealing with outsiders
- C** They are remarkably talented or learned at some activity, They appear harmless at first encounter, They have considerable virtues to go with their terrible vices
- T** Locally-produced good of value, Loot from their victims, Tribute given by frightened neighbors
- P** Fighting pit for local entertainment, Chieftain's barbaric hall, Ancient structure put to misuse

Ruined Fortification

This place was of great strategic importance in some prior age, and a ruined castle, outpost, waystation, or military base can be found here. It may have been destroyed by the slow march of time, or some great military catastrophe may have shattered it. The site is probably too remote or now of too little military value to attract the interest of current governments, but it may still serve as an excellent lair for a more local tyrant or bandit lord.

- E** Failed usurper "ruling" from this new seat, Zealous rebel chief marshaling strength here, Ghostly shade of the fortress' last commander
- F** Native forced to take refuge here, Remnant survivor of the original garrison, Government agent sent to investigate the site for usability
- C** The fortress was built to keep something in rather than out, Some political change has just made the site very valuable once more, The real bulk of the site is hidden from easy view
- T** Key to open restricted areas of the site, Massive fixed weapon that still works, Precious trove guarded by the fortress
- P** Long-broken gate, Wall slumped into a ramp, Tower snapped halfway up

Sculpted Terrain

In a former age some tyrant or artist sculpted an entire landform here into a statue, monument, or artwork that is visible for miles. A carved mountainside, a molded hill, an intricate pattern of waterways, a mesa pierced with music-emitting tunnels, or some other huge artwork is obvious here, and probably can be seen from any point nearby. Such structures likely have some form of defense to prevent their vandalism, and may contain components that are very valuable in the present age.

- E** Priest of a sculpture-worshiping cult, Berserk guardian of the art, Chief of a sculpture-dwelling remnant of the original creators
- F** Courageous art-seeker, Artist desperately in search of inspiration, Treasure-hunter looking for the art's loot
- C** The art is mobile or otherwise active somehow, The art has some very dangerous effect, The art is damaged and now causes an unintended consequence nearby
- T** Precious fragment of the art, Magical relic used by the art, Regalia of the former keeper of the art
- P** Viewing-site built for the art, Damaged or defaced area of the art, Pilgrim quarters meant for those coming to see the art



Seductive Peril

There's a very appealing place, resource, or structure in the area that's actually a dangerous snare for the unwary. Pools may be laced with slow poisons, bright flora might be carnivorous, valuable natural crystals might be radioactive, or ancient pleasure-pavilions might not let revelers go. Some natives might lurk near the peril to loot its victims, while others might intentionally drive prey into it.

- E** Malevolent spirit of the peril, Cruel looter who uses the peril as a tool, Experimenter looking to exploit the peril
- F** Companion or friend of a victim, Clueless seeker of the peril's treasure, Native who knows about the peril
- C** Dangerous as it is the peril does offer a very real reward, The peril is worshiped by locals, The danger is unintentional and related to the peril's original function
- T** Loot left by victims, Valuable component of the peril, Bait placed to lure victims
- P** Hidden charnel pit for victims, Enticingly charming facade, Now-abandoned camp of former prey

Toxic Ruins

There's a ruin in the area, but it's poisonous or disease-infested. Such a blight may not be immediately obvious, with the effects slowly taking hold the longer an intruder remains. There's probably something about the ruin that's attractive to others, and the toxin isn't quick enough to make plundering an obviously futile effort. In other cases, the toxin might be fast, but there could be some item or magic to resist it.

- E** Toxin-warped beast within, Sorcerer exploring the toxin's potential, Cruel plunderer using expendable help to loot the site
- F** Native who knows a cure for the toxin, Explorer trapped within the ruin, Native life form that's immune to the toxin
- C** The toxin was a healthful atmosphere to the Outsider builder of the ruin, The toxin is radiation or some other invisible poison, The toxin is exuded by the substance or objects that are most valuable in the ruin
- T** Cure or protection from the poison, Incredibly toxic weapon or object, Damaged ancient relic that's causing the toxic effect
- P** Eerily barren land around the ruin, Camp full of poisoned explorers, A grove of unnatural life amid the toxic stew

Taboo Territory

Part of this area is strictly off-limits. It may be restricted to a particular holy priesthood, local rulers, the heirs of a particular lineage, or to everyone. The taboo may be the product of local religious beliefs, ruling edicts, or a practical realization that intruders keep stirring up perils that the locals have to deal with. Watchers likely keep guard over the area and may or may not speak up to warn off potential trespassers.

- E** The horrible thing within the territory, Bandit chief taking advantage of the taboo to hide there, Ancient guardian of the domain
- F** Explorer lacking in caution, Accidental trespasser into the zone, Local who desperately needs something from inside the area
- C** Entering the zone visibly marks trespassers for a time, A hostile force too strong for the warders is trying to get in or out, The taboo is rational but the reason the locals have is badly mistaken
- T** Treasure unplundered within the zone, The precious relic the taboo is meant to guard, Valuable plant or animal that grows undisturbed within
- P** Ancient ruin untouched by intruders, Watchpost with a view of the site, Sealed gate to the zone

Treacherous Terrain

A stretch of this area is naturally treacherous and dangerous in its terrain. It may be prone to sinkholes, mudslides, avalanches, quicksand, explosive flora, magical eruptions, boiling geysers, plunging crevasses, or falling stones. This terrain should block the path toward some interesting site or desired destination, or else the party likely has no reason not to simply turn around or go around it.

- E** Malevolent nature-spirit of the place, Vile outcast who lairs amid the terrain, Monstrous beast native to the dangerous area
- F** Native guide who knows a way through, Explorer fascinated by the terrain, Traveler forced to find a way through
- C** The perils manifest on a particular little-known schedule, The perils sometimes uncover lodes of valuable materials, The perils are an accidental legacy of an ancient malfunction
- T** Map of the safe way through, Device to protect against the peril, Ancient treasure hidden within the peril
- P** Small safe zone inside the terrain, Ruined road or path amid the peril, Site of a camp destroyed by the peril

Twisted Fauna

The fauna in the area has been warped by some power, and is now dangerous to other forms of life. A lingering curse may have twisted the beasts, as might have ancient techno-sorcerous waste, Outsider manipulation, half-faded *arratus*, mad wizardry, religious cult manipulation, or ancient artistic goals. The beasts probably have some unifying characteristic or trait imbued by the process that warped them.

- E** Savage beast-tamer, Hideously intelligent god-beast, The mad power that warped the beasts in the first place
- F** Native trying to cope with the fauna, Hunter determined to bag one, Scholar trying to find the cause of the change
- C** The beasts are very useful or valuable in some way, The beasts were once humans, The beasts masquerade as normal animals
- T** Loot of a victim of the beasts, The thing that changed them is a treasure itself, Trove coincidentally located in their territory
- P** Fetid lair of the beasts, Grove scarred by their activities, Tainted site that birthed them

Working Wreckage

A Working once was in the area, but has long since collapsed, decayed, or been destroyed by others. It's at least building-sized, with some Workings being full-scale megastructures raised by ancient empires. While the Working's original effect has long dissipated, pockets or fragments of it may still persist in the area, along with the automatons or servitor-people once charged with maintaining the site.

- E** Animated manifestation of the Working's power, Sorcerer-looter gutting the wreck, Brutal chief of the natives mutated by its power
- F** Scholar dreaming of activating it once more, Treasure-hunter eager to pick its bones, Local from the surviving caretakers
- C** It would cause a regional catastrophe if re-activated, Even its remnant effects have large consequences, It was ruined when it was re-tuned to create a different effect
- T** Key to controlling its remaining power, Spare part that's now priceless, Valuable fragment of wreckage
- P** Abandoned control room, Site of massive destruction from the Working's collapse, Nest or lair built into the ruin

Uncanny Weather

The area is affected by unnatural or magical weather conditions. It may be a pocket of snowy wasteland in a jungle, an area racked by cataclysmic storms, a shifted zone of space that overlaps with some alien world's atmosphere, an area of perpetual balmy summer, or some other obvious anomaly. Natives may have figured out some way to exploit this condition, or it might be too dangerous for regular occupation.

- E** Ruthless sorcerer bent on unlocking its secrets, Monstrous beast that thrives in the environment, Dangerous remnant of the zone's creators
- F** Native who's learned to live in the zone, Refugee trying to hide in it, Entrepreneur trying to profit by it
- C** The weather is controlled by a site or object, The change is very recent and is disrupting the locals, The weather leaves behind a valuable resource
- T** Ancient weather-control relic, Texts describing how to stop or control the weather, Abandoned loot from the original inhabitants of the area
- P** Weather-blasted natural feature, Structure built to endure the weather, Relic building from before the weather happened

Zealot Colony

There is a settlement of radical religious or ideological zealots here, ones too extreme to be tolerated in civilized lands. They may not necessarily be hostile, and they might have need of outside assistance, but their principles are likely to be bizarre or abhorrent to the PCs. Most such colonies are bent on creating new societies that may not actually be physically or psychologically possible for unaltered humanity.

- E** Charismatic demagogue, Iron-fisted hereditary dictator, Dreamer willing to break any number of eggs for their theoretical omelet
- F** Local who quietly wants out, Reformer trying to temper things, Relative of a now-trapped member
- C** They've recently acquired an object or an alliance that gives them great power, The ostensible leader is just a puppet of the real and more pragmatic boss, They're beginning to purity spiral into violent factions
- T** Desperately-necessary supply cache, Wealth given up for the group, Product manufactured by near-slave members
- P** Grand temple or ideological hall amid shanties, Mass public meeting, Prison for deviants



USING THIS GAME IN OTHER SETTINGS

It's frankly expected that a lot of readers of this game won't be using it with the Latter Earth as their campaign setting. Indeed, a considerable number of you won't be using the system at all, instead taking advantage of the content creation tools in these pages to build worlds and adventures for your own favorite game. These are perfectly reasonable things to do and the game has been written to accommodate these goals as cleanly as possible.

Still, there are some extra tools and items of advice that can be given to those GMs who want to use *Worlds Without Number* as their system, but want to play in a more conventional fantasy setting. In particular, some GMs may want to import character classes, spells, magic items, or other content from existing old-school-compatible games and may need some advice on how to do that.

WHAT MATERIALS TO IMPORT

A GM can reliably import almost any material written to target the pre-third-editions of the world's most popular role-playing game. Games that target this same general material such as *Labyrinth Lord*, *Old School Essentials*, *Lamentations of the Flame Princess*, *OSRIC*, *BFRPG*, or similar games should also translate with little or no difficulty. Importing materials from more modern editions is possible, but they would need significantly more conversion and adjustment, since the hit point and damage ranges tend to be much wider than in the older games.

Some GMs might worry about whether the balance is quite right between this game and materials built for others. While it's true that there are some differences in the prowess or survivability of *Worlds Without Number* characters as compared to those of older editions, the difference isn't generally enough to matter to most groups. Heroes in this game don't die immediately at zero hit points and the PCs often have more powers or tricks to play than a B/X Fighter might, but they also have to face Shock damage and generally play in smaller groups than the massive parties of yore. The resultant power match is close enough for most groups.

IMPORTING ADVENTURE CONTENT

Monsters, adventures, and other such content should come through with no necessary changes in hit points, damage rolls, or other numeric details. The one big difference found in some old-school games is the use of ascending versus descending Armor Classes; in some editions, lower is better, so an AC of 0 is equal to ascending AC of 20. For these editions simply subtract the Armor Class given from 20 to find the ascending AC.

These same descending AC systems often record a creature or PC's hit bonus as the number they need to roll on a d20 in order to hit an AC of 0. To find an equivalent *Worlds Without Number* hit bonus for the creature, subtract this "THAC0" from 20. Thus, if it needs a 17 to hit an AC of 0, then its hit bonus is +3.

IMPORTING CHARACTER CLASSES

Some GMs may want to add character classes that exist in other old-school games. Instead of making a paladin-flavored Warrior, for example, they might want to import the traditional Paladin class, or they might see some interesting new class that they want to bring into their game. In general, this is a simple process.

Overall, use the same class abilities, hit dice, and details as the original version. If the class gets the power to shapeshift at level 3, then it still gains that power at level 3 in this system. If it rolls 1d8 for its hit points, then it still rolls 1d8 for them here. If it can cast one spell a day from that game's list of magic spells, then the same spellcasting ability applies here.

If the class has special weapon or armor restrictions, they also apply in *Worlds Without Number*. Many old-school classes are balanced around restricted access to the best armor and weapons, so it's important not to meddle with this carelessly.

To identify the class' hit bonus, check to see how many special abilities the class grants. One with very few special powers, such as an old-school Fighter or Ranger, would use the Warrior table for determining hit bonuses. One that has a significant number of special powers but doesn't actually get the spellcasting abilities of a wizard or old-school Cleric would use the Expert hit table. One that gets full spellcasting or a similarly potent array of abilities would use the Mage hit table.

Finally, check to see how many Focus picks you should peel off from the class in exchange for their special abilities. Look at the special powers the class grants and compare them to the benefits reasonable for a single Focus pick. Some "class powers" might not be very powerful at all; a classic Thief's special abilities of lockpicking and sneaking are really nothing that isn't better-represented in this game as a *Specialist* Focus in Sneak. Others might be substantially stronger than a Focus normally grants, such as an old-school Druid's shapeshifting powers. Full spellcasting is something you can set aside; the class paid for that with their shabby hit bonus and hit points, so you don't need to take away Focus picks for it.

Once you've decided how many Focus picks the class' powers are worth, then that many Focus picks are taken away from the class as they advance in experience levels. A class with a lot of special abilities might not get to pick new Foci at all when they go up in levels, simply getting the special powers of their class instead. Particularly straight-forward classes, like the old-school Fighter, might not sacrifice any Focus picks at all. All PCs should be allowed to pick at least one Focus at first level, however.

Note that many old-school games offer various different types of saving throws. For this game, it's easier to ignore those tables and simply calculate Physical, Mental, and Evasion saving throws as usual for the PC.

RESKINNING CHARACTER CLASSES

In many cases, however, a GM will simply want to use normal *Worlds Without Number* classes for their own campaign. To help simplify your task, here are some recommendations for what classes to use to substitute for more “traditional” old-school professions.

Fighters are simply Warriors. **Rangers** and **Paladins** are Warriors who’ve invested in Survive or Pray, and possibly put some Focus specialization in bow use or dual-wielding depending on the interpretation of Ranger being used. Paladins who want some measure of miracle-invoking ability have partial-classed into the Sarulite Blood Priest class described in the deluxe edition of this book. Rangers who want a “pet” minion will have partialled into the Llaigisan Beastmaster class in the deluxe edition.

Thieves are Experts who have probably taken the *Specialist* Focus in the Sneak skill and invested their skill points in assorted larcenous talents. **Assassins** have taken the appropriate Focus and might’ve invested more heavily in combat skills; some of these might actually be Warriors with a Sneak investment.

Clerics have taken the Warrior/Sarulite Blood Priest class in the deluxe edition if they want to be a traditional head-bashing, miracle-invoking cleric. If they want actual spellcasting abilities, however, they may partial-class into an appropriate Mage tradition, and may have to take the *Armored Magic* Focus if they want to do their spellcasting while in full harness. **Druids** are Llaigisan Beastmasters if they want to focus on pet control and Darian Skinshifters if they want to emphasize shape-shifting. If they want to add spellcasting into the mix, they’ll need to decide which aspect to forego in order to add an appropriate partial Elementalist class or the like.

Monks are Vowed, with Warrior-Vowed representing the standard punch enthusiast while Expert-Vowed make for effective ninja-flavored martial artists. Practitioners of animal-based arts might add in some bestial shapeshifting with the Darian Skinshifter partial class.

Magic-users are represented by whatever Mage class best fits the character’s concept. Optionally, the GM can include some fan-favorite spells from different old-school games into the High Magic spell list if they wish, but such conversions should be done carefully, as explained below.

A GM is generally best off asking the players first what kind of PCs they want to play before going to the trouble of converting character classes or homebrewing new roles. Character classes only exist for the convenience and use of the PCs; if nobody wants to be a paladin, then there’s no point in going to the effort of converting the class for this game.

In the same fashion, if you introduce some new heroic profession or role into your own campaign, don’t bother to turn it into a PC class unless someone in the party actually wants to play one. You don’t have to spell out everything simply for consistency’s sake when your available time and effort is limited as it is.

IMPORTING SPELLS AND MAGIC

Many GMs may have an inclination to use this game with settings where magic is considerably easier to use than in the Latter Earth. Magic-users in these settings may have access to a much larger selection of spells, both to learn and to cast on a daily basis, and the spells might be much better-tuned to accomplish specific purposes. For these games, the basic idea is that the magic-user should always have something magical to do in a given situation, even if that’s simply blasting magic bolts.

This is not the philosophy of *Worlds Without Number*. Mages in this game are intended to find themselves in some situations where their magic is simply not relevant, much like a Warrior sometimes finds his sword useless or an Expert finds her skills unable to address a problem. PCs are expected to have to use their less-best options to overcome some problems or deal with certain situations. Still, this doesn’t mean that GMs should never include more magic, or that they can’t have their own ideas about a proper balance.

Most spells imported from existing old-school products will be significantly weaker than equivalent-level High Magic spells. There’s usually no issue with simply halving their original level, rounded up, and then adding them to the High Magic spell list. The exceptions are three different classes of spells that need more careful examination.

Spells that do damage or eliminate enemies need to be toned down or made less convenient to use. Any spell that does area damage should always affect everyone in the area, friend or foe, and spells that inflict damage on a single target should always allow saving throws for half damage. Neither should ever do more than ten dice of damage, regardless of the caster’s level. Spells that render a victim unable to fight should either not work on targets with more hit dice than the caster or should require more than one failed save to finally put the target down. Any spell that threatens to dethrone the Warrior’s primacy in combat needs to be trimmed back.

Spells that give bonuses to hit rolls, skill checks, or other attributes should generally not be allowed. A spell that simply makes you do what you always did 10% better is a very boring spell that doesn’t change the situation at all when it is used. Casters end up with a powerful inducement to simply carry a load of buffs, because they’re by definition always useful whenever the buffed abilities are relevant. If the spell doesn’t change the situation when it’s used, it’s probably not going to be a good addition to the game.

Spells that step on another PC’s concept should not be allowed. If you have a stealthy, sneaky Expert in the party, don’t let the wizard add spells that let them replicate or better that talent. If you have a social-master PC with heavy investment in social Foci and skills, don’t let the wizard add a bunch of mindbending powers to their spell list. This limit is table-specific, because if there is no PC occupying a niche then there’s much less danger in letting that niche get stepped on by the wizard.



CREATING ADVENTURES

Adventures are where all the sweat, toil, and fevered thought of the GM finally becomes something real at the table. No matter how finely-sculpted your world or inventive your fiction, if you can't deliver a playable bit of fun at the table then your job as a GM is not done.

This pressure to create the session's content and administer its play is what keeps a lot of players from ever becoming GMs. They find it too intimidating or burdensome to have such a responsibility, and it's not unreasonable that they should just want to sit down and have an evening's fun dicing with their friends.

Yet GMing does not have to be some special province of voice-acting improv artists. Almost anyone can be a perfectly good GM with the right techniques and a complementary group of players, and there are certain rewards to being a sandbox GM that can't be had from the player's side of the screen.

The GM gets to be surprised. In a traditional story-arc campaign, the GM plots the general outline of the story well in advance, and often knows the rough shape of the next several sessions. They might be surprised by how the PCs handle certain events or negotiate certain plot points, but the basic outline is not a mystery to them.

This is not the case for a GM in a sandbox campaign. Lacking any overarching plot to pursue, with no obligation to worry about the shape of a story or the consequences of an unpredictable choice, a GM has the pleasure of seeing their friends navigate the situations they've set up for them without having to worry about the consequences. A sandbox GM never has to be concerned about anything in play except the immediate situation to hand. If the PCs veer off in a mad direction, nothing is lost; no future session prep is wasted and no story is derailed, because *the story is what happens*.

The GM gets to pick the situations. If you're running the campaign you can be reasonably sure that the content you create will not be boring to you. The PCs get to pick the direction of a sandbox campaign, and can decide which of your interesting situations they want to engage with, but you're ultimately the one coming up with the content they pick. If you want to run a campaign with a particular flavor, or one set in a specific fantasy world, or one that includes or excludes particular tropes, then that's what's going to happen.

Because in the end, the GM decides what kind of game is being played. The players may decide that they're not interested in the same things, and it's perfectly fair of them to decline a game that doesn't match their own tastes, but you're the one doing the heavy lifting. The games that get played are the games that have GMs, and it doesn't matter how many willing players a traditional RPG has if none of them want to GM it.

The GM always has something to do. When the session is over and the pizza is gone, that's it for the players. They might reminisce over mighty or foolish

deeds, mull over what their hero plans to do next, or make plans with their fellows for some shared goal, but none of that will actually matter until the GM gavel in the next session.

The GM, on the other hand, can always go back to their campaign world and move the pieces around. They can flesh out aspects of the setting, cook up a quick mini-dungeon, paint up an NPC, work out some homebrew rules, or do other things that actually change the game. They might choose not to use a particular between-sessions creation or omit some content they brewed up, but that remains their choice. A GM can "play" the game whenever they have the time and inclination and know that their choices will matter.

Thus, this section of the book contains guidelines and techniques to help you become a good GM for a *Worlds Without Number* campaign.

USING EXISTING ADVENTURES

This game is built on an "old school" chassis, taking many of its basic concepts from the B/X edition of the biggest role playing game of the seventies and eighties. Six attributes ranging from 3 to 18, d20 rolls to hit, armor classes, saving throws, hit points, character levels, and the like are fundamental to this gaming *lingua franca*, and while the details may differ, the chassis remains.

As a working GM, you should take ruthless advantage of this. Almost fifty years of published adventure modules and homebrew adventures exist for you to pilage for your own campaign, many of them available for free or cheaply in PDF online. Virtually any adventure published before 2000 for the world's most popular RPG can be used with *Worlds Without Number*, with no more effort than converting descending AC and THAC0 scores to this game's scale and turning gold piece values into silver piece values. Spells used in the module that don't exist in this game can be replaced, or you could just use the original spell's effects without breaking anything important. Supplements and other old-school core games can also be looted for content that suits your tastes.

By plundering these venerable texts you can spare yourself a great amount of work, and save your effort for the parts of the adventure you *want* to work on. As a mortal human you only have so much time and creative energy. Whenever you can borrow the toil of some prior creator to spare yourself exertions that aren't fun for you, it's something to be embraced.

When looting these adventures, don't feel obliged to keep them all in one piece. You can carve out interesting situations and slice up dungeons into pieces that you can later reskin for your own creations. With some tweaked names, a change of scenery, and a scalpel taken to any recognizable intellectual property, your players will never guess that the adventure they're playing was written before most of them were born.



WHAT GMS AND PLAYERS NEED TO BRING

Many gaming players and GMs are familiar with the tacit expectations of their table. They know what everyone is supposed to be bringing to the session, and they know what their share of the work is supposed to be. For new players or those introduced into a new group, however, these tacit understandings might be a little *too* implicit. To help clarify these points, here are some of the basic expectations that players and GMs need to have about a standard *Worlds Without Number* campaign.

DUTIES OF THE PLAYERS

Players have the relatively “easy” job in a campaign, but it doesn’t mean it’s one they can wholly neglect. There are some things every player needs to bring to the table if everyone there is going to have a good time.

PCs need to want to work together. It doesn’t matter how or why your PC wants to work with the other characters. Maybe it’s a spirit of grudging cooperation, or suspicious association, or an alliance of convenience. It can be any reason that your character concept can justify, but it has to boil down to your PC wanting to help and cooperate with the other PCs. It’s *your* job to explain why your PC is willing to adventure alongside the other characters. If you can’t come up with a reason, it’s not the GM’s problem; you need to find one or make a new PC.

Note that some campaigns might be explicitly adversarial among the PCs, or involve specific contrary goals or purposes. If everyone at the table is fine with that, then that’s perfectly acceptable, but the default assumption is that everyone is working together.

PCs need to have a motivation to act. Your PC need to want to interact with the world. They need a goal, or a motivation, or an inclination to *do* something. When they see adventure, they need to have a reason to jump at it. Sometimes a character concept gets created that is all about *being* something; the character is a taciturn archer, or a beautiful young priestess, or a farm-boy warrior haunted by the specter of battle. That’s all well and good, but all of these concepts need a driving motivation that will get them tangled in plot hooks and seeking wild adventures.

Players need to pay attention. Put away the phones, stow the talk about the latest podcast, and listen to what the other players are doing even when it doesn’t involve you. Listen to what the GM is saying, think about the choices your PC is going to make, and engage with the game as it’s going on.

Players need to trust the GM. The GM is going to be making a lot of judgment calls and quick decisions during play. Not all of them are going to go your way, and some of them are inevitably going to seem downright poorly-reasoned. Still, you need to trust that the GM is doing their best to deliver a fun session for everyone. Rules disputes and other issues with the way they’re running a game should be saved for after the session is over.

DUTIES OF THE GM

The GM has a heavier load than the players bear. While the players only need to worry about a single character in the world, the GM has to handle the rest of the campaign setting, ensuring that everyone there has enough material to have a good time.

A GM needs to be fair. You are not the party’s adversary. You are not the party’s cheerleader. You are not here to test their mettle or usher them toward their destiny. You are the indifferent prime mover of your campaign who gives the PCs the results that their efforts have earned. Tilting dice rolls to save or damn a PC is not part of your role. However heart-rending or cruel it may be, the default assumption in *Worlds Without Number* is that the GM does not cheat the dice when PCs are involved.

In the same vein, a GM doesn’t play favorites among the players. While friendships or relationships may vary, everyone gets the same dice and the same odds at the table. Once special favors start getting handed out every decision the GM makes starts to be viewed with suspicion, whether or not it was deserved.

A GM needs to respond to the PCs. If the party decides to venture into the cursed Ashblight *arratu*, then you need to make up an adventure revolving around that expedition. If the beautiful young priestess has convinced the party to help her assassinate the leader of her temple, then you need to make an adventure about how they do or don’t achieve that. On a smaller scale, when the PCs do something in the world, it should leave marks and consequences that they encounter later, even if only in passing. When the PCs do things, the GM needs to do things in response; they should feel as if their actions have actual consequences in the world.

A GM needs to account for PC goals. If the PC has a goal of accumulating vast wealth, then the GM needs to be ready to throw out hooks to adventures that promise monetary rewards. If the PC’s goal is bloody vengeance on a tyrant, then hooks need to be made that involve resisting the monarch’s rule. These hooks and adventures need not simply grant the PC’s wish or give them a golden road to success, but if the players say they want to have adventures revolving around a topic, a GM needs to give them hooks that will get them there.

A GM needs to have an evening’s adventure. At the start of the session, the GM needs to have enough material to reasonably occupy the group for however long they’ve decided to play. This is the most time-consuming part of a GM’s job, because brewing up an adventure can take a great deal of time and effort to do well. The tools in this section are meant to help ease the GM’s burden in this, however, and make it as quick and painless as possible. A prudent GM can also loot material from existing old-school adventures to fill any sudden gaps.

GM ISSUES AND HOW TO HANDLE THEM

Certain topics and issues come up regularly for GMs, and it can be helpful to have some advice as to how to handle these ordinary situations. The tactics below are certainly not the only way to deal with matters, and may not be the best way for your particular group, but they've proved effective at many different tables.

DISPUTES DURING PLAY

It's inevitable that people at the table will eventually disagree about how a particular rule works. Often as not, this disagreement arises when it is *extremely important* to some PC's future health and well-being. This kind of tension can make for sharp disagreements, so some points should be remembered when trying to deal with the situation.

Debates are for after the session. If serious discussion of a ruling needs to happen, it should take place after the game session is over. Whatever the GM decides goes for the time being, and afterwards the player can make their case and the GM can reflect on their choices. This doesn't mean that the GM will agree even then, but the middle of the session is not the time to break out the page number arguments.

Don't sweat the small stuff. Both players and GMs shouldn't bother spending time arguing over trifles. If a ruling doesn't seriously affect a situation or a PC's health, there's no reason to give it more than ten seconds of back-and-forth. For every decision the GM makes that cuts against a PC, odds are there'll be one that grants them an edge, so it's really not worth arguing over.

This book is not holy. While this book provides a baseline set of rules and default assumptions for play, it is by no means more important than the specific mix of people, situations, and goals that a particular group has at their table. Some default rules might be genuinely terrible for a particular mix of people. Others may not satisfy their interests, or be generally disliked by those who are playing. While it's good form for a GM to discuss any house rules they'll be using and make sure all players are amenable to them, disputing these decisions because of what this book says is not particularly helpful. The GM may reconsider their decisions based on new information or new interpretations, but ultimately, it's up to them. The canonical rules are the ones the GM has decided to use. If their judgment really is no fun for the players then somebody else can do the work to create the play session.

ARGUMENTS AMONG PLAYERS

A little intra-party tension is normal and reasonable, and two adventurers who trust each other with their life in battle might not trust each other with their sisters in town. Sometimes this ordinary tension heats up, however, and PCs start actively working against each other. In the worst cases, this bleeds over into reality or stems from out-of-game animosity between them.

Worlds Without Number is not designed to be a good PvP game. It's not built to provide balanced conflicts between PCs, and it assumes that all the PCs will be working together or at the very least not trying to undermine each other. If the entire table is keen on the conflict and everyone trusts the GM to handle any judgment calls, then it can be used that way, but it's not a situation that the game natively supports.

If the quarrel is distracting the rest of the party, however, then the GM needs to call a time-out and get the players back on the same page. Have them decide how they work out their dispute... and they *will* work it out, because the rest of the group's fun isn't going to be held hostage by two players.

If they can't come to some *modus vivendi* and keep interfering with the rest of the group's fun, tell them that they're out of the game until they can play nicely. Their fun is not more important than the rest of the group's fun, and if they've got the bad manners to disregard the rest of the group's time and enjoyment then they're not a good match for the table.

It is nobody's obligation to play with people who aren't fun for them, and no one is obliged to justify their tastes in idle entertainment. Not everybody will be a perfect match for everyone else; the problem player of one table might be the life of the party to another. It is not cruel or selfish to restrict your efforts to those groups that reward your time and labor, and you should not feel obligated to spend your leisure hours amusing anyone who doesn't provide their own fair share of fun for you.

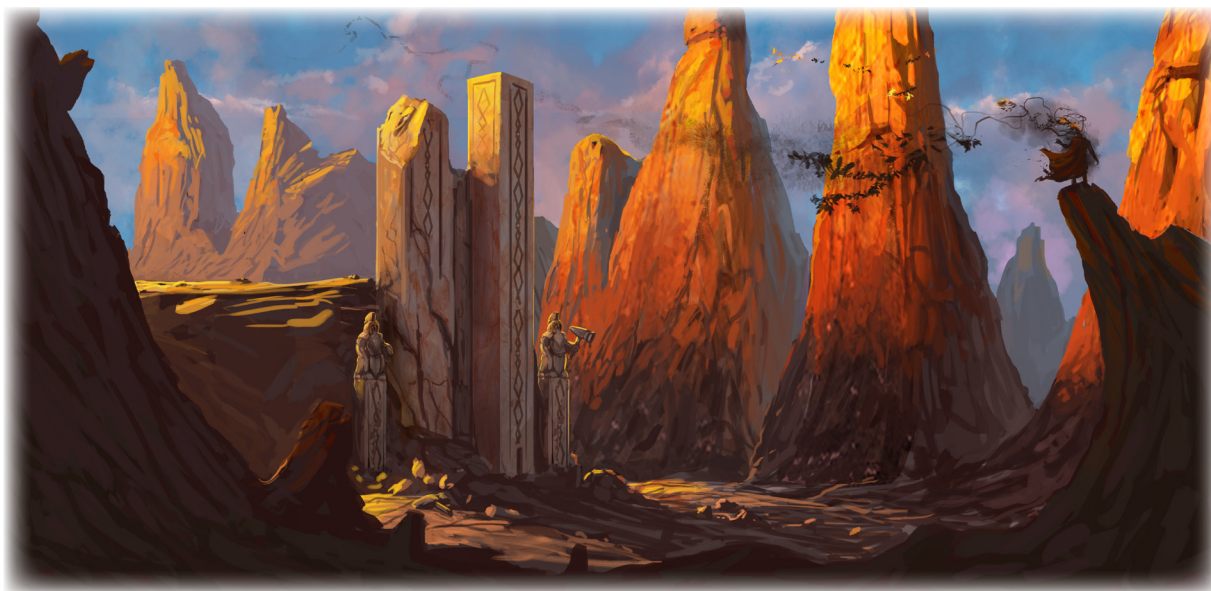
RULES IN AMBIGUOUS SITUATIONS

In the course of a campaign, there will be plenty of occasions when the PCs end up doing something that hasn't got a matching rule or guideline in the book. It's necessary for the GM to make an ad-hoc ruling in such cases, and in doing so a few things ought to be kept in mind.

Don't worry about large-scale balance concerns. Such extemporaneous rulings can always be changed or revised between sessions if they seem like they're going to come up again. All you need is a ruling that makes sense for this specific situation. Everyone should accept that there may be changes later if the outcome doesn't seem to make sense or if it looks likely to be a recurring issue in need of appropriate balance.

Decide based on logic rather than outcomes. If the PCs come up with a brilliant plan that totally circumvents the challenge you thought they were going to face, don't deny them their success simply because it would spoil your preparations. You may need to call a short session, or throw in some filler content as aftermath to their success, or pull out some emergency backup material to throw in another problem to keep them amused, but let them have their fairly-schemed victories. "But this would ruin the adventure" is almost never a good basis for





decision making; their course of action *is* the adventure, and a GM's job is simply to administer it fairly.

Use existing rules as guidelines. If what they just did would probably kill an ordinary person it happened to, then maybe it does 2d6 damage, because that'd usually kill an ordinary person. If the party can usually move twenty miles a day, then the expert native guide might let them cross thirty miles of terrain in her company. Grant +1 bonuses to skill checks, or +2 if the situation is extremely positive, or invert them for negative situations. Don't worry about matching everything perfectly, but instead just take your cues from what already exists.

GM CALLS FOR SKILL CHECKS

As a general rule of thumb, it should be the GM deciding when a skill roll is in order. There's a certain habit some players have of simply saying, "I roll Convince" or "I roll Notice" or otherwise simply pushing the button on their sheet to get a desired result. That's not generally the best way to handle the situation, because the GM has very little information on how to respond to such efforts.

Instead, the player should describe what their PC is saying, or doing, or trying to accomplish, and then the GM decides whether a skill check is in order, and if so, what the difficulty might be. If they end up saying or doing the exact right thing, or exact *wrong* thing, then there may be no need for a skill check at all. If the tactic they're choosing is exceptionally apt or unfruitful then the skill check difficulty will reflect that.

This is also important when running for players who are new to the game system, who can't be expected to know or remember all the rules. If they learn to simply say what they're trying to do and let the GM tell them what to roll, they can still play comfortably.

Skill checks should also be used sparingly in general. If nothing particular interesting hinges on the roll, there's no point in making it. Experts who use their class talent on a skill roll should be able to feel confident that its success or failure is genuinely important.

USING SOCIAL SKILLS

Players who invest a lot of their character concept into social skills such as Convince, Lead, and Connect have the fair expectation of being able to use those skills in play, even if they themselves aren't all that socially adroit. GMs should recognize the general level of comfort that a given player has with describing their specific words and social gambits; some players will gladly extemporize their persuasions and others will have a harder time picking their words. The latter shouldn't be penalized.

As a basic guideline, when the player wants to persuade or manipulate an NPC, they should explain what they're trying to get from them and what reasoning or motivations they're offering to get that result. They can express these elements with as much in-character persuasion as they like, but what you really need to know is what they want and why the NPC should give it.

In some cases, no skill check is then required. Either the reasoning is solid and the NPC has no cause to object to the inducement or else what the PC wants is so unreasonable or emotionally intolerable to the NPC that no plausible incitement can get it from them. If the situation falls between those two extremes, then you can call for a Convince or Lead skill check at a difficulty appropriate to the persuasiveness of the offer.

No degree of glibness or charm will persuade an NPC to do something obviously harmful unless an equal or superior reward seems promised. The smoother the talker, the more trouble the NPC may be willing to get into, but the PCs are going to need to provide very practical reasons for them to take such risks or expenses.

Remember that social skill levels, no matter how high, are not mind control. They can't get people to do things they would never normally do unless overwhelming situational pressure is involved. Conversely, they're also completely impossible to *block* with magic, so if an Expert con man can get next to an Emperor there's no magical bar or saving throw that's going to prevent him from persuading the demigod of a seemingly good idea.

PC DEATH AND REPLACEMENT

Worlds Without Number is a relatively lethal game by default. A single good spear thrust can usually put paid to any novice adventurer and there are no easy means of reviving the dead. Shock damage from a mob, the gnashing teeth of fell beasts, or taking a sorcerer's murderous bolt of energy directly to the face can all terminate even an experienced hero's career.

It's important that the GM and the party all be on the same page about character mortality before the campaign begins. If the players are accustomed to systems with a more forgiving attitude toward character survival, or those in which heroes are protected by plot armor until they intentionally make themselves vulnerable, the shock of the difference can spoil their fun. The GM should make *abundantly clear* to the players that people with big knives are dangerous in this game and that combat is likely to get novice heroes killed if it's not approached with a maximum of tactical advantage.

Given a long enough campaign, it's likely that even a storied hero of numerous adventures is going to make one gamble too many and end up dead from one cause or another. The default assumption of the game is that the players salute the departed legend, perhaps arrange for a tasteful monument, emotional drinking binge, or pragmatic corpse looting, and roll up a replacement. If the GM is feeling charitable then the replacement might be no more than a couple adventures' worth of experience points behind the deceased hero.

GMs should be very generous about getting fresh PCs into the action. It's bad enough that a player's PC died; they shouldn't be made to sit around for half an hour while everyone else gets to have fun. Let their replacement be found lost in the same Deep, or rescued from the foes the PCs just overcame, or out in the wilderness on some conveniently minor errand when the others happen to march through. Questions of trust and comradeship should also probably be glossed for playability's sake. The point is to get the player back in the game as soon as possible, because playing the game is the reason everyone is there.

While this kind of character fragility can be dismaying to players of many modern games, there's a point to it beyond mere bravado. A character who accomplishes grand adventures and survives horrible perils this way has actually accomplished something difficult. There were no plot points in his favor, no narrative tweaks to ensure his survival, and no cushion of fate to keep him from being pulped by a bad choice.

The player made a lot of very good choices, picked the right battles to fight, and made decisions that were objectively wise if they've managed to get this far, and they've done it while absorbing the inevitable amount of bad luck that honest dice would have thrown at them. There's a genuine feeling of pride and accomplishment that comes from bringing a hero that far. The PCs that didn't make it are just proof that the game wasn't rigged in their favor.

Even so, that's not the kind of game every group wants to have. While the satisfaction of proving your skill at navigating the game world is real, some groups want to focus more on character development and following the lives of the particular PCs they want to play. Some may want to play a full-fledged story-arc campaign where the PCs explore a particular plot line, while others just don't want to deal with developing a new PC whenever their choices and their dice end up demanding it. For games like this, there are a few different options the GM can use, assuming the group is all in agreement.

Heroes never die. In these games, the PCs cannot die unless they take bad-faith advantage of this protection. So long as they behave sensibly, no combination of dice can result in their death or permanent invalidation as an adventurer. They may be knocked unconscious, thrown off cliffs, left for dead, blasted into the shrubbery by sorcery, or cursed with afflictions that don't leave them unviable for adventuring, but they won't actually die. Instead, whenever they would die, something Very Bad happens in their life as a kind of karmic balance.

Each player should tell the GM three things that their PC would hate to have happen, whether that's a ability-score-lessening wound, limb loss, death of a loved one, loss of most of their wealth, collapse of a friendship, or the like. These things might change over the course of the campaign as new factors become important to the PC. Whenever the hero would die, one of these things somehow comes to pass, through some stroke of ill-luck or consequence of their failure. Optionally, the GM might pick some other calamity, one the players don't know about until it's too late. The point is that something bad will happen, so the PCs should try very hard not to die.

Negative ten and counting. In these games, PCs are knocked unconscious at zero hit points as usual, but don't actually become Mortally Wounded until they reach -10 hit points or below. Heroes merely reduced to zero hit points will wake up at the end of the fight or scene with 1 hit point, able to act normally. This buffer ensures that a normal spear wound or ordinary bestial chomp might be able to knock a hero down, but it won't put them at immediate risk of death. Higher-level heroes facing multi-die damage sources might have more to worry about, however. Any healing applied to the downed PCs should count from zero, so a PC at -5 hit points who gets 6 points of healing from a friend can stand up with 6 hit points, not 1.

Not my time. Meant chiefly for story-arc games, each PC has a grand ambition or ultimate goal that they're destined to pursue. So long as they honestly and reasonably pursue that goal they cannot die until it has been achieved or been rendered conclusively hopeless. They might suffer the slings and arrows of misfortune, and the consequences of their failures might be dire, but so long as they have some hope of attaining their great goal and don't lose faith in the pursuit of it, they can't be permanently put down.



PLANNING AND RUNNING ADVENTURES

Some experienced GMs will have their own well-tested habits for creating and running adventures for their group. Others need a little more guidance, however, and so this section explains how a GM might go about preparing an evening's adventure, and the steps such a creator will need to go through in order to brew up a suitable session's worth of fun.

SANDBOXES AND STORY ARCS

The tools in this section are meant to support a "sandbox" style of campaigning, and for some GMs this might need a little explanation. Sandbox gaming is relatively less popular than the more prevalent "story arc" style of play, but it has a long and splendid tradition of fun behind it.

A sandbox campaign is built with no presumption of an overarching plot or direction. The PCs are not particularly chosen by destiny, and their fates are wholly undirected by narrative fiat. Each PC has their own goals, motivations, and hopes, and it is the GM's job to provide them with interesting situations and engaging adventures in which they might strive to carry out their plans. Some will succeed, and others will perish hideously, perhaps of no greater crime than sufficiently bad luck. The campaign world shifts and reacts to PC actions, and the overall goal of the party might change from one session to the next.

Story arc campaigns are built around a particular plot line or narrative thread. The campaign is about how the heroes deal with that plot and the actions they take in response to the inevitable events and situations that the narrative thrusts upon them. It's tacitly assumed that all the PCs are going to get involved in the plot and cooperate with it to at least a basic level; they won't simply decide to wash their hands of the affair and go hunt monsters two nations away.

Both styles of adventuring are perfectly valid and provide their own pleasures. A good story arc can hit narrative beats and emphasize coherent themes that would be impossible to ensure in a sandbox campaign, while a sandbox campaign allows for a refreshing amount of surprise for both players and GMs, as neither of them can be entirely sure what's going to happen in the next session. This surprise helps keep things fresh for the GM.

Worlds Without Number is built chiefly to support sandbox campaigns, but there's nothing stopping you from using its tools to help build some story arc game with a specific narrative your group wants to explore. In the same vein, there's nothing immoral about mixing the two styles in the same campaign, so long as the players know what the expectations are. The heroes might venture as their whim takes them through the Latter Earth until they find some situation that so interests them that the GM turns it into a tightly-plotted set of sessions that everyone agrees to follow to their end. The styles are simply play models to help you find the fun you like, not fealties to be pledged.

PREPARING YOUR ADVENTURE

When you sit down to prepare a session's adventure, you can follow the steps below to help produce something playable in a reasonable amount of time. As you grow more experienced with the process, you can start adjusting it to better fit your own interests and skills, but using it as written will work fine for first-time GMs.

Identify the purpose of the adventure. You need to know what kind of fun or opportunity this session is supposed to give to the party. If they're trying to do something, the session needs to give them a chance to further their goal. If they want a particular kind of play, then the session needs to offer them that kind of play.

If this is the first adventure of the campaign, then you need to make a short, one-session adventure that will pull the PCs together, introduce the players to the rules of the game, and give them a chance to learn about the campaign backdrop. At the end of the session, you need to throw them some obvious hooks to other potential adventures and then find out what they want to do next.

If this is a later adventure, you should've asked the players at the end of the last session what they wanted to do for the next. If they told you they wanted to explore a Deep, then you need to flesh out a local Deep and make it adventure-ready. If they wanted to get back at a tyrannical lord, then you need to give them an adventure that lets them try to take that revenge. In a sandbox campaign the goals and interests of the PCs are what drive the adventures, and so you should always be ready to simply ask the party what they want to do.

Pick a primary challenge for the adventure. There are four basic types of adventurous challenge: combat challenges that revolve around killing something, exploration challenges that revolve around exploring a dangerous place, investigative challenges that focus on discovering some hidden truth, and social challenges that require convincing or manipulating someone into compliance.

Pick a primary challenge that matches the party's goal. If they want to pillage a Deep, then that's basically an exploration challenge. If they want to avenge themselves on the tyrant, then that's likely going to be a combat challenge. In some cases, the party's goal might be so large or so distant that it can't reasonably be attained in a single adventure; killing the tyrant might eventually be a combat challenge, but initially it might be better represented as a social challenge to ingratiate the PCs into a cell of rebels, from which further progress can be made.

Use the challenge tools in this section to flesh it out. Each of the four types of challenge have their own section in this chapter giving tools and guidance on making a good obstacle of its type. If you're making an exploration challenge, you'll need a map, things to discover, and interesting environments to interact with.

If you're building a social challenge, you'll need to identify people who have or can do the things the party wants, and the particular problems, wants, and relationships these people have.

Add extra layers of challenges. Sometimes a very short session or an optional side-challenge might consist of nothing more than the primary challenge. It's a relatively simple situation where something needs to die, a small strange place might get explored, or a single NPC might need to be induced to cooperate.

Usually, however, you'll want to add one or more additional layers of challenges beneath the primary one. If the PCs are exploring a Deep, then there are probably major monsters in there that are worth fleshing out as combat challenges, and maybe some enigmatic ancient mysteries that could qualify as investigation challenges. There might even be some not-necessarily-hostile powers in there that could be amenable to being a social challenge. If they're trying to persuade an NPC as part of a social challenge, a means to induce them might be to kill a dangerous rival, or dig up well-hidden blackmail on them, or find a particular relic for them in some ruin.

A GM can take this fractal down as far as they have the time and need to do so. A massive megadungeon Deep might be composed of a half-dozen layers of sub-zones to explore, each with their own mysteries, dire foes, and sinister bargains. A campaign-scale effort to depose a mad emperor might take a dozen sessions to work its way up to the final conflict as the PCs find secrets, fetch relics, kill loyalists, and persuade wavering neutrals.

Stitch the challenges together. If you've used multiple layers of challenges the different moving parts probably have some inkling of each other. The dire beasts in a Deep probably know about the existence of their peers, and two different society grandees that are each their own social challenge could well have their own relationship to keep in mind. If the existence of some element in your adventure would have an obvious consequence to the rest of it, make sure that consequence is accounted for by the other parts of the session. Just because only one NPC wants some treasure from a Deep doesn't mean the others don't know about it... or don't know about that NPC's desire.

Identify rewards and consequences. Finally, what do the PCs get for overcoming the challenges? Why should they actually care about any of this? Keep in mind the initial purpose of the adventure and make sure that the motivations and rewards the situation offers are ones the players are actually going to want to have. Some PCs will be easily motivated by the chance to fight for truth and justice, while other parties won't lift a finger without silver to induce them. An adventure hook that doesn't have any bait on it is unlikely to entice them.

Also keep mindful of the consequences of this adventure on the wider campaign world. You may not know exactly who will be made angry or happy by an adventure until after it's over, but it's a certainty that *somebody* is going to care about what happened.

RUNNING YOUR ADVENTURE

Once you have your adventure built, you're ready to present it to the party. Every group will have its own tastes when it comes to face-to-face play versus virtual tabletops, or the use of digital devices at the table, or who brings the snacks, and such matters are best discussed and agreed on beforehand.

Despite these universal imponderables, a GM should keep a few things in mind when actually running the adventure in a sandbox style of play.

Don't force outcomes. You're putting the heroes into an interesting situation that gives them opportunities to pursue their goals. You're not promising them any particular outcome, or any certain likelihood of success. It may further the plot wonderfully if the duke takes a shine to the party, but if they set fire to his rose garden and taunt his mother then that furtherance will not happen. *The plot is what happens*, not what anyone has planned to have happen.

Have filler ready. Sometimes the PCs will hopelessly ruin a situation or shut themselves out of success in some resounding fashion. This may be intentional as they flip the table on an unacceptable situation, or it may be the result of bad luck, poor planning, or general imprudence. You should have some light filler content you can throw in to keep them occupied for the rest of the session, such as conveniently-discovered Deep on their path of retreat, or an easily-reskinned peasant who's offering good pay for a little adventurous favor. You might generate such a filler adventure with the tools in this section and then just keep it on hand for emergencies.

Find out what they want to do next session. At the end of every session, *ask them what they want to do next*. This is absolutely crucial for saving yourself time and wasted effort and ensuring that the entire group is on the same page about the next session's general plan. They might choose to bite on a hook you've thrown out to them or come up with their own idea, but you need to know what kind of content to make for the next session.

In a sandbox campaign, you only ever need to be one session ahead of the players. You don't need to plot out vast narratives or design lands the PCs might someday reach; all you need to know is what they want to do next time, and then make your preparations accordingly. Remember, if you don't need it for the next session, and you're not having fun making it, *stop working on it*.

Update your world after the session. Heroic adventures have consequences, both on the PCs and the world around them. Small-scale heroics might only affect a small region of the campaign world, but that region matters if it's where the PCs are. Think about what the heroes have done, who profits by it, and who might be upset with their heroics.

Ideally, you can then work in some callbacks to these changes in your future adventures, letting the players feel that their actions have consequences and that their goals and plans have a meaningful effect on the campaign. Such tokens do much to encourage player engagement.



CREATING COMBAT CHALLENGES

Combat challenges revolve around situations where a hard fight is a likely outcome for the PCs. They may have a burning desire to murder some hated enemy, or they might be facing a creature that has no capacity for peaceful interactions, or you might simply know your party well enough to know that there's no way they're going to let a particular NPC live once they find out what they're like.

As always, you should take care not to force this outcome. Cunning PCs might manage to avoid the target entirely if their goals can be achieved without violence, and exceptionally diplomatic groups might find a way to force a more peaceful conclusion to the challenge. Smart PCs will try to avoid combat whenever it's not a direct necessity, and as the GM you should make sure that you're not forcing their hand by putting unavoidable brawls directly in their path. It's fine if the PCs decide they absolutely must kill a dragon. It's not fine if the PCs decide that all they want is its money, and yet you arrange things so that the only way to steal the dragon's hoard is to murder it in a setpiece battle.

The goal of building a combat challenge is to equip yourself with all the facts you need to run the likely fray. For minor challenges, like sorting out the likely disposition of a sullen Anak with a pastry who happens to be lurking in a Deep closet, you might need nothing more than a brief stat line to remind you of its combat statistics. For more elaborate challenges, like an attempt on a vile cult leader's life, you're going to need something more developed.

THE LOGICAL ESSENTIALS

The first step is to think about the target and any surrounding protectors or associates it might have. A rich merchant will have guards at their estate, a cult leader will have fanatical minions, and an Anak warrior is unlikely to leave his warband behind. Allied groups might also have representatives in the area, or the target might have hired or coerced others into their retinue. If you're stocking a Deep or some other lair of monsters, the creatures there are probably whatever type are common in the area or have adapted to the alien environment.

It's a great temptation to worry about "balance" when plotting out these details. If there are forty combat-capable Anak in the tribe then it is ridiculous to suppose that any ordinary band of novice heroes will be able to kill them all in a single pitched battle. As a consequence, a GM is tempted to shave down the number of foes for too-weak parties or add in extra muscle to give a "good fight" to a more experienced band. The assumption is that if there is a combat challenge in an adventure, the PCs ought to have some non-trivial chance of beating it in a fight, or a non-trivial chance of incurring grave losses.

GMs in a sandbox campaign are encouraged to fight this instinct. Your job is to make a logical, coherent

world that can be engaged with by intelligent and observant players. A full Anak tribe would logically have at least forty capable warriors so there is no justification in shaving them down to match the party's capabilities. A king would naturally have ferocious bodyguards, an evil sorcerer would have inhuman minions, and the most fearsome swordsman in the kingdom is not going to be any less fearsome if the PCs encounter him at first level rather than tenth.

With that said, a GM also needs to think about the context of the adventure's purpose. If you're making a Deep for novice adventurers to explore, then at least some of the combat challenges in it should be winnable by the party should it come to blows. If there's no logical reason why it has to be full of PC-slaughtering hellbeasts, then you do no violence to the campaign's fabric by including foes both trivial and grand. The guidelines on page 295 offer suggestions on how to assess a given combat encounter's likelihood of slaughtering the PCs.

Thus, your first job in the combat challenge is to draw up a list of the creatures and NPCs involved in it. Figure out who should be there and generate or note down combat statistics for them. Don't worry about further details yet; just get the bare minimum down.

FRAMING THE ENVIRONMENT

Once you know who might be involved in the fracas, you should think about the location the conflict might occur in and the kind of information you need to establish about it. A merchant's house will require a map of the grounds, a sinister high priest lurking in a Deep will necessitate a plan of the subterranean passages, and a murder in the midst of some highly-populated area will inevitably draw some sort of hue and cry from the surrounding inhabitants that needs to be kept in mind.

It's tempting to turn significant combat challenges into set-piece battles, with different environmental elements all arranged to provide tactical opportunities. Pressure plates, sheer cliffs, howling winds, fiery pits, and other traditional epic-combat battlefield decorations might be involved. While an interesting environment for a fight is always a plus, it's important to maintain the logic of the situation; most people are not going to spend much time in areas where a hideous death awaits a misplaced step or a lethal trap is waiting to spring on the first drunkard to forget to pull the disarming lever.

It's also quite possible that the heroes will not be considerate enough to fight the enemies on their chosen ground. They might draw them out to their own prepared killing field, hit them in detail, or collapse the supposed enemy lair rather than risk engaging them.

Even so, personalizing a combat challenge with the specific perils of the environment is always to be recommended. If the PCs are trying to kill a duke, then the fact that the noble is surrounded by swarms of retain-

ers and has mobs of guardsmen that will rush to any alarm is a fact the PCs need to deal with. A combat in a blizzard-prone forest of frozen alien glass is going to involve blinding winds, razor-sharp flora, and dangerous collateral damage. If the environment the combat challenge takes place in has interesting or significant qualities like this, you should note down the likely effects in your preparation.

IDENTIFYING ALTERNATE ROUTES

The next step is to think about ways the PCs could engage with this challenge without drawing their blades. If it's a fearsome set of opponents, rational PCs will do their best to avoid fighting them unless there's some strong motivation to risk their lives in battle. Even if the PCs are dead set on murdering the target for one reason or another, they might end up looking for ways to do so safely, without letting the enemy strike back.

There are almost no circumstances in which you should force the PCs to engage a combat challenge directly. If the PCs are absolutely determined to draw steel on a target, then so be it, but any adventure that includes irrelevant but inevitable fights is an adventure that will probably go very badly for the party. If your adventure hinges on the assumption that the party is going to attack some particular foe head-on, or even that their interactions will inevitably be violent, then you risk railroading your players into situations that will likely get some portion of their PCs killed. Morale checks, reaction rolls, and a creature's basic inclination not to court death casually should always be kept in mind when building combat challenges.

You might choose to flesh out a social challenge associated with the subject, some angle of manipulation that

might turn them from an enemy into a peaceful neutral, if not an ally. You could stick in a minor exploration challenge that rewards the PCs with a secret back door into the target's lair or a bypass that lets them skip the potential fight entirely. You should look at the environment you've designed, consider the habits and goals of the party, and think about what alternate courses they might take rather than an immediate recourse to initiative rolls.

RECOGNIZING CONSEQUENCES

The villain is dead; now what? Targets that were subordinates to some greater power are going to need to be replaced and potentially avenged, if their employer liked them very much. Those with minions of their own will now see them look for new patrons and providers. Friends and family will be infuriated at the killers, while their enemies might feel a certain gratitude toward the people who performed such a favor.

As a final step, take some time to think about the consequences for the death of the challenge's targets. They serve some purpose in the world, even if that purpose is nothing more than terrorizing a merchant road or intimidating their peers in the depths of a Deep. With them gone, that purpose is either going to cease or be filled by some other entity. It may be that the death of the bandit chief sparks fresh trade between two towns, and the local lords begin squeezing their merchants with extra taxes on their newfound wealth. The slaughter of some monstrous tyrant far below the earth might be the catalyst for massive bloodshed among the natives as they sort out a gory new pecking order below, with the losers fleeing to the surface. The players won't always know or care about the consequences of their red-handed work, but the GM should remain mindful of their fruits.



COMBAT CHALLENGE COMPLICATIONS

Six bandits in a Deep chamber might be a combat challenge, but it doesn't give the GM much to work with when it comes time to make the encounter interesting. The tables on these pages offer complications and twists you can throw into the situation to enliven an otherwise banal brawl. Simply pick the tables that are most relevant to the situation and roll or select options to spice things up.

d12 What's Going On Right Now?

1	They lost a fight or had an accident, and are tending their wounded
2	They're absorbed in eating a meal
3	They're arguing over some pertinent matter
4	They're busy trying to repair a broken object or structure of importance to them
5	They're having some sort of religious ritual
6	They're resting after hard labor
7	They're interrogating a prisoner or suspected traitor to the group
8	They're training or practicing their skills
9	They're drinking or celebrating some win
10	There's a tense leadership showdown
11	They're lolling around in indolent idleness
12	They're conducting the business of daily life and other duties of common necessity

d12 What Problems Do They Have?

1	An ambitious underling plots against the leader or undermines their control
2	They're arguing over the fair division of some recently-gained spoils
3	Some are seriously ill with a disease
4	The leader is being foolish or irrational, driven by their own desires
5	They're overconfident and careless
6	They've lost some treasure precious to them
7	The underlings are ignoring the leader's will
8	They've been afflicted by some danger of their current environment
9	They're out of food or some other supply
10	They're being targeted by some hostile rival or dangerous local denizen
11	They've been driven from their usual home by an enemy or a natural hazard
12	Some of their members have been taken prisoner or lost.

d20 Twists About the Target or their Allies

1	They are or have access to spellcasters or mages of some kind
2	They have a useful magical power uncommon to their kind
3	An unusually strong ally serves the group's leader for its own reasons
4	The group is divided into parties or factions that cooperate poorly with each other
5	Killing them would enrage a seemingly-unrelated person or group
6	They have some reason to mistake the PCs for allies or hirelings
7	One member is a secret traitor in service to some other cause or group
8	Another group would pay very well or be very pleased at the death of the target
9	Eliminating this target would somehow release or remove a check on a dire foe
10	The target wants to get a member of their group killed in a deniable way, and will try to use the PCs to do it
11	They're religious zealots who may or may not have some blessing or affiliation that fits
12	They're searching for something that the PCs may or may not be able to help them find
13	The leader is desperately in love with one of their underlings or vice-versa
14	They're tampering with some object or structural feature that's extremely dangerous
15	They're foreign to the other examples of their creature type around here, having come from far off for their own reasons
16	They fight in an effective but abnormal way for their type or nature
17	Their leader has ensured that some dire consequence will ensue if they are killed
18	Some portion of the group would really rather not fight but are feeling compelled by their peers or the leader
19	Some other group has a spy or observer who is watching during a potential conflict
20	The leader is an impostor or catspaw of some power that would normally be their enemy, and acts as best they can to serve them

d12 What's That Bestial Monster Doing?

- 1 It's eaten recently and is lolling around, disinclined to hunt new prey
- 2 It's fighting with another of its kind over a mate
- 3 It's guarding cubs, eggs, or a recent kill
- 4 It's currently hunting something else but might choose to select the PCs as new prey
- 5 It's asleep or torpid, and has probably chosen a seemingly-safe spot to do so
- 6 It's playing after the manner of its kind
- 7 It's patrolling its territory to repel intruders or rivals for mates
- 8 It's fleeing, having been driven out by a foe or a more powerful rival
- 9 It licks its wounds after a hard battle, perhaps still surrounded by the corpses of its prey and their remaining belongings
- 10 It's digging, marking, or otherwise preparing its new lair, and may have a mate helping it do so
- 11 It's grooming itself or engaging in behavior specific to its type of creature
- 12 It's starving, and is ravenous for prey that it might not dare attack in more prosperous times

d12 Urban Dwelling Complications

- 1 An inquisitive neighbor is always watching the place
- 2 The guards are unusually vigilant and attentive to their duties for some reason
- 3 The target's living quarters are uncommonly difficult to access
- 4 There's a dangerous beast guarding the grounds of the place
- 5 The dwelling is unusually well-fortified
- 6 Servants and minions are thick in the halls
- 7 The owner has access to some kind of magical ward or divine blessing
- 8 The place is right next to a very vigilant and dangerous neighbor that will respond to alarms or disorders
- 9 The interior is mazy, abnormal, or difficult to navigate for some reason
- 10 Poor repairs or recent damage makes the place dangerous to unknowing outsiders
- 11 There are several traps or alarms there
- 12 It's connected to some kind of underground passages or ancient tunnels

d12 Wilderness Lair Complications

- 1 Hazardous flora make up a natural trap for those ignorant of their perils
- 2 Numerous deadfalls or covered pits have been placed on side paths here
- 3 The lair is positioned somewhere that has an excellent view of most approaches to it
- 4 You need to go underwater or through some noxious gas in order to reach the habitable part of the lair
- 5 It's surrounded by some natural peril, radioactive zone, *arratu*, or other hazard
- 6 There's a nest or lair of some dangerous animal obstructing easy entrance, but the occupants know how to deal with them
- 7 A fearsome local predator has been tamed or pacified and will attack intruders
- 8 The lair's built at least partially into some ancient structure or ruin
- 9 The lair's inside the hunting territory of some dreadful creature
- 10 It extremely well-concealed amid the terrain
- 11 Unrelated people are also living in or near it, and disturbing them would be hazardous
- 12 It's contaminated with soured magical energy, a damaged Working, or some other curse

d12 Deep Chamber Complications

- 1 A dangerous standing magical effect is present in the room
- 2 Part of the structure is fragile and prone to collapse if damaged
- 3 There's some noxious gas or substance tainting certain areas
- 4 A dangerous fall is possible in some part of the room
- 5 An ancient guardian risks being awakened by disturbances here
- 6 Strange ancient engines churn nearby and can cause dire injury to the careless
- 7 There are secret passages here
- 8 The room is very vertical in its shape
- 9 A certain path must be known to safely cross a particularly treacherous surface
- 10 It's somehow prone to flooding or currently a swampy mess
- 11 A valuable object here is extremely fragile
- 12 Some ancient magic or Deep functionality has been repurposed for a purpose convenient to the current occupants



CREATING EXPLORATION CHALLENGES

Exploration challenges revolve around plumbing the mysteries of some unknown site or long-vanished ruin. Not every exploration challenge is a conventional dungeon; searching a stretch of wilderness for points of interest is just as much an occasion of exploration as crawling through the tunnels of a buried Deep. Some exploration sites teem with hostile creatures and malevolent foes, while others simply contain obscure objects or enigmatic devices that make a puzzle of their operation.

The goal of an exploration challenge is to engage the players in the setting and make them think carefully about how to navigate it and its mysteries. When building them, a GM needs to stock the area with plenty of things to manipulate, steal, prod, fight, and flee from. This section will discuss one method of creating such an exploration site; there are ten thousand other ways to do it, but this one is simple and replicable by anyone who follows the steps involved.

The style of map this procedure creates is an abstract sort of map, one focusing on particular rooms or points of interest and largely glossing over the corridors or trackless miles between them. It's taken as a tacit understanding that there will be no traps, treasures, edifices or other things of interest in these interstitial spaces, and the PCs won't be punished for not carefully mapping every ten-foot square of dungeon or surveying every furlong of wilderness. Of course, some groups do prefer the classic graph-paper dungeon-crawls for inhabited areas, so advice is given at the end for converting these abstract maps into more concrete plans.

CHOOSE THE SITE TYPE

If you're building an exploration site centered around a structure, you may already know what kind of edifice this dungeon is. You may have already decided to build a Deep, or craft a haunted castle, or send the PCs into the sand-choked passages of a buried city. If you need further inspiration, however, you can use the table on page 238 for some suggestions or randomized results.

If you're building a "hexcrawl" wilderness exploration, your site will be the wilderness itself. It's usually best to worry about no more terrain than the PCs could cover in a single session of play. A twelve-by-twelve hex zone is usually plenty, assuming it's a standard six-mile wilderness hex. Such a zone assumes that the PCs will be searching it methodically for interesting sites rather than racing straight across it as quickly as possible.

Hexcrawls work mainly as a matrix in which the GM embeds interesting ruins, lairs, hamlets, and other points of interest as detailed on page 242.

The structure's type will help flavor the contents of the dungeon and the kind of inhabitants it might attract. It'll also help you establish what sort of locations might be found inside, and what manner of strange devices or peculiar workings might be there.

CHOOSE INHABITANT FRAMEWORK

For structure-based sites, it may be that your dungeon is entirely devoid of inhabitants, whether bestial or intelligent. Most dungeons will have something crawling around in them, and it's useful to determine the general shape of its occupants early, so as to let their presence flavor and influence your later decisions.

You can use the table on page 240 to define the general outline of the dungeon's inhabitants. A single dominant group may control the area, or there may be multiple groups with varying relations between them. Unintelligent monsters may be a major factor in the place, or they may have been driven out by the sentient occupants. If you want additional layers to the site's history, you can use the "What happened to their predecessors?" table in multiple "generations" of occupants, rerolling the framework for each period and seeing how it ended each time.

The associated tables provide suggestions for what kind of inhabitant groups might fill the various roles of the framework. If you have access to some of the copious numbers of old-school monster manuals that exist, you can also swap in assorted humanoids or monstrous beasts to fill the roles the table offers.

For wilderness exploration, you can use the same inhabitant table, but change the context to make it apply to tribes, hill clans, hidden villages, refugee encampments, or other population centers somewhere within the zone you're developing. At the same time, you should factor in any inhabitants that might already exist on the map, such as a village or border outpost you've already established as existing there.

GENERATE ROOMS OF INTEREST

A structure-based dungeon is built of "rooms", with each room being a particular defined location within the structure. An armory in a fortress might be a room, a carved plaza in an underground city might be another, and a monster-infested moat around a ruined watchtower might be treated as a room as well. A room is simply a place that has its own defining character and might contain something the PCs would want or need to interact with.

The tables on page 241 provide examples of different types of rooms or different overall functions and roles for a location. You should tailor these results or options to the general purpose or character of the structure; an armory in a noble lord's estate is going to be very different from the armory found in a wizard's tower or a military barracks. An "armory" in a private residence might be nothing more than the storeroom where the owner once kept their grandfather's dusty old armor.

Ten rooms of interest are usually sufficient for a small dungeon that won't eat up an entire evening's play

to explore. A twenty-room dungeon is usually enough to occupy a several-hour session, while thirty or forty rooms is probably as large as is convenient for a particular site. If a site has multiple clusters of rooms or multiple “levels,” then you might assign each level or area of the dungeon its own budget of rooms.

You should assume that at least half the rooms of interest will have nothing significant in them. They may have distractors or flavor elements present, but they’ll lack inhabitants, treasures, or substantial mysteries to investigate. If you pack every room with something shiny or sharp-toothed, your dungeon will tend to feel claustrophobic and overly-busy, and there won’t be any periods of calm downtime to contrast with the excitement that comes from perilous encounters.

Sketch or dimension each room on an index card. The layout of these rooms is apt to be important if the heroes start fighting in them, and having a general idea of their shape and contents is critical when it comes time to describe them to the players.

For a hexcrawl, each “room” is an individual hex. Many will have nothing of special interest in them, while others might have a structure or situation worth closer inspection. You will “stock” each of these hex-rooms later in the development process.

LAY OUT THE ROOMS

Next, for structure-based sites you need to establish the spatial relationships between rooms and identify any interesting topological features that exist in the dungeon. One of the easier ways to do this is to write each room of interest down on its own 3x5 index card, numbering all your rooms in order. Later, as you stock each room with its contents, you can write it down on the index card, adding notes in play to record any changes the party’s actions may have caused.

Take your deck of index cards and pick a room to serve as the entrance into your dungeon; this is where the PCs will enter the complex. You may add additional entry points later, but just one will serve for now. Put the card down in front of you on the table.

Now roll on the table on page 243 to determine how many exits depart from this room; reroll results of zero for this first room. The table below it gives choices for the direction of each exit. If the same result is rolled twice, roll or pick again. Place a new room on the table in the indicated direction. You can mark the existence of a connection between rooms by laying a coin or counter between the two adjoining room cards.

Repeat this process for each room you lay down. If a path dead-ends with zero egresses, return to an earlier room and add a fresh connection. If the route turns back on itself so that a room opens an exit to an already-existing room, just mark it down as a loop in the dungeon. Stop adding new connections when you run out of rooms to place.

Now look at the stylized map you’ve made and adjust it to your liking. Maybe you’ve got too many connec-

tions in one place or too few in another. Maybe you want to make sure there’s at least one loop in the dungeon’s framework. Maybe it’s too sprawling, and you want to bring it into a more condensed clump.

Wilderness hex crawls don’t need to bother with this step, as only in rare cases will some hexes be physically inaccessible from neighboring areas. Crevasses, impassable mountains, ancient megastructures, or large natural features might block free travel in such cases.

ADD OPTIONAL MAP FEATURES

For structure-based dungeons, you can continue on with the stylized map as it is, or you can pause to add some additional features to the map. Their exact implementation will depend on what kind of structure it is; a new ingress into a buried Deep will look different than a new ingress into a ruined city.

The section on page 243 lists a selection of possible map quirks or complications you can add. A portion of the map may be elevated, requiring the PCs to climb to get to it, while another portion might be separated by a deep crevasse, perilous environmental hazard, or rushing torrent. One exit might actually be a secret door, and another might be concealed due to debris, decay, or the work of inhabitants.

At this stage, you’ll also want to add any connections to different dungeon levels or areas. Stairways down into darkness, wells that plunge into lightless zones, crumbling bridges that connect different districts in the ruined city, or other connection points need to be established here. Generally, you should put them in rooms far away from the ingress point. Don’t hesitate to place more than one connection to the same area, with some perhaps being more obvious than others or leading to especially dangerous or interesting locations in the target area.

Again, wilderness hex crawls can skip this step, as they’re on such a large topological scale that small details of elevation aren’t generally applicable.

STOCK THE ROOMS

For each structure-site room, decide whether a creature, a treasure, an enigma, or a distractor can be found there. Some rooms may contain several of these things, such as a creature guarding its treasure near some ancient enigma. The table on page 244 provides a way of randomly determining these things, or you can use your own good judgment.

While creatures and treasures are largely self-explanatory, an “enigma” is some mystery, secret, trap, or other gubbin that the PCs can interact with to gain a reward of treasure or knowledge or to suffer harm from its activation. A “distractor” is a piece of decor or an event in the room that is without significant peril or reward, but adds to the overall flavor of the place or reinforces the theme of the site. The tables on page 245 offer suggestions for these things.

As a general rule, no more than a third of the rooms should contain creatures, and probably less. About half



the rooms with creatures in them should have an associated treasure, while a sixth of the rooms without creatures should have something valuable or loot-worthy to be found in them. If every treasure is kept behind guardian monsters, the PCs will rapidly learn to ignore empty rooms and try to win their fortune exclusively with drawn blades.

For the inhabitants, draw creatures from the groups you established earlier. The majority of inhabitants in the dungeon should be from those groups, but you might allocate as much as a third of the results to one-off monsters, wandering intruders, or unassociated entities.

For treasures, use the table on page 256 to get an idea of the total loot that could be reasonably found in the site, based on how important it is and how powerful the inhabitants are. The mightier the occupants, the more loot they'll have likely accumulated in the course of their activities. Divide this total loot into as many portions as you have Treasure results in your site. Half the treasure should go into one or two portions representing the major troves gathered by the strongest inhabitants or locked behind some enigma left by the site's builders. The rest of the treasure should be divided up among the other Treasure results, providing an array of smaller loot opportunities for lesser foes or more minor unguarded finds.

Wilderness hex crawls use different tables on page 242 to provide potential stocking. Many hexes will be devoid of anything particularly interesting, while others may have remnant ruins, lairs of dangerous creatures, remnants of past explorers, or other gubbins for PCs to interact with. A GM can make these ruins "shallow", making them no more than a few crumbled walls or still-standing chambers that might be fleshed out with a few dungeon room content rolls, or they can develop them into their own exploration sites with these steps.

ESTABLISH WANDERING ENCOUNTERS

The inhabitants of a structure-dungeon are unlikely to spend every waking hour sequestered in their assigned rooms. Creatures wander, inhabitants have tasks in different places, and things happen independently of the explorations of the heroes. At this stage, you should create a table or list of potential encounters that the PCs can run into while traversing the dungeon or exploring its rooms.

A table with six entries is usually sufficient, each entry being a group of creatures or a random event appropriate to the dungeon. One entry might be 1d6 sullen bandits on an errand for their leader, while another might be a sudden blood-curdling scream echoing down the halls as a victim is cruelly done in. Not every entry has to be a mob of enemies, and perhaps a third of the entries might just be environmental events. Wandering creatures rarely have any treasure worth note, and not all will be automatically hostile. Remember to make use of reaction rolls when the PCs meet the locals.

You'll use this table during the exploration of the dungeon. Usually, after each scene or during each transit between rooms, you'll roll 1d6; on a 1, you roll on

the wandering encounter table to see what happens to the PCs as they explore. The purpose of this table is to discourage time-wasting and excessive caution when exploring the dungeon. The PCs are in a potentially lethal hive of perilous foes and natural dangers, and the longer they spend in there, the more likely they are to get worn down by hostile inhabitants. If they can safely camp out in any random room they'll be tempted to spend hours carefully inspecting everything or recuperating overnight after every minor fray.

For hexcrawls, the same sort of wandering encounter table is necessary to reflect the beasts of the wilderness and the roaming sentient inhabitants to be found there. An encounter check can be made each time the PCs spend a day in a single hex and each time they spend a night camping in the wilderness. If they're crossing the wilds rapidly and not pausing to search a place they usually need to make only one check per day's travel or night's camping.

ESTABLISH DAILY LIFE

Now that you know who is where in a site-based dungeon, take a moment to think about their interactions and relationships. The initial inhabitant framework rolls may have given you some clues about how these groups relate to each other, but here you should nail down the specifics. If the Anak warband squatting in the old amphitheater hates the human bandits that fortified the ruined caravansary, then you can expect that they'll keep a distance from each other when not fighting. If the dungeon is a subterranean Deep, how do the occupants get food and water, and what do they do with their time? Do any of the inhabitants venture out of their home areas, and if so, where do they go?

Make some notes in each room about what the inhabitants are likely to be doing when the PCs first encounter them. Only automatons and mindless undead are likely to be standing in silence, waiting to be disturbed. Other creatures will be involved in sleeping, eating, arguing, gambling, standing watch, or doing necessary labor.

Also make some notes about what the inhabitants will do upon being disturbed. Will an attack cause some of them to run for reinforcements? Have they got some reason to be especially friendly to intruders? As the GM, you need to be careful about telegraphing a willingness to parley, as many players will just automatically reach for their swords as soon as they spot something warty and green. If you don't give the players some obvious clue that a more peaceful interaction is possible, they may not risk the attempt.

Keep in mind the general scale of the map when determining what kind of reinforcements could be summoned or what sort of notice would be taken of a fight. If the map you're making represents a single urban townhouse, then a bloody brawl in the kitchen is almost certainly going to be audible throughout the entire structure, alerting the whole dungeon. If you're mapping out a lost



city, on the other hand, the individual “rooms” might be hundreds of feet apart, and a screaming fray in one place might be wholly inaudible elsewhere.

Wilderness hex crawls can skip this step, unless there’s some titanic beast in the zone with a daily routine significant enough to affect the entire area. Knowing that a dragon has a 1-in-6 chance of flying over a hex on any given day is information likely to be relevant to explorers, but tracking the daily details of an Anak camp you rolled for a particular hex is unlikely to be worth your time.

COPY THE FINAL MAP

For site-based dungeons, once you’ve got everything arranged on the table to your liking and have decided which rooms might be affected by optional map features, copy the map to your notes for the site. Simple dungeon room numbers and names connected by straight lines are usually sufficient, with any terrain features noted alongside the connection lines. During play, you can consult the map and then pull out the relevant room cards to handle the exploration of these individual places.

For hexcrawls, make a copy of your hex map and write in the numbers of particular hex-contents index cards into the hexes where they’re found. Optionally, you can use a row-and-column grid reference for the cards instead, or use a hex map generation program that prints individual hex numbers in each hexagon.

MAKING A DETAILED MAP

For many groups, a stylized map is sufficient for exploring a structure. They really don’t want to pay attention to mazy blank corridors or the twists and turns of dungeon intersections. Each room of interest’s dimensions and shape are important to the encounters within, but the nebulous space between is glossed over with a few words about dank dungeon tunnels or empty streets.

Other groups want something more specific. They enjoy the process of mapping a dungeon, or the GM wants to take advantage of the kind of traps and obfuscations that work best in the connecting spaces between points of interest. In that case, the GM can take the stylized map and use it as the framework for laying in individual corridors, intersections, turns, and twists.

Using standard graph paper, start at the edge of the map and draw in a peripheral room. Working from that start, connect the various rooms with whatever twisty little passages, all different, that you wish. You might keep the overall alignment of the rooms the same as on the stylized map, or you could just use them as prompts and suggestions.

Don’t hesitate to lift chunks and fragments from the innumerable host of old-school dungeons that exist in the wild. More than four decades of material has been created on the care and construction of graph-paper dungeons, and much of it is available online. It’s perfectly fair to lift some dungeon map wholesale for your own table’s needs and simply change the room descriptions to fit your own rooms of interest.



TYPES OF RUIN SITES

The table below offers suggestions as to what kind of structure the exploration site might be. An initial d6 roll gives a general type of structure that you can use as grist for your inspiration, while an additional d12 can be rolled to get a specific example.

Some of the listed sites might not make sense in a particular context. While you can always just re-roll or pick something, it can sometimes be interesting to read the result metaphorically, and then put a structure in that matches the essential significance of the rolled result.

d6	Basic Type	d12	Site	d6	Site
1	Residential Site	1	Isolated rural estate of nobility	7	Townhouse of minor gentry
		2	Massive tenement or slum tower	8	Rural grange with outbuildings
		3	Compact fortified village	9	Hidden shelter against calamity
		4	Mazey urban residential block	10	Rubble-wrought makeshift village
		5	Ancient arcology or fragment of it	11	Outpost of refugees or recluses
		6	Sprawling slum of shanties and huts	12	Inhabited natural feature or cave
2	Military Site	1	Grand fortress of major significance	7	Hidden bunker or strongpoint
		2	Remote frontier keep	8	Secret operations base
		3	Isolated watchtower	9	Battered front-line fortress
		4	Military training camp	10	Gatehouse controlling a vital pass
		5	Half-subterranean entrenchments	11	Military cache or storehouse
		6	Battlefield littered with fortifications	12	Fortified waystation
3	Production Site	1	Illicit manufactory for illegal goods	7	Mine or open pit for excavation
		2	Sacred shrine for holy product	8	Overgrown ancient plantation
		3	Destroyed camp or extraction site	9	Managed woodland gone feral
		4	Inexplicable ancient manufactory	10	Farm for now-feral valuable beasts
		5	Outsider goods production site	11	Repurposed ancient manufactory
		6	Magical production facility	12	Fishery or salt extraction site
4	Religious Site	1	Lost pilgrimage destination	7	Fortified frontier monastery
		2	Tomb of some mighty ancient	8	Prison-monastery for heretics
		3	Shrine repurposed for a newer god	9	Fragment of megastructure temple
		4	Inexplicable sacred structure	10	Place of some holy trial or test
		5	Outsider fane to an alien god	11	Prison for a sealed demonic force
		6	Pilgrim hospital or waystation	12	Holy archive or relic-fortress
5	Cultural Site	1	Inscrutable Outsider art structure	7	Library or ancient archive
		2	Ancient culture's gathering site	8	Resort for nobles at ease
		3	Monument complex to lost glories	9	Enormous musical structure
		4	Abandoned school or study center	10	Massive ceremonial structure
		5	Indoctrination camp or prison	11	Preserved "heritage" village-resort
		6	Museum of a lost nation	12	Taboo site of dark magic
6	Infrastructure Site	1	Psychic or tech communications site	7	Subterranean transit tunnels
		2	Canal or aqueduct control center	8	Weather-control Working ruin
		3	Reality-stabilizing Working ruin	9	Ancient road through an obstacle
		4	Massive bridge or tunnel	10	Huge ancient dam
		5	Ancient power production center	11	Outsider xenoforming engine
		6	Semi-ruined teleportation node	12	Now-incomprehensible wreckage

THE FRAMEWORK OF INHABITATION

Some sites will have no significant inhabitants: no monsters, no skulking raiders, no wild beasts or abominable flora worth mentioning. Most, however, will have something dwelling in the place.

The adjacent table offers suggestions on how to structure the inhabitants. While any result might also include a scattering of randomly-chosen monsters or inhabitants, these major dwellers will be the main potential foes or subjects for parley within the ruin or wilderness.

If your structure is particularly small, such as under ten rooms, these numbers may be shrunk somewhat. Very large sites or wilderness points of interest might double the numbers to provide adequate populations.

The tables below offer optional prompts for relationships between groups and motivations for intelligent dwellers in the ruin. The following page offers tables to help determine who exactly these beings are.

d12 Potential Reasons for Hostility

- 1 They raided us and stole our resources
- 2 They're from a rival religion
- 3 Our kinds naturally hate each other
- 4 They took advantage of us in the past
- 5 They're weak and ripe for plunder
- 6 They broke an alliance in a treacherous way
- 7 They caused a local disaster or problem
- 8 Our leader has a personal hatred for them
- 9 Local resources are insufficient for us both
- 10 They're crowding into our territory
- 11 They tricked us and led us into a disaster
- 12 They stole a treasure or an important slave

d12 Why Did They Come Here?

- 1 Driven here by a terrible monster
- 2 No one remembers when they first came
- 3 Forced out of their old home by enemies
- 4 Sent out as a colony from their parent group
- 5 Gathered from scattered exiles and outcasts
- 6 Enlisted to come by a powerful leader
- 7 Drawn by the prospect of resources or loot
- 8 Making a cultural or religious pilgrimage
- 9 Came to fight an enemy that lairs here
- 10 Sent by visions, prophecy, or oracles
- 11 It's a refuge from some pursuing foe
- 12 To guard something precious here

d6 Important Inhabitants

- 1 One major monstrous beast, with the other inhabitants avoiding it or supplicating it
- 2 One major intelligent leader with their followers, slaves, or associates
- 3 1d3+1 major inhabitants, at least two of which are hostile to each other
- 4 A major inhabitant and the remnants of another group or pack they deposited
- 5 A relatively harmonious group of 1d3+1 significant figures
- 6 No discernible major figures, only a disorganized conger of beasts and beings

d12 Possible Causes for Alliances

- 1 We have a shared enemy
- 2 Our leaders are personal friends
- 3 We intermarry or have a blood relation
- 4 We each have goods the other needs
- 5 Each has skills the other lacks
- 6 We give protection for a tolerable price
- 7 We share the defense of the territory
- 8 We share the same religion
- 9 We overcame a great peril together
- 10 We used to be under the same leader
- 11 We recognize them as our rightful masters
- 12 We gain a great profit by mutual cooperation

d12 Why Are They Staying Here?

- 1 It's rich in resources useful to them
- 2 A foe outside threatens them if they leave
- 3 They're trying to find something specific here
- 4 It's simply always been their home
- 5 An important member is immobile somehow
- 6 Some drug or pleasure here has caught them
- 7 They've been enslaved by a power here
- 8 They're being paid to do so by someone
- 9 They haven't anywhere better to go
- 10 They're waiting for someone else to arrive
- 11 They're trapped here by something
- 12 Their leader has a personal reason to stay



TYPES OF INHABITANTS

These tables offer general suggestions as to what kind of inhabitants might occupy particular types of sites. Specific details of species or monstrous kind will depend on your own campaign setting, with Anak serving as hostile humanoids in the Latter Earth, while goblins or kobolds might fill the role in a more conventional setting.

The types of inhabitants rolled or chosen here reflect the major figures in a site, but they shouldn't be taken as the only creatures to inhabit the area. Some portion of a ruin or wilderness site's inhabitants should be taken from exotic beasts, unaffiliated sentients, or other figures of happenstance. Such variety helps keep foes fresh.

If you need additional monsters, virtually any old-school monster handbook should provide you with beasts you can import largely unchanged for your *Worlds Without Number* campaign. If you'd like to brew your own, you can reference the bestiary chapter in this book.

d12	Ancient Sorcerer-King Ruin
1	Altered human servitors of the former owner
2	Magic-forged monstrous beast
3	Adventurers searching for loot
4	Heirs of the last human inhabitants
5	Cult dedicated to a now-dead faith
6	Summoned creature that broke its fetters
7	Magical automaton servitors of the ruler
8	Decorative magic animals gone feral
9	Necromancer and their undead servitors
10	Outsider prisoners gone native here
11	Restless dead of the inhabitants
12	Zealots in service to a long-dead mage

d12	Alien Arratu
1	Animate and lethal plant life
2	Remnants of the Outsiders who made it
3	Adventurers daring the perilous terrain
4	Human natives trapped here for generations
5	Humanoids adapted to life there
6	Blighted raiders semi-native to the place
7	Automatons built to serve or fight the arratu
8	Outsider ruler still controlling a site within
9	Undead shades of swallowed cities or lands
10	Vicious alien fauna
11	Human cultist-servitors of the Outsiders
12	Explorers searching for a route through

d12	Subterranean Deep
1	Cruelly Outsider-warped original humans
2	Outsider monster that once ruled here
3	Swarm or pack of scavenger-beasts
4	Blighted intruders that sacked the Deep
5	Outsiders descended from the local lords
6	Degenerate or crazed native humans
7	Outcast surfacers lairing in the Deep
8	Non-human sentients who now live here
9	Undead relics of former inhabitants
10	Still-sane human heirs of the original folk
11	Surfacer colonists forgotten by their kin
12	Automaton servitors now lacking their lord

d12	Modern Ruin Site
1	Local bandits or highwaymen
2	Cult of some unacceptable god
3	Deposed noble and their retinue
4	Adventurers trying to plunder the place
5	Troops garrisoned there by the local ruler
6	Remnants of the original inhabitants
7	Sorcerer of detestable inclinations
8	Refugees or runaway peasants
9	Vicious local monster lairing here
10	Foreign raiders using it as a base
11	Whatever ruined the place is still here
12	Interlopers with some tie to the original place

d12	Trackless Wilderness
1	Alpha predator of the area
2	Intelligent monstrous beings
3	Swarms or packs of dangerous beasts
4	Violently reclusive local natives
5	Remnant of a destroyed state
6	Survivors of a displaced ethnic group
7	Demihumans who prefer isolation
8	Bestially savage tribals, perhaps inhuman
9	Expedition from a surrounding nation
10	Prospectors or resource-hunters
11	Spirit or elemental related to the wilderness
12	Sorcerers, cultists, or other solitude-lovers

ROOMS OF INTEREST

The table below gives different functions and specific examples of rooms that might be found in a site. You can use them verbatim when that would make sense, but you can also use the results as general metaphors, converting them into something similar that fits the site's nature.

For one technique, take your structure's general type and think of at least three rooms or locations that would be characteristic of it. Include those rooms and round out the rest of your needs from the table below, rolling or picking whatever results suit the job.

d6	Basic Function	d12	Example	d6	Example
1	Residential Room	1	Dormitory barracks for servants	7	Meager room for minor servant
		2	The owner or ruler's bedchamber	8	Sickroom for patients
		3	High-ranking resident bedroom	9	Guest chambers for visitors
		4	Latrine or privy	10	Kitchen or dining hall
		5	Kennel or beast pen	11	Bathing chamber or washroom
		6	Prison or slave cages	12	Study or private library
2	Work Room	1	Smithy or forge	7	Alchemist's workshop
		2	Smokehouse or food preparation	8	Artisan's work area
		3	Sewing or weaving room	9	Artist's workroom
		4	Torture chamber	10	Washroom or scullery
		5	Healer's work room	11	Brewery room
		6	Arcane laboratory	12	Processing room for a raw good
3	Cultural Room	1	Plaza or meeting area	7	Garden or flowing water feature
		2	Amphitheater or recital room	8	Ornately iconographic chamber
		3	Art gallery	9	Room for a particular cultural rite
		4	Cultural monument	10	Drinking hall
		5	Grave, cemetery, or ossuary	11	Performance stage or area
		6	Library or archive	12	Drug den or place of debauchery
4	Martial Room	1	Armory or martial storage	7	Map or planning room
		2	Training area	8	War machine fabrication or storage
		3	Barracks for soldiers	9	Dueling area
		4	Guard post	10	Beast-fighting arena
		5	Parade ground	11	Strong point or fortification
		6	Commemorative hall	12	Gate or fortified entrance
5	Religious Room	1	Private shrine	7	Room for a labor holy to the god
		2	Altar room	8	Storage for religious equipage
		3	Monastic prayer cell	9	Secured chamber for holy relics
		4	Ritual chamber	10	Secret or unofficial chapel
		5	Monument to a deity	11	Priest's private chambers
		6	Ceremonial bath	12	Public area adorned with icons
6	Utility Room	1	Work materials storage	7	Concealed servant's passage
		2	Pantry or food storage	8	Domestic staff head office
		3	Storeroom for random detritus	9	Vault for valuables
		4	Furnace or boiler room	10	Secret or unobtrusive entrance
		5	Exotic ancient power or light room	11	Grand passage or ornate corridor
		6	Pool or water source room	12	Barn or fodder storage



HEX POINTS OF INTEREST

For a hexcrawl, where a “room” consists of an entire hex of terrain, a point of interest is defined a little differently. First, decide how many hexes in your map should have anything particularly interesting at all. One simple way to do so is to roll one die for every hex in your map; on a roll of 1 or 2, there’s something worth noticing there. Use 1d6 for the die if you want a densely-populated hexcrawl, or 1d8, 1d10, or even 1d12 if you want sparser results.

For each hex of interest, a general feature or event is selected for the terrain, and then two tags are chosen for it from the appropriate lists in the world-building chapter. A crumbling ancient watchtower might use two Ruin tags, while a backwater village might pull a pair from Community, an isolated monastery might take two from the Court list, and an enchanted grove might pull tags from the Wilderness section. These tags are then synthesized with the result to produce something to catch the players’ interest.

Some results are “shallow” in that they consist of a fairly simple situation, enigma, or very small ruin that can easily be summed up on an index card. These shallow sites can be generated as you build the hexcrawl, and it’s assumed that each one won’t take more than five minutes to develop using the tags and other tools in this section. If the PCs run into one of these shallow hexes of interest, they can explore or engage with the feature immediately.

Other hexes of interest are “deep” in that they involve substantial ruins, complex situations, or significant communities. If you’ve got a half-dozen of these on your hexcrawl, how do you handle them in play? It would be exhausting to flesh out several entire dungeons on the off chance that the PCs will find one and want to explore it.

For deep sites, prepare only the most superficial external details, the sort of thing the PCs would notice only at their first encounter with the site. If they decide to explore it further, just explain to them that you’ll need prep time to bring it into adventuring order and that if they really do decide to investigate it, you can have it ready for the start of the next session. In the meanwhile, they can continue exploring the area.

This kind of just-in-time creation spares you the crushing burden of developing every major ruin or site of interest in a 70-mile span before the PCs even begin exploring the place. It also ensures that the site is as big as the players need it to be; if they really want to dig into a place, you can make it deep enough to reward their interest if they give you some between-session downtime.

The exception to this just-in-time rule is if you know the PCs are specifically seeking a particular site in the wilds. If you know they’re looking for the Deep of the Tarnished Knife, or know that events are very likely to propel them to the site, you’re justified in building that ruin out completely before the game starts.

d10	Basic Type of Feature
1–2	Roll on the Types of Ruin table on page 238
3–5	Roll on the Community Sites table below
6–7	Roll on the Court Sites table below
8–0	Roll on the Wilderness Sites table below

d10	Example Community Site
1	Village of aboriginal natives
2	Small colony of a nearby nation
3	Soldier-farmers dispatched to the wilds
4	Sectarian village of unorthodox believers
5	Demihuman enclave
6	Village of not-always-hostile monsters
7	Bandit meeting camp for trade and fun
8	Remnant of a major settlement swallowed up
9	Village of rebels or exiles from a nation
10	Oppressed group’s settlement of refuge

d10	Example Court Site
1	Small group of isolated recluses
2	Monastery or hermit retreat
3	Degenerates forced out of civilized lands
4	Wizards conducting esoteric business
5	Demihumans of neutral disposition
6	Small tribal clan living in seclusion
7	Monsters not immediately hostile in nature
8	Another adventuring or explorer party
9	Traders or merchants risking the wilds
10	Miners, prospectors, or woodsmen

d10	Example Wilderness Site
1	Cavern or cave complex
2	Extreme example of the native terrain
3	Valuable natural resource site of some kind
4	Lake, spring, or major water source
5	Crevasse, rift, or broken ground
6	Megastructure remnants or fragments
7	Traces of a long-lost road or canal bed
8	Mountain, high hill, or commanding height
9	Treacherous ground suited to the terrain
10	Pocket of unusual or atypical terrain type

ROOM LAYOUT AND MAP FEATURES

To begin, pick a room as an ingress point, the place where the heroes will enter the site. There may be other places to get into the structure, but this is the most obvious. Place this room's index card on the table in front of you.

Then roll on the adjacent exit table to find out how many egresses exist. You might arbitrarily decide to give two or more exits to this initial room so the PCs have some decisions to make as to where to explore.

For each exit, roll on the egresses table to see what direction it runs in. If the direction is impossible, such as heading west out of a room you know is on the western edge of a structure, then flip it in the opposite direction. Take a coin or other temporary marker and put it on the index card to indicate the egress' location.

Now, for each egress, place a room's index card adjacent in the matching direction, gradually building out the site as you continue to roll exits and egresses for each.

If a room only has one exit, then it's a dead end. If the egresses fold back on the map to create a new link with an existing room, place a marker accordingly between the two cards. Keep adding cards and rolling for exits until you run out of room cards for your site.

Next, go through the map you've generated and clean up the connections. Remove excess connections between rooms or bend long strings of rooms back toward the center of the structure. Try to ensure that at least one "loop" of rooms exists, so the entire site isn't just a clump of mutually-segregated linear arms.

Lastly, sketch an outline of each room's dimensions on the index card. If there's a fight there, you'll need to know the room's shape and size to run the hostilities.

At this stage, it's possible to stock this map exactly as it is. You can copy its configuration down in your notes and then go on to add room contents to each of the index cards, with notes on the margins about exits and where they lead. If you want to add further spice to the site, you can go on to add some map layout features before you do this, however.

MAP FEATURES

At its simplest, a map layout feature is just some quirk about the site's geography that affects multiple rooms that the PCs cannot readily ignore. As examples, here are some options you can add.

Different levels exist in some ruins. Some rooms will have stairs or slopes up or down, and the cluster of rooms beyond this point will be at a higher or lower elevation. Traditionally, the lower levels of a Deep tend to contain the worst abominations and most fearsome monsters.

Rivers or streams flow through some sites, cutting off rooms on either side in the absence of a bridge or a party of brave swimmers. Monstrous life forms like to live in such rivers, and falling in might result in more conventional perils of drowning.

d8	How Many Exits	d12	Egresses
1	One	1–2	North
2	One	3	Northeast
3	Two	4–5	East
4	Two	6	Southeast
5	Three	7–8	South
6	Three	9	Southwest
7	Three	10–11	West
8	Four	12	Northwest

Crevasses and pits bisect some sites or have opened up in some rooms. Those who climb down might gain access to a whole new level of the site, or there might be creatures that travel up and down the cleft to reach their lairs or hunting grounds.

Toxic atmospheres are common in *arratus* and other xenoformed areas. They may not be poisonous enough to kill a human outright, but lingering in such places usually increases System Strain until the humans must flee or pass out. A mild *arratu* might just prevent humans from recovering System Strain while inside it, while an alien xenoforming structure might inflict a point of strain every hour. The right protective enchantments or devices might be needed to make exploration possible at all.

Timed accessibility exists in some sites, with particular areas only being accessible at particular times. They might be behind ancient time-locked doors, or it the vast swarm of man-eating vermin that blocks the only ingress into the sub-zone might go out to hunt during the day. Sometimes accessibility is predicated on having particular key objects or succeeding in an Investigation challenge to learn the proper methods to open a sealed portal.

CORRIDORS AND DETAILED MAPS

The maps you create with this technique are simple diagram maps, ones that focus on points of interest and handwave the corridors or tunnels between the rooms. When the party goes north out of the armory, they arrive outside the south door of the grand dining hall; the space between is unimportant.

This doesn't mean you don't need to give it even a little thought, however. If the PCs get jumped by a wandering encounter on their way between rooms you may need to improvise a section of corridor for the fight. Conversely, if the site is a single small building, there may not be any meaningful corridors between rooms, and loud activities in the armory will be clearly audible to whatever's dwelling in the grand dining hall.

GMs for groups that prefer more concrete sites can always plunder one of the myriad dungeon maps available online, re-keying rooms to fit their needs and cutting out sections that are surplus to requirements.



STOCKING ROOMS

Stocking an exploration site's rooms is the most demanding part of site preparation. A ruin map can be scrawled out in moments, and deciding or randomly generating a room's purpose can take only a few minutes, but giving each such place a degree of flavor and interest is a much more challenging prospect. Fortunately, a basic system can smooth this creative work.

ROLLING FOR CONTENTS

First, roll 1d8 and 1d6 together and consult the adjacent table. The 1d8 will determine what's in the room; a creature, a dangerous hazard, a peculiar enigma, or a bit of distracting background flavor. About a quarter of the rooms will be entirely empty and devoid of anything worth interacting with.

The 1d6 will then indicate whether or not there's any treasure or objects of value in the room. Thus, if the 1d8 is 6 and the 1d6 is 2, you can see that there's a distractor in the room but no treasure.

It's not impossible that a creature could share the same room as a hazard, or there might be an enigma with some distractors scattered about, but if you don't want to hand-decide such instances you can go back and re-roll the 1d8 on a selection of rooms to get a second contents result.

PLACING CREATURES

If you get a creature result, place one or more of them into the room, using the inhabitants results from page 240 to guide your selection. Remember to make about a quarter or a third of the creatures inside the site unrelated to these rolls so there's some variety in the inhabitants.

If the inhabitants are living in the site, make sure there are locations designated for sleeping, cooking, latrines, and other necessities of daily life. The creatures may not be present there all the time, but the evidence of their activities should be obvious.

As for how numerous and strong the creatures should be, keep in mind the logic of the site and the needs of your upcoming session. A random minor ruin in the woods is unlikely to be housing a bandit army or a vengeful arch-wraith, and if you are intentionally creating a ruin to engage a party of novice adventurers the inhabitants shouldn't be so strong as to kill them out of hand unless there's a good reason for them to be so. You have flexibility on this count, so long as you don't contradict what your world has already established; if the PCs have learned that the Tower of Iron and Salt is the lair of a devil-god, make sure there's either a devil-god in it or a clear reason for people to think that there is.

PLACING HAZARDS

Hazards can take the form of traditional pit traps and poisoned needles, or they might be unstable construction, dangerous miasmas, or anything else that could cause

d8	Contents	d6	Treasure?
1–2	Creature	1–3	Yes
		4–6	No
3	Hazard	1–2	Yes
		3–6	No
4	Enigma	1–2	Yes
		3–6	No
5–6	Distractor	1	Yes
		2–6	No
7–8	Empty	1	Yes
		2–6	No

harm to PCs in the area. Most traps or snares should allow an appropriate saving throw to avoid the worst results. Poison needles or toxic clouds might inflict flat damage on a failed save, and crumbling floors might send the PCs careening into a new area entirely.

PLACING ENIGMAS

Enigmas are any magical or mechanical oddity that might be appropriate to the site's nature. An abandoned manor in the wilderness is unlikely to have ancient megastructural power conduits flaring in its basement, but it might have a relic of the past owner's arcane experimentations or an eerie trophy taken in some former age.

An enigma result is an excuse for you to put something odd in the place, something that could perhaps help as much as harm. Complex or esoteric enigmas might take their own Investigation challenge to make them operational, with clues scattered elsewhere in the site.

PLACING DISTRACTORS

Distractors are just objects or situations that the PCs can interact with and investigate, even if there's nothing particularly important about them. Use them to flavor the site and emphasize its past use and current activities.

Whatever you use for a distractor should be something the PCs can touch or otherwise interact with. Mere backstory is not a distractor; it doesn't matter what happened in a given room unless it's something that left a tangible legacy behind for the PCs to meddle with.

PLACING TREASURE

Once you know how many rooms in the site have treasure in them, take the total site loot you've already determined and divide it into halves. Put half the treasure into one or two major troves in appropriate locations in the site. Divide the other half of the loot among the other treasure-positive rooms, putting trifling finds in some and bigger hauls in others. You can play with these proportions as your own judgment recommends, but make sure that not all treasure requires a fight to get it.

d20	Example Types of Hazards
1	Tripwire alarm or other alerts
2	Unstable floor that crumbles under weight
3	Dangerous fumes or miasma
4	Trapped containers or portals
5	Explosive dust or gases
6	An object makes a loud noise if disturbed
7	Damaged supports that give way in combat
8	Dangerously high or deep water
9	Trap set on a path of travel
10	Device here is dangerously broken in use
11	Trap that seals intruders into an area
12	Treacherous footing over dangerous terrain
13	Uncontrolled flames or dangerous heat
14	Torch-extinguishing winds or vapors
15	Ordinary-seeming object harms handlers
16	Crushingly heavy object is going to tip over
17	A savage foe can be attracted by accident
18	Something here is cursed by dark powers
19	Seeming treasure is used as bait for a trap
20	A contagious disease is on something here

d20	Example Distractors
1	Books or records from the site's owners
2	Unique furniture related to the site's past
3	Trophies or prizes taken by the owners
4	Portraits or tapestries related to the site's past
5	Ornate, imposing, but harmless doors
6	Daily life debris from the inhabitants
7	Worthless ancient personal effects
8	Odd-looking but normal household goods
9	Shrines or hedge ritual remains of inhabitants
10	Corpses of fallen intruders
11	Bones and other food remnants
12	Statuary or carvings related to the site
13	Signs of recent bloodshed and battle
14	Empty cabinets or containers
15	A discharged or broken trap
16	Remnants of an inhabitant social event
17	Mouldering or ruined goods or supplies
18	Half-completed work done by inhabitants
19	Once-valuable but now-ruined object
20	Broken or expended once-magical object

d20	Example Enigmas
1	Magical fountain or pool
2	Control that opens paths elsewhere
3	Spatial warp between locations
4	Enchanted statue or art object
5	Magically-animated room components
6	Substance with physically impossible traits
7	Altered or augmented gravity
8	Zone that empowers foes or magic types
9	Magical ward or seal on a summoned thing
10	Oracular object or far-scriving device
11	Standing magical effect in the area
12	Temporal distortion or visions of other times
13	Sounds being shifted over long distances
14	Zones of darkness or blinding light
15	Enchanted seals visibly locking up loot
16	Magical or elemental force emitting unit
17	Enchantment tailored to the site's original use
18	Unnatural heat or chill in an area
19	Magically-altered plant life here
20	Restorative magical device

d20	Possible Treasure Locations
1	Stored in a visible chest or coffer
2	Hidden in a pool of liquid
3	Behind a stone in the wall
4	Underneath a floor tile
5	Hidden inside a creature's body
6	Inside an ordinary furniture drawer
7	Slid beneath a bed or other furnishing
8	Placed openly on a shelf for display
9	Hidden in a pile of other junk
10	Tucked into a secret furniture space
11	Slid behind a tapestry or painting
12	Heavy, protective locked chest or safe
13	Buried under heavy or dangerous debris
14	In the pockets of clothes stored here
15	The treasure's a creature's precious body part
16	Scattered carelessly on the floor
17	Tucked into a pillow or cushion
18	Hung on a statue or display frame
19	Hidden atop a ceiling beam
20	Resting atop a desk or table



WANDERING ENCOUNTERS

Once you've stocked the hexmap with points of interest or filled out the contents of the rooms of your dungeon, you need to put together a Wandering Encounter table for the region or ruin. Some situations might call for more than one table, such as a hexcrawl that covers different biomes or a Deep that has levels controlled by different groups.

THE PERILS OF THE UNKNOWN

The ultimate rationale of a Wandering Encounter is to remind the party of the danger of their surroundings, to wear them down over time, and to penalize time-wasting or carelessness inside a dangerous area. The longer the PCs spend exploring the wilderness or delving in a Deep, the more encounters they're going to have and the more they're going to deplete their available resources.

Wandering Encounters keep the players from having full control of the pacing of their explorations. They can't simply decide to hole up in a room for 12 hours to rest up and refresh their abilities; odds are that something's going to find them, and the encounter check is the impartial mechanism that determines whether or not that happens. A party that plunges a hundred leagues into a trackless jungle may decide that they've gone far enough, but bad luck with encounter checks on the way back may teach them that they've actually gone considerably farther than they should have. The party can decide when they've had enough of danger, but the dungeon gets a vote.

Wandering Encounters may not be a good fit for story-arc games, however. If the next plot point requires the party to make it to some distant wilderness location, rolling a particularly dire encounter might disrupt that plan. A planned climax may turn out to be decidedly anticlimactic when the PCs stagger in, their resources all but gone after being spent on several unlucky encounters. A GM who wants to firmly control the pacing of challenges for one reason or another may choose not to use them.

SOURCING YOUR PERILS

Where do the creatures that make up these encounters come from? With hexcrawl encounter tables, this isn't a difficult question to answer. The creatures are either beasts that live in the area, sentient inhabitants that have communities there, or interlopers and hermits from outside the region. It won't strain the party's suspension of disbelief if they keep running into the same kind of creatures because it's always plausible to assume that there are more of them lurking somewhere in the wilderness.

Things are different in a Deep, a ruin, or a noble's townhouse. There are only so many creatures that could reasonably be lairing there. If the PCs kill the bandit chief and drive his lieutenants out of the abandoned fortress, it doesn't make sense for them to continue to encounter bands of his minions roaming through the castle's mouldering corridors.

For these situations, where there are only a finite number of wanderers that could reasonably occupy a site, each creature entry in the table should be allowed to happen only a few times, or perhaps only once. If that same entry is rolled again, then no encounter happens. If the PCs leave the ruin long enough for the locals to regroup and reinforce their numbers, this entry might be refreshed... or reinforced, if the inhabitants are braced for another PC invasion.

BUILDING THE TABLES

As a general rule, a table of six or twelve entries is usually enough to give a good variety to encounters. About half the entries should be run-ins with the usual inhabitants of the area, a quarter should be some environmental peril or complication appropriate to the surroundings, and a quarter should be false alarms, explicitly non-hostile encounters, or non-harmful environmental activity.

The creatures met in a Wandering Encounter are probably either patrolling their territory, hunting for food, or going about their daily life. Most of them are not going to be expecting imminent danger unless the site has already been alerted to intruders, in which case the encounters might be considerably reinforced with creatures drawn from the stocked areas of the site.

Wandering Encounters almost never have any loot of note aside from petty personal belongings.

RUNNING ENCOUNTERS

Outdoors, most encounters begin at the terrain's maximum sight range, with opposed Wis/Notice checks to see who spots the other first. Ambush predators, stalking hunters, or prowling scouts might engage from a much closer distance. At long range, many PC groups will have time to attempt to flee a hostile group, with escapes being handled with the flight guidelines on page 52. Mounted groups will almost always overtake unmounted groups unless they can be led into terrain unsuitable for horses.

Indoors, the usual range for first notice is 2d6 x 10 feet, assuming the site is large enough to have corridors and rooms of that scale.

Remember, all but the most mindlessly hostile creatures deserve a reaction roll as per page 296 to determine their initial disposition toward the PCs. Even a group of patrollers charged with guarding against intruders might pause long enough to simply demand the PCs leave, or find them interesting enough to offer silence in exchange for gold or favors. A high reaction roll won't turn a committed enemy into a friend, but it could be enough to defuse immediate violence, or open the door to a mutually-agreeable parley.

Dead Wandering Encounters are likely to draw the alarm of the site's inhabitants. If enough of these patrols are killed, the locals may choose to migrate elsewhere, taking their treasures with them.

EXAMPLE TABLES

The table below is an example of the kind of encounter table you might make up for a ruin or wilderness, filling in the entries with results specific to the place. To expand it or to get more ideas for complicating encounters, you can use the other tables to add some extra content. Some entries might be plausibly encountered several times, while others might be setpieces to be met only once.

d6 An Encounter Table Template

1	Dangerous animal living in the vicinity
2	Small group of local inhabitants
3	Local elite or lieutenant with retinue
4	Solitary intruder or unaffiliated creature
5	Environmental effect or ambiance
6	Sound or side-effect of inhabitant activity

d12 What Are They Trying To Do?

1	They're hunting or gathering foodstuffs
2	They're patrolling their territory
3	They're investigating other intruders
4	They're hiding a cache of wealth
5	They're raiding their rivals
6	They're escorting a wounded comrade
7	They're fleeing a worse foe
8	They've been summoned back by the chief
9	They're escorting prisoners or slaves
10	They're working at a necessary labor
11	They're repairing or maintaining the site
12	They're sneaking away from work

d12 What Mood Are They In?

1	Furious and looking to take it out on someone
2	Hungry and needing food
3	Belligerent and looking for a fight
4	Suspicious even of what they see themselves
5	Wary of strangers and their powers
6	Greedy for gold or glory
7	Spitefully angry at a rival or enemy group
8	Temperate and reluctant to fight
9	Frightened of something terrifying nearby
10	Drunken or intoxicated in some way
11	Benevolent and feeling magnanimous
12	Happy after a recent stroke of great luck

d20 Example Wilderness Events

1	A horse or pack animal goes lame
2	Cart wheel breaks or vehicle overturns
3	Sudden flash storm makes travel perilous
4	Skill check or get lost for the day
5	Find the hideous remains of a massacre
6	Landslide blocks the path
7	Dust storm or deep fog obscures everything
8	Poisonous flora force saves or debilitation
9	Mold or vermin destroy some foodstuffs
10	A piece of equipment breaks during use
11	Find the remains of a lost traveler
12	Find territory-markers of nearby natives
13	Insects or parasites; save or get sick
14	Run into a dire monster when next foraging
15	Route dead-ends, wasting a day's travel
16	Sudden great heat or cold snap
17	Steady, relentless rain halving all travel
18	Contaminated water; save or get sick
19	Maddening insects; can't sleep well
20	Find signs of a lethal predator in the area

d20 Example Dungeon Events

1	Native religious chants echo down the halls
2	Disgusting local vermin, but they're harmless
3	Spores or filth ruins some foodstuffs
4	Strong winds or heavy gases snuff flames
5	Floor or ceiling collapse in a rickety place
6	Next door or furniture touched falls apart
7	Cryptic scrawling found on something
8	Makeshift burial of an adventurer by allies
9	Dropped trinkets from the site's major loot
10	Mephitic stench from activity here
11	Pounding or booming from the deeps
12	Gravely wounded intruder begs aid
13	Tide of vermin fleeing a danger or predator
14	Prey animal fleeing nearby local hunters
15	Sound of nearby local activity
16	Piece of equipment breaks during use
17	Escaped slave or prisoner of the locals
18	Mold or noxious liquid spills on someone
19	Hidden alarm trap is in the PCs' way
20	Local being is in trouble and needs help



CREATING INVESTIGATION CHALLENGES

While most players can hum along with how an adventurous sword fight or perilous dungeon delve ought to be done, very few of them have much practical experience as private investigators. Give them a sinister pit and they'll have a list of exploration supplies drawn up in minutes, but ask them to find Leper Tom in the grim city of Gath-is and they'll flail in vain. Many of them will try to move directly to Notice or Connect skill checks for lack of any better ideas.

This isn't exclusively the fault of their innocence, but also because investigations and searches are so reliant on masses of detail. Without a real scene to investigate or a real city to comb through, the players can only interact with those parts of the world that the GM describes and defines. If the GM forces them to hit the right magic pixel before they cough up some important description then the players can end up frustrated... and frustrated players tend to do very reckless things in a campaign.

It's inevitable that a GM's going to need to brew up some mystery for an adventure, or plant a sinister plot, or bring in some hidden person that the party desperately needs to find. These enigmas might be single strange rooms in ancient Deeps or they might be sprawling cultist schemes that encompass half the campaign setting. What they all have in common is that there is a secret and the PCs are expected to want to find it out.

WHY MYSTERIES ARE HARD

Enigmas are much more difficult to GM than many other common elements of play. A dungeon can be mapped and keyed with everything of significance in it. A wilderness crawl rarely involves any questions from the players until they run into an encounter, site, or situation that the GM has designed and placed on the map. Even courtly intrigues usually involve a fixed roster of characters and a limited scope of relevance that is obvious to the players.

Mysteries and investigations don't have that conveniently closed scope. Questions like "What was Irrelevant NPC #5 doing at six in the morning on that day?" or "What do I find when I investigate this dubious baker?" can come flying at a GM when the players try to follow some sudden flash of probably-erroneous insight. Anything could be relevant, so the players start to ask about anything, and it's a gifted GM that can ad-lib while keeping every fact straight. A mistake in a timeline turns into a Telling Clue, and the GM then has to pause and explain to the players that no, the butler had nothing to do with it and it was only a GM error.

It is for this reason that most GMs are best off structuring their mysteries in a less sandboxy way. It may sound heretical to suggest this, but for reasons of practical playability it can be necessary to force things into a more fixed structure and let the players explore this particular web of facts rather than risk the need to generate an endless supply of internally-coherent ad-libs.

FOCAL AND PERIPHERAL MYSTERIES

Before using the tools in this section, it's important to distinguish between those mysteries and investigations which are the focal point of the party's exertions and those plots and schemes that just happen to be going on in the area they're exploring. You only need to worry about the tools and templates in this section when you expect the players to be specifically trying to unearth a mystery. You do not need to use them if there just happens to be a sinister plot or hidden truth somewhere in the dungeon or city area they occupy.

The point of these tools is to help the GM build a session that revolves around PC investigation, and if the players aren't trying to have a session like that then you don't need to bother using them. Maybe they find out about the peripheral scheme or maybe they don't, but your content for the evening doesn't rely on that outcome so you don't have to worry about it.

SCENES AND INVESTIGATIONS

Investigations are broken into several specific scenes. Each scene is a setpiece encounter, place, or situation that the PCs are expected to run into, either because it's logically obvious or because the GM is nudging them in that direction. It may seem blasphemous for an honest, dice-fearing sandbox GM to tilt the table in that way but it is often a practical necessity, simply because the GM can't possibly ad-lib all the coherent details that the players might demand if they had a wholly unrestrained scope.

The structure for an investigative adventure is built backwards, starting from the Resolution. This is the big moment of confrontation or revelation, the point at which the PCs discover the ultimate truth or find themselves with swords drawn, facing the sinister cultists at their hidden ritual site. Think about what the climax is likely to look like, even if that's something as simple as the PCs finding the right book on some forgotten library's shelves.

Once you have the Resolution, you need about three Investigation scenes. Each Investigation scene should give the PCs one fact they need to reach the resolution with all relevant information. To make it to the hidden cult ritual, for example, they might need to know where it will be held, when it will next happen, and what kind of defenses or preparations will be there. The necessary information to establish each of these facts is put in its own Investigation scene, where the PCs will have to either infiltrate a place to get the information, negotiate with an NPC, unearth it from a hidden location, or otherwise overcome some challenge.

With the three Investigation scenes and their rewards of information established, you pull them together into a single Introduction scene, where the PCs will be

given pointers toward each Investigation scene. They may not know anything about the challenges waiting for them there, but they have at least an actionable amount of information necessary to get to the Investigation scenes.

Finally, and optionally, you might glue on a Hook scene at the very beginning of the investigation, some event, NPC, or situation that clues in the PCs that there even is something worth investigating here. If you know that some grand mystery or sinister scheme is going on in the next place the PCs are going, you might throw them a Hook scene to establish that something pressing is going on in the area that the PCs might want to look into. In the same vein, you might throw the Hook out so the players know that choosing to spend the next session investigating it is something that will get them worthwhile adventure. If they don't bite, then you can just leave it until local events would logically come to a head.

A simple investigative adventure requires nothing more than these five or six scenes: a Resolution, three Investigations leading to that climax, an Introduction pointing to each of the three Investigations, and an optional attached Hook scene to alert the players that there's something worth looking into here. If you want to elaborate the session, you can insert additional types of scenes, or have them waiting in the wings as consequences if the PCs screw something up or draw the wrong attention.

PLANNING SCENES

Each scene should have very clearly-drawn boundaries around the places, people, and facts of relevance. *How* clearly will depend on the players you have; some groups will pick up on mere whispers and allusions, while others need a finely-engraved invitation to a specific place and time before their suspicions are aroused. When in doubt, err on the side of blatancy, because if they don't pick it up organically you'll need to simply tell them directly that a particular line of interest is outside the scope of the adventure.

Failure states in an investigation challenge come in two varieties, and you need to decide which state you're going to risk happening when you build your scenes.

The players miss the clue and dead-end. If they can't pick up the fact, lead, or hook the scene is trying to feed them, they simply don't get it and can't progress the investigation. Maybe they come up with some brilliant out-of-the-box solution for sidestepping the issue, but you may just have to let them know that they blew it. If you don't make their failure clear to them, they'll just keep flailing around until they get sick of trying or meet an ignominious end. This failure state accepts that some investigations are simply stillborn due to PC failure.

The players miss the clue but get it at a price. In this case you feed the party a Failsafe scene to get them the clue, hook, or lead they botched and enable them to progress the investigation. This mercy comes at a price, however, and the situation will become worse, the enemy stronger, or an ally will pay a dear price for it.

When planning your scenes, you need to decide which failure state is going to be acceptable to you and take steps accordingly. If the PCs can botch the entire job early on, then you need to have the consequences of that botch in mind and some filler content to occupy them if you want to avoid the risk of a short session. If the PCs are going to get the clue no matter what, you need a Failsafe scene or two prepped to explain how the precious datum is going to be put in their hands and the grim price that they're going to pay in getting it that way.

Once you know what the consequences of failure are for your scene, plot out at least one method in the scene that would let the PCs obtain the clue. The PCs can and probably will think of others, but you need to make sure there's at least one feasible way to succeed. Remember that the entire point of the scene is to enable the PCs to get the information; logical steps and rational efforts should be rewarded, and failing to get the data should be the result of a significant mistake rather than the default outcome without some heroic effort.

HANDLING SCENES IN PLAY

Managing investigative scenes can be painful for those GMs averse to ad-libbing, but there are a few basic principles that can make your life a little easier.

Be blunt about irrelevancies. Red herrings are poison to a lot of groups, creating confusion that's delightful in a novel and often painful at the table. So long as it's just one line of investigation out of several it can be allowed to continue, but if the players really start digging into something totally outside the scope of the investigation, cut it off and feed them a lead back into the real matter.

Reward efforts with information. If they are trying something logical and rational, give them something. Even if it's just a pointer toward a more relevant topic, always let them feel as if their efforts are getting them somewhere, even if it may not be done as efficiently as they like. A reasonable plan that ends with "You learn nothing and obtain no new leads." is tremendously frustrating to a lot of groups.

Don't allow naked skill checks. You should never look kindly on an unadorned request for a skill check, but this is especially to be avoided in an investigation. If a PC wants to find someone, don't just let them roll Connect. Have them give at least a sentence or two to explain what kind of steps they're taking to find a person, and then use their efforts to sensibly inform the result of their Connect check. By knowing *how* they're doing something, you get the contextual information you need to slip them side clues and helpful pointers, even if the check itself is a failure.

Always be pushing forward. When players dead-end in an investigation, they get frustrated, and when they get frustrated, they often start doing reckless or stupid things just to get some kind of movement from the situation. The players should never be without at least one tangible lead forward, unless you're reconciled to the "allow complete failure" model of running investigations.



RESOLUTION SCENES

As the first scene to plan, think about the final moment when the PCs finally reveal the truth, place the incontrovertible proof before authorities, confront the malefactor in their hidden lair, or otherwise bring things to a head. In some cases this resolution will be unhindered triumph; the PCs figure out how to unseal the ancient vault and plunder the wealth within. In other cases, they might just buy themselves the opportunity to face an unmasked enemy, and may or may not prevail in the end.

Make sure you have prepared any necessary combat stats, relevant maps, and notes on any likely consequent social results. If the PCs successfully resolve the investigation, who will care, and who will be upset or pleased about it? If you choose to add a twist to the situation, make sure it's foreshadowed and properly hinted earlier in the investigation.

INVESTIGATION SCENES

Now pick three facts that together should give the PCs the information they need to reach the Resolution. Each one of those facts gets its own Investigation scene. Parcel out the truths to likely NPCs, particular significant places in a ruin, the abandoned homes of the long-dead secret keepers, or other people or places who ought to have the facts that the PCs want to find out.

Then put an obstacle in each between the PCs and the knowledge. The NPCs will want something in exchange, or have reason to avoid cooperating, or be people the PCs have a hard time reaching. Clues found in the environment will come with attendant dangers and perilous effort to reach them.

Avoid ambiguity in your clues, when possible. The point of the scene is to let the PCs face the challenge to get the information; don't play coy with the rewards.

INTRODUCTION SCENES

How will the PCs even know that the clues exist or where to look for them? The Introduction scene gives them directions to each of the three clues you've placed. It's unlikely to be a perfect map to the exact NPC or precise abandoned archive that has the clue, but it should give them a clear idea of where to look next. Usually, such an Introduction scene takes the form of the PCs' first encounter with the mystery and its NPC participants, with the leads being implicit in that situation's events.

Introduction scenes need to give the PCs actionable intelligence, and point them to specific directions they can take to progress the mystery. They may need to navigate dangerous social situations, search perilous Deeps, carve their way through trackless wilderness, or negotiate with less-than-trustworthy informers, but they should have an obvious "Do this next." imperative as part of the Introduction scene.

d6 Twists to the Resolution

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | The culprit or object actually had a reason to want the mystery to be solved |
| 2 | The culprit's actions are being shaped or influenced by seemingly-uninvolved party |
| 3 | Someone who ought to be happy about the discovery will actually have cause to regret it |
| 4 | The resolution carries hints of an even larger mystery the PCs may or may not pursue |
| 5 | The resolution coincidentally entangles itself in a completely unrelated social conflict |
| 6 | The most obvious act to resolve the mystery is one that comes at some dear price |

d6 Possible Investigation Complications

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | The information is obviously time-sensitive, and the PCs know they have to hurry to get it |
| 2 | There's an obvious, easy way to get the information but it's morally repugnant |
| 3 | Unless obtained carefully, the info is only partial, enough to direct but missing vital bits |
| 4 | The information is of a sort the party will be absolutely certain to be unhappy to learn |
| 5 | The information is true, but deeply misleading unless the full context is investigated |
| 6 | An ally is going to be hurt if the PCs obtain the information. |

d6 Why Is the Intro Worth Following Up On?

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Some known enemy or suspicious person clearly does not want them to follow it up |
| 2 | The manner of its discovery makes clear that somebody was trying to keep it hidden |
| 3 | An ally or existing NPC they trust has reason to vouch for its validity |
| 4 | The introduction comes with a reward or token that is enticingly valuable |
| 5 | Part of the introduction involves facts or elements that the PCs already know are true |
| 6 | The intro happens to lead them in a direction they were already planning on going |

HOOK SCENES

Introduction scenes are necessary to give the PCs a clear direction for their investigations. Yet for some mysteries, it might not be obvious that there is any investigation to be had at all. A glowing sphere of glyphed jade invites curiosity; a silent conspiracy of noble cultists is less obviously interesting.

The purpose of a Hook scene is simply to let the players know that there's something they might want to look into. An involved NPC can go to them, or they might stumble into the aftermath of an event related to the mystery, or an old acquaintance might seek them out for help with some seemingly-unrelated problem.

If the players have all agreed beforehand to explore the mystery, then a Hook will usually be swallowed on the spot. If that's not the case, however, be prepared with alternatives should the Hook be ignored or de-prioritized in favor of a more pressing adventure.

REACTION SCENES

In active conspiracies or secret intrigues, the players aren't the only ones with volition. The participants are going to react to the PCs getting involved in their affairs, and that response may not be particularly gentle. Reaction scenes are optional scenes you can work out if you want to think about how a culprit or a conspiracy might respond to PC meddling.

Do they attempt an ambush? A sinister warning-off? A friendly spot of bribery? Do they go after sympathetic NPCs, or perhaps after those NPCs who let out their secrets in an Investigation scene? Does the reaction itself risk giving the PCs more clues about how to find the truth?

Reactions are contingent on the culprit actually realizing that they're being investigated. Sneaky and subtle PCs might do their work without ever raising suspicion.

FAILSAFE SCENES

Sometimes the PCs just totally fail to find the clue, or else misinterpret it drastically. It's perfectly acceptable to let them botch things as a consequence and leave the mystery impenetrable. Not all adventures are a success and there's always something new to do in a sandbox.

In other cases, you'll want to make it certain that the PCs will eventually pick up the clues. A Failsafe scene allows the GM to hand the PCs a fact or realization they might have missed, though usually at some dire cost to a friendly NPC or at the risk of making the culprit all the more ready and able to deal with the investigators.

For a Failsafe, think about some way an NPC, coincidence, or misstep by the culprit could get a missed clue into the PCs' hands. At the same time, think about the kind of karmic negative consequences that might come from the need to resort to such cosmic forbearance.

d6 What Makes the Hook So Enticing?

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | A great sum of wealth or the promise of rich treasures are dangled by it |
| 2 | Following the hook would clearly win great favor with an important NPC |
| 3 | An allied NPC or friendly character is appealing to them to follow it up |
| 4 | Following it would clearly hurt or discomfit a person or group the PCs hate |
| 5 | Following it offers an easy escape from some current bad situation or approaching foe |
| 6 | The hook directly ties into an ambition or goal of one of the PCs |

d6 What's Their First Instinct of Reaction?

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | They invoke some kind of summoned beast or occult peril against the investigators |
| 2 | They call on favors or mundane agents to wield secular forces against the PCs |
| 3 | They put pressure on friendly NPCs or threaten allies to get the PCs to back off |
| 4 | They offer bribes that are genuinely tempting to the PCs |
| 5 | Their minions or direct servitors seek to use brute violence to quell the PCs |
| 6 | They change locations or plans in an attempt to throw the PCs off the scent |

d6 What's the Cost of the Clue?

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | A sympathetic or friendly NPC dies in the process of revealing the clue to the PCs |
| 2 | The coincidence that reveals the clue also greatly strengthens the culprit |
| 3 | Some portion of a treasure or reward is spoiled by the way the clue is revealed |
| 4 | A positive NPC relationship with the PCs is sacrificed by the circumstances of the scene |
| 5 | The culprit becomes acutely aware of the PCs' involvement by the way the clue is revealed |
| 6 | The clue's revelation is made contingent on the PCs making some significant sacrifice |



CREATING SOCIAL CHALLENGES

In many ways, social challenges are extremely simple. The PCs want something, the NPC has it, and the PCs need to figure out some way to make the NPC give it to them. They may want favors, information, money, or some particular action on the target's part, but it's essentially a challenge revolving around making the transaction.

In other ways, social challenges are hard. How can a GM figure out what kind of deals an NPC would be willing to make, or how much payment they'll want for their help? How can social skills and powers earn their keep in such challenges without trivializing matters into a simple skill check?

BUILDING THE TARGET

A social challenge has a target, a particular person the PCs need to persuade or compel into doing something for them. If you're to make a good challenge out of the matter, you need to build a target that can sensibly respond to the often-exotic persuasions that PCs tend to offer to NPCs. Answer the questions below to fashion this target.

Is the desired result possible? Do the PCs want something that the target even can or would possibly be able to provide? What they want might just be beyond the power of the NPC, or so hateful to them that they'd never grant it.

If that's the case you either need to telegraph this to the PCs and prepare alternate material for when they give up, or else you need to provide a lead to some action or motivation that might change the situation enough to make the result possible. Maybe some special favor, the death of a rival, the loss of some authority, or some other twist can turn the unthinkable into the feasible.

Why won't they give it? Why won't the NPC simply grant the result for the asking or for some easily-paid price? If a modest bribe is enough to get the result the PCs want, you haven't made much of a social challenge. That might be okay for you, but you need to know it before the PCs breeze past it. Knowing why the NPC won't cooperate easily helps inform the next step.

What do they want from the PCs? What kind of favor, payment, or service do they want from the heroes that would make their desired result possible? What kind of problem does the NPC have that the PCs can plausibly resolve? It may be that nothing the PCs can do can satisfy the NPC, in which case a less equitable form of persuasion is needed.

What can the PCs do to pressure them? What levers can the PCs pull to force the NPC to cooperate? Blackmail, old friendships, naked physical force, or some other squeeze might be enough to force the NPC into accepting terms they would never consider otherwise.

How can they hurt the PCs? What qualities do they have that would make their enmity dangerous? Are they personally mighty in their combat prowess? Do they have

a lot of friends at court? Are they connected with the criminal underworld? If the PCs get their way through pressure and don't intimidate the NPC so completely as to make them swear off further contact, there will likely be consequences from the NPC's enmity.

How will the PCs learn about them? A social challenge only works if the PCs know who they need to persuade. A particular crime boss might be the woman they need to win over, but if the PCs never hear about her there's not much point in prepping the challenge. Be generous about throwing hooks to the target, because the real meat of the challenge happens after they meet.

HANDLING SOCIAL SKILLS

A PC built for smooth-talking and golden persuasion should feel as good about their character choices in a social fray as a Warrior does in a melee. Their skills should give them a distinct advantage, but just like a Warrior, bare rolls shouldn't save them from bad judgment.

Make sure the rest of the party isn't left out of any negotiations. Every PC should be invited to give their own two cents at each stage. Don't penalize PCs who have players that might not be the most socially-adroit; assume whatever they say or do is taken in the spirit intended, even if it's expressed inelegantly.

When the PCs make their request, the target will usually then refuse them or demand a particular favor. At this point, most players will want to roll their social skills to persuade them otherwise or sweeten the terms.

Every player who makes such a roll needs to explain what reasons or terms their PC is giving to persuade the target. What are they offering in exchange? Only after they've made their pitch should they roll the check.

The difficulty is privately set by you based on the quality of their offering versus the magnitude of their demand. A very good offer might be difficulty 7, while a risky or dangerous deal with poor inducement might be 12 or more.

On a success, the NPC either accepts the terms outright or adds a condition that they think the PCs can reasonably accomplish. If the PCs can meet the terms they offered, they'll get what they want from the NPC, barring treachery.

On a failure, the NPC either refuses them flatly or demands some term that the PCs may not be able to meet. In this case, however, don't simply kill the negotiation. Instead, offer the PCs some hint or clue as to potential ways to pressure the NPC or change the grounds of their refusal.

A failed social negotiation should almost never end in a simple flat refusal. There should always be some way forward for the PCs, and some evident means of improving their case. They may decide that the effort is too onerous, or they may attempt it and fail, but they should never be left with nowhere to go.

ONE-ROLL SOCIAL CHALLENGE TARGETS

The tables in this section can be used to quickly generate a social challenge target by rolling one die of each type, or by picking entries from the tables to suit your needs.

The bare skeleton produced can then be dressed in the specifics of your need, with names, social roles, and particular capacities added to fit the social challenge you're creating. When possible, tie outside elements such as rivals, enemies, allies, and other connections back into your existing adventure, using other NPCs and events you've already created. Several targets can thus form a web of rivalries, friendships, and associations that can make it easier to come up with their problems and needs.

The Court generators on page 167 can also prove convenient for creating a target's social context, along with giving them minions and resources of their own.

d6 How Do The PCs Learn About Them?

- 1 They have a mutual acquaintance
- 2 They were involved in a problem the PCs had
- 3 Their name is widely known to the public
- 4 They do something that the PCs will notice
- 5 An NPC ally mentions them to the PCs
- 6 They have a reason to seek the PCs out

d8 Why Won't They Cooperate?

- 1 They're too absorbed in some other issue
- 2 They're being watched by a rival
- 3 They begrudge the PCs for some reason
- 4 They want more than the PCs can give
- 5 They're afraid of the consequences
- 6 They doubt their ability to do it
- 7 They think the PCs aren't worth their time
- 8 Someone they care about is against it

d10 What's Their Weakest Point?

- 1 There exists grave blackmail on them
- 2 They're enamored of a manipulator
- 3 They're a physical coward
- 4 They're in serious and pressing debt
- 5 A rival is beating them at their own game
- 6 They recently made a grave error of judgment
- 7 They're lamentably overconfident
- 8 Their social standing is being undermined
- 9 Someone they love makes horrible choices
- 10 An underling plots to betray them

d4 What's Their Current Mood?

- 1 Something good happened; they're happy
- 2 It's just a day like any other
- 3 Uncharitable, tired, bored, or irritated
- 4 Something bad happened that upset them

d12 What Do They Want Accomplished?

- 1 They want someone murdered
- 2 They want to make a lot of money
- 3 They want to discredit a rival
- 4 They want to help a friend or ally in trouble
- 5 They want a mystery solved
- 6 They want a monster slain
- 7 They want to elevate their social standing
- 8 They want someone subverted to their cause
- 9 They want a crime committed
- 10 They want someone to be driven away
- 11 They want to obtain a particular object
- 12 They want a matter hushed up

d20 Twists to the Negotiation

- 1 They're planning on reneging on the deal
- 2 They misunderstand what the PCs want
- 3 They'll deal only at a dangerous location
- 4 They somehow think the PCs betrayed them
- 5 They have a reason to want to make the deal
- 6 They hate to negotiate directly with the PCs
- 7 Someone wants to make them a better offer
- 8 They think too much of the PCs' capabilities
- 9 They think the PCs are someone else's agents
- 10 Payment is a ruse to cover for their real desire
- 11 What they want will turn out terribly for them
- 12 They're so open that they seem suspicious
- 13 They're the front man for the real target
- 14 Someone's tracking those they deal with
- 15 Their request is much harder than it seems
- 16 Their request has a very harsh time limit
- 17 Their request changes mid-stream
- 18 Their request hurts the PCs' interests
- 19 PCs need to be vouched-for to meet them
- 20 They're also doing favors for PC enemies



REWARDS, RENOWN, AND EXPERIENCE POINTS

The room stocking rules on page 244 explain how to divide up an adventure's treasure, but how much should you be giving in the first place? How many experience points should the heroes get for an adventure, and how much Renown should you parcel out for their deeds? These matters will be influenced by the tastes of individual tables, but some suggestions are offered below.

MONETARY REWARDS AND PAYMENT

Adventurers tend to be hired by patrons to do dangerous or unpleasant tasks. The table below gives a general benchmark of what various kinds of average patrons can afford to pay for a job that is important to them.

Some portion of the reward might be offered in material goods, property, favors, noble titles, or other non-coin form, particularly if the patron is richer in such things than in silver. Jobs involving unusually great danger or that promise dire consequences for failure are worth twice as much, and if the work is so vital that they'd give everything they can scrape together on short notice, the reward is four times as much. Rewards in land or portable goods are higher too, as they're harder to sell.

There may be times when the PCs want to bribe an NPC or offer them an inducement potent enough to get them to risk major dangers. Such a price is usually equal to twice the average reward below; a peasant will risk great danger for a hundred pieces of silver, while a king might expect a hundred thousand for such a service. Such a cash inducement will be enough to get most people to accept substantial risks of harm, but they won't sign up for likely personal ruin.

Type of Patron	Reward in SP
Common peasant / Laborer	50
Prosperous farmer or artisan	300
Rural village head / Tribal chief	500
Peddler or minor trader	300
Rural Chief Priest or Abbot	1,000
Comfortable merchant	1,000
Minor mage	2,500
Rural gentry or minor noble	5,000
Urban official or minor courtier	5,000
City mayor or its local lord	10,000
Regional noble / Great mage	25,000
Chief High Priest	25,000
Monarch or Merchant Prince	50,000
Paid in land or goods, not cash	x2
Great danger or desperate need	x2
They'd give everything for this job	x4

RENOWN REWARDS

A basic game session is worth one point of Renown for each PC, assuming they did something suitably adventurous or challenging during the evening's play. Their adventuring need not be entirely successful to get this basic point of Renown; they just have to have done their best to accomplish something worth mentioning.

If the PCs have done a significant service to some local NPC, provided useful cooperation to a local authority, or done some notable feat of helpfulness to the populace, they each get an additional point of Renown. If their adventure materially improved things for the locals or was helpful to the rulers, it's usually enough to get this bonus point.

Finally, any PC who spends at least a quarter of whatever they earned from the last adventure on carousing, local charity, benevolent tithing, holding parties, or otherwise self-indulgent or non-remunerative ends will gain one point of Renown. It's up to the GM to decide what counts as "the last adventure". Blowing the loot from the last trip down into the Deep is usually fine, even if the PCs aren't done exploring it, but if they're midway through some story-arc adventure or larger scheme the GM is justified in making them wait until they've finished with it before granting them Renown for their carousing.

These rewards assume that the PCs are letting their exploits be known by the general populace or someone in authority. Working as a secret troubleshooter squad for a local baron would still win Renown, as at least the baron knows how useful the heroes are, but a band of professionally secretive PCs who don't let anyone know what they're up to is unlikely to earn much of a name.

Aside from these basic rewards, the PCs might choose to undertake adventures tailor-made to win the hearts of the populace or the local authorities. They might perform generous deeds of heroism and fight mighty foes without asking for material reward. They might go into service with a great noble, doing their dirty work in return for the noble's cooperation in the party's own goals. When the PCs decide to aim for glory more than gold, the GM is justified in increasing the Renown reward.

For these glory-hound adventures or charitable undertakings, pick a patron reward that would fit what the job would normally earn the PCs. Then convert it to Renown using the conversion table on page 338, rounding up to the next point. Then divide the total Renown among all PCs as a bonus, rounding up for each. This reward assumes that no one is paying the PCs for their help, though they might find considerable treasures in the course of their good deeds.

Note that it is not generally possible to *lose* Renown simply by infuriating rulers or upsetting the natives. Such capriciousness is intimidating, and the PCs who are capa-

Ways to Earn Renown	Renown
Participate in a game session	1 point
Help a local NPC, aid authorities, or solve a local problem	1 point
Spend 25% of the last adventure's reward on charity or carousing	1 point
Succeed in a helpful adventure without accepting recompense	Special

ble of causing so much trouble are perhaps best placated with cooperation, at least as far as their Renown requires. There are numerous lords of the Latter Earth that do little all day but bedevil their subjects, and their minions are as eager to avoid their anger by swift obedience as to please them with their service.

For simplicity's sake, Renown is assumed to travel with the PCs wherever they may go. If they have done wonderful things in one region of the world and travel onward to another, it might take a little time for tales of their heroism to catch up with them, but once they do the impressed locals will likely be inclined to cooperate with their plans. If the PCs travel truly vast distances or adopt entirely new identities elsewhere, the GM might be justified in making them keep separate Renown totals for each of the different areas.

EXPERIENCE POINT REWARDS

The experience point requirements for advancing a level are predicated on a certain model of play. It's assumed that PCs will rapidly advance one or two levels in their first few adventures, linger for a while in the mid levels, and then slowly advance to the campaign-crowning maximum of tenth level. The guidelines in this section presume you want to keep that pacing, and you may need to adjust things if you prefer a different speed of advancement.

There are several different ways to award experience points, depending on the kind of activities you want to prioritize in your games. You should pick one that the table can agree on, as the things that you reward with experience points are the things that are likely to form the focus of your gaming sessions.

The default system is to give each PC three experience points for each game session in which they tried to do something adventurous or in pursuit of someone's character goals. So long as their efforts involved a challenge or an attempt appropriate to their characters' capabilities, they get the full reward, even if the attempt was a failure. If they laze around the home base or spend their time squashing trifling problems then the reward is lessened or eliminated entirely. This system encourages players to go out and adventure, and it doesn't especially care what exactly they *do* in this adventure so long as they are trying to do something worthwhile.

A goal-based system is to have each player identify a short-term goal and a long-term goal for their PCs. The short-term goal should be something that could conceiv-

ably be achieved in one adventure, while the long-term one might require several. These goals could change on a session-by-session basis if it seems reasonable to the GM. Whenever a PC achieves a short-term goal, they get three experience points and every PC who helped them gets one. Whenever they manage a long-term goal, they get nine experience points and every PC who helped them gets three. To ensure every PC gets their share of the limelight, a PC can't get goal experience again until everyone else in the party has gotten it.

For this system it's entirely acceptable for the short-term goals to be something the PC could accomplish this same session. If a short-term goal is achieved every session and a long-term one achieved every three or four, the party's total advancement is only slightly slower than with the default system.

A mission-based system is to have the players all agree on a mission goal, either one given them by a patron or one derived from their own ambitions. The goal must be an honest challenge for their capabilities, but when they achieve it they each gain three experience points. If they decide the goal is too much for them, they can change it at the end of any session, giving the GM time to prepare content for the new goal. This system makes for slightly slower advancement than the default, as the PCs aren't guaranteed to achieve a new mission goal every session.

A spending-based system encourages behavior in line with classic sword and sorcery heroes who are always spending the wealth of kings on debauches, vain purchases, and casual largesse. For a campaign like this, a PC earns three experience points at the end of each session provided they spent all their accumulated liquid funds at the end of the prior session. Thus, if a bronzed barbarian came into a royal ransom during the last session's adventure, he could spend all but a trifling few coins of it on whatever he wished. He'd start the next session near-penniless, but he'd receive three experience points at the end of that next session.

For this system, PCs are allowed to spend their wealth on useful things, such as equipment, or holdings, or Workings, or services from others. They are also allowed to keep magic items or objects of more than mere material value. They simply are not permitted to keep any meaningful liquid funds beyond those necessary for bare survival if they mean to gain experience points. Every session they need to go out and earn fresh rewards in order to fund their heroic lifestyle. They might choose to save up a few sessions worth of cash for a major purchase, but they'd get no experience points until they spent it.

The system to use is up to the GM and the players, and adjustments can always be made to suit the particular goals of the group. Remember that the activities that reward experience are the ones that are going to motivate the players the most, so be careful to put the focus on the kind of play and purposes you want to have. Don't hesitate to mix and match systems to find one that rewards the kind of play your group wants to engage in.



PLACING TREASURES

Adventurers have a habit of plunging into uncharted Deep, mysterious ruins, lost cities, fetid jungles, and similar places where large amounts of valuable objects may have been mislaid at some point. Sometimes they are motivated by the rewards given by patrons, but often as not their own curiosity and avarice are the chief drivers. A GM will often be obliged to figure out what kind of loot might be found in a particular place.

While the adventure chapter's section on exploration sites gives guidelines on dividing up a site's treasure, a GM first needs to decide how much loot should be in the place, and what forms it should take. This amount will depend greatly on the details of the location, but there are a few basic considerations that can be kept in mind.

The table below lists various different types of sites, ruins, and treasure storehouses. Pick the most appropriate line and roll 2d6 to see which column you should use to determine the total silver piece value of the goods within the site. This is the basic cash value of the ruin once all its lost coin hoards, concealed jewels, and luxuriant ornamentation is taken into account.

This total value should be adjusted to fit the site's importance in the area and the economy of your particular setting. If you've established that adventurers have long delved into the Deep of the Waning Hour then it's probably fairly picked-over by now. The PCs are also unlikely to find all of the treasure when they investigate the place, and if they miss one of the major portions of the trove they might come away with half or less than the total.

Once you have this total value, you can start dividing it up into various troves for placement in the site, as explained on page 244 in the adventure chapter. While some treasures might consist of nothing but a pile of ancient coins, others could use more flavor in being jewelry, gemstones, or objects of art. The tables on the adjacent page offer suggestions for such items. You can assign each such item a portion of the trove's total worth.

Values for jewelry and art object are based on what they could be sold for in a major city on short notice. Merchants might be able to get far more for it with time and skill, but adventurers take what they can get.

Important figures or rich troves might have one or more magic items among the finds. Some GMs will prefer to place magic items "by hand", placing elixirs, calyxes, and more potent artifacts at the density which fits their particular idea of a good balance. Even GMs who prefer a more randomized distribution should always feel free to reach in and hand-place certain items with the creatures or plunder that ought to have them.

In other cases, the table on the facing page can be used to determine whether or not a creature or pile of loot should have a magic item. Pick the line that best describes the possessor or treasure cache that you're checking and roll 1d20. The result will indicate how many magic items are in their possession, with the table below giving a distribution of potential item types. In almost all cases an intelligent possessor should be expected to use the item if they realize its worth.

Silver Piece Value of the Site's Contents

Type of Site	2–3	4–5	6–8	9–10	11–12
Minor bandit cache or petty find	1d6	1d6 x 10	1d6 x 25	1d6 x 50	1d6 x 100
Successful bandit chief's loot	1d6 x 10	2d6 x 20	2d6 x 50	2d10 x 50	2d10 x 100
Rural noble or gentry's estate	1d6 x 100	2d6 x 100	2d10 x 100	1d4 x 1,000	1d8 x 1,000
Great noble's country estate	1d6 x 500	2d6 x 500	2d6 x 2,000	2d10 x 2,000	2d10 x 4,000
Solitary dangerous monster's loot	1d10 x 50	1d8 x 100	2d10 x 250	2d4 x 1,000	4d6 x 1,000
Solitary legendary monster's trove	1d10 x 1,000	1d8 x 10,000	3d10 x 10,000	3d6 x 20,000	2d6 x 50,000
Minor Deep or ancient ruin	1d6 x 500	1d6 x 1,000	3d6 x 1,000	2d6 x 2,000	2d6 x 5,000
Significant Deep or ancient ruin	1d6 x 1,000	1d4 x 5,000	2d4 x 10,000	2d8 x 10,000	4d6 x 10,000
Sprawling Deep or megadungeon	1d6 x 5,000	2d6 x 10,000	1d4 x 50,000	1d10 x 50,000	2d6 x 50,000
Merchant prince's estate	1d10 x 100	2d6 x 500	2d6 x 2,000	1d10 x 5,000	2d6 x 5,000
Outsider settlement or outpost	1d8 x 1,000	2d10 x 1,000	1d4 x 10,000	1d10 x 10,000	3d6 x 10,000
Outsider city or major power center	2d6 x 1,000	1d8 x 10,000	1d10 x 20,000	2d10 x 20,000	3d10 x 20,000
Ancient royal palace or seat of rule	2d6 x 1,000	1d6 x 5,000	2d6 x 10,000	1d6 x 50,000	2d6 x 50,000
Richly adorned great temple	1d6 x 1,000	2d10 x 1,000	3d6 x 5,000	2d6 x 10,000	2d6 x 20,000
Lost settlement of limited size	2d6 x 100	1d6 x 500	1d10 x 1,000	2d8 x 1,000	1d10 x 5,000
Lost city with many explorable areas	1d6 x 1,000	2d8 x 1,000	2d8 x 5,000	4d6 x 10,000	4d6 x 20,000
Great wizard's domicile	1d8 x 1,000	2d6 x 2,000	2d6 x 5,000	1d6 x 20,000	1d12 x 20,000

Type of Trove or Owner	Chance for Magic Items Rolled			
	No Items	One Item	Two Items	Three or More
Trove of 1 HD creature	1–19	20	N/A	N/A
Trove of 2–4 HD creature	1–18	19	20	N/A
Trove of 5–10 HD creature	1–10	11–17	18–19	20
Trove of 11+ HD creature	N/A	1–8	9–16	17–20
Minor unguarded trove	1–18	19–20	N/A	N/A
Major unguarded trove	1–5	6–18	19	20
Adventurer or noble	1–10	11–19	20	N/A
Veteran adventurer	N/A	1–5	6–15	16–20
Minor mage or shaman	1–10	11–18	19–20	N/A
Great wizard	N/A	N/A	1–5	6–20

d8	Types of Jewelry
1	Rings, whether for fingers, toes, or body parts
2	Crowns, tiaras, fillets, or headdresses
3	Piercing jewelry, perhaps non-human
4	Necklaces, torcs, or strings of jewels
5	Bracers, wristlets, anklets, or limb decorations
6	Hair ornaments, clasps, sticks, or pins
7	Jeweled clothing, straps, or meshes
8	Jewelry for non-humanoid alien bodies

d20	Valuable Objects or Precious Goods
1	Spices of rare worth
2	Recreational drugs
3	Elaborately-woven or exotic textiles
4	Household goods, jeweled or in rare metals
5	Coffers, casks, or jeweled containers
6	Ornate and luxurious clothing items
7	Preserved antique gourmet foodstuffs
8	Paintings of exquisite skill
9	Carved ornaments in precious materials
10	Uncut or unset jewels
11	Ingots of rare or precious metals
12	Useful raw magical ingredients
13	Books of historical or literary value
14	Deeds of ownership or tokens of legitimacy
15	Statues or figurines of material value
16	Religious tokens in precious materials
17	Medicinal herbs or compounds
18	Liquors of rare provenance
19	Vividly illustrated ancient erotica
20	Musical instruments of precious materials

d20	Type of Magic Item Found
1–6	Elixir
7	Exemplar or Grimoire
8	1d3 Ancient Salvage for modifications
9–11	Calyx
12–14	Weapon
15–16	Armor
17	Shield
18–20	Device

d20	Why is the Object Particularly Valuable?
1	It's contraband, forbidden by a local faith
2	The gemstones on it are very strange
3	It's made of an unearthly material
4	The workmanship is superlative
5	It's somehow related to the local rulers
6	It's abnormally large or bulky for its type
7	It's clearly sacred to a local faith
8	There's a magnificent jewel set in it
9	It figures in an important historical event
10	It has some petty enchantment on it
11	It induces a positive emotion when touched
12	It's a prized trophy taken from Outsiders
13	It has a famous maker's mark on it
14	It's a matched set of something collectible
15	Other items like it were all lost long ago
16	It's a perfect example of a particular style
17	It was part of an ancient ruler's regalia
18	It belonged to a famous ancient palace
19	It's remarkably durable and hard to harm
20	Its material can no longer be produced



LAND OWNERSHIP AND DOMAINS

It's not uncommon for heroes to come into noble titles as rewards for their adventuring or to seize *de facto* control of some stretch of wilderness, and most such newly-minted lords want to know what such a promotion is worth to their purse.

Other times, the PCs might buy or earn significant holdings of agricultural land or possession of profitable businesses. These pages provide a set of simple guides meant to apply to the kind of relatively small-scale domains that PCs are likely to rule. GMs should keep in mind that the finances of major kingdoms and true empires may not scale so well to these rules.

GETTING AND IMPROVING PROPERTY

Actually acquiring land and titles is generally the product of adventuring, and may come as an addition or substitute for some monetary reward. Rulers are notorious for handing off the most wretched, dangerous, worthless parts of their claimed lands to adventurers; they're ideally equipped for handling abnormal dangers, and if they fail, no one of importance will be lost. It's not unknown for kings to hand over disputed territories to such heroes, trusting in them to make the royal writ run there despite the rival claims of their foes.

To determine how much land a ruler might give as a reward in lieu of cash, assume that a full six-mile hex of wilderness with only marginal agricultural value is as good as 5,000 silver worth of cash reward. Good farmland in the wilderness is worth 15,000 a hex, and barely-habitable land is worth 2,500. Anything better than wilderness is almost certainly already in the hands of one of the lord's vassals and won't be given over unless circumstances have justified a forcible confiscation.

If the lord is granting existing farming villages, business monopolies, or other personal estates, a grant is the cash equivalent of a reward twenty times the size of its yearly income. Thus, a market village that generates 1,000 silver of profit a year is generally considered a fair equivalent to a 20,000 silver reward.

PCs with spare cash in hand might actively look for land to buy from a noble or grandee in need of quick money. Whole hexes of wilderness terrain might be sold at the prices noted above, or specific farms, businesses and granges might be purchasable at twenty times their yearly income. Better prices are not impossible for PCs who perform suitably useful favors for the seller, and some independent landowners might voluntarily enter the party's service if they can provide much-needed protection and security.

PCs may also choose to simply declare themselves the lords of a particular piece of wilderness. If it's far enough from any existing authority, they may only need to subdue or kill all potential rivals within the hex to be its nominal overlords, rather than fight off military reprisal expeditions. Their success may not actually earn

them any money, however, unless colonists can be enticed to start inhabiting the hex and building up the kind of population that can be taxed or worked in corvée labor. Open conquest of cities, farming villages, mines, ports, and other profitable places is always an option as well, though such places invariably have some martial power with an interest in them.

To improve a hex, such as increasing its level of development or improving its security, the party will need to carry out a major project at a difficulty determined by the GM and the cleverness of their own plans. Affecting a six mile hex counts as a city-scale change, for a x4 multiplier, but whether the improvement they're seeking is plausible, improbable, or impossible is up to the GM. The local monsters and bandits will almost certainly act as active opposition, and greater foes may start to move if they find the prospect of PC success to be a threat.

Not every alteration in a hex or property need necessarily be about making it more profitable. PCs who want to establish military outposts, clear dangerous areas, or resolve local social problems might undertake major projects to do those things as well.

FARM AND BUSINESS INCOME

PCs who aren't the lords of full, six-mile hex-sized domains might still own some valuable farmland or a working business. Other great nobles might own extensive personal estates in addition to their tax rights over a hex or more of land. While these rules aren't meant to be a full-scale treatment of fantasy business, they provide a simplified framework for these personal estates.

Note that it's assumed the PCs will have acquired workers and lieutenants of ordinary competence and loyalty, and that day-to-day matters will be handled by these reeves. If a problem arises as indicated by the dice the PCs might need to step in, but keeping and administering these holdings isn't usually meant to eat up much play time at the table.

A business or agricultural land will generally produce 5% of its purchase price in income each year, assuming nothing goes wrong. Thus, a 500 silver plot of farmland will produce 25 silver worth of income over the course of a year, usually mostly around harvest time. In the same way, a shipwright's factory that commands a 50,000 silver sale price would return 2,500 silver a year under ordinary circumstances. These are clear profits earned after the normal expenditures of hiring farmhands and business employees and buying materials.

Each year, the GM should roll 1d6. On a 1, something will go wrong the following year and there will be no income unless the PCs can fix whatever the problem was. If a business enterprise rolls a 1 two years in a row it will completely collapse, unless the PCs can act to save it. Agricultural land never collapses like this, barring its military loss or conversion into a wasteland.

NOBLE INCOME

For very minor lords and gentry, their yearly income is worth only what their farmland and the serfs or tenant farmers on it can generate, as noted in the farm and business income section.

For lords that rule at least one six-mile hex of land, or about 30 square miles, they usually have not only the profits of their personal estates but assorted fees, scots, tariffs, feorms, mercies, donations, tithes, and gifts that amount to a varying sum based on how developed and safe the land is, as indicated below. War-ravaged urban heartlands may be less profitable than peaceful frontiers, and the overall development and security of the hex is of great importance.

Some hexes will have minor or major cities in them, which greatly increases their value. Note that while hexes with cities in them can be very profitable, this assumes that the noble actually has taxation rights there, and that it's not a free city or under direct royal rule. If that's the case, such a hex is worth no more than the densely developed hexes with a x2 multiplier.

The multipliers listed for development and security are applied in sequence. Thus, if it's fertile farmland at 5,000 a year, with frontier population density at a x0.5 multiplier, and wilderness-grade security at a x0.25 multiplier, the yearly income is $5,000 \times 0.5 \times 0.25 = 625$ silver. Even though a lord might own the whole hex, the bulk of his income is probably coming from his well-fortified personal estates, assuming he's managed to carve them out of the wilds.

If a noble rules only a few hexes of terrain, roll 1d6 each year for each hex to see if some calamity will prevent income from it; on a 1, it's worthless that year unless the ruler can somehow fix the problem. For rulers of very large domains, it can be easier to just subtract a sixth of their income each year and assume that they don't really have time to personally resolve all the problems in such a wide demesne.

THE OWNER'S PERQUISITES

Being a lord or a landowner comes with inevitable benefits, but most of these are wrapped up in the profit produced by the fief or holding. The services and work performed by subjects or tenants should be billed at the usual rate against the holding's income, and if it's inadequate the PCs will need to bring some of their own money to the table or else the locals will be too busy looking after their own survival to be of much use.

Lords who want more reliable or elaborate benefits from their holdings should purchase buildings and hirelings from the major project section pages. Such minions and wholly-owned institutions will always be pliant towards their masters, provided those masters don't start asking unreasonable things from their servants.

Lordship may also come with more abstract benefits, such as the right to rule on legal cases or the privilege of direct audiences with rulers. The GM can specify such perks when they become relevant.

Income/Year	Hex Type
10,000	Has a major mine or rare resource
5,000	Rich agricultural land
2,000	Marginal crop or pasture land
1,000	Poor and barely-habitable terrain
0	Wastelands and barrens

	Population
x10	A major city is present there
x4	A minor city is present there
x2	Dense villages and market towns
x1	Backwater population density
x0.5	Frontier population density
x0.1	Barely-inhabited wilderness
x0	Uninhabited wilds

	Security
x2	It's unusually safe and orderly
x1	It's ordinary civilized terrain
x0.5	It's as dangerous as a frontier or borderland near hostile wilds
x0.25	It's untamed wilderness with no real law or government control
x0	Active warfare went on for at least a season within the year

OBLIGATIONS OF OWNERSHIP

The profits of personal estates and businesses take into account the customary taxes and duties owed the land's ultimate lord. No extra payment need normally be made to the overlord, though times of great strife or exceptionally rapacious rulers might be a different matter. A roll of 1 on the yearly peril die might mean the king has laid a special tax on the land, and only a special favor can get him to lift the exaction.

The same generally applies to the profits earned from rulership over hexes. No normal payment is required, but if a 1 is rolled on the yearly peril die the lord may have made some demand that eats up all available profit. If the nation's political or military situation is particularly dire, the overlord might demand all his nobles come to his aid to overcome the present challenge, but the GM should be light-handed about things like that. Most players have no desire to spend their adventuring time doing poorly-rewarded work for a king.

As a general rule, both landowners and lords are expected to extend the usual degrees of personal hospitality and cooperation with the agents of their overlord. Again, the GM should avoid turning this into a tool to push players into adventures unless the players do something to specifically incite it.



HANDLING WEALTH IN YOUR CAMPAIGN

Industrious adventurers have a habit of accumulating vast piles of coinage and heaps of glittering jewelry from their exploits. In some settings this money can be swiftly converted to magical items or personal character bonuses that directly improve the strength of the hero. In others, there is less that money alone can buy. A GM is often obliged to think about the ramifications of a party's discovery of some great hoard of wealth.

SELLING TREASURE

Gemstones, jewelry, and precious art objects are often a far more compact way of carrying around value than chest upon chest full of silver coins. Heroes also tend to find such shiny plunder in the depths of the earth or on the cold limbs of their slain enemies. While you may have recorded a particular necklace's worth as being 500 silver, how do the PCs go about actually turning that trinket into spendable cash?

A community has a limit on how much loot it can buy before all local purchasers are fully stocked. As a general rule of thumb, use the patron reward levels on page 254; pick the patron that best represents the richest or most influential figure in the community and figure that the place's total budget for buying loot is equal to twice their average reward. Thus, in a humble rural village whose most important figure is the village head, up to 1,000 silver coins worth of loot can be sold. At the royal capital where the king dwells, the goldsmiths and usurers can afford to buy up to 100,000 coins worth of goods. A local community's budget refreshes monthly, assuming the locals are able to sell their newfound treasures onward in the meanwhile.

For convenience's sake, the sale value of loot is assumed to include a margin for local taxes, reseller profit, and other realistic but often-tedious considerations. A group that enjoys the extra verisimilitude might have the local lord taking a tax of 10% or more of all adventuring profits within his territory in exchange for receiving the security of his courts and legal enforcers. While some lords are recklessly venal, most find no reason to pick fights with powerful adventurers by demanding more than a relatively modest due.

Selling magical items is not normally practical without a full-fledged adventure revolving around the effort. Elixirs and calyxes might possibly find a buyer at their listed creation cost, but significant artifact sales will likely draw too much attention from greedy locals or worried rulers. Few of them have any incentive to permit ordinary subjects to buy inexplicable devices of eldritch power. While it's too hazardous for most lords to dare direct confiscation of such things from experienced adventurers, only black market arrangements and private "gifts" for certain favors are likely to be feasible means of exchange.

SPENDING WEALTH

Having made their pile of silver, what do the PCs do with it? There are several possible ways for the heroes to enjoy their hard-won plunder, assuming that mischance or dire need doesn't quickly strip them of it.

They can buy Renown to support their personal projects or goals, with the prices listed on page 338. Throwing silver at a problem is usually helpful to some degree, and some major projects could feasibly be accomplished just by buying certain properties or structures.

They can support needy NPC allies. If their friends know the PCs are rich, they're likely to make requests for help. As a GM, try to avoid having every bit character crawl out of the woodwork to beg for a handout, but NPCs you know the players are fond of might speak up or discreetly draw attention to a way in which cash might solve some problem they are currently having.

They can buy gear or property. While it's not generally possible to buy magical items, a country estate, a secure urban safehouse, a sailing ship, or a new suit of heavy armor all have their charms to an adventurer. Low-level heroes often spend much of their first profits simply in kitting themselves out fully for their trade.

They can make alliances, befriending useful NPCs with gifts or material support. In many cultures, the giving of valuable gifts may be the most fundamental way to forge an alliance and indicate a desire for cooperation. In others, it may simply be a matter of the king deciding to forget to demand an oath of fealty from the border baron who just swelled his coffers.

TOO MUCH MONEY?

Many GMs get nervous about giving the heroes "too much wealth" for their current level or station. This isn't generally a major problem in *Worlds Without Number*, because there's no easy way to turn cash into direct personal power, such as by buying magic items. Beyond a masterwork sword and a good warhorse, there's not much the extra silver can do to directly buff a PC.

If the PCs start to wonder what to do with their pelf, give them answers. Throw needy NPCs at them, or point out political alliance opportunities, or direct them to some calamity that can be solved or ameliorated with a sufficient amount of money. Give them exciting exploration possibilities that require a costly expedition to be fitted out, or let them burn their cash in excavating a path into a heretofore unreachable Deep.

Ultimately, money is a way for the PCs to control and influence the campaign setting. As the GM, you want them to do that, because the more they entangle themselves with its people, problems, and opportunities, the more likely they are to feel engaged with the campaign.

MAGIC ITEMS AND ENCHANTED TREASURES

As delightful as shining silver can be, and as satisfying as it is to own rich lands and prospering enterprises, the greatest greed of most adventurers is for items of magical power. Even the most fabulous hoard of coin can buy nothing more than mortal art or cunning can make, but a magical ring or enchanted sword can grant the bearer powers wholly impossible to gain any other way. Those lucky enough to find the right mystical bauble can leap over challenges that would slaughter a less fortunate hero.

Because of this, it's common for GMs to be more anxious about the right placement and provenance of magic items than of simple coin. At the worst, too much money might trivialize a social challenge or make a major project provide less adventure grist than they hoped. The wrong magic item, however, can sometimes erase whole swaths of different challenges.

The guidelines provided earlier in the chapter are usually safe to use when placing magic items. The rewards are a little thinner than they would be in some other games, but a little GM discretion can bulk out the finds when they seem too sparse, and their rarity makes them all the more valuable. In this section, you'll be introduced to several different types of magical rewards.

Magical armor and shields are beloved of combatants the world over. Magic armor has an improved AC over its mundane brethren, and some suits have additional special defenses or powers. Magic shields don't boost the user's AC more than usual, but every one has some special power that can prove handy to the user or that will protect them from some peril in battle.

Calyxes are crystallized spells trapped in some small physical token. Even non-mages can use their powers, if they're adequately trained in the occult skills of Magic.

Grimoires and exemplars are of use only to Mages. The former contain spells that they can learn for their own use, while the latter are full of lost occult lore that can substitute for silver when doing magical works.

Magical devices make up a catch-all category for rings, staves, occult objects, or enchanted trinkets that have some special ability. Most of them have very narrow effects or benefits, but they can be extremely useful to a party that knows how to set them up for best effect.

Enchanted elixirs are among the most common magic items, each one a potion or salve that can be used once to grant some temporary magical benefit. In some campaign settings, their creation is simple and common enough that they can even be bought openly, though usually they must be pried from some lost hoard or abandoned wizard's cache.

Magical weapons are desired by anyone who swings a sword or fires a bow. Each one grants a bonus to hit and damage rolls, and can harm magical creatures that might otherwise be immune to mundane steel. The more powerful weapons have special abilities as well to aid their bearer.

The magical items in this section are but a small selection of the possibilities. Most other old-school games have lengthy lists of occult items that can be plundered for ideas, and your players themselves might come up with a charm or two they'd like their wizard to forge.



MAGICAL ARMOR AND SHIELDS

Just as sorcerers have always found use in enchanting the weapons of allied warriors, magical armor is by no means unknown in the lands of the Latter Earth. Some of these suits are simply better than their mundane equivalents, while others have certain special benefits unique to their particular enchantments.

ARMOR AND SHIELD BENEFITS

A suit of armor's enchantment is measured from +1 to +3. This bonus is added to the armor's base AC; thus, a *war shirt* +3 would grant an effective AC of 14 to the wearer. Magical armor is almost always masterwork quality, so its effective Encumbrance is one point less than that of the base version, albeit not for purposes of the *Armored Magic Focus*' limits. Most suits of magical armor are designed to be adjustable to most humanoid wearers.

Magical shields do not have enchantment bonuses that add to the user's Armor Class. Instead, they're empowered with unique abilities or benefits that apply to the bearer. Magical shields cannot be ruined with the *Shatter Shield* combat maneuver mentioned on page 44, though they can be destroyed by intentional abuse.

ANCIENT PANOPLIES

The ancient cultures of the Latter Earth often had very exotic ideas about what armor should look like, either due to very different conditions of warfare or their ubiquitous access to magical materials. These ancient suits of armor might appear as ceremonial robes, harnesses of glass or crystalline mineral, baroquely impractical plate armors, or enchanted ornaments that cover hardly a handspan of the wearer's skin. Despite these various appearances, these ancient armors have the same statistics as the modern armors they emulate, including Encumbrance and skill check penalties. Thus, a multicolored and brocaded robe that functions as a suit of plate armor would have an Encumbrance value of 2 and apply its penalty to Sneak and Exert skill checks.

Some regions of the modern Latter Earth have preserved the techniques for fashioning armors of this kind, or have so many surviving suits that they are in common use among adventurers. Others make a point of dressing their elite guards or temple defenders in appropriate panoplies to better show their status. The presence or absence of such armor in a campaign is up to the tastes of the GM and the table; some groups love the pulp aesthetic of fur loincloths and scaled bikinis, while others prefer to rely on unisex cuirasses and rust-smelling chain hauberks.

Ancient panoplies come in both normal and enchanted versions, just like any other suit of armor. Where such armor is commonplace, normal versions cost no more than their mundane equivalents and artisans can craft them out of commonly-available components.

CREATING MAGICAL ARMOR

When you need to place a suit of magical armor, first decide whether it is a minor, major, or great artifact. The context will usually determine just how potent a relic you want to place, though sometimes a seemingly minor item might turn out to be unexpectedly powerful. Once you've chosen the general category, roll a d20 to find out the armor's enchantment bonus, and again to find out whether it has some special power. Magical shields never have an enchantment bonus, but always have one special power.

Armor Enchantment Bonus

Bonus	Minor	Major	Great
+1	1–16	1–5	1
+2	17–19	6–17	2–4
+3	20	18–20	5–20

How Many Special Abilities does the Armor Have?

d20	Minor	Major	Great
1–16	None	None	One
17–19	None	One	Two
20	One	Two	None

Lastly, roll to see what base type of armor or shield it is, assuming you don't have a particular type in mind.

d20 Armor Type

d20	Armor Type	d20	Armor Type
1	War Shirt	11–13	Cuirass and Greaves
2–4	Buff Coat	14–15	Scaled Armor
5–6	Linothorax	16–17	Mail Hauberk
7–8	War Robe	18	Plate Armor
9	Pieced Armor	19	Great Armor
10–11	Mail Shirt	20	Grand Plate

d20 Shield Type

d20	Shield Type	d20	Shield Type
1–5	Small	6–20	Large

Some special abilities might grant bonuses to skills or other numeric benefits. These bonuses don't stack with other armor or weapon powers that boost similar scores; only the best bonus is applied. In the same vein, a shield and a suit of armor that both have the same ability benefit the user only once; an *Impervious* shield and suit of armor only allow one instance of Shock to be ignored each round rather than two.

ARMOR AND SHIELD ABILITIES

Below are merely a few of the special abilities that might be found on magical armor and shields. Other graces can be added, but should generally revolve around protective and utility functions rather than offensive magical effects.

Augmented: The bearer can carry four more points of Readied encumbrance. Once per scene, they can lift or briefly manipulate with brute strength anything a human possibly could.

Bracing: As a Move Action, the bearer can brace against one specific foe. Until they voluntarily move from their location, they're immune to Shock from that foe and cannot be forcibly moved.

Clotting: Once per day, it automatically stabilizes a Mortally Wounded bearer.

Feathery: The user is immune to falling damage and can choose a landing site within 30 feet of their target.

Feral: At the cost of one System Strain, the bearer can talk to animals for a scene, who will reply with human intellect but bestial interests and focus.

Fireproof: The bearer ignores the first 10 points of fire or heat damage they suffer each round.

Fortified: The bearer ignores the first point of System Strain they'd otherwise incur in a day.

Graceful: The bearer walks so lightly as to leave no footprints and cannot slip, trip, or be subject to forced movement by a man-sized foe.

Harmonic: An allied mage can cast a spell on it; the bearer is then immune to that spell until it is changed.

Impervious: Once per round, the bearer ignores an instance of Shock they would otherwise have suffered.

Inspiring: Allies who can see the wearer gain a +1 Morale bonus and may reroll failed Mental saves against emotion or thought-controlling effects.

Lucky: Once per day, as an Instant action, turn a failed save into a success.

Majestic: Its magnificent appearance makes it socially acceptable wear in any situation or context.

Sealed: The bearer ignores toxic atmospheres, terrestrial temperature extremes, and has no need to breathe.

Shifting: The bearer can teleport up to 30' to a visible location as a Move action.

Shining: It can emit light in a 30' radius at will. Once per day as an On Turn action, force a melee foe to make a Physical save or lose their next Main Action from being dazzled.

Silent: It applies no penalty to Sneak skill checks. If light armor or a shield, it grants a +1 bonus to the checks.

Soaring: As a Main Action, the bearer can move twice their movement rate through the air. They'll fall if they end the turn on an unsupported surface.

Sustaining: Once per day, cause the bearer to gain a point of System Strain and lose all need for sleep, food, air, or drink for the next 24 hours.

d00	Magical Armor and Shield Abilities		
1–4	Augmented	53–56	Sealed
5–8	Bracing	57–60	Shifting
9–12	Clotting	61–64	Shining
13–16	Feathery	65–68	Silent
17–20	Feral	69–72	Soaring
21–24	Fireproof	73–76	Sustaining
25–28	Fortified	77–80	Thorned
29–32	Graceful	81–84	Transient
33–36	Harmonic	85–88	Unsleeping
37–40	Impervious	89–92	Vigilant
41–44	Inspiring	93–96	Warded
45–48	Lucky	97–00	Weightless
49–52	Majestic		

Thorned: Successful grapple, unarmed or natural weapon attacks against them also inflict 1d6 damage on the attacker, plus any armor enhancement bonus.

Transient: It can vanish from its wearer or return to their person as an On Turn action once per round. It appears if they fall unconscious or die.

Unsleeping: The bearer need not sleep, but will not get the benefits of a night's rest unless they do so.

Vigilant: The bearer can see normally even in deep mists or total darkness. They cannot be surprised.

Warded: The GM chooses one weapon entry from the table on page 37. Non-magic weapons of that kind can't hurt the bearer, and magic ones do only half damage, rounded down. Neither inflicts Shock.

Weightless: It has no Encumbrance, but this benefit does not apply to the *Armored Magic Focus*' limits or the armor's usual skill check penalties.

MAGICAL ARMOR CREATION COSTS

Crafting magical armor or shields is usually an expensive, complex process. The demands of forging powerful armor are often too great for ordinary mages of the modern day, and they might need to seek out special ingredients or particular lost tomes to lower the base difficulty.

The base creation difficulty for +1 armor is difficulty 10 and requires 25,000 silver and a masterwork suit of armor to enchant. Each additional +1 bonus adds +2 difficulty and doubles the price, up to a maximum of +3.

Adding a minor special ability with a narrowly-applicable effect to a shield or suit of armor costs 10,000 silver and adds +1 to the difficulty. Broadly-applicable or potent special abilities add +2 to the difficulty and cost 20,000 silver. If enchanting a shield, the difficulty additions of its special abilities are added to 9, so a shield with one minor and one major power would cost 30,000 silver to forge and a difficulty 12 skill check.



GRIMOIRES, EXEMPLARS, AND CALYXES

With legions of dead sorcerers marching back into ages unnumbered, it's no wonder that the Deeps and secret places of the world are littered with their scholarly leavings. Arcane grimoires hold the secrets of their spells, occult exemplars provide insight into mysterious magical principles, and empowered calyxes preserve spells in physical objects for later use by those versed in their proper employment. Most of these items are of no use to those unable to work magic, but they have potent benefits for a mage.

ARCANE GRIMOIRES

Almost every wizard needs some sort of grimoire, tablet, portable shrine, or collection of occult paraphernalia in order to prepare their spells. The calculations required for adjusting the preparations may be too complex to be kept in mind, or they may require certain specially-purified tokens that can be kept in the book, or particular signed and sealed contracts with ineffable powers must be at hand to win the ability to wield particular spells. Whatever the particulars, a wizard cannot change their prepared spells without having their grimoire at hand.

Grimoires are not generally interchangeable. The pacts and rituals that one wizard uses to access a particular High Magic spell may not be the ones another employs, and being "gifted" the sack that holds all the former's ritual implements may not be any immediate use to the latter. It takes time, effort, and careful analysis to derive a spell from another wizard's grimoire.

If learning a spell from a grimoire or a tutor, it takes one week per spell level, less one week per level of the learner's Magic skill, down to a minimum of one day. Thus, a wizard with Magic-1 skill learning a second level High Magic spell would do it in one week. At the end of that time, they've created a preparatory ritual for the spell that will work for them, and inscribed its particulars into their own spellbook.

A cooperative wizard can teach any spell they know. If the wizard is forced to work purely from an "acquired" grimoire, however, there are inevitably critical lacunae, personalized scraps of jargon, and missing fragments that were self-evident to the original owner. This means that not every spell in the book will be complete enough to be learned without its owner's help.

A captured or found grimoire will usually have one legible spell per level or hit die of the original owner. To select these spells, start by picking a first level spell, then one of each successive level that the wizard was able to cast. Thus, if they could cast fourth-level spells, you'd pick one spell each of first, second, third, and fourth levels. Then start over at first level and repeat the process until you run out of spell picks.

You can pick spells you know the wizard knew, or randomly pick spells from the applicable lists. The table below offers some suggestions for spellbook contents if

you're creating some dusty grimoire originally held by an unknown wizard. Such books are also an excellent opportunity to give a wizard access to an unusual spell that might not be one they'd otherwise choose to obtain.

Random Grimoire Contents

d20	Total Spells	Max. Spell Level
1–5	1	1
6–10	3	2
11–14	5	3
15–18	7	4
19	9	5
20	11	5

Note that it is by no means unknown for some grimoires to be guarded by curses or other magical defenses. Others contain versions of spells that worked perfectly in a former age but no longer operate reliably in the present. The GM might add a spell flaw to these from the table on page 89 to surprise the wizard once they master the flawed sorcery.

OCCULT EXEMPLARS

Some ancient arcane treasures are of great value to sorcerers but do not contain magical spells. These *exemplars* are artifacts that provide deep insight into the workings of the Legacy, or provide a worked example of some magical process that has since been lost or degraded. A mage can come to understand deep truths about the operation of modern magic through studying an exemplar and use these insights to improve and simplify their own magical undertakings.

Exemplars usually take the form of small, wondrous objects that visibly defy the operation of normal physical laws. A sphere that forever floats six inches above its opalescent base, a mirror that gives images of some lost age, a crystalline rod that never quite reaches the floor when it's dropped, or some other seemingly trifling work of magic might all be exemplars. Other exemplars are larger and more impressive in their effects, some of which might have actual practical use. A few exemplars exist as monographs or tomes by some ancient worthy, books containing secrets and insights that modern wizards would prize.

Exemplars are usually obvious on close inspection by a PC with at least Magic-0 skill. It takes a full day of study to deduce their silver piece value, but it's immediately clear that they have something useful to impart.

Every exemplar has a value in silver pieces given by the table below, whether it's a minor, major, or great exemplar. This is not its sale price, though some wizards would pay a significant part of the sum to have it. Instead, it's the amount of aid its insights can give toward a Working, spell research, or magic item creation.